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GEERT LOVINK

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Dialogues with the Virtual Intelligentsia

Uncanny Networks

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Uncanny Networks

Dialogues with the Virtual Intelligentsia

Geert Lovink

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Series Foreword

*Editorial Board: Roger F. Malina, Denise Penrose,
and Pam Grant Ryan*

The cultural convergence of art, science, and technology provides ample opportunity for artists to challenge the very notion of how art is produced and to call into question its subject matter and its function in society. The mission of the Leonardo book series, published by the MIT Press, is to publish texts by artists, scientists, researchers, and scholars that present innovative discourse on the convergence of art, science, and technology.

Envisioned as a catalyst for enterprise, research, and creative and scholarly experimentation, the book series enables diverse intellectual communities to explore common grounds of expertise. The Leonardo book series provides a context for the discussion of contemporary practice, ideas, and frameworks in this rapidly evolving arena where art and science connect.

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Leonardo, the International Society for the Arts, Sciences, and Technology, and the affiliated French organization Association Leonardo have two very simple goals:

1. to document and make known the work of artists, researchers, and scholars interested in the ways that the contemporary arts interact with science and technology, and
2. to create a forum and meeting places where artists, scientists, and engineers can meet, exchange ideas, and, where appropriate, collaborate.

When the journal *Leonardo* was started some thirty-five years ago, these creative disciplines existed in segregated institutional and social networks, a situation dramatized at that time by the “Two Cultures” debates initiated by C. P. Snow. Today we live in a different time of cross-disciplinary ferment, collaboration, and intellectual confrontation enabled by new hybrid organizations, new funding sponsors, and the shared tools of computers and the Internet. Above all, new generations of artist-researchers and researcher-artists are now at work individually and in collaborative teams bridging the art, science, and technology disciplines. Perhaps in our lifetime we will see the emergence of “new Leonardos,” creative individuals or teams who will not only develop a meaningful art for our times but also drive new agendas in science and stimulate technological innovation that addresses today’s human needs.

For more information on the activities of the Leonardo organizations and networks, please visit our Web site at <http://mitpress.mit.edu/Leonardo>.

Roger F. Malina
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Foreword

Joel Slayton

Uncanny Networks, by Geert Lovink, is a collection of interviews with a diverse range of media and cultural theorists, philosophers, critics, and artists. The collection represents an inquiry into various ideological, theoretical, and political orientations that have illuminated the relational blurring of information and cultural theory over the past decade. The interviews contained in *Uncanny Networks* offer perspectives on cultural imperialism; globalization; nationalism; access and distribution; social, informational, and cultural inequality; the virtual class; the hyperbole of technological positivism; the cultures of consumerism; the emergence of network strategy; liberal elitism; the capitalist appropriation of the avant-garde; the political economy of media; and the suspicion of postmodernity. *Uncanny Networks* is a call for new tactical strategies, cultural laboratories, and synergies of creative practice that question how art, politics, and economics are relational.

Geert Lovink is a media theorist and publisher currently based in Sydney. He is an organizer of conferences, online forums, publications, and projects such as community Internet providers, mailing lists, and media laboratories. He is a former editor of the new media arts magazine *Mediamatic* and a member of Adilkno, the Foundation for Illegal Knowledge. In 1995, together with Pit Schultz, he founded the international mailing list *Nettime*. Some interviews were produced for *Mediamatic* magazine; however, most were first posted to the *Nettime* mailing list (www.nettime.org). Others appeared in the German online magazine *Telepolis* (www.heise.de/tp). Numerous conversations were recorded in Hybrid WorkSpace, during the Documenta X Festival (Kassel, Germany, 1997).

Uncanny Networks is comprised of thirty-five interviews including the opening self-interview by Geert Lovink, in which he establishes a methodology of the social interface. The interviews conversationally locate arguments

on cultural production and control among varied theoretical orientations. The interviews function as an interface of which he is neither inside nor outside, but rather is enabled to perform as an embedded participant in what he describes as the "rich culture of confusion." As such, *Uncanny Networks* locates reference points in the political, economic, and technological entailments evidenced by cross-cultural advocacy and apprehension of media technology. *Uncanny Networks* is also a book about projecting possibilities. The interviews intentionally open new spaces for intellectual cross-fertilization and interdisciplinary analysis.

Any characterization of *Uncanny Networks* must take into account Geert Lovink's position as interviewer-theoretician. He embraces a criticality informed by the paradoxical nature of technological irony and desire in which conflict, inequality, doubt, skepticism, and suspicion are employed to shape a coherent methodology of investigation. That said, a survey of the interviewees' orientations is useful, but only insofar as it is indicative of the tone and parameter of the text. I, of course, readily admit that a characterization is just that, a characterization, and it is up to the reader to navigate among the opinions and arguments undertaken. Without overstating such a schematization, I observe that the discourse falls roughly into four overlapping terrains: (1) media theory and criticism; (2) sociology, economics, and cultural theory of digital computation, networks, and communications; (3) theoretical ontology relating to an architecture of media; and (4) new media art as information strategy. In fact, the terrains are more like membranes than subject areas with borders, and therefore serve to define a shared conceptual territory of intellectual concern.

Frank Hartmann expresses the need for a social context of philosophy. Michael Heim describes the implication of technological metaphysics. Bruno Latour responds to the tremendous hype surrounding globalization,

immediacy, universality, openness, and speed. Eduard Muka discusses the implications of post neocolonialism and the implosion of media in Albania. In an exploration of the interdependencies of social transformation and economics, Susan George implicates the invention of financial instruments as a phenomenon faster than that which we can get a grip on. Herbert I. Schiller suggests that we are living in a period of innocence and bankruptcy of values. Gayatri Spivak questions the ethics of choice between telematic culture and the reality of a developing state. Ravi Sundaram describes the alternative of a quotidian commodity culture centered on locality and neighborhood. Kuan-Hsing Chen describes media activism for the enabling of alternative critical cultures that operate outside the boundaries and control of bourgeois democratization. Pauline Borsook reflects on the values, ethics, and morality of Silicon Valley by arguing that there is no new economics, no virtuality, just pure financial speculation based on nothing. Arthur Kroker describes the virtual class as predatory capitalists and computer visionaries. These frameworks are referenced by Mark Dery's advocacy of a progressive pragmatic futurism, in which critical resistance is more than just symbolic, and by Jonathan Piezer's justification for the collateral benefit of programs that address specific cultural needs, not open access for all. Thomas Keenan discusses the relationship of humanitarianism and media intervention. There are two interviews with Leonardo Book Series authors: Lev Manovich (*The Language of New Media*) and Peter Lunenfeld (*The Digital Dialectic*). Manovich espouses a digital modernism for a new era, while Lunenfeld calls attention to the symbiotic nature of art and economics. Theorist Slavoj Žižek relates his suspicion of multicultural, neutral, liberal attitudes that see only a surrounding nationalistic madness. Dietmar Kamper calls for a mimetic undermining of simulation to relieve us from the disguised form of authenticity and simulation represented by cyberspace. McKenzie Wark argues that the masses are simply a fetish object of communication professionals. Mike Davis describes the militarization of space justified in terms of personal security, and Saskia Sassen describes the social and political difference between public and private digital space. The situational prospects of artistic media strategy are discussed with London-based collaborative Mongrel (multiculturalism as stereotype), Luchezar Boyadjiev (financial sector as the avant-garde), and Tjebbe van Tijen (dramatization of pluralistic social and historical information). Additional artists interviewed include Marita Liulia, Rafael Lozano-Hemmer, János



Sugár, Zina Kaye, and Calin Dăn. And lest theory itself not come into question Norbert Bolz calls for the transformation of media theory into computational theory; Toshiya Ueno promotes a dissident sociology of constructing a political practice; Hartmut Winkler advocates a revisionist media theory connected to social activities; Boris Groys examines the ontology of media theory; and Kodwo Eshun describes the significance of “fluctuating bits,” where theory loses authority, deauthorizes itself, and starts to become Babelogue. The social interface of the interview provides access to the relational terrain on these topics and more.

Uncanny Networks challenges euphoric, utopian, romantic, and cynical speculations associated with conceptions of information society. It points us to the possibilities of new laboratories of experience, particularly those represented in Eastern Europe, Asia, Indo-China, and the Far East. It implicates imperialistic culturalism, liberal elitism, globalization, and social and cultural inequality. It asks us to question our misgivings and our speculations. But most important, it asks us to create the spaces of intervention.

Acknowledgments

It was in the Blue Mountains behind Sydney, in late 1999, while visiting McKenzie Wark, who had taken up residency in the Varuna Writers' Centre, that the idea of this collection of interviews was first discussed. Thanks to his consistent and straightforward editorial support, work was finished with ease. Writing and editing was done in Canberra, Amsterdam, and Sydney in a few stages in 2000–2001. It was series editor Douglas Sery at The MIT Press who believed in the book and made it all happen. I am grateful for his generous support.

Accompanying each interview is a short headnote with background information. Some of the interviews were conducted for *Mediamatic* magazine back in the early nineties. Between late 1995 and mid-2000, most pieces were first posted to the Nettime mailing list (www.nettime.org). Others appeared initially in the German online magazine *Telepolis* (www.heise.de/tp). Several conversations were recorded in Hybrid WorkSpace, during the Documenta X Festival (Kassel, Germany, 1997) with guests of the “100 Days–100 Guests” program curated by Catherine David. Additional information is available online at <http://www.medialounge.net/lounge/workspace>. A good number of these have not yet been available in print.

I am most grateful to the following individuals, who helped me edit the original versions: Ted Byfield, Patrice Riemens, Geneva Anderson, Matthew Fuller, Linda Wallace, Kevin Murray, David Hudson, McKenzie Wark, and to Douglas Sery, Kathleen Caruso, and Chryseis Fox at The MIT Press for the final book version. Grants from the C@MP/Media Loan Fund in Prague and the Dutch Thuisopiefonds and the Netherlands Foundation for Visual Arts, Design and Architecture have made it possible to conduct a few more interviews, update others, and finalize the manuscript. Finally, it was my lover, wife, and fiercest critic Linda Wallace who encouraged me most in bringing together this rich and diverse material. It is to her that I dedicate this book.

Sydney, September 2001

Uncanny Networks



The Art of Electronic Dialogue: Self-Interview as Introduction

Geert Lovink

Going through the table of contents for this book, I see a few familiar names, but not that many. How did you select them and what do the people you've exchanged ideas with have in common? What is your conceptual framework?

The people I exchanged ideas with combine a passionate pragmatism to define and shape the architecture of new media with a similar drive to investigate its tools. They love to speculate about the coming of something yet unknown, while being aware that technology is not developed in a vacuum. I am interested in the beauty of digital discord. Business interests from both the Old and New Economy, in close harmony with governments and the moral majority, will do whatever they can to limit the potentials of new media. The right mix of speculative imagination and thorough economic analysis—and competence—could therefore have fantastic, subversive impacts. This will happen if this potential movement, if I may use my favorite concept, becomes transcultural, multilingual, and truly global, not just Western. As this selection of interviews shows, new media culture is nowhere near global. Yes, the user base is gradually changing, but this has not yet affected the core of matters such as discourse, software, and interfaces. Still, we are moving away from the narrow world of the male, geek culture and its libertarian visionaries. This book reflects this trend. I believe that it should be possible to exchange and amplify desires among different generations and social groupings and not get caught in a ghetto of terminology, identities, lifestyle, or choice for this or that standard or platform.

Over the last decade much effort has been put into overcoming the differences among artists who do conceptual work; old-school political activists, involved in investigative journalism and developing political arguments; theorists and critics, constantly in danger of getting stuck in structural analyses; the programmers who are writing the code, or installing and maintaining the networks; and last but not least designers shaping the media aesthetics (graphics, interfaces, etc.). An independent new media culture needs all these disciplines. I am talking here about a delicate balance among individuals, groups, and companies/institutions. Even though people are increasingly forced to develop a variety of skills, multidisciplinary remains an idle goal, not a daily reality. The division of labor is still there, due to the highly specialized knowledge of each field. All of these people are using and contributing to the network (not just their own), and this is one place where they meet and converge. At least that's my utopian drive. This

book is an expression of tactical and temporary synergies that tries to further encourage cross-fertilizations of concepts and experiences, not only among professions but also among different cultures and social groups worldwide.

This all sounds inspiring and idealistic. I am not sure if the cultural networks you are referring to here have a long-term goal. Certainly they have pasts. What would these suggest?

Unlike most of their predecessors, the artists and critics featured in this book are working with the technology itself. There is no outside position anymore, nor is this perceived as something desirable. The laity has become engaged in the fight over the rules and tools with which we communicate and work. For decades the research and development of these media spaces was in the hands of politicians, companies, and their engineers. It is only in the nineties that we see a democratization of new media worldwide. It is no longer about rejecting or embracing the new media. Computers had become what they had originally been envisioned as: general computational devices. They come in all shapes and sizes, to be used for any possible purpose, including global surveillance and virtual sex.

In retrospect, the eighties in Europe look like one crisis-prone, apocalyptic age, dominated by conservative postmodernists, privatization and budget cuts, fading social movements, and new wave "guitar" music. There was a hardware revolution taking off, with the rise of VCRs, fax machines, PCs. Despite the personal computer's reputation as a hippie invention, the self-satisfied 1968 generation had a rather hostile stance toward the introduction of computer networks. Its members did not want another revolution. Reworking their own New Left past was time-consuming enough. New media did not fit in their traditionalist concept of culture. This inward-looking intellectual climate, dominated by deconstructivist historicism, caused the cultural and academic sector in the West considerable delay in dealing with these issues. Both the fall of the Berlin Wall and the rise of computer networks took the postwar generation by surprise.

The rise of institutional cultural studies wasn't much more than a *petit salon* revolution. Identification with media consumers and their small pleasures was still situated in the realm of broadcast media, television, radio, and film. Cultural studies was all about creating meaning, not data. It is only in



the mid-nineties that we found ourselves in the middle of heated debates over software piracy, the heroic Netscape, privacy issues, telecom pricing, the monopoly of Microsoft, cool and bad interface design. New media had become an issue you could exchange arguments about with perfect strangers, on the streets of Melbourne, in a Bucharest café, at a bus stop in Montreal, on a suburban train gliding over Osaka.

Where does your fascination with this "secondary" text genre of the interview originate? Wouldn't time be better spent writing original pieces? You are not a journalist. Shouldn't a media theorist stick to theory?

It is certainly easier and more rewarding for today's intellectual to withdraw into his or her own work than it is to engage. Interviews are all about creating contexts, together with chats and debates, reviews, links, and other reference systems. The genre fits very well into the general tendency to break down the text and create a social-technological knowledge environment. Interviews are one of many sorts of imaginative text one can use in creating common, networked discourses.

I started conducting interviews in 1980–1982 while working on two books as a member of a student research group on the Dutch antinuclear movement. In that same period, I coedited the weekly newspaper of the squatters movement, called *bluf!*, in which I also published interviews. One of the best interviews from that period was an exchange between me and Eveline Lubbers. We wrote our master's thesis together and included a self-reflexive "conversation between two typewriters." This both serious and funny work on squatting, alternative media strategies, and their economic models even had a guest researcher who wrote a chapter. The day our supervisors rejected the thesis, while we were selling printed versions outside, certainly counts as the height of my academic career. We rewrote the thesis a bit and in the end got our M.A. degrees. Still, a lot of my later work as a media theorist, doing research on the economic dynamics and social psychology of new media culture, can be traced back to that 1983 study.

I really got the taste and understood the routine of doing interviews when I started a weekly radio show in 1987 called *The Portrait Gallery*, first at Radio 100, then Radio Patapoe, both free, pirate stations in Amsterdam. I made around 120 of these one-hour programs. The idea was to give weird, fringe thinkers and researchers from both inside and outside academia the

“royal space” to talk about their topic: a space they would normally not get in the mainstream media, not even in academic journals, especially not in an anti-intellectual culture such as Holland where everyone is forced to speak in a “normal way.” There is an amazing consensus, among everyone from conservative liberals to radical squatters, that sophisticated intellectual discourses do not belong in the public domain. Theory is perceived as deeply elitist. You can do that perhaps among your peers (if you can find them) but not in public. The attitude of most science and humanities journalists was, and still is, to behave in a pseudo-critical way, complaining about typos, mistakes in footnotes, and other nonsense details, and ridiculing whichever person they talked with in the name of the imagined “average listener” who was portrayed to be too stupid to understand anything. In response to this organized innocence, I offered Ph.D. students, theorists, and lay thinkers the possibility to talk freely and encouraged them to push the envelope in front of the microphone. I hardly edited the programs. Instead, I learned to listen patiently and encouraged the interviewees to create a shared space of immense density—and freedom of thought.

The introduction of the PC and word processing programs around that same period gave a similar possibility to create dense “compact texts.” When did you start using online interviews? Are they that much different from face-to-face conversations?

I gained access to the Internet in early 1993 after having played with bulletin board systems earlier on. Conducting interviews online—sending questions and answers back and forth, thereby composing a common text over a period of time—is a surprisingly recent phenomena. It may be hard to comprehend, but people really had to get used to email. It took a while for everyone to discover its potential, which, in my view, is still not entirely unveiled. It has been argued that people are more open and straightforward in email. This is why flame wars start so easily—over nothing, seemingly out of the blue, and with sometimes tragic, even fatal consequences. Real-life conversations create trust, often quickly, but that’s no guarantee for a better reflection. Online interviews in this book usually took weeks or months to accomplish. That’s terribly slow of course, compared to the speed of light at which we are supposed to communicate. You need to be really patient and unconcerned with deadlines. The good thing is that the result will not simply be a snapshot full of timely references.

Can you explain what exactly is being exchanged during an interview?

Certainty not arguments; in most cases, not even information. I am more curious about opening new possibility-spaces than in having a polemic. Unlike their public image, most of the cybertribes, whether organized as company, newsgroup, list, or “virtual community,” are not keen to engage in dialogue with outsiders. Libertarian thinkers, instrumental in creating the Internet hype in the mid-nineties, have been preaching “value creation,” not the creation of public discourse. Like the big guys in the corporate world, they knew that dialogue with some wacky outsiders could potentially endanger one’s market position. In volatile times, one bad remark in the (online) press can bring down your stock or postpone your initial public offering (IPO) to infinity. Playing down your critics could have the opposite effect and might be too late anyway. It is much wiser to ignore them altogether. New Age gurus unanimously promote “positive” thinking and strongly advise today’s leadership to route around “negative” sources. Cross-cultural and cross-disciplinary dialogues on the Net are still rare, despite the common belief that crossing borders is what the Internet is all about.

This very principle has so far prevented any real debate over the future of the “information society.” There is simply no time, and as Paul Virilio and other have pointed out, reflection needs time, which is the scarcest of all commodities in the Society of Speed. With unaccountable companies, incompetent politicians, and isolated artists and researchers not familiar with the language of the mainstream, no wonder we end up with the “eternal repetition of the same.” In general no big ideological debates occur in society. The Internet is no exception there. I am not enough of a believer in technological determinism to think that the global dissemination of a dialogical medium will eventually spur real discussion, guaranteeing social change. Technology itself is the change.

At numerous occasions you have used the terms “old” and “new” media. What do they mean to you?

First of all, they are to be used in an ironic way. We have warm, nostalgic feelings for authentic photo cameras, rusty magic lanterns, and valve radios, even though they were as virtual and alienating, as fascinating and global, in their time as “new” media are in ours. Still, we are such simple human



creatures who love to forget and are easy to impress with the “new new thing.” The promises of the new tap into amazing, undiscovered sources of libidinous energy. It is a lazy, even cynical intellectual exercise to deconstruct the new as an eternal repetition of the old. Scientific and historical “truth” in these cases does not empower today’s tinkering subjects. I am all for a passionate form of Enlightenment that is willing to cross borders. The absolute, radical new is a deeply utopian construct, which should not be condemned because of its all-too-obvious shortsightedness. It is only when the mythological storytelling gets reduced to a rigid set of ideas that vigilance needs to be exercised for a belief system in the making. So, through redefining categories such as the old and new, one gets a better understanding where analysis and critique could start in order to be productive.

What examples of famous interviews did you have in mind while putting together this book?

I have always loved reading interviews, starting with the Bibeb interviews in *Vrij Nederland*, a Dutch weekly. In the late 1980s, when I became involved in the new media scene, I got acquainted with the work of the German critic Florian Rötzer, who interviewed most of the contemporary French and German philosophers, artists, architects, and scientists. He published two collections of interviews, both in German. I suppose I was influenced by him—namely, the issues of *Kunstforum* he edited in the late 1980s and the collection of essays he edited called *Digitaler Schein*. Then there are the interviews in *Mondo 2000*, the early issues of *Wired*, and the collection of interviews by John Brockman called *Digerati*. My book can be read as Brockman’s shadow.

Be careful, though. It would be wishful thinking to start making up some global opposition against technolibertarianism. I have never seen what is often most visibly represented by *Wired* magazine as a true enemy. There are lots of common roots. I think it was mainly used as a virtual punching bag, for those in need of a reference system. It would be a tactical mistake to position oneself on the opposite side of “freedom.” It would be ideal to be uncontemporary, completely out of context. I myself have practiced post-modern metaphysics, “deep irrelevance” European style, for years. At some stage I started to miss the challenge and political context. It had gotten too safe, too easy, to be constantly in theory-fiction mode speculating about the

end of the digital age. I got tired of the 1980s rhetoric of starting one's philosophy with the end. Deconstruction and postmodernism fulfilled their function. Even though much of the criticism of Western rationalism remains valid, I experienced a lack of strategy among cultural critics who were unable to undermine effectively the hegemony of global neoliberalism. By 1995 I thought it was time to return to practicality. As Kodwo Eshun says: "Everything was to be done." That's the spirit I am working in.

Who is in and who is out?

I don't think I have selected any interview partners because of their alleged subcultural, pop theory "celebrity" status. I only wish they had it. I think that they need more publicity, much more glamour. Perhaps, unlike others, I did not experience the nineties as the Golden Age of Theory. By and large intellectuals are artists who are being marginalized, and have, in response, isolated themselves. Within their small scenes there might have been a rise in the celebrity phenomena, yes. Unfortunately, neither media theory nor new media arts has this social status. The scenes these people are operating in are small, in fact way too small if you compare them to the hypergrowth of the IT (information technology) sector as a whole. It makes you wonder whether, against the will of its participants, this new media culture isn't unconsciously reproducing the highbrow-lowbrow divide. This is a sophisticated "developers' community" that incorporates critical discourses in its work, unwilling to simplify just for the sake of the market. Its concepts will spread like memes (cultural viruses), I am sure. Ideas have to grow and do not immediately spread. It is a modern marketing myth that ideas travel at the speed of light. At some stage they do, yes, supported by huge advertisement budgets. Most concepts in the IT branch have a long and rich history—and so do the ideas voiced in this book.

I noticed that you haven't included many interviews with media activists or programmers.

True, the choice could be much more balanced. The same could be said about gender and geography. I have a slight preference for my colleagues, media theorists, who, paradoxically, become known because of the books they wrote. This must be a transitional phenomena. The figure of the

“virtual intellectual” whose reputation solely exists within the Net is still one of the many utopian promises and perhaps even one the many “unlikely futures.” Valuable knowledge about new media culture is still usually stored in book form. “Ideas are cheap, what’s valuable is their implementation.” Those who manage to administer the implementation of ideas, with the help of lawyers and accountants, are today’s role models. Yes, Michel Foucault, you are right: Ideas are tools. Some will design them, others will use them. Claiming intellectual property doesn’t help much in such a case. It seems better to conceptualize and start building economic models for the distribution of content.



“We don’t know what it is we invented”

An Interview with Dietmar Kamper

In the Gulf War winter of 1990–1991, one year after the fall of the wall, I lived in Berlin in order to become better acquainted with “German media theory,” practiced by a specific group of unattached intellectuals. The professor of German literature Friedrich Kittler is perhaps the best-known of this group. Because of the classical background of its members, this group can confront the glittering world of high tech with an old-age conceptual framework, without glorifying technology or being too distant from it in advance. What characterizes German media theory is the attention it pays to the physical aspects of relations with the media. Its practitioners no longer believe that a distance exists between the subject and the image or sound. Looking and listening have become physical, tactile experiences. At the same time, one can say of media theory that it does not engage in metaphysics, but rather displays a great interest in the hard facts about the effect of technology. According to this view, the new concepts ought to be identical to the design of the hardware.

Dietmar Kamper’s contributions to media theory consist of writings about the nature of human perception, in which he often refers to the world of Greek mythology. He makes use of the treasure trove of interpretations in this mythological universe in his experiments, which are aimed at a conceptualization of contemporary technology. Kamper displays a certain caution in taking this approach during the following interview, but that’s his style of thinking, one that has allowed new insights to emerge.

When the Gulf War broke out, Paul Virilio made an appeal in the Berlin daily newspaper Die Tageszeitung for a reconquest of time. In it, he claims that we must analyze and interpret the images before protesting. How might such an analysis look?

I think that we must employ a certain reserve if we wish to avoid falling into the mentality of contemporary commentators, who are only capable of presenting us with the choice of thinking either the one or the other. We all still remember Paul Virilio and Friedrich Kittler's hypotheses that the media are offspring of the war. What dumbfounds me about the Gulf War is that the media are denying us images. Officially, it's based on considerations of military secrecy, but I think that something else is going on. All of these images radiate an air of competence. Over and over, ad nauseum, we're convinced of the fact that they are in control of the situation. Only we're not allowed to see whether that indeed is the case. The selection of images amounts to an adoration of the absolute weapon, as Virilio terms it. That is unheard of and unbearable, in the long run. As long as no images of the dirty war are shown, human beings continue to appear to be the lord and master of the situation. But as soon as the dirty images begin filtering in, that competence is done for.

This means that images no longer show the power of people. Do they indeed have power of their own, a strategy of their own? Does the reporters' fear of the images have to do with the fact that the images no longer increase the power of human beings?

I suspect that because of the remarkable ban on images and the apotheosis of competence, images will acquire a new status. The excessive use of images in past decades has led to the images causing a reaction in the viewers and makers. In ancient religions, the ban on images was effected because they were thought to amplify human beings' potential for power. Now that interaction with images has become extremely commonplace, the images have lost their potential power for those who use them.

At the moment, I lean toward viewing the image more as a window than as a mirror. The mirrors have been shattered to pieces. Historically considered, the mirror stage is finished, which brings about a great anxiety. The phantasms that Sigmund Freud and Jacques Lacan saw as emergency solutions, which offered something of a foothold, have disappeared. What remains is the naked fear of a hard reality. This new situation raises

the question of the extent to which we can exist in a myth-free space, stripped of any symbolic order at all. Perhaps we will become aware now that images have always played a game with us and a new passion for images that no longer submit themselves or serve for submissions will come into being.

You write that because of the erosion of virtually all criteria, the authentic is glorified more and more, and simulation is denigrated. You appeal not for a return to the authentic, but for a mimetic undermining of simulation, that which Jean Baudrillard calls the strategy of appearances. How should we picture this, in this media world?

People are used to opposing simulation to authenticity; a deception is considered the opposite of realness. In our relations with the media, it's been apparent to me for some time that both authenticity and simulation are on the same side. They belong together. If you long for something authentic because of a lack, then you yourself are not. Someone who is alive doesn't know this desire at all. If one wishes to be authentic, one has only the means of simulation at one's disposal. Then one journeys into history in search of moments that radiate realness, which, in my opinion, never came into being because of an urge to be authentic—one already simply was. The simulated realness that results from this is ultimately not real either, causing one to dispatch it as simulation. That's an endless spiral.

I believe that opposed to this is mimetic behavior, which can't be traced back to imitation. As early as the Greek fathers of the mimesis idea, we find the fallacy that something like authenticity can be brought about by upbringing. In both Aristotle and Plato, mimesis is an imitation of nature based on a lack, which inescapably results in simulation. In fact, the entire imitation concept is based on a misconception about the meaning of mimesis. This actually has its origins in the capacity of the human being for play. When children play, they don't simply imitate the world of adults. They possess a power that one could describe as a premonition. They develop a premonition in order to achieve a specific goal.

This desire to bring about analogies isn't just an attempt to imitate something already existing, but that this power gives rise to something that didn't exist previously. Mimesis is original and creates a new world, that of imagination and fantasy, of artificiality and art, which can be assigned a real-

ity of its own. The relapse into fundamentalism in evidence everywhere at the moment is the inability to play, to attain a distance from oneself and regard oneself with irony, to be humoristic, take oneself less seriously.

This is only possible with the help of play. As soon as people lose the ability to play, they conflict. In earlier times, people lessened this by means of war games. Up until the eighteenth century, one can say, in retrospect, war was also a kind of game. Today, war results in a complete state of emergency; the only things at stake are life and death. The ability to play has become one of the stakes. That is the reason for my appeal for a revival of mimesis, as a way of departing by means of fantasy from the established paths, abolishing automatisms. That may cause irritation and confusion among our dead-serious, fantasy-less fellow human beings, but otherwise, those like yourself and me, who hold to a playful relationship toward ourselves and others, are in danger of going under. Once play disappears, then difference will too, and only more of the same will remain. One can dispatch this as blasphemy. Play is indeed directed against deadly earnestness, which asks for sacrifices and must make them.

How would mimesis in the present situation look? In this regard, I've described a paradoxical state that I've called "conscious self-deception." It creates skills for dealing with pain, hunger, and desire. This doesn't relieve people, but it does make it possible for them not to hold the world to that they're condemned to be the only possible one. When play disappears, one can only go through life as a perpetrator or a victim.

You claim that new technologies can't be covered with one theory. What might be the element that connects the new media theories?

The artificial world that has been created is characterized by polyvalence. It is not centered. Where could the center lie, anyway? Practice refutes any theory, that's become obvious to me in my meetings with video artists and with radio and television makers. This doesn't mean that we should lay aside the "technical a priori" being researched by Kittler. The questions he raises are of great historiographical interest but don't apply to all periods.

I would like to turn back the time machine and take a look at how the artificial world must have looked when there were no microphones or technical image reproduction. Just as in the case of exchanging paradigms in the natural sciences, one can't claim that earlier practices were superfluous or

even wrong. That which is applicable to a special area can't become a generalization. We're not so far along that we can claim that video has taken over film theory. Once I've seen a lot of video art, I quit seeing anything at all. I wonder why video makes it possible once again to delve into systems of thought. Because video isn't image production, it's image destruction. Images aren't built up, they're broken down. The images are worked on, and, often, it's thought that is unleashed on them.

This kind of development isn't linear, as people often think when technical innovations happen. The media move on different levels. You could indeed claim that the media give us new insights about the human body and that the order that we encounter within them might be of crucial significance for the relationship between the different media theories.

What caresses the eye, pleases the ear, and stimulates the tactile sense can coincide quite well in a physical reality that doesn't per se have to be portrayed on a monitor. Language will remain in the game, as will writing. Writing about media that lay on the other side of the written word will continue to exist, in light of the fact that reflexive capabilities develop only very slowly. An alliance comes into existence, but what supplies the inner coherence no longer needs to be "the concept" or that one theory.

The cyberspace that we know to date is too much oriented to imitation and attempts to create a disguised form of authenticity. It will only become interesting when video and radio makers, filmmakers, and writers come together and distribute their knowledge. We find ourselves at present in a phase of remarkable competition between the different media, which also makes itself felt in theory. That will pass. I hope that the way out will have a physical dimension, which prescribes an order in which one expresses various time dimensions via the body. In the construction of the human world, I see time emerge as a secret pattern. That's the time that we've actually lost, time in its whole extent and multiplicity. Then it will have become clear that the duration of a human life can't be compared to that of stars, that light is not the absolute measure of all things, but that a mixture of shadow and light is absolutely necessary, that past, present, and future.

One can only narrate the past. One can only fight with the present; a battle must be waged for it. One can't do otherwise than prophesize about the future, and, as far as that goes, I'm a strict follower of the Old Testament. Every person has gifts of prophecy, if he only knows how to mobilize the power in that direction. Words do indeed have a structure that is aimed at

the future: once spoken, one must prove one's words, follow them with one's deeds. One must account for them, either to oneself or to others. The future shines through the word once spoken. Images, on the other hand, show us a special mixture of past and present. We're rightfully witnessing the disappearance of the unidirectional, linear media theories, which are making way for a physical, multidimensional agglomeration.

In November 1990, you organized a conference in the Literaturhaus in Berlin with the title "Das Ohr als Erkenntnisorgan: zur Anthropologie des Hörens." In light of the dominance of the eye, can we see this discussion as an attempt to rehabilitate the ear?

To my amazement, what emerged from this seminar is that the ear isn't just a passive organ that obediently records. The idea was to do more listening than speaking. In the beginning, we were able to do so only with great difficulty, which is already an indication of how unusual it is to assign the human ear a power of its own, which isn't only subservient to thought but also to speech. What someone has to say is highly dependent on the extent to which he is listened to and who is listening. No pure research has been done on that. What everyone does know is that if you can't hear yourself, you can't say a single sensible word or you can only make sentences with great difficulty.

The ear specialist Tomatis from Nice ran into this problem after the Second World War. He cured opera singers by teaching them to listen better. The voice healed on its own, as the source of the singers' complaints was not their voices but their hearing. This discovery in physiology parallels the reappearance of the Jewish oral narrative tradition in this century, in which one assumes that the ear is a tiny step ahead of what one wishes to say. The ears have a small head start on speech, so the voice can be corrected.

The ear, which has been declared dead, possessed such power in the Middle Ages, but it was only used to enforce blind obedience and servility. Now that the eye has attained the peak of its capabilities and is becoming overloaded, a new chapter of reason can be opened up with the ear. It's remarkable how, from various different angles, one arrives at the point at which the eye loses itself in looking, while the ear finds itself hearing. That's such an asymmetrical result that research into it must be promising.



Rethinking Media Aesthetics

An Interview with Norbert Bolz

The West German philosopher Norbert Bolz enjoys international fame as a specialist in Walter Benjamin's *Passage-Werk*. He proved to be an expert on modern classics with the 1989 publication of his book *Auszug aus der Entzauberten Welt* (Departure from the Demystified World). In it, Bolz treats the philosophical extremism between the two World Wars no longer as something that must be condemned in retrospect. A number of years back, with this well-equipped luggage filled with nineteenth-century concepts, Bolz relocated to the world of twentieth-century media technologies. The following conversation took place in January 1991 in Berlin.

You deal with a very wide range of thinkers, from Walter Benjamin and Ernst Bloch to Carl Schmitt and Ernst Jünger. For the most part, you indicate what they have in common. According to you, they all display a negativity with respect to their own time. Does this also apply to their view of technology? To what extent did they go further than applying simply instrumental criticism of technology?

The blind spot of thought between the two World Wars is the “technological a priori” of individual thought. An exception, perhaps, would be Walter Benjamin and Ernst Jünger. They occasionally depart from an instrumental view of technology, which regards machines as objects that are situated in the outside world. Jünger’s “organic construction” indicates synergy between man and machine. This is a formulation that comes close to Marshall McLuhan’s “extensions” of the individual body, the senses, and the central nervous system. Not “outside,” that is.

The claim is still made that media are objects that one can turn off and shove into the corner. That’s possible, but the function no longer has the character of a tool. Intellectuals, especially, have difficulty seeing media as prostheses. The media addicts are evidence that we aren’t simply dealing with a tool here. To Jacques Lacan, these gadgets are objects that are desired, “object lowercase a,” detached parts of the individual’s body. In this way, the utopias of the 1930s, which tell of a symbiosis of machines and collectives, become more understandable. Then, they were fantasies, but, now, that interweaving isn’t far away.

*Your book *Theorie der neuen Medien* opens with a chapter about Nietzsche. Why do you find this antiquarian from Basel to be the founder of modern media theory?*

Nietzsche is one of the first to discuss the widely divergent meanings of the word “medium,” from telepathic to technical. He does that within a broad framework in which he indicates the blind spots of the second Enlightenment, which was beginning in his times. He produced a theoretical concept of the first mass medium in a pregnant sense, namely the works of Richard Wagner. Nietzsche’s *The Birth of Tragedy* is a description of the first mass medium, in my view. The analysis of the Apollonian and the Dionysian, which has always been dispensed with as having to do only with mythology, turns out to be a fairly adequate typification of the bodily condition of the media. The world of images and sounds is called into being by

inner excitement and is made visible and audible by actors and musicians in a rain of images and an endless melody. Together, this causes an effect that hadn't yet been shown, in an aesthetic sense, and may rightfully be termed a *Gesamtkunstwerk*.

This can no longer be called the production of "object art" in the strictest sense of the work, but, rather, of a mass medium which stages images and sounds and which takes possession of the spectator completely. It's a multimedia, staged event in which the spectator is absorbed into the work of art from the beginning onward. Nietzsche emphatically points out the rebirth of the aesthetic spectator. Since classical antiquity, aesthetic reception has viewed art as alien objects that one perceived from some distance. And then, suddenly, under the denominator of "intoxication and dream," a manner of reception is discovered in which the distance between subject and object no longer exists. This is paradigmatic for all mass media. It is senseless to introduce the difference between subject and object. The spectators are consumed by the performance. If one reads soberly, one sees that *The Birth of Tragedy* can easily be rewritten to form a first theory about multimedia staging.

Nietzsche later accused Wagner of having exchanged the path of multimedia aesthetics for that of art that propagates a message. Up until now, Wagner wasn't regarded as a media artist simply because the techniques of mass communication weren't at his disposal. This causes Nietzsche's texts to sound unreadable and archaic, while he discusses the most modern aesthetic products. His texts about Wagner can only be lifted out of this traditional context by short-circuiting them with today's media theories and by creating an interface between Nietzsche and McLuhan.

What is the significance of following the path leading backward from McLuhan to Nietzsche, for us?

The significance is that only in retrospect does the genealogy of the new media become visible. A history of the individual media, of photography, or of film is not capable of that. It's McLuhan who turned the history of technology into a retrospective view of the way in which we perceive. Moreover, he made the professional literature in the area of the psychology of perception accessible, in which it is demonstrated that images are experienced not so much visually as tactilely.

Nietzsche points out the connection between individual endogenous signal production during dream and intoxication, and mass-staged events. Dream images and intoxication-experiences connect aesthetic perception with mass communication. The goal of this is the creation of connections, not the propagation of messages; it's to make a large-scale connection between the central nervous system and the collectively experienced aesthetic product.

But, certainly, in the beginning of the twentieth century, no connection existed between the public realm and the world of individual experience? The German authors you deal with are no exception to this, are they?

Walter Benjamin and Ernst Jünger are the only two who break free to develop a new concept of politics under the precursory sign of collectivism. Benjamin's "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction" in *Illuminations* and Jünger's *Der Arbeiter* were both written in the context of collectivism, even though they were written by individualists. It was no longer possible to analyze with the experience of separate individuals as a point of departure. It had become insignificant: that had been demonstrated by the First World War.

The bourgeois individual is let go of, and a collective body replaces it. In Benjamin's case, the matrix is communism, in Jünger's, it's the mythic form of the worker. They may mean little to us now, but what's important is the urgent need that they conceal: the need to think of a collective body. The political body of Benjamin and Jünger is of the same order as the aesthetic body of Wagner and Nietzsche. If mass communication is to have any meaning, then one should first define it as the technical organization of a collective body.

Carl Schmitt has proposed that all concepts of politics are of theological origin and have been secularized in the course of time. Can we say that about the concepts that are employed in media theory as well?

The question of whether a "theology of the media" exists arises as soon as one takes even one step away from a functional description and begins to doubt the rather stiff, masculine conviction that the functioning of the system has become a goal in and of itself. When the connection of various media and its users has progressed to such an extent, immaterialization will have reached a critical boundary and all subjectivity will dissolve. The "consummate

anonymity" that then comes about certainly has a theological background, conceptually. For Søren Kierkegaard, anonymity was the "incognito" of negative theology.

In my view, the new theology should take the form of gnosis, a theology that is based on an absolute claim to knowledge. Theology is only still tolerated if it takes the form of an integral knowledge of the world. The new gnosis that the Pax Americana brings will find itself confronted with old, fundamentalist religions, which will withdraw into remote regions. Militant sects that succeed in mobilizing the population can link with the religious reserves that people possess during the total *Entzauberung der Welt*.

Is Hans Jürgen Syberberg a member of one of those sects? Why did this filmmaker suddenly turn against the media?

Syberberg believes that his own project is threatened by the gadget lovers. What he wants is a *Durcharbeitung* (further development) of the German myth. Alexander Kluge and Hans Jürgen Syberberg are some of the few in Germany who are convinced of the need to continue working on the myth. It is no coincidence that both work in film. The fact that the filmmaker Syberberg is a Wagnerian fits perfectly into my hypothesis, of course. Continuing to work on the myth and the ability to understand how the new media work are two complementary enterprises, in my view. At present, there's a real danger of both of them being paralyzed. Enlightened minds make research of the myth impossible, while mythologists pronounce the media taboo. I think that such fears disappear if you show that media and myths overlap.

I know that Syberberg is scared that his own productivity will be hindered by new techniques. That's the product of ignorance. And it's grotesque, of course, if you know the extent to which he's connected with the classic, new medium of film. He sees the *Gesamtkunstwerk* as the theatrical staging and reduces the multimedia character to theater. That is a typically conservative interpretation of Wagner. Instead of recognizing that film does indeed offer the possibility of liberating the *Gesamtkunstwerk* from old chains, he reverses the whole case and returns to the form of theater.

I suspect that Botho Strauss, with his plea for a "primary literature," will have a considerable influence within the bourgeois discourse and that aversion to the media

will become the dominant mentality. Don't you think that this conservative attitude will hinder media theory in its further development?

Writers like Botho Strauss are becoming more and more conscious of the media premises of their work and can no longer withdraw from the media. That's why they respond with a hysterical counterreaction. They refuse interviews, stay far away from television, and act as though what they write is free of secondary literature. However, if you look at his books, which I admire, by the way, they are full of references to Lacan, for instance. In *Paare*, Passanten there's a quote from *Gnosis und Politik*, a book I collaborated on. Intertextuality can't be removed as easily as all that.

Today, texts are a part of a media conglomeration; they form a moment within the network. Out of fear of the disappearance of writing, Peter Handke turns up with the "history of the pencil." This is a return to the idyllic idea that one can evoke one's intuitions with the most primitive of tools. And, indeed, one can, within an artificial paradise, which, in its turn, is a part of the media landscape. Stories written in pencil can be sent quite well by fax! They stick to humanistic ideas such as geniality and intuition with great refinement. That Handke presents himself as a poet and Strauss as a creator of primary literature forms expressions of the religion of individuality, which find a great deal of acceptance in the media as a surrogate. Messages like those are gladly heard. But they contain no innovative potential.

Their appeal is directed at a class of *Bildungsbürger*, like the teachers who read the serials in *Die Zeit*. But this bourgeois intelligentsia is all but dead. They'll be replaced by a polytechnical intelligentsia and people who have a good nose for the true poetry of today. That doesn't necessarily have to be cyberpunk, either. There are refined methods for receiving the sparks from the media world. Hans Magnus Enzensberger sometimes succeeds in doing so. The victory over "real literature" is just a question of time, until this enlightened humanistic clique is done for.

Isn't it strange that it's precisely science that is preoccupied with texts, which is producing the foundations for a media theory?

One of the greatest, Marshall McLuhan, was a literary scientist. Friedrich Kittler is, too. I think this has to do with a change in paradigms during

the last twenty years. It goes from structuralism to discourse analysis and, subsequently, makes the step to media theory. Those three are not mutually incompatible. They emerge from crisis phenomena, from the blind spot possessed by every system of thought. Thus, discourse analysis has outdone structuralism and media theory is now doing the same. It contains that which went before it and produces new ways of formulating questions posed earlier.

To begin with, structuralism divested itself of the central role of the individual. One no longer concentrated fetishistically on a sender or a receiver; rather, one looked at the structure of language or the exchange relationships. Discourse analysis added a number of historical preconditions to that, which made possible the transformation of such structures. It indicated discontinuities, named concrete dispositions of power, and showed what happens when discourse allies itself with certain institutions.

The blind spot of discourse analysis is technology, however.

It is fascinating to see how immune Michel Foucault is to new media, while he does welcome their coming. For the system theoretician Niklas Luhmann, it's unthinkable that communication technology has a logic of its own. The discourse is so immaterial that it's impossible to even connect it with alphabetic symbols. Discourse analysis has overlooked the hard facts of technical determinations. On the other hand, I must admit that media theory is in danger of neglecting power. It has no answer to questions called up by politics.

Which texts indicate the transition from representation analysis to media theory?

Indications can be found in Derrida, for instance, in *The Postcard*, in which his examination of the crisis of broadcasting, the broadcast, led to a theory of telematic technologies. This text dramatically embodies the shift from discourse to media. In *Of Grammatology* there are some important passages about storage and archive techniques. Moreover, Derrida took the step from the book to the electronic media in his definition of writing. From this, we can conclude that media theory originates in a media-technological view of discourse analysis.

What do you think will occupy media theory in the future?

I think that media theory will retain a retrospective character for some time to come, in order to map out its own genealogy. The countless books about computers appearing today lack any historical awareness at all. Even obvious founders like Alan Turing, John von Neumann and Claude Shannon aren't mentioned. This amnesia applies to very recent history: someone who speaks about cyberspace should at least have read Norbert Wiener!

The task that media theory is confronted with is the transformation into computer theory, because that will certainly become the metatheory in this area. Within it, the connection will have to be made between the electronic media and the metamedium computer. One could view all of this as a retrospective task. It only becomes diagnostic when it reshapes itself into a media aesthetics and studies changing perception.

This brings to mind "scientific visualization," in which people begin to argue with images. This is sensational when one considers that the Enlightenment, up to now, has destroyed images in order to replace them with concepts. Also, I think of the simulation techniques that compress information in such a way that you can maneuver through the data masses like a pilot. There are institutions, such as the one here in Braunschweig, at NASA, and at Boeing, at which research is being conducted on a visual technology. In my view, they're practicing media aesthetics there.

Is media theory based on a new aesthetics?

Yes, it is, if you define aesthetics as the "theory of perception." The eye absorbs five gigabytes per second. This is such an enormous amount that the biggest mainframes can only barely equal it. With the eye, one can absorb much more information than with any other sense or intellectual capacity. This means that information processing must be visual in the future, because the eye possesses the potential for processing large quantities of information in a meaningful way.

This kind of research goes back to the Second World War. At that time, Boeing ordered research to be done on what actually happens within the eye of a pilot who is landing his plane after combat activities. The result was that the eye turned out to be an ingenious processor of information, which does not work statistically, but dynamically. From these studies of

the capacity for absorption of information, one can draw conclusions about how images should be generated and which characteristics they should possess in order to be optimally “readable.”

In researching the image, we can hardly resort to philosophy. Hasn't philosophy always attempted to throw off the yoke of images?

The argument in favor of a world without images is that one no longer gets around to thinking and is swamped by images. Ergo: the mind can only be liberated in an imageless society. Images, according to this view, were used in animistic practices and served to outdo the speaker. Just consider the similarity to Plato's Cave story, the first pamphlet against the power of images. Even Adorno's aesthetic theory was based on a radical aversion to images. He even went so far as to say that the aesthetic image is an imageless image, that is, an image that has been divested of all of its image-qualities. One might think of Mondrian and abstract art. This is a good indication of the impasse at which twentieth-century aesthetics has arrived.

This argument can be traced back to the biblical ban on making representative images. The images that art creates are then no longer allowed to be representations. Art would then only be considered good when it no longer exhibits representations but represents only itself. Images are actually misleading and belong to the realm of illusions. Not only do priests employ images to mislead the people; in general, images aren't capable of representing the complexity of reality, in this view. Just consider the famous statement of Brecht's: A photograph of the AEG factory doesn't say anything about the reality of the AEG factory. That was dialectical thinking. Concreteness is only achieved through dialectical constructions, not simply by looking: if I simply look, I see nothing at all.

The remarkable thing about present-day research on scientific visualization is that it's now rationality itself which demands representation, while, until recently, it was assumed that true knowledge was unimaginable: Our reality was thus abstract to such a degree, because it was unimaginable. And then, suddenly, the whole business got stood on its head: In order to conceptualize knowledge at all, we must visualize it, in light of the fact that images produce a higher information density than concepts. In fractal research and chaos theory, one can see well how the computer first produces images that are subsequently interpreted.

Does art history say nothing about images, then?

About art history, one can say that it's been occupied with art that did not produce representation, with realism as the fall. It would be interesting to explore the exact ways in which realistic art interprets its own images as constructions of reality. But abstract art provides us with more, as it's a construct from the very beginning. One can say about art, à la McLuhan, that it has not made any images; rather, it has shown the way in which perception took place. One painted the perception, not the perceived situation. History shows how important the a priori of perception is. That's why media theoreticians don't emerge from sociology or philosophy, but from aesthetics and literary science. They have a better sensorium for the historical a priori of perception.

If we assume that all images will be calculated in the near future, earlier works of art that enjoyed an aura will become electronically readable and just as subject to deconstruction. We'll see how they react to their absorption into the realm of electronic images. The most beautiful paintings were created in a conflict with new media, in my view, eye to eye with photography and film. Painters wondered what the consequences of those registration techniques were for their own, archaic occupation. This is how the deconstruction of their own techniques came about, a shift that caused a new perspective to be created, one that expressed itself in pointillism, cubism, and so forth. It's to be hoped that artists take up the present technological challenge. McLuhan already envisioned artists leaving the ivory tower and taking up their places in the control room. Should they fail, then their work will simply be taken over by the makers of music videos.



Heidegger Online

An Interview with Michael Heim

Michael Heim has been called “the philosopher of cyberspace.” He does not take a critical postmodern stance, nor is he euphoric about the arrival of new technologies. Rather, he adopts a pragmatic view of technology as a fate that human beings must make the best of. According to Heim, there is no standpoint beyond or above technology. Humans are imprisoned in cyberspace and it is up to the philosopher to comment on conditions in this Plato’s Cave. Heim spoke at the conference “The Doors of Perception” on October 30, 1993. This interview took place at Amsterdam Schiphol Airport, while Heim was waiting for a flight to Washington, where he was heading to address a commission on “virtual reality and technologies.”

Why did you use the word metaphysics in the title of your book The Metaphysics of Virtual Reality?

I wonder if I should tell you the real reason. In the United States the word *metaphysics* is not meant in the traditional sense, as it is in Europe, a discipline overshadowed by science. There is another meaning in the United States. There's a whole movement of people who are exploring other traditions, especially Asian religions, which are not scientifically classified. That is often called metaphysics. Some of our popular celebrities use the word metaphysics to describe their interest in astrology and palm reading. I like the word metaphysics for that reason. I intend to mean it in a strict, traditional, European sense. But I also like the idea that it's not all that serious either. I call it "metaphysics lite"—not so heavy, easy to digest.

Do you mean this in the sense that philosophy can no longer be "the king of the sciences"?

I like what Martin Heidegger said, that science should not be far ahead of philosophy, but rather philosophy should be willing to go ahead of the sciences. But he meant it maybe in a way that would set out everything for the sciences. I use it in a much more pragmatic, light way. Philosophy should be projecting possibilities, as part of a team of scientists, technicians, artists, designers, people who are coming from different areas, to create future environments.

My sense of a philosopher is someone who is not a totalistic theorist, rather someone who is spinning possible worlds, conversations, tracks that can be picked up and also coordinating the discussion, helping to coordinate the teams that are creating our virtual worlds and our new technologies. Metaphysics does leap ahead, it puts out a light in the dark future, it does risk difficult questions and is willing to be ridiculous, by being radical, but it does not have the seriousness of a system, a closed book, that is to be followed in a pious way. Rather, metaphysics is also light, it's human, pragmatic, it's willing to project speculation, at the same time not willing to go to war for the speculation.

But why do philosophers speak so much about metaphysics lately? Will there be a return of this term?

The next century is going to be a rediscovery, an unearthing of traditional metaphysics. It will be taken up as ways in which we can try to articulate these deeper questions that are presented directly by our technologies. It was not wrong, that stage when neopositivism rejected metaphysics to clarify, to get anything clean and clear. But now we are facing such things as "presence." What does it mean "to be present," somewhere, as a human being? What is to be, in a human being? Presence as the existence of an entity is a crucial question in the building of virtual reality technology. It is not a speculative question, in the bad sense.

MIT used the philosophical term *Presence* for the title of its new virtual reality (VR) journal. I think we are going to rediscover this vocabulary in a fresh way. It will not have this absolutistic, theological background. But it will still be a thought experiment and exploration that will make the logical positivists shiver.

What could be "Gelassenheit" in this world of choices and options through which we navigate?

There are some aspects in the work of Heidegger that I'm not comfortable with. Because he was so profound in his genius to see ahead, he was aware of the powerful changes that were going to happen after his death. After all, the personal computer wasn't even developed when he died in 1976. The whole sense of Heidegger's *Gelassenheit* is maybe more of a retreat from the things we'll have to deal with.

But at the same time he was also working with Asian thought. He admitted that he didn't know it directly. We are in a position now, in the Western world, to know the Eastern tradition directly, by practice. The cross-fertilization of Western culture with Eastern is becoming a practical thing, not just a "Zen of the mind." It's becoming a natural practice of things like yoga, tai chi, aikido, acupuncture, the medical theories of Chi-Gong. These practices are what might be a correlate to *Gelassenheit*. They are an alternative to the high stress of the mind-brain-visual focus of Western technology. Not like not a substitute, but a complement, a counterbalance. I'm trying to deal with how to build this into a design, into the system.

But I can't come with a theoretical axe and say: If it's not internal, throw it out, it's not helping. Now is the time to practice, and we'll have to be patient and nurturing with these developments and not hope to get a theory

that's going to, once and for all, answer the questions, and then we can implement it. People have to learn over a period of time, what these disciplines have to offer. Only then they will be ready to design environments and technologies that will have this balancing effect, intrinsically, and not be simply aggressive, masculine, Western approaches. Jürgen Habermas would often say, these activities are merely symbolic. I don't think "merely" is the thing we should think about and insist on more. Small practice is a beginning, not only a symbol. It's a doing that leads to results.

Some French and German theories work with the assumption that media are rooted in the logics of the military. One can also find this in the writings of Thomas Pynchon. Why don't you mention the military aspect of the new technologies?

That's true, I don't directly confront that aspect. But the development of virtual reality in the military is not the only source, however. My friend and inspiration in virtual reality is Myron Krueger. Originally an artist, he was working as early as the late sixties, at the same time as the military, developing the types of virtual reality (VR) on his own. A parallel development, it is very different. The military approach is a head-mounted display, a very restricting kind of bodysuit. Krueger's work was obscure and he was ignored, but now becoming very prominent, as people realize the limitations and dangers of the head-mounted display. My purpose recently has been to point out these two streams and see the way each will take us in different directions. But I don't think the head-mounted display technology is by any means restricted to military use. It has very practical applications in building automobiles, airplanes, in directing traffic at the airport.

Virtual reality is a universal simulator, not just a flight simulator. The military contributed a lot in the hard- and software development. This has always been the case, because human beings care about saving their lives when they're fighting. Certainly, we have serious ethical problems about use of simulation in the Gulf War. We sometimes have small wars, invasions, based on experiments, an attempt to try out the technology, by using them on a nation.

But my focus has been rather on the technology as it connects with our culture at large. Although I admire, for example, Paul Virilio's work, at the same time there is a one-sidedness, that some academics and French philosophers can enjoy, because they are not dealing with the pragmatics of the

world. They have a tradition of absolute freedom to criticize life as a whole. But I myself have to deal with a technical, wired-up world, and that is going to be increasingly that way. It's just impossible to condemn technology as a military phenomenon.

In your book The Metaphysics of Virtual Reality, you write that VR will be the first technology to be born socially self-critical. Where do you see the opportunities to produce self-criticism?

We have computer networks that are making the connections between people, conferences, grassroots groups that meet. These have sprung up—most cities in the United States have virtual reality groups. Attempts to get the conversations going about the technology, because the information is out there. These virtual communities are concerned about the future and fascinated by the technology. We have no illusions about denouncing the computer world, this is not even an option or possibility. We are dealing with the pragmatic situation of how we can better shape the future of the computerized world.

I work on the level of national conferences, and I see the impact of the grassroots discussions on the national level. The influence is not formal or explicit. There are no ultimatums or manifestos. But there are words that are put out strongly, that have a ripple effect. The people from the Pentagon and government offices, who are making the investments in the data highways, are being influenced by conversations that are going on in small groups.

Commercialization is certainly moving apace. But the question of content and style is all up in the air. We have a whole generation coming up, who are skilled at interactive devices, that is migrating to this world of virtual reality, where they can develop their dreams and fantasy games. The technical people may be left behind if they don't include the imaginative young people. I don't think the entertainment industry is going to be able to impose the old models of the movie industry. I know people in film theory would like to think that virtual reality will be an extension of film. I think it's radically going to change the way we approach the idea of viewing things in a passive way.

How will it be to have the works of Martin Heidegger online?

There are philosophical texts that are being compiled and made available on CD-ROMs already and they are in the stores. One of my students is publishing Aristotle, Locke, and Hume, among Shakespeare and Homer, on CD-ROM. One of the difficulties that plagues something like Heidegger is that he was very conscious about marginalia and the history of his thought. We might be able to use hypertext to indicate different levels, because right now, the texts of Heidegger are a mess. There are so many different versions of *Being and Time*. So Heidegger was continuing the nineteenth-century concept of a written text. He was trying to date it, by using his marginalia. It's a very understandable approach, but we are now living in an era where the notion of text is in flux. It might be possible to represent Heidegger's text better online, because of the hypertext abilities, to go to different levels, to see alternatives, instead of deciding what is the best edition.

So far, the language of the Net is English. Would you prefer to see a change toward multilingual communication?

I take Ernesto Grassi very seriously. He takes Heidegger's idea of *Sprache* and the originality of language, its poetic nature, not so much in its *völkisches* character, its national quality, but rather more in its capacity to generate new metaphors. I like this more than the nationalistic understanding of the untranslatability of language. Heidegger felt that language had to be imbedded with a national, *völkisch* quality, and that's why it was untranslatable. There may be dangers in machine translations, because not being able to catch the metaphors, rather, that language can shape and create by using street language, for example, to refer to something, in a new way that shed a different light on it. I don't think of language having any magic.

We mix different languages in English. Heidegger seemed to think that there was a purity in Greek or German that gave it an integrity and an ability to generate new things in a self-consistent way, which is an admirable philosophical view, but I don't share that feeling, because I suppose I feel comfortable with English and borrowing foreign languages.

If Europeans think about the United States, they think about poverty, crime, the moral crisis, and the panic state in which this society is at the moment. At the same time there are huge investments in virtual technologies. Do you see a relationship between social decay and the rise of cyberspace?

It's true that we may leave a part of the population behind, as we move into cyberspace. So it is urgent that we articulate, from a grassroots point of view, to get off our couches and become active, as a public, about the technology that's coming. I don't think there is any way in which we can say, let's take our money back and invest it in the society, and hope we don't have to involve any further technologically. I don't know what is the logic of this proposal.

I don't think that the military is driving it all. I think it's more what Heidegger calls *Seinsgeschichte*, there is destiny there, somehow, our faith. We have to go toward something we love, Augustine would say, be driven from the heart of our civilization. We have to be aware of the need to expand the base of technology, to bring the technological human being alive, everywhere, as much as possible, so that we become self-consciously technical, technological beings and don't leave people behind. So that we don't fall back in national nationalities, ethnic groups. We need to realize our technological destiny.

Cyberspace is the next frontier, a place we are moving toward, and there is a certain inevitability about it. I don't think there any way of retreating from it, unless we're going to resign ourselves to a backseat somewhere. We have to face what is happening. You can't chose whether to upgrade your computer or not. You have to do it, even if you don't like it, because technology is something we're getting more and more involved in. Once you've adopted the new version, you realize why you needed to do it. You then realize the power you get from it and that's a thrill.

In your writing you refer to Leibniz and his model of the monad. Do you agree with this description of the current situation, in which the individual is completely isolated in this capsule yet connected at the same time?

What I'm trying to do when I delineate Leibniz is to bring out the implicit logic of computerization. It's three hundred years old, and we are developing Leibniz. He does represent something of what we are doing, like the monad at the computer screen, the windowless, connected part. It's a cautionary metaphysics; it's realizing what has shaped the technology and once we clearly realize it, we are already outside of that and thinking of the richness of our bodily existence. It's my effort to develop criticism by bringing fully to awareness the limitations of the rationalist model. While I was wri-

ting about the monad, I had the speed-driven, pizza-eating MIT student in mind, who's working all hours on his computer, not being socially involved. Joseph Weizenbaum's criticism on this is right. Part of what we do is to unearth the past of metaphysics as our present. We can learn from the metaphysics, but learn from its limitations too, as we realize them.

Michel Foucault analyzed the relation between power and the body. In The Metaphysics of Virtual Reality, there's no reference to the body in the age of the computer, in fact, no power analysis at all. Why did you leave out this aspect?

I had to firmly reject and renounce the use of any theory that could in any way be taken to be obscure. I had to be very careful, to avoid deconstruction theories, because they do not help clarify the issues that can bring together the technical community with the public and thoughtful people. There has been a lot of damage done by theories that propose very complex, psychoanalytic-based analysis, in terms opaque to the average person. This does not help the dialogue that is needed, to make technology an issue for our people and to get them engaged, in a thoughtful, philosophical way.

I sense too, that the suspicion that is imbedded in much Marxist theory, fearful of the powers of oppression, even if those theories might be proposed from within the safe walls of a fortress, in an academic context, cannot work pragmatically. I need something that's gonna help me deal with the specifics of the technology, in order to propose suggestions for the users and developers. Not general fear, not general euphoria, nothing general. I try to deal with electric language, to take specific programs, analyzing actual practices. We have to accept a new role for thoughtful people, trying to help a conversation, not trying to dominate it or scare people, raise suspicion in their minds or cause a revolution. We have to help one another, become clear, understand where we are. Having a group talk together, that's the ideal.



Civil Society, Fanaticism, and Digital Reality

An Interview with Slavoj Žižek

Slavoj Žižek is a leading intellectual in the new social movements of Eastern and Central Europe. His main fields of research are Lacanian psychoanalysis, film theory (in particular, Hitchcock), and political philosophy. Žižek ran as a pro-reform candidate for the presidency of the republic of Slovenia, then still part of Yugoslavia, in 1990. The interview was conducted for the Japanese ICC magazine. The conversation took place in a hotel lounge in Linz, Austria, along the Danube River, June 1995. Žižek had just spoken on the topic of identity and virtual sex at the 1995 Ars Electronica Festival called "Welcome to the Wired World."

I was not going to ask him too much about his remarks because of his apparent lack of insider knowledge about and hands-on experience in, in this particular case, online communities and cyberspace. He seemed to be criticizing film without ever having seen one—a widespread problem among intellectuals in the 1990s who mainly analyzed popular discourse surrounding cyberspace, produced by old media, and not the technology itself. There were enough other matters to be discussed. Žižek's political position inside Slovenia was relatively unknown to his Japanese and Western readers, so that turned out to be a good starting point.

Let's discuss the role of intellectuals. Before 1989, a strange relationship existed between intellectuals and those in power in Eastern Europe. Both bureaucrats and dissidents had some sort of relationship with politics. Even now, this is partly the case. In Western Europe this phenomenon disappeared, and it is hard to see any relationship or even dialogue. What should the role of intellectuals be?

For me what was partially so attractive, so sympathetic about real socialism, despite being a corrupt, cynical system, was the belief in the power of the spoken word. Some twenty years ago, I was editor of a small art-theoretical journal with a circulation of 3,400. Once we published a small, obscure poem, incomprehensibly modern, but between the lines there was a dissident message. If the ruling powers had ignored the poem, nothing would have happened. But there was an extraordinary session of the Central Committee. Okay, this is repression, but what I like about it is that the communist power took the potential, detonating force of the spoken word very seriously. They were always interested in arguing with intellectuals.

Let's take an artist like Andrei Tarkovsky, who was half dissident. He was half allowed to work, even if they suppressed some of his films. They were impressed, they bothered. Fredric Jameson made a nice point about this: We are only now becoming aware that what we liked about Eastern European dissidents like Vaclav Havel is only possible within a socialist system. Our influence, beginning in the mid-eighties, was at that time incredibly large, especially the philosophers, sociologists, literary theoreticians. But this was a very limited conjunction. Now there is the pure ignorance of the regime, which is simply not interested in ideological questions. I feel sorry for those countries in which writers nowadays play an important role. Take Serbia, where this nationalist madness was fabricated by writers. Even in Slovenia it's the same with the nationalist writers, although they do not have much influence.

But you have been and still are involved in politics yourself. There are a lot of controversies in Slovenia about your involvement in the governing party and the fact that you write speeches for them.

There is a messianic complex with intellectuals in Eastern Europe. Nothing against it, but it becomes extremely dangerous in Slovenia when this vision of intellectuals is combined with a vulgar anti-Americanism, which is a very

popular political attitude of right-wingers. America for them means no national solidarity, filthy liberalism, multiculturalism, individualism, the market. They are afraid of a pluralistic democracy and there is a protofascistic potential in their hatred of it. This combination of nationalist writers, whose obsession is how to retain national identity, and an anticapitalist right-wing movement is very dangerous. I did something for which I lost almost all my friends, what no good leftist ever does: I fully supported the ruling liberal democratic party in Slovenia. For this all my leftist friends hate me and of course the whole right wing.

What the liberal democratic party did was a miracle. Five years before we were the remainder of the new social movements, like the feminist and ecological groups. At that time everybody thought that we would be vanishing mediators. We made some slightly corrupted but good moves, and now we are the strongest party. I think it was our party that saved Slovenia from the fate of the other former Yugoslav republics, where they have the one-party model. Either right-wing like in Croatia or left-wing like in Serbia, which hegemonized in the name of the national interest. With us it's a really diverse, pluralist scene, open to foreigners (of course there are some critical cases). But the chances of a genuine pluralist society are not yet lost.

It's typical that this position triggers an enormous hatred against me. Slovene media absolutely ignore me, there is never an article about me. On the other hand, if some nationalist poet publishes a small poem in some obscure Austrian journal, it's a big success in Slovenia. I am rather perceived as some dark, ominous, plotting, political manipulator, a role I enjoy immensely and like very much.

You have not become cynical about the current power struggles in which you are involved?

It's a simple, professional choice. Now politics is becoming business-as-usual in Slovenia. It's no longer that once a week you write a heroic article and you are a hero. It means intrigues and meetings. I simply had to choose. Do I do serious theory or politics? What I hate most are the beautiful souls of the left wing who complain about their losses, that everything is corrupted. Where are the good old days of the original, left-wing dissidence? No, you must accept the rules of the game.

Svetlana Slapzak and the group around her present themselves as marginalized victims. But her groups control two departments and the most powerful publishing house. They get the most money from the ministry of science. And via the Soros Foundation they are selling the story of being surrounded by nationalism. Let's take me. I was blocked from working in the university before; I was only teaching abroad, in France and in America. I never taught at any university in Slovenia, I was absolutely alone, without any research assistant. They just give me enough money in order to survive.

My answer to Svetlana Slapzak would be: why did she [leave Serbia and] become a Slovenian citizen? Her very position is a contradiction of what she says. In a state of less than two million we offered 100,000 non-Slovenians permanent citizenship, against terrible nationalistic resistance. There were no dirty tricks involved, like a test to determine if you knew Slovenian. We are still in an intermediate stage. When a new political logic imposes itself, the *Sittlichkeit*, the unwritten rules are still unsure, people are still searching for a model. The question is: Will we become just another small, stupid, nationalistic state or maintain this elementary, pluralistic opening? And all compromises are worth it for this goal.

What is your view on the work of the Soros Foundation and the concept of an "open society" that it promotes?

If you look into my heart, you'll see I am an old-fashioned left winger. In the short term I support the "open society," but I don't have Karl Popper notions about it. Soros is doing good work in the field of education, refugees, and keeping the theoretical and social sciences' spirit alive. These countries are not only impoverished, but the sphere of social sciences is hegemonized by Heideggerian nationalists. But the Soros people have this ethic of the bad state versus good civic, independent structures. But sorry, in Slovenia I am for the state and against civil society! In Slovenia, civil society is equal to the right-wingers.

In America, after the Oklahoma bombing, they suddenly discovered that madmen are everywhere. Civil society is not this nice, social movement, but a network of moral majority, conservative, and nationalist pressure groups, against abortion, for religious education in schools. A real pressure from below. For me the open society means something very practical: the unwritten rules of the political space. For example, if you oppose the present government or

the hegemonic party, are you then still accepted or is there an unwritten, unspoken stigma that you are a half-nationalist traitor and so on? Up to what extent can you make a career without making political compromises?

I don't have any fundamental hopes in a socialist revolution or whatever. We have several big crises coming: the ecological, the developed against the underdeveloped world, and the loss of the sense of reality in the face of all the rapid changes. I don't underestimate the social impact of the loss of stability. Is the frame of liberal capitalism able to solve this antagonism? Unfortunately my answer is no. Here I am the old-fashioned left-wing pessimist. I think that ghettoization, like half of L.A., is far stronger than the Marxist class struggle. At least both workers and capitalists still participated in legality and the state, whereas liberal capitalism simply doesn't integrate the new ghettos. Liberal democracy has no answer to these problems.

A lot of times, this Soros approach of openness indulges in its own species of covert racism. Recently at a conference in Amsterdam, *Press Now* asked whether it was possible to find a universal language so that intellectuals from various parts of the former Yugoslavia could start a dialogue. I find this cliché extremely dangerous, because it comes from an idea of the Balkans as the fantasmatic space of nationalistic madness.

This fantasy is very well manipulated and expressed in some popular works of art, like Emir Kusturica's film *Underground*. He said himself, in *Cahiers du Cinema*, that in the Balkans, war is a natural phenomenon, nobody knows when it will emerge, it just comes, it's in our genes. This naturalization of the Balkans into an apolitical, primordial theater of passions is clichéd, and I find it very suspicious. I would like to quote Hegel here: "The true evil is an attitude which perceives evil everywhere."

I am very suspicious about this apparent multi-cultural, neutral, liberal attitude, which only sees nationalistic madness around itself. It posits itself in a witness role. The post-Yugoslav war is strictly the result of European cultural dynamics. We don't need this simplistic liberal deploring of "why don't people speak to each other?" Nobody is doing power analysis. A common Western cliché is the so-called complexity of the Balkans. This specifically allows the West to maintain its position as an excluded observer.

What you should do is what I call a phenomenological *reduction à l'envers*. You should not try to understand it. It's like the funny effect when you turn down the sound of a TV and have only these stupid gestures. Cut off the meaning and then you'll get the pure power battle. The Balkans are a symp-

tom of Europe in the sense that it embodies all that is wrong in the light of the utopian notion of the European Community itself. What is the dream? A kind of neutral, purely technocratic Brussels bureaucracy. They project their mirror image on the Balkans. What they both have in common is the exclusion of the proper political antagonisms.

The campaign in Holland, Press Now, supports so-called independent media in the former Yugoslavia. One of its premises is the idea that the war started with propaganda from above through state-controlled media. Seeing that any Western intervention already came too late, it states that, for example, through independent media, one could work on a long term solution. Do you agree with this analysis?

Up to a point I agree with this, but I have always been in favor of military intervention from the West. Around 1992, with a little bit of pressure, the war would have been over. But they missed the moment. With the shift of balance and the stronger Russia, this is no longer possible. At that time, Croats and Slovenians were in favor of independence, and the Bosnians were much more ambiguous and they are paying the price for it. The Bosnians didn't want to prepare for war; they were slower, more careful, and that's why they are now so mad at the West. There was no protection of Bosnia from the Yugoslav army, despite all the guarantees. And then, after the attack, the West suddenly started talking about ethnic struggles, how all sides must be guilty, and primordial passions.

I don't cry too much for Yugoslavia. The moment Milosevic took over and annexed Kosov@ and Vojvodina, the balance of power shifted.¹ There was the choice between a more federal Yugoslavia and a new, centralist one. Do not overestimate the role of the media in the late eighties. Media were allowed to play this role in order for local communist bureaucracies to survive. The key to the Yugoslav crisis is Milosevic's strategy to maintain the power of the old *nomenklatura* by raking up this national question. The media did their dirty work.

It was horrible to watch day by day the stories in Slovenia about Serbs raping us and in Serbia about Albanians raping them. All the news was filtered through this poisoning hatred, from everyday crime to economics. But this was not the origin of the conflict. That was the calculation from the power elite to maintain power. If you define independence in terms of not being supported or controlled by the state, then the worst right-wing

weekly is an independent medium and should be supported by Soros. I do admit that in Serbia and Croatia there is absolute control over the media. What they allow are really small, marginalized media. Impartial, independent information can help a lot, but don't expect too much of it.

In your speech during the Ars Electronica Festival, you emphasized the fact that after a phase of introduction, the seduction of the new media will be over and so will "virtual sex." So the desire to be wired will be over soon?

What impresses me is the extent to which these virtual phenomena retroactively enable us to discover to what extent the self has always been virtual. Even the most physical self-experience has a symbolic, virtual element in it. For example, playing sex games. What fascinates me is that the possibility of satisfaction already counts as an actual satisfaction. A lot of my friends used to play sex games on Minitel in France. They told me that the point is not really to meet a person, not even to masturbate, but that just typing your fantasies is the fascination itself. In the symbolic order the potentiality already gives actual satisfaction. In psychoanalytic theory the notion of symbolic castration is often misunderstood. The threat of castration as and its effects acts as a castration. Or in power relations, the potential authority forms the actual threat.

Take Margaret Thatcher. Her point was that if you don't rely on state support but on your individual resources, luck is around the corner. The majority didn't believe this; they knew very well that most of them would remain poor. But it was enough to be in a position where they might succeed. The idea that you were able to do something, but don't, gives you more satisfaction than actually doing it.

In Italy, it is said to be very popular during the sexual act for a woman to tell a man some dirty fantasies. It is not enough that you are actually doing it, you need some fantasmatic, virtual support: "You are good, but yesterday I fucked another one and he was better . . ." What interests me are the so-called sadomasochistic, ritualized, sexual practices. You never go to the end, you just repeat a certain foreplay. Virtual in the sense that you announce it, but never do it. Even when you are doing it, you never lose control, all the time you behave as the director of your own game.

What fascinates me is this *Spaltung*, this gap in order to remain a certain distance. This distance, far from spoiling enjoyment, makes it even

more intense. Here I see great possibilities for the VR stuff. In the computer I see virtuality, in the sense of symbolic fiction, collapsing. This notion has a long tradition. In Jeremy Bentham's panopticon, we find virtuality at its purest. You never know if somebody is there in the center. If you knew someone was there, it would have been less horrifying. Now's it's just an "utterly dark spot," as Bentham calls it. If someone is following you and you're not sure, it is more horrible than if you know that there is somebody. A radical uncertainty.

You are famous for your film analyses. But can you imagine also using examples from computer networks, analyzing the story line of a CD-ROM, or using television material?

The British Film Institute proposed to me to choose my own six, seven films and to do a couple of lectures there, since I use so many film examples. They came up with the idea to do a CD-ROM, because I write in the same manner: click here, go there, use this fragment, that story or scene. My books are already failed CD-ROMs, as someone told me. But because of copyright, it is extremely difficult to realize and dirty capitalism will destroy this plan. Don't they realize that if you use an excerpt of theirs, you create propaganda for them? But it is my dream to do something like this.

In my favorite book, *Tarrying with the Negative*, I use some fragments of Hitchcock. How nice it would be to have it included in the text. But concerning film, I am indeed rather conservative. At this moment I am working on the theme of the role of music in cinema. The idea is that in the mid-thirties, when the classical Hollywood code was established, it was strictly Wagnerian, pure accompanying music, radical underscoring, determining your subjective perspective. It's a classical case of a conservative revolution. As Wagner said about his *Gesamtkunstwerk* (total work of art): if we allow music to develop by itself, it will become atonal and inimitable.

What I also study are the soundtracks in the films of David Lynch and Robert Altman and the shift from the landscape to the soundscape. With Altman and Dolby stereo, you no longer need the soundtrack as a general frame, as if you have inconsistent fragments. The unity is no longer established at the visual level. I want to connect this with Altman's *Short Cuts*, with its series of faiths, contingently hitting each other. Very Deleuzean: global nonsense where contingent encounters produce local effects of sense

in order to understand what subjective in our late capitalist society means. Or let's take Lynch's biggest failure, *Dune*. Did you notice the use of multiple inner monologues? Reality is something very fragile for Lynch. If you get too close to it, you discover Leni Riefenstahl.

I am not interested in direct content analysis, but the kind of purely formal changes in how we relate to the physicality of the film and the shifts in the notions of subjectivity. Of course all of this is done in a kindly anti-Derridian swing. For us, it is the sound that is the traumatic point, the cry, or even the song. The point where you lose your unity and the ways the self-enjoying voice always gets controlled.

What interests me at the political level is how the discourse machinery, in order to function, has to rely on the obscene voice. What appears to be a carnivalesque subversion, this eruption of obscene freedom, really serves the power. But these are my B-productions, if you want to put it in Hollywood terms. The A-production of the last two years was a book on Schelling that I just finished.

The centenary of cinema was recently celebrated. What's the condition of current film theory? What will come after the critical, semiological, and gender approaches? Is it still useful to see film as a unity, or should we surf through the media, like the users do, and use a variety of sources?

Fredric Jameson has already made this point. What goes on in cinema is determined by what happens in other media. Concerning theory, there are a lot of others, the whole domain of cultural criticism in America is basically cinema theory. What attracts me is the axis between gaze and voice—and nowhere will you find this tension better than in cinema. This still is for me the principal axis.

Cinema is for me a kind of condensation. On the one hand you have the problem of voice, on the other the narrativization. The only change I can think of is that up until twenty years ago, going to the cinema was a totally different social experience. It was a Saturday or Sunday afternoon, and this changed. But what still appears in ordinary commercial films is the shift in the notion of subjectivity. You can detect what goes on at the profoundest, most radical level of our symbolic identities and how we experience ourselves.

Cinema is still the easiest way, just as for Freud dreams were the royal way to the unconscious. Maybe I am part of a nostalgic movement.

Nowadays, because of all these new media, cinema is in a crisis. It becomes popular as a nostalgic medium. And what is modern film theory really about? Its ultimate object is nostalgic films from the thirties and forties. It is as if you need the theory in order to enjoy them. It's incredible how even Marxists enjoy this game. They have seen every film, I'm not joking. It's not only this paternalizing notion that it is good to use examples from cinema. I would still claim that there is an inherent logic of the theory itself, as if there is a privileged relationship, like the role literature played in the nineteenth century.

You have been to Japan. What's your opinion of the technological culture in that country?

I don't have my own positive theory about Japan. What I do have, as does every Western intellectual, are the myths of reference. There is the old, right-wing image of the Samurai code, fighting to death, the absolute, ethical Japan. Then there is the leftist image, from Eisenstein: the semiotic Japan. The empty signs, no Western metaphysics of presence. It's a no less fantasmatic Japan than the first one. We know that Eisenstein for his montage of attractions used Japanese ideograms.

Then there is Bertolt Brecht as an exception. He took over elements like sacrifice and authority and put them in a left-wing context. Here in the West, Brecht was seen as someone introducing a fanatic Eastern morality. But now there's in Suhrkamp Verlag a detailed edition of his "learning-plays." They discovered that all those moments the Western critics perceived as remainders of this imperial and sacrificing Japan were indeed created by Brecht. What they perceived as Japanese was Brecht. Then there is the capitalist Japan and its different stages. There is the myth of nonoriginal Japan taking over, but developing better. Philips for the rich and Sony for the poor. Twenty years later, this was of course the other way around.

Then there is the Kojevian Japan. First, for Alexandre Kojève, the end of history was Russia and America, the realization of the French Revolution. Then he noticed that something was missing. He found the answer in Japan, in the little surplus. If everything only functions, as in America, you would kill yourself. In Japanese snobbism, drinking tea in a nice way, he found that life still had meaning.

But there is another Japan, the psychoanalytic. For the multiculturalist approach, the almost standard example is Japan and its way of *Verneinung*, saying no. There are thirty ways to say no. You say no to your wife in one way, no to a child in another way. There is not one negation. There is a small Lacanian volume, *La Chose Japonaise*. It elaborates the borrowing of other languages, all these ambiguities. Didn't Jacques Lacan say that Japanese do not have an unconscious? For the West, Japan is the ambiguous Other: At the same time, it fascinates you and repels you. Let's not forget the psychological cliché of Japan: You smile, but you never know if it is sincere or if you are mocking us—the idea of Japan as the impenetrable Other. This ambiguous politeness. What do they really want?

There's also the idea of the Japanese as the “ersatz” Jews for the Americans. The Japanese governments together with two or three megacompanies, plotting. All this spleen, this palette of phantasies, is Japan for us. But what surprised me is that authors I considered strictly European are widely read in Japan, such as, for example, Georg Lukács.

Then there is a Japan, loved by those who criticize our Western, decadent way of liberal democracy and who look for a model that would combine the dynamics of capitalism, while maintaining some firm traditional structure of authority. And again, it can work both ways. What I like about phantasies is that they are always ambiguous. You can turn it in a negative way, Japanese pretending to play capitalism, while in reality what you have is conspiracy and authority. On the positive side you see that there is a capitalism possible with moral values.

What I liked about the Foucault conference in Tokyo I attended was that one would expect the Japanese to apply Foucault to their own notions. But all the Japanese interventions were about Flaubert. They didn't accept this anthropological game of playing idiots for you. No, they tried to beat us at our own game. We know Flaubert better than you. Every nation in Europe has this fanaticism, conceiving itself as the true, primordial nation. The Serbian myth, for example, is that they are the first nation of the world. The Croatians consider themselves as primordial Aryans. The Slovenians are not really Slavs, but pretend to be of Etrurian origin. It would be nice to find a nation that accepts the fact of being the second and not the first. This might be a part of the Japanese identity, if you look at the way they borrow languages.

I recently read a book on Akira Kurosawa. It is said that *Rashomon* was seen in the early fifties as the big discovery of the Eastern spirit. But in

Japan it was perceived as way too Western. My favorite Japanese film is *Sansho* by Kenji Michoguchi because it offers itself for a nice, Lacanian reading, the problem of the lost mother, the mother's voice reaching the son, etc. This is the Japanese advantage over America when the mother's voice tries to reach the son. In America one would get madness, like Hitchcock's *Psycho*, but in Japan you get a normal family.

The Balkans is now a region on which the West is projecting its own fantasies, as it once did on Japan. And again, this can be very contradictory. The film *Rising Sun* ambiguously suggests that there is a Japanese plot to take over and buy Hollywood. The idea is that they do not just want our factories, our land, they even want our dreams. Behind this there's the notion of thought control. It's the old Marxist notion of buying the whole chain, from the hardware until the movie theaters.

What interests me in Japan is that it is a good argument against the vulgar, pseudo-Marxist evolutionary notion that you have to go through certain evolutionary stages. Japan proves that you can make a direct short circuit. You retain certain elements of the old hierarchical superstructure and combine it very nicely with the most effective version of capitalism it pretends to be. It's a good experience in nonanthropocentrism. It's a mystery for Western sociologists who say that you need Protestant ethics for good capitalism.

What I see in Japan, and maybe this is my own myth, is that behind all these notions of politeness, snobbism, etc., the Japanese are well aware that something that may appear superficial and unnecessary has a much deeper structural function. A Western approach would be: Who needs this? But a totally ridiculous thing at a deeper level might play a stabilizing function we are not aware of. Everybody laughs at the English monarchy, but you'll never know.

There is another notion that is popular now among American sociologists, the civilizations of guilt versus civilizations of shame. The Jews and their inner guilt and the Greeks with their culture of shame. The usual cliché now is that Japan is the ultimate civilization of shame. What I despise in America is the Actor's Studio logic, as if there is something good in self-expression: do not be oppressed, open yourself, even if you shout and kick the others, everything in order to express and liberate yourself. This is a stupid idea, that behind the mask there is some truth. In Japan, and I hope that this is not only a myth, even if something is merely an appearance, politeness is not simply insincere.

There is a difference between saying “Hello, how are you?” and the New York taxi drivers who swear at you. Surfaces do matter. If you disturb the surfaces you may lose a lot more than you think. You shouldn’t play with rituals. Masks are never simply mere masks. Perhaps that’s why Brecht became close to Japan. He also liked this notion that there is nothing really liberating in this typical Western gesture of stealing the masks and showing the true face. What you discover is something absolutely disgusting. Let’s maintain the appearances, that’s my own fantasy of Japan.

Notes

1. What is Kosovo to the Serbs is Kosova to the Albanians—hence the coinage Kosov@, which can be read as combining both.



Data Trash: The Theory of the Virtual Class

Arthur Kroker in Conversation

Arthur Kroker is a Canadian media theorist. Over the past years he, together with Marilouise Kroker, were often in Europe and made appearances at Virtual Futures, the V-2 Lab in Rotterdam, at Eldorado/Antwerp, and so forth. Recently, they have also been discovered in German-speaking countries. Both are noted for their somewhat compact jargon, which made their message appear to drown somewhat in overly complex code.

Data Trash (1994) changed that once and for all, at least for me. The long track through the squashy discourses had not been in vain. Firmly rooted in European philosophy, yet not submerged, Arthur Kroker had found his topic: the virtual class. The ongoing worldwide commercialization of the Net today produces a new sector in the economy and hence social categories.

Kroker's virtual class appears to be remarkably aggressive and cynical and seems to have little to do with grassroots democracy or public access issues. In today's exploding digital markets, it's grab as much as you can. Now that he has been able to define the adversary in such clear terms, Kroker is understandably thriving. The critics in the media are outraged: Why such pessimism? Aren't the good intentions of the media pioneers for all to see? The rapping Kroker is becoming a nuisance. Apparently he kicks where it hurts.

Kroker wrote *Data Trash* with Michael A. Weinstein, a political philosopher, rap poet, and photography critic. Kroker describes him as "a Nietzschean underground man who thinks deeply about the United States." *Data Trash* is hypertextual, which is remarkable for such a slow medium as a book. It leaves manuals, introductions, and speculations behind in order to kick-start a movement, telling the story of the rise of a new class while at the same time reflecting upon its consequences. This is a far cry from the usual activities of media theorists for whom the Net is still more something of a rumor than of a concrete experience.

The interview took place in a rustic backroom of a hotel in Köln, Germany, where Arthur and Marilouise Kroker were giving a presentation at the School for Media and the Arts (KHM).

How is it that your book can be so topical and reflective at the same time?

My body does a lot of traveling. I like to take deep plunges in the San Francisco spreading psychosis. I visit MIT and the Boston area and I spend time in Europe as well, roaming between Grenoble and Munich, to understand the cybermatrixes. And I spend a lot of time on the Net. *Data Trash* was written on the Net, which means the writers haven't seen each other face to face in five years. We experienced that there was a third person, the "third mind," who wrote the book. The computer had come alive, and *Data Trash* was the result.

The cultural strategy followed in this book is called "Hacking the Media." We like the notion of overidentifying with the feared and desired object, to such a point of obsession that you begin to take a bath in its acid juices. You travel so deeply and quickly in cyberculture that you force it to do things it never wanted to. I try to live my philosophy through cyberculture. For Michael Weinstein too it was an unique situation because he is mostly outside the glowing horizon of technoculture and does not live in the corporate capital of America. He dwells in the twilight zone of Chicago, which produces rough Midwestern thinkers, who reflect on the howling winds of sacrificial violence and the decline of the American empire.

Why doesn't this emerging class have a class consciousness of its own?

If it did, it would be doomed as the emergent class. *Data Trash* is on suicidal and passive nihilism, as the radical Nietzsche predicted it in his *Genealogy of Morals*. Virtual reality (VR) means to us the humiliating reduction of human beings to servomechanisms, or as Heidegger would say, as a standing reserve: the humiliation of the flesh as you are poked and proved and sucked by the harvesting machines of the virtual reality scanners.

To Kroker and Weinstein, virtual reality does not mean head-mounted scanners and data gloves. In their terminology, VR is a whole assemblage of experiences, involving a traditional class consciousness, the spread of the ideology of technoculture, and the

hegemony of "liberal fascism" and its swing back into "retro fascism" as the political force behind the so-called will to virtuality. Data Trash seems the purest consummation of Marxism, the severance of the commodity form from its economic base, into the notion of the pure aesthetization of experience.

We talk about the recombinant commodity form, in an economy run by the biological logic of cloning, displacing, and resequencing. Or virtualized exchange, the replacement of a consumer culture by the desire to simply disappear, from shopping to turning your body into a brand name sign.

Now that the Berlin Wall has crumbled and everyone has left Marxism, Kroker and Weinstein have gone back to Marx for a close reading of the movement of capitalism into the phase of pure commodification. Living in America is not a question of trying to catch up with the media. The body is always moving to the speed of the media itself. Data Trash begins with two fundamental rejections: the techno-utopian stance taken by Howard Rheingold in his book Virtual Communities and Neil Postman's neo-conservative position. On the other hand, it critiques all brands of technological determinism, which state that we don't have choices. There are real contradictions and lots of fractures, even in the supposedly closed virtual class. For Kroker and Weinstein, the field of political contestation is wide open.

Politically, the locus standi of the virtual class is already in place.

Look at Rheingold, saying, in a pessimistic mood, "It's all over in America," meaning that the Internet is too expensive, which is not true. It is one of those self-fulfilling arguments, which seek to displace the Internet as a public institution and to silently justify a corporate takeover of the information highway. There are a lot of conflicts in America, it's not all "all over." Rheingold is here expressing a specific world view and presenting it as the totalizing perspective. But then, that is what ideology always does. But is this class in itself, not already virtual, in the sense of being invisible, dispersed, and without clearly formulated class interests? We have done our investigations in many countries, to try to understand the different class fractions.

How would the virtual class be actualized in France as opposed to in the United States or Canada?

In every case it turns out to be this curious mixture of predatory capitalist and computer visionary. But it strikes us that it is a coherent class with pretty straightforward ideological objectives. It has to suppress the working class. In North America, one should position it within the framework of the NAFTA agreements. It freezes the working class and lower middle class in place so that they cannot move easily over national borders. When the workers complain, then they bring in the mechanism of a disciplinary state, the punitive side of the virtual class.

It's commonplace rhetoric now: They have to stampede everybody on the information superhighway, and every businessman knows that if you're not going on it soon, you are going to be eliminated, economically and historically. And this whole notion has been appropriated by the virtual class. But at the same time it is not a traditional class because it does not operate in the traditional logic of the political economy. The very notion of capitalism has already mutated, not really into technology, but into virtuality.

Our work is a prolegomenon to the study of the virtual class, about the coming to be of a much more sinister and demonic force and that's the "will to virtuality," a deeply disturbing, nihilistic aspect of the culture in which we live. It's about this suicidal urge to feed human flesh into image processing machines, in such intensity, hyperacceleration, and suicidal seductiveness that flesh appears humiliated before it.

In the end you have to choose for an existence as a "honored collaborator," in Whitehead's sense, of technoculture, rather than to not act at all. For a lot of thinkers, the position of the human species as "honored collaborator" of technoculture, is their idea of a modernist position, what I call "technological emergentism." The human species is being superseded by technology. All right they say (Claude Shannon, Marshall McLuhan, etc.), but we still can be an honored collaborator, we can probe around the world, and we can have media extensions of man.

The notion of exteriorization is the possibility of discovering new religious epiphanies of technological experience. We reject that perspective. It is not about "reaching out" but about "reaching in." Human beings have become like the dangling flesh. It's necessary to kick-start the will to virtuality into real existence, after which the human species will be dispensed with, in a kind of waiting time. He or she can do what it wants, because it is not going to be necessary for the operation of the recombinant culture.

Data Trash is an anthropology of a dying species and the emergence of a new species, which is purely telematic. It is not only the story of class quislings and collaborators, but it is against the human species itself. Selling the human race out to a technoculture that exists with such intensity that its existence comes alive as a new species."

How does the virtual class relate to neoliberalism?

The political program of the virtual class goes way beyond the Reaganomics and Thatcherism of the eighties. The agenda of the corporate class is to remove all barriers for the transnational movement of products. The knowledge industry, which is computer based, should also move freely and universally. The technocratic class is not so much conservative as liberal. It stands in opposition to national political forces that would obstruct pure transnationalism.

President Bill Gates and President Bill Clinton have a common class ambition, that is to get everyone on the cybernet as fast as possible, through "policies of facilitation." Cyberspace promises better communication, greater interactivity, speed: A whole seductive rhetoric is offered. Once everyone is on, there's going to be privatization, what we call the "politics of consolidation": shutting down the Net in favor of commercial interest or pay in order to have your body accessed.

There is a big shift happening in the field of labor. Those portions of the workforce that belong to industrial capitalism are to be shelved. They will either be controlled through the disciplinary state, which is cutting their welfare and unemployment checks, or they will be integrated to low-level service jobs.

On the other hand, a section of them can be telematically reengineered to become specialists within the technoculture, privileged people with high-paying techno jobs. They will become the cadre for making the United States and Canada globally competitive. For those whose labor is disposable, funds will be provided for technical retraining. This is being explained to the population as a whole in terms of living in the age of the inevitability of the technological imperative: We have no choice. This drumbeat is being repeated by the ideological apparatuses of the state, to impose this rhetoric as a closed horizon.

Yet to outsiders, this virtual class doesn't appear at all to have an aggressive policy. Its daily work, writing software, seems to be pretty dull and harmless.

A characteristic of the virtual class is that it is autistic. It's an absolute melt-down of human beings into these autistic, historically irresponsible positions, with a sexuality of juvenile boys and being happy with machines. Shutting down the mental horizon while communicating at a global level and preaching disappearance. And why not? You've already disappeared yourself . . . But as the guide at Xerox PARC said, "Who needs the Self anyway?" Privacy for these people has always been imposed on human beings by corporations, it's not something they claim they wanted.

The Xerox PARC of the future is not about copying paper anymore, but copying bodies into image processing machines. And who needs privacy in such a situation? They are not employees anymore but missionaries. Think about the various stages of repression, from primitive capitalism, to the limitation of social choices. None of those limitations apply to the virtual class. Their form of domination is psychological repression. They don't have a clear class consciousness. They truly believe that technology equals human freedom. The tour guide at Xerox PARC again: "We just want to do good for the human race." Yet this is not experienced as an ideological rhetoric. As the philosopher George Grant put it, "They have never learned to hate themselves," so they're not capable of thinking either the worst or the best of human experience itself.

The other mental characteristic of the virtual class is that it is deeply authoritarian. It believes that virtuality equals the coming to be of a fully free human society. As CEOs of leading corporations used to say, "Adapt or you're toast," and they utter this with the total smugness of complacency itself. The other side of cyberauthoritarianism is the absolute outrage that grips them in the presence of opposition. Qualms about the emergence of the virtual class, or about the social consequences of technology, are met with either indifference or total outrage. Quite on the contrary, members of the virtual class see themselves as the missionaries of the human race itself, the avant-garde, in their terms, of the honorable collaboration with the telematic machines.

But when they are confronted with my theory, they immediately fall into confusion and that is what gives me great optimism. It is a deeply fractured

class, not just at the level of social or economic contradictions, but at the individual level also. It is an unstable sign system. As the lead designer at Xerox PARC told me, "I have had my doubts. Who needs all this junk anyway?" This can be read either as cynical piety, where you are aware of what you are doing but it also could mean the first glimmerings of the poverty of the imagination. There have been many members of the virtual class who have experienced exactly that type of deep ambivalence within themselves because they are visionaries and authentically creative human beings and artists. At the same time they find themselves caught up in a flaw, an experience that has a historical velocity in power that they do not understand.

The program of the virtual class is a curse for those who stand outside. It's not even a hostile position, it is simply contempt, for those members of the working class that do not have easy access and who cannot experience the new universal communion. At the same time you see the virtual class shutting down the Internet and it feels nothing but contempt for the lost ideas of what they would like to call blue-eyed utopian thinkers who called for the possibilities of a democratic use of the Internet, outside the barriers of the state. But when they get challenged, they go for their class interests and actually suppress those members of competing classes that stand in opposition to themselves.

The virtual class has this aspect of seduction and on the other hand the policy of consolidation, which is the present reality in which we live. It is a grim and severe and deeply fascistic class because it operates by means of the disciplinary state, imposing real austerity programs in order to fund the research efforts benefiting itself. At the same time it controls politically the working classes by severe taxation in order to make sure that people cannot be economically mobile and cannot accumulate capital in their own right. When it comes to Third World nations, they act in classic fascist way. They impose strict anti-emigration policies in the name of humanistic gestures. They shield their own local populace from the influx of immigrants by creating a "bunker state," by going for a will to purity. In this way it can tolerate "ethnic cleansing" by way of infinite media coverage. The Western reaction to the genocide in Bosnia is symptomatic of this. Cynical piety is one of the real features of the politics of liberal fascism, and Clinton is a typical representative of this policy.

Still, you are not moving into a technophobic position, because you use computers yourself and enjoy them. How can we make a distinction between the goals of this virtual class and opposite, alternative ways of using technologies?

I have to be honest with myself, and it's hard to think of life without computers. I genuinely believe that these technologies, on the base of real struggle and reflection, do offer alternative possibilities from domination, toward certain forms of emancipation. *Data Trash* is also written as a manifesto for the coming to be of geek flesh, a realistic look at the world. It would be interesting to look at the role of traditional political strategies in cyberspace itself.

For example, the notion of "squatting the media" for me is a fundamental point of media contestation and a theory in itself. Just as interesting would be the question of subversive forms of sexuality in cyberspace itself, like what the cyberfeminist group VNS-Matrix from Australia are doing. Try to make the stable science systems as unstable as possible to open up possibilities for ambiguity and paradox and for the reversal of reversionary mechanisms. That is done now through these playful but deadly serious interventions into the media itself, enriched with imagination. It attacks the system exactly in its own language and opens up possibilities for democratic consensus, without in any way being dogmatic.

Squatting the media after all is politically significant, but it does not want to be explicit about it. When Karl Jaspers wrote *Man and the Modern Condition*, he said that the fundamental act of political rebellion today is the human being who refuses, who says no. It marks the end of any hegemonic ideological position and the beginning of politics again. Squatting the media represents a refusal and marks a return of morality into politics. It would be important to take practical examples of subversive intentions that operate deeply in cybernetic language itself, not outside the media but inside it.



How to Turn Your Liability into an Asset: Media, Art, and Politics in Post-Communist Bulgaria

A Series of Interviews with Luchezar Boyadjiev

Luchezar Boyadjiev (born in Sofia, Bulgaria, in 1957) currently works as an artist. His background is in art history and theory, studies he pursued in both Bulgaria and the United States. He had shows at the Fourth Istanbul Biennial, in Chicago ("Beyond Belief" at the Museum of Contemporary Art), in Liverpool (Video Positive '97), in Cologne and Berlin, and at the annual exhibition of the Soros Center for Arts in Plovdiv, Bulgaria. The first interview was conducted during the opening of Hybrid WorkSpace in June 1997, the temporary media lab in the margins of the big art show, the Documenta X Festival in Kassel, Germany.

Can you explain the current situation in Bulgaria from your point of view? For a long time, the Bulgarian communists have stayed in power, after having changed faces. Recently, a lot has happened in Southeast Europe . . . student demonstrations in Serbia, the first non-communist government in Romania, anarchy in Albania . . . What is the reason for the apparently unique position of Bulgaria?

The more time passes after 1989, the more differences there are between each country in Eastern Europe. In the past, Bulgaria had a privileged position, in terms of being one of the closest allies of the Soviet Union. The country enjoyed an almost free supply of raw materials, crude oil, electricity. A utopian situation, having no worry about how to produce and make a living for its citizens. Now, it looks as if time has stopped after 1989. We realized this only recently.

On the surface, a democratic reform took place. A free-market economy was introduced, of which I am not a fan, but which seemed to be the only way out of the deadlock. As it turned out, there is no capitalism, so consequently, there is no opposition to capitalism. This applies also to the social situation. A redistribution of the old money of the regime is now taking place among its loyal followers who are now top bankers or mafia leaders. This is not capitalism, it is Monte Carlo money. Easy come, easy go, no reinvestments.

In the 1994–1996 period there was a full-fledged socialist government in power that had no agenda whatsoever. It supported the infrastructure of organized crime. In the late spring of 1996, there was a severe banking crisis. This government was sticking to the state owned property, lending money to nonproductive sectors in order to hold down social unrest. The result was hyperinflation: Each day new exchange rates were issued, five or ten times higher than the day before, a situation other countries had been through five or six years ago. This situation resulted in a lot of street unrest in January and February 1997, which started with people breaking into the parliament building.

It has been said that the protests in Sofia were inspired by those in Belgrade. Through television images, one got the impression of a large, diverse, and creative movement.

The situation in Belgrade was totally different because in Serbia there were legitimate elections and the results were simply not recognized by the governing power. In Bulgaria there were no elections. People went out on the

streets simply because they could not take it any longer. Given the quality of life, if I can permit myself this expression, you can either fuck or eat. You can not at the same time buy condoms and meat. In those weeks there was a great feeling of unity on the streets. It turned out that there was a new generation of students. Unlike the 1989 generation, the new students are not leaving the country. They want to stay, work, and have a decent life. They are fully aware that no matter who comes to power, they will be corrupt. Like in Jenny Holzer's slogan: "Abuse of power comes as no surprise." These students will go on strike again.

As of July 1, 1997, Bulgaria will have lost its independence. It will be put under the control of the International Monetary Fund. We are going to have a currency board and the Bulgarian leva will be tied to the German mark. It is going to be hard. But ironically, it is a way of having a tangible feeling that somehow there is a relation to the world. All Eastern European countries want to become part of NATO or the European Community, or even better: both. No one is inviting Bulgaria, yet we are already discussing the possibility to join in. There is this utopian feeling that all things will change overnight and everything will be alright. So there are illogical emotions toward Western Europe and toward the rudimentary remains from the distant past, like the former monarch, who showed up in Sofia a year ago, with huge masses on the street, simply crying on the streets. But he never returned—clever guy.

The media situation in Bulgaria seems to be mixed: lots of radio stations, software piracy, loosening control of the State over television, and some Soros publishing activities, combined with a considerable amount of chaos. Is this correct?

Absolutely. After 1989 the student TV program *Cuckoo* made a perfect simulation of a news announcement concerning a nuclear accident in the Kozlodui nuclear plant on the Danube River. It was so convincing that people behaved just like after Chernobyl. This program was immediately stopped. The state channels became more and more commercialized. The few private channels are also not of much help either. The only useful media are some private, independent radio stations. Recently, there was a report on the Nettime mailing list about software piracy in Bulgaria. Out of all the Comicon countries (the former Soviet equivalent of the EC), Bulgaria was allocated the task of developing computers.

Funny enough a factory for hardware was built in the village of our former dictator, just to show how progressive he was. The computers they produced were not of high quality, but there were a lot of well-educated programmers who were not allowed to work on their own programs. Industrial espionage was heavily encouraged, and the Bulgarian spies were given the task of getting hold of software. That led to programmers not working on their own programs but breaking into other people's programs.

As a sort of revenge and a way to transgress while somehow "participating" in the larger world, they created a lot of computer viruses as well. Some of those are still around. That tradition continues: a group of youngsters in the Black Sea coast city of Varna was arrested recently. They managed to steal the codes from credit cards of tourists. They used these cards to order computer parts through the Internet from the United States. They were so confident that they gave their own home addresses for the parts to be delivered. This went on until somebody got a Christmas card from a company he did not know at all, thanking one of its best customers. That's how it was traced back.

What is the current influence of computers and new media on the arts and culture?

It is growing. Recently, three media labs opened in Sofia. In the past it was stagnating. Now this is, again, a substitute for a physical reality. When you have a deficiency of the physical reality, you have some hopes that in the virtual reality you may find some compensations. For example, in Bulgaria there is no museum of contemporary art, for good or bad. One could probably make a virtual museum and appropriate some existing space, make a CD-ROM, a Web site somewhere, almost like a computer game. Video is also compensating for the lack of possibilities. It is a symptom of crisis and of utopian hope.

Now that production is almost at ground zero and the country is bankrupt, virtuality seems the only solution. Is this what you are saying? And what is the role of the artist in all this?

Everything that could be sold is being sold and this is the only way to make fresh cash, as they say. Bulgarians have this survival capability, which is very high. The absurdity is taking place on many levels, not only in the media,

the economy, or the social situation. Concerning art, in the past in Bulgaria there was no dissident movement. The regime found flexible ways of accommodating deviations in the sphere of art. Unconventional art started in the mid-eighties. It was not underground by any definition. You cannot really say that it is backward. In any case, there are not more than twenty-five to thirty people working in the field of contemporary art.

Then comes in the Soros Foundation and its Centers for Contemporary Art. When the Center in Sofia was about to be opened, in early 1994, the Soros Foundation itself had changed. George Soros had given more authority to the local branches. The Sofia Center is an outcome of this bigger power of the local branch. It was established by the local office, not by the international network, Suzy Mészöly and the headquarters in New York.

The good thing is that it has more programs, related to theater, music, literature, not only visual arts. The bad thing is that it was quite provincial. It took them four years to make more relevant exhibitions. Bulgarian art is always first and foremost content-oriented art. It does not really matter what the medium is. The message is one of absurdity. How to turn a liability into an asset. A liability in terms of inferiority, identity or provincial complexes, is turned into a bombastic statement of one sort or another.

How did the artists you know respond to the current economic and political crisis?

They responded in a very direct way. For about two months, we had a special meeting at 4:00 p.m. each day, in front of the parliament. Artists would meet and demonstrate. We used cans full of coins to produce a lot of noise. The big change compared to 1989 is that people, artists included, can change things.

After these seven years of having simulated reforms, without actual change, people all of a sudden became dissidents. They lost all their feelings of nostalgia for the security of the past. Unfortunately that also applies to the word *socialism*, which is compromised in many ways. A new party was founded in the winter and is already called in the parliament "the Euroleft." It brings together former socialists, liberals, and intellectuals. It is a significant sign that very soon there will be the possibility to name things with the proper name. Soon it will be possible to work on alternatives and create progressive, radical movements, without being immediately branded a communist.

Should the World Bank also take over the branch of contemporary art? You have been stating this in the catalogue Menschenbilder—Photo und Videokunst aus Bulgarien, an exhibition organized by the IFA Gallery in Berlin, held in February–March 1997.

Traditionally, Bulgaria has been in and out of its own history, as well as in and out of European history, as if it were a supermarket. The country has always been performed better when it was not independent, whenever it was part of a larger empire, be it the Byzantine, the Ottoman, or the Soviet Empire, or as an ally to Germany in two World Wars and now (it has tied itself up to) the German mark. My only suspicion is that we have always tended to side with the losers. I don't mean to offend the Germans, but I would hate to see this happen again.

There is a lot of interest and the potential for reciprocal exchange. The reason is that there is no infrastructure in Bulgaria. There is interest for not more than two artists at a time. If it is ever there it is stable because it is based on individual artists. We certainly cannot sustain reciprocal exchange. We do not have any infrastructure to speak of. Outside the Soros Center there is hardly any sponsorship for art. The annual budget of the Soros Center is probably ten times larger than that of the Ministry of Culture.

So I developed the idea of having an international curatorial board, to control contemporary art in Bulgaria, like the currency board. It would be easy to fill up an exhibition hall. Then you start sending information, right now the most important aspect: exchange of information. Not necessarily for promotional purposes. Just to keep the communication lines open. Every visitor coming to Bulgaria is influencing the situation there, in a good and in a bad sense. People tend to be disoriented afterward. To avoid this problem, we could have an international board. Would you like to join?

A little later the following text was published on mailing lists such as Nettime and Syndicate:

Culture Board for Bulgaria: A Body for Cultures in Ruin [extract]

Ever increasingly, we are witnessing the phenomena of ruined nation-states, crashing financial markets, and bankrupt governments. So far, this is only interpreted in the usual journalistic way of reporting the political and financial aspects of the crises. But the cultural workers should know better by now. The crisis is only perceived as "news." Arts and culture in this situation are the last to be considered contemporary,

sensitive instruments that could express the “signs of the times.” The financial sector has taken over the role of “avant-garde.”

Let's face it: culture is a prime target of budget cuts and this has become the only language in which officials can speak. Art, by definition, is always in a defensive role and is unable to make demands. So let us quit this culture of complaint . . . We propose to radically face current global economic forces. We will intervene in their sphere. Culture should no longer be left out, condemned to compensate for and be at the receiving end of this trauma.

The proposal is to form, install, and implement “Culture Boards,” which are modeled after the Currency Board—the main instrument of the International Monetary Fund (IMF) to straighten out ruined economies. This supranational body, unaccountable to the electorate, actually controls the government. It is the result of an agreement between the government and the IMF—its sole purpose being to control the issue of new bills and manage all foreign currency reserves. In reality, this body *is* the government because it defines financial policy and steers legislative initiatives. Still, there is little awareness about the way these boards work. Knowledge about these mechanisms has not been transferred to the field of culture. It is about time to change this in a radical manner. . . .

Before 1989, culture was managed as a prime state affair (and so was its funding). This logic changed overnight in the nineties and step by step culture was being run as a business, including sponsorship, self-financing, post-Fordist working circumstances (freelancers, etc.). This is now the dominant (“neoliberal”) ideology. The Culture Board is both the ultimate expression of this, flipping into a radical critique. We can no longer speak in the melancholic terms of postmodernism. Nor do we need a self-imposed (cyber)optimism, selling a future which is actually fading away. We need concrete facts, reports on the actually existing poverty in museums, artistic circles, closed magazines and missed opportunities, encounters with the migrated Others and their remembered shadows.. The motivation and the purpose of the Culture Board is the stable cultural credibility of a country. . . .

Luchezar and I met again, one year later in Manchester, during the follow-up of the Hybrid WorkSpace project, the temporary media lab called Revolting, curated by Micz Flor.

Can we speak of a Sofia School of Contemporary Art? The title of the recent exhibition in Munich, Bulgariaavantgarde, suggests this. It seems that this group, this generation, presents a coherent picture.



It is a group of people that has been working in a parallel way. People from different generations—artists, curators, art critics, and people who are into cultural theory/studies. The activities of this group are centered around the Institute of Contemporary Art, a small NGO that did not have an office for a long time, only a rotating computer. Nedko Solakov and I have been doing contemporary art for the last seven or eight years. And then there is this group of younger people who started experimenting with video and recently computers.

Bulgariaavantgarde was held at the Kuenstlerwerkstatt Lothringerstrasse in Munich in May 1998. We did not want to present any distinct, oppressive identity of ours. We wanted to make it clear that we are transparent, open-minded, adaptive to circumstances, ready to enter a dialogue, without having to impose on anybody our complaints and miseries. The exhibition space turned out to be a space full of light, transparency, and air.

The most significant, emblematic work was an installation by Pravdoliub Ivanov, consisting of twenty-five hotplates on the floor. On each plate there is a pot of different color and size. Each morning these pots would be filled up with water. The electrical power is switched on. Within an hour, the water starts evaporating and a barely visible steam goes up in the air. But since the hot plates are too small and not strong enough, the water never actually reaches the point of boiling. The title of this work is *Transformation Always Takes Time and Energy*. You see something is cooking, but nothing is ever cooked. In Germany this made a lot of sense. The unification has been going on without any concrete results, like a never ending process. There was very little obvious ideology in this show.

This absence of ideology and identity goes well with the current stagnation and ongoing crisis in Bulgaria. Little development or progress, trapped in the vacuum of permanent restructuring, budget cuts and political malaise.

Yes, people lack a perspective on having better lives, production picking up, and so forth. State finances seem to be alright. Renovation of streets in the center of Sofia is happening, in part financed by the European Union, in order to beautify the city. But there is always a strange aspect. The story goes that the old cobblestones have been sold to the city of Vienna, to give it a more authentic touch, while Sofia is getting asphalt. There are signs that police activity is on the rise. Some say a police state is imminent. If people

do not pay attention, it might go that way. But so far it can be interpreted as an attempt to crack down on organized crime.

Most obvious is the disappearance of pirated CDs. You do not see them being displayed on the city squares anymore. The production facilities seem to have been transferred to Russia and the Ukraine. This crackdown was the result of a direct threat of sanctions from the American President Bill Clinton to our president. In a matter of two weeks, Bulgarian CDs just disappeared. Of course you can still get them, but you have to know the right people.

This is the age of Multi Group, a financial corporation with offices not only in Bulgaria. The official rumor says that the founding of this group goes back to the money laundering operations with ex-communist party assets at the end of the eighties. There are also other similar companies. Now the government has to deal with these big companies that are controlling big parts of the country on various levels. The previous government of former communists, which is now called the Socialist Party, tried to get back the laundered money of these groups, which are actually mafia. But they failed. The only thing the new government can do is engage and work with these businessmen making it possible for them to relegitimize their "capital" by bring it back into the country as investments.

Like in Russia, the issue now is how to make a historical compromise in order to get the badly needed tax money, in exchange for legitimization and economical power. So on the whole, we can see a process of adaptation to the so-called European standards. This counts for taxing, the banking system, and the newly established border police. Next year we will have a new set of IDs, driver's licenses, and passports that are made according to EU standards. There are no concrete plans to bid for the membership of the EU and NATO, but they are doing everything possible to make themselves more acceptable. We are all trying to prove to foreign investors and our rich citizens that we are exploitation-worthy Europeans.

For many, the time of expectations has expired. Standards of living for the majority have been declining continuously. Will they continue to wait patiently for prosperity to arrive?

Concerning rejuvenation, all hope is lost. The majority is now living under the poverty line and fighting for their daily survival. It gets especially tough for retired people. On the other hand, there is now an entirely new

generation that grew up after 1989. They have taken for granted that the situation is chaotic. The father or mother may not have a job. These young people are very inventive. Unfortunately, the government does not know how to support their initiatives. It can only control state affairs.

How is the long equilibrium being represented in the mass media? What is the response of television?

Recently, I visited the small village where my father was born, with roots going back five generations. Two hundred meters from the house my family originated from there is a church from the early nineteenth century with a graveyard. Here stands the tombstone for the eight Bulgarian victims of the Titanic catastrophe. They actually came from that village, a story that only became well known after the hype of the *Titanic* film. They must have been males in their early twenties, *Gastarbeiter*, making some money to send home. This story relates to this national inferiority complex. Have we given anything to the world? Yes, these victims are a form of giving. Our contribution right now lies in the calamities. It is not as bad as in Albania. It is a specific kind of misery.

Here, in Manchester, you are participating in the Virtual Revolution workshop. The revolution is all over, and your installation also refers to it. You project an image of Lenin, speaking at a gathering . . .

It is a social realist painting from the thirties. I do not even know the name of the artist. The image probably refers to one of the rallies, just after the revolution, between November 1917 and the early spring of 1918. In the dark gallery space, I capture the faces of the visitors, pasting them into the mass meeting, using the scheme of police surveillance. There is a digital video camera at the entrance. The faces of the visitors are captured in stop motion and then are processed manually with two computers in Premier and Photoshop. Then they are sent to a third machine that runs a program titled "Revolution.Exe," which I have designed with a programmer in Sofia. This program is actually replacing the faces of the revolutionary workers with the faces of visitors to the space, and you can see the new faces appear on the wall. It shows that you can be manipulated. I can steal your image and do anything I want with it.

I do not want to show that you can time travel and participate in some historical event. That idea has already been overexposed. We have had decades of time to dream what it would be like if we had been there. People really identified themselves with the October revolution. Even I, as a young kid, had those nostalgic dreams of wanting to be a revolutionary, getting involved in conspiracies, the underground. These days the organization of a revolution is much more complicated. And there are so many different perceptions on these events. It is easier to speak about terrorism. We can never be sure about the revolution. Who is behind it? Events are not limited to a particular place anymore. It is old news and embarrassing for me to say, but still many Western intellectuals have such romantic ideas. They have missed forty-five years of the discourse, and the experience. It still has not been included.

How about technological changes? What do you think of terms such as "biotech" or "digital revolution"?

Social revolution is suspect, the digital changes aren't, yet. I still have to experience it. Each one of us, in Bulgaria, have a computer of some kind, a 486 with 16 KB of RAM. Recently we, at the ICA-Sofia, got a Pentium computer and free Internet access. It is nothing exceptional. Everyone has to wait for his or her turn to use the equipment. Yes, there is some commercial activity, but we are not talking about that here. We are waiting in line to take part in the digital revolution. From our perspective, it is like a flood that has not yet arrived to Bulgaria.

For one semester each year, you offer classes at the New Bulgarian University, in the Department of Media Studies. What methods do you use, and what are you teaching your students?

My course is titled "Art and Media Space." These are young kids, producing for radio and TV stations and/or PR. I am teaching them how to grab attention and what visual language could achieve that goal, techniques that have been developed by artists, and explaining what has already been done. I am aware that they are going to use this mostly for commercial purposes. What I can do is to put it within a social context. What I ask them to do is to design a public relations campaign for something that has an entirely

negative image. Take the mafia. It shows them that design is not an innocent practice. In the end, it has got to do with ethics, not just about the image that is going to bring a profit.

These students do not read much, they are practitioners. The only thing I can do is to provoke them. They are surprising me, if I am not precise enough about the carriers of information. This they know; it is part of a game they are playing. Their point of reference is techno music. The Brazilian soap operas are for their parents; they do not care about trash television. They will shape the visual landscape, which is defined now by the interface of the computer. Contemporary art, in this context, offers a strategy, a critical context for their future concepts, which might be lost by now.

In the last year and a half it has become obvious that the subject of culture before 1989 was supposedly the worker, which was only a cover for the *nomenclatura*. The working class was merely a projection screen. That was the addressee of everything. The new subject of culture is the quasi-liberal group of businessman and mafia people. A person thirty to thirty-five years old, who has made fast money through speculation, who is not investing, does not own a currency exchange bureau or insurance company. This is being offered in the media as the model to follow.

Intellectuals are marginalized. They do not fit into this picture. One of the concerns of intellectuals is, for instance, to not let the former security state apparatus take over, to prevent them from legitimizing themselves back into normal life, by being sponsors, for instance, supporting hospitals and museums. Members of this class have gone through a process of money laundering and have gained a monopoly in certain businesses, let's say cable TV. Many intellectuals are now opposing the government, because an alliance with this mafia class is just immoral.

Last year, you came up with the idea to install a culture board that would take over the bankrupt Bulgarian culture and arts scene. How do you think people will respond to this radical idea to delegate the entire national heritage to a transnational body?

Bulgaria is definitely not ready for the final sellout. Actually, my perception is that everything else Bulgarians might be readily willing to let go but when it comes down to the so-called precious national heritage—then they get overly jealous. The point that is hard to grasp for politicians and

ordinary people in Bulgaria now is that the main cultural assets are not to be found in the past. Of course, there is a lot there but it has been the instrument for ideological manipulations and it has been neglected, in terms of conservation, restoration, and scientific research, for such a long time that it is only functional now as a sentimental, nostalgic remedy for diverting attention from the real hardships. People might not give a duck's shit if a whole block of the actually functioning state industry (let's say arms production—not that it is good on moral grounds, or chemical industry, or the tourist one) is sold out to private foreign or domestic businessmen under the table and practically for peanuts, but they will kill you if you tell them that the country does not really need and can't really afford to have and keep up another medieval church or a manuscript, let alone a monastery or a Thracian tomb.

At the same time a good theater company, a gallery space, or a library might be falling apart. Actors or musicians, and so forth, might be just starving—no one cares and I have the feeling that this has to do in part with the old mythology of socialist times according to which the “cultural worker,” the creator of art and culture, the intellectual, was a divine being (to be bought for an ideological price, of course). So now, people say—it's just too bad, you had it too good, for too long.

That's the reason for the proposal for a Culture Board for Bulgaria, “modeled” after the Currency Board introduced in the country by the IMF in 1997. The latter is supposed to control the stabilization of the country's finances, while the former would take care of its cultural stabilization. It's on the symbolic “front” that the Culture Board is most likely to operate. And “symbolic fronts,” although bloodless, have seen many more battles, fought for far longer times. Bulgarians have just gotten out of the symbolic battle with the real utopia and they don't need a new one. Well, it's just too bad—they have had it too good, for far too long with their cultural heritage, now is the time for some tough wake-ups.

Again, we make a jump in time, to June 2000, when we taped a third short update. I met Luchezar in Sofia. We were both on the way to the Southern town of Plovdiv, where Communication Front was located, a temporary new media lab for artists.

Bulgaria must have been affected by the nearby Kosov@ crisis. How did you respond to this war next door, and how did you address it in your work?

Bulgarians were mainly influenced on the level of mass psychology. I was not watching television. I got all my immediate information through mailing lists such as Syndicate and Nettime. I was unable to do anything at that moment, I was so depressed. The government here was also passive throughout the crisis. They got into politics instead of doing some real actions, like taking in refugees, thereby taking the pressure off Macedonia.

In the middle of the crisis, I got the invitation to participate in a group show titled *The Other Side of Europe* at the Jeu de Paume Museum of Contemporary Art in Paris. The curators asked for a spectacular project. After thinking for a while, I came up with a proposal that may sound a bit humanitarian. Invite four young artists for one month to work together in the museum and meet the public. They should come from the four countries most affected by the Kosov@ war. I invited Uros Djuric from Belgrade (Serbia), Sokol Beqiri from Pristina (Kosov@), Alban Hajdinaj from Tirana (Albania) and Slavica Janeshlieva from Skopje (Macedonia).

I used my experience at Hybrid WorkSpace, during Documenta X, three years earlier. It was supposed to be a relaxed, hybrid space, with moving furniture and equipment to present work. It took me six months to locate the artist from Kosov@. It turned out that he had been deported to Montenegro and returned in November 1999 to Peja, the second largest town in Kosov@, to find his house destroyed. He has three daughters, so it was a very difficult situation. I managed to get sponsorship from the Swiss Pro Helvetia foundation and its three branches in Sofia, Skopje, and Tirana.

I was invited to participate, as a guest, and turned myself into a host by inviting other artists. The artists I invited started to invite still others, to come to Jeu de Paume, French artists or people who stayed in Paris in that period. Between March 13 and April 9, 2000 we were in the museum every day, presenting video documentaries, video art, until at the end, we hosted also presentations of local artists, who otherwise never would have had the opportunity to show their work within the walls of this rather conservative art institution. It was funny. In the eye of these local French artists, we from the Balkans were the global artists, coming from the international art world.

Did you want to reconcile the four artists who come from such different, opposite sites of conflict? Was it your intention to simulate a civil war, have a reasonable dialogue, and open negotiations?

I knew all the four artists from before. I invited them on the basis of the quality of their work, on their ability to communicate, and on their political views. We all try to disregard the politicians. On a human level, communication is possible. In the space we had to speak English for the simple reason that the artist from Albania could not speak Serb or any other Slavonic language. On a daily basis, all of us had to answer questions from the audience. This gave us the possibility to see all the different point of views, in a combination. The four artists did not know each other from before and had a lot to learn from each other.

How would you describe the position of arts and culture in 2000, one year after the Kosov@ crisis, when parts of Eastern Europe might be integrated into NATO and the EU over time, whereas others will be contained, neglected, and forgotten?

On the level of arts and culture, there are many initiatives to network, such as the Balkan Art Generator, and there is the Balkan Art Network that brings together artists, curators, collectives, institutions, galleries. The idea is to bypass the political situation, leaving aside the European Union and the question of who might or might not be allowed to join Brussels. It is so important to know each other and take common initiatives.

Where is your own work? You told me you are doing HTML Web design to earn money.

With the money from a prize I won in Tirana at the end of 1998, I bought some computer equipment. HTML is just to get some income. I started using Photoshop and Macromedia Director. With it I designed a small computer game that was shown in Skopje, in July 1999, at the Institute for Seismology to commemorate the anniversary of the Skopje earthquake of 1963. *Always Already Apocalypse*, curated by Suzana Milevska, dealt with visions of the end of the world and natural disasters. I can joke about the end of the world, because it is an abstraction, but certainly not about earthquakes.

The game starts with an image of Durer, the *Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse*. You can kill them, etc. But you can also leave the game and log onto a sophisticated Web site of the American government that gives you information about earthquakes worldwide in almost real time. In late July

this show was still scheduled to go to Istanbul in September of the same year, parallel to the Istanbul Biennial. At the day of the opening, there was this huge earthquake outside of Istanbul. That afternoon people were playing my game, going to the Web site and getting the latest information about the nearby disaster. I found a way to go back to reality, via the Internet, without many emotions. Just data.

Now I put my digital works on a Director-based CD-ROM called *E-Face*. It includes this game, some other works, and a new piece called *GastArtBeiter*. For a while I was depressed about the whole East-West discourse, which, ten years later, is still in place. Based on this depression I started calculating how much money the so-called West has spent on me, from 1991 to 1999, provided now I have no money or property whatsoever. I travel a lot, I am quite well known, and I still don't have anything. There must be a symbolic exchange going on.

I calculated that they spent significantly more than US\$120,000 on me in nine years. Per diems, airplane tickets, hotels, catalogues, production costs, and so forth spent on me were calculated based on the documentation I saved. I realized that, for instance, most of the German money that comes from German taxpayers is going back into German pockets. A Lufthansa ticket, a hotel in Munich, and a per diem mostly spent there. There is no progress in terms of communication. There is knowledge, awareness, certainly, but there is no sharing between East and West.



Pax Electronica: Against Crisis-Driven Global Telecommunication

An Interview with Gayatri Spivak

The following interview with Gayatri Spivak was recorded on July 23, 1997, during the Documenta X Festival (Kassel, Germany). Spivak was invited by curator Catherine David to give a lecture as a part of the "100 Days–100 Guests" program and visited Hybrid WorkSpace the day after her lecture. Born in India, she is professor of English and comparative literature at Columbia University in New York. Her name is primarily associated with the concept of postcolonial studies, and along with Edward Said and Homi Bhabba she is regarded as one of the most important representatives of this Anglo-American theoretical field. Her literary analyses and theoretical writings have invariably dealt with the deconstruction of neocolonial discourses and a feminist-Marxist approach to postcolonialism, particularly to the schematized forms of representing women in the Third World. During the summer months, Spivak works with a nongovernmental organization in Bangladesh to organize an educational program for women and a teacher-training course. Our conversation focused on Spivak's view on the global use of new media. I was curious about her view on the "digital divide" discourse.

You are writing by hand?

It is not so much deliberate, but I just can't help writing by hand. One types by hand also. It is not that the hand disappears, but if I start typing, or working on the screen, I am a dinosaur. I find that it disappears from me. I have a secretary, but she certainly does not type the stuff I write. I am from the manual typewriter era. The extraordinary editing capacities of the computer also touch me. That second typing on the screen is a creative moment. It is just not the first moment. Is writing the first moment? We do not know. I consume the effect of writing by hand. Another reason is that I do a lot of work in areas where there is no electricity at all.

Here at Hybrid WorkSpace we are trying to mix real and virtual spaces, old and new media, thereby polluting the clean, bright concept of high tech. We are trying to get away from the autopoietic, self-referential tendencies and ideologies written into both the hardware and software.

High tech is an epistemological constraint I want to escape. That's the secret of hybridization. The biggest hybridization is of course the sexual encounter that you want to escape and at the same time are seduced by. Yes, epistemological constraints seduce me because they are outside of me, while at the same time I want to escape them. This is how the game of hybridization in my life goes on.

Do you consider the computer to be a machine of exclusion? Or is it just a tool?

It does seem to me that in one way the computer is part of an empirization of the desire for virtuality. This made D. H. Lawrence write some time ago that the sexual encounter is the eternal virginity of the soul. To an extent, real virtuality is the imagination, which does indeed exclude. It constantly makes you other than yourself and other than the Other. So it is not as if the computer is alien to the way we are. I don't see a distinction between natural and artificial intelligence. I think that's bogus. At the same time it can become exclusive, an instrument of a certain narcissism, a simulacrum of reaching the other, which is exactly a withdrawal of the responsibility. In a much broader, political sense, it can be exclusivist because of the stratification of the world. But that's another story. Like most answers, what is poison is also medicine.

In what direction would you like to see this new genre of "Net criticism" grow? Is there something we can learn from literary criticism?

I can only tell you what my notion of literary criticism is. The imagination is the possibility of real virtuality. The claims made for virtual reality are sometimes, somewhat empiricized. The imagination is the possibility of being somewhere that is not the Self. This is related to being human, as already being open to a connection with something other. That is what to be human is. Otherwise the infant would not be able to invent his or her mother tongue. That is how the infant begins, by creating a language that the parent then learns, as it were. Through that it develops into a language with a history. That is the synthesis with the absolutely Other that is monitored by the imagination.

You could look at literature in this way, as a kind of machine for the training into relating with the Other. I am not in the business of getting information from the South and then doing research in the North. I teach Marx to Americans. And I do practical work in Bangladesh so that I can learn. I say to my American students, let us now imagine that there has been no history. Nothing has happened, this text is about to be written. It is not that one denies history. We learn to learn from the singular and the unverifiable—that is what the literary is. It is hard to describe because it is a doing thing. It sounds romantic if you talk about it.

I believe that this literary critical practice has connections with the notion of virtual reality, but I don't know what they are. You will have to think about it in your own way. I don't see the literary primarily as a field of expression. I see it as a field of being impressed: *gepraegt*. Perhaps that is one way of looking at the Internet. If I ever got into developing Net criticism, I think I would probably be as eccentric as I am in the field of this literacy stuff. Maybe you could pull me in and see what peculiarity comes of it.

For a country like India, it seems of strategic importance to introduce cybertechnologies. Do think that this has priority over other infrastructures, like roads or electricity, or even over education or food?

I don't think that is a choice anymore. Here in Kassel I will talk about a conference that took place in Toronto on June 25, 1997, called "Global Knowledge." The actual agenda said that the so-called developing coun-

tries should be given preferential treatment. It was all about selling access to telecommunication-as-empowerment as such. There is this picture of a very tall and lovely African woman, in her cloth, with a spear in her right hand and a cellular telephone in her left. It is scary.

Global telecommunications combined with women's "micro credit" is spelling out the importance of finance capital. In a situation where financial capital turns over twenty-five times more than world trade, states are undermined, and the possibility of social redistribution is being questioned, it is a Luddite idea to think that one can stop the world and that a developing state can choose whether to prefer electricity, food, roads, seeds, biodiversity, or primary health. This is not a choice because telecommunications are being sold as access to all of this.

The idea of the Pax Electronica, coming from the Pax Romana, the Pax Britannica, and the Pax Americana is a very welcome notion when one is not aware of the worm in the rose. McLuhan was the avatar of this "Global Knowledge" conference. Both McLuhan with his "Global Village" and Jean François Lyotard in his *The Postmodern Condition* suggest that with telematic societies, what prewriting societies used to have—the oral cultures—will come back. The first world will be able to access the internal, unmediated richness of the oral culture. Not only go back, but go forward. One of the highlights of the "Global Knowledge" conference was a school in Alaska for the Inuits, so far West that if you cross the water you cross over to the East. That is the ultimate notion of the slogan "Go West, Young Man." McLuhan said that today's Third World has lost touch with the holistic view, and in the telematic world we will go back this immediacy.

Lyotard's example in *The Postmodern Condition* is of the Gashiahoo Indian, the native Canadian American. There is certainly an allure here to the post-affluent, superannuated hippie—the walking wounded from the sixties. I got news of this conference in Bangladesh, I was not in Toronto. What was striking was that the mailing from this conference has already started. The so-called least developed nations are already getting the letters. If we protesters take our time, we will have missed the boat. It is no use vaulting the World Bank. The notion that "women are truly stepping forward to an unexamined notion of global feminism through telecommunication" is a very scary thing.

Can you tell us about the work you have been doing in Bangladesh regarding the media situation and the question of access to telecommunications?

I am not connected to an NGO, as the Documenta X brochure says. I am not connected to anyone. Since you can't work completely alone, I am friendly with, tolerated by, a group that is an alternative development policy research collective in Bangladesh. They are deliberately not an NGO, they pay taxes. In the current post-Soviet conjuncture we have to be very critical about this new, rising NGO culture. They call themselves a consulting agency. They produce research that is not government sponsored or NGO sponsored. NGO is not really a category. You can't define something simply by saying that it is nongovernmental. An organization is content specific, funding specific, structure and salary specific, who evaluates, what kind of advisers exist, and so forth.

In India there is now a new category called "people's movement," which is neither a new social movement, according to the European notion of the greens. Nor is it an NGO thing, to the extent that a people's movement must be a group whose work will survive even if the funding is stopped. The critique of the NGO is that in the New World Order of economic restructuring, whereby barriers between state economies and international capital are removed one by one, you need something that can take over the "economic citizenship," as Saskia Sassen calls it, and this is done by the huge structure of collaborative NGOs. This is called the "international civil society."

In 1995, after the GATT was concluded, immediately the World Trade Organization began making the GATT something that could be enforced. In this context, NGOs are not a useful group to work with as they are too involved in the New World Order—in terms of big players like the World Bank, the International Monetary Fund, and the World Trade Organization as the economic arm and, unfortunately, more and more, the United Nations as the political arm.

How does this group you work with look at global telecommunications and at whether access is important?

Yes, access is important. This group I work with brings out a journal in Bengali called *Informatics*. They use the English word in Bengali script. What they are interested in is strategy-driven, rather than crisis-driven, access to telecommunications. Certainly not the idea that simply access as such is empowerment. In the old days we used to say that rights are an

empty notion. You have to bind every freedom to a content, so that in its binding a freedom is exercised, otherwise you only have nonexercised guarantees. When they are exercised you have riots and violence. They are trying to effect the changes that are being imposed, so that your idea of a public space becomes class-fixed.

Can you tell us more about this group? Who are they, and what they are doing?

They are called, in English, Alternative Development Policy Research. They focus on ecological agriculture on a large scale. One of their main projects is the struggle against pesticides, chemical fertilizers, and bio-piracy. Bangladesh has 12,000 kinds of rice. As monoculture is coming in, the farmers are having to buy back their own seed. What they also do is struggle against the international population control lobby, not against family planning, but against pharmaceutical dumping, coercive contraception, and so forth. These are the negative uncertainties. They are part of the Third World Network and are connected to the Asian Women's Human Rights Council. The development of a notion of informatics fits into this.

They are also active on the cultural front. They are profoundly connected to Bengali Sufi: a detheologized Islamic-Hindu combination on the ground, which is very different from either bourgeois secularism or virulent nationalism. This comes through their attachment to music. Also they are involved in the reform and restoration of old Arabic-Persian words in Bengali, which were suppressed in the nineteenth century when Indian nationalism picked up Bengali and made it into something more Hindu.

What I am interested in doing is learning to learn from below. I hang out with extremely deprived groups to see how their children should be taught. I am with the children so that I can find ways to tell the teachers what to do. Now this is very slow work, one on one. I have been doing it for the last ten years. You can't do it by reading Paolo Freire. Each place is different and the teachers are full of good will, but extremely ill educated. I can't do this for long because the teachers, given the way in which they have developed, cannot believe that the ideas that I am giving are any good at all. The workshops given by NGOs or the government are so different from what I say. If they start obeying me, everything will be ruined. If there is going to be democracy in the world, the largest sectors are the rural poor in the South. And there is no other way of doing this.

More and more I feel that I don't want to give time and skill to the resource-rich. My teaching in the United States is no longer filled with the kind of enthusiasm I had during the eighties. I tell my students that. On the other hand it is fieldwork for me, to study the ignorance of the advanced student who wants to do good. I am of course seduced by the comfort and money there, and to have this money is useful if one is as quixotic as I am in the other work that I do. What is also useful in the United States is New York. I love New York, and this is a contradiction in my life. I am a real New Yorker.



Digital Constructivism: What Is European Software?

An Email Exchange with Lev Manovich

The first time I heard Lev Manovich speak was in Helsinki, at the ISEA electronic arts conference, in August 1994. Ever since, he has further developed his analysis of the aesthetics of computer interfaces. Manovich's method consists of blending two rather different disciplines: technology developed within the military and concepts of the historical avant-garde. It is fascinating to see the way he links early Cold War U.S. radar screens with the works of Vladimir Mayakovsky and Dziga Vertov.

Yet Manovich is not just a historian. He teaches software to arts students in San Diego and is well informed about the latest technological developments, which enables him to put the latest gadgets into a larger, cultural perspective. His is a rare skill. This email exchange, which took place in late 1998, related to a debate between us in the *Theatrum Anatomicum* of the Amsterdam Society for Old and New Media, can be read as an attempt to put Manovich's historical notions back into current affairs. What is to be done?

If we look at the hardcore IT sectors, the United States seems to dominate the market. How do you see recent developments on the European continent? For a while, it looked as if continental Europe was determined to become a dusty "history belt," obsessed with its own micro difference, and driven by the passion to deconstruct its own past, including its current projects. Europe is culture and cuisine, but also war and poverty. It is defined by Hegelian forces, still very much stuck in the nineteenth century, despite all its attempts to leave this tragic realm, full of (fatal) grand ideas. But now it looks as if there may be a slow recovery. Do you see European ideas blossoming before the next recession will hit us again? Will there be a short summer of digital constructivism?

It seems that until now Europe was about two years behind as far as the Internet is concerned. At the same time, this notion of "behind" is complex, because in some areas related to computer culture, such as user safety and new media theory, Europe has had a lead for quite a while. And obviously there are substantial differences from one European country to another. Concerning the notion of European software, it's easy to adopt the idea of U.S. software design dominating the world. I myself am guilty of it. For instance, I wrote that just as Hollywood cinema dominated global imaginary for decades, today the United States is doing this in yet another way: It dominates people's vision of what a computer is by exporting a particular human-computer interface to the rest of the world.

But how true is this? Given how easy it is to customize software—think of Netscape's release of the code for its browser—the simple concept of "domination" isn't adequate. At the same time, it seems to me that U.S.-designed software reflects sociological and ideological specificity of the United States in many ways, which is a phenomenon I'm trying very actively to understand. Take computer games as an example: The popularity of the navigation through space idiom in the U.S. games can be related to the traditional U.S. idea that you travel through space to build a character and to find your identity. In contrast, Japanese games seem to focus on competition between two subjects, something that I assume is central to Japanese definition of identity.

I read Internet software as also reflecting forms of social communication that are specific to the United States (or, let's say, specific to capitalism in its most pure form, unencumbered by traditional culture). It is very easy to establish communication, to enter into a dialogue with one person or a group (email, newsgroups, chat); but it is equally easy to exit it without any

responsibility. You make immediate “friends” who you can always “drop” at any time. And this is how social communication in the United States works in real life as well: Contact is easily established but easily broken as well.

If space is American and the play with identity Japanese, would “history” therefore be the European equivalent? Big gestures, dialectics, rising and falling empires, the avant-garde?

History, yes. And also, the cultural and linguistic differences between all the different people crowded together in Europe. So I would like to see a design for a Renaissance interface, Baroque interface, Neoclassical interface. An interface that, on the one hand, reflects the visual mentality, so to speak, of a particular historical period, and, on the other hand, that period’s semiotic worldview, the way “world” is understood and mapped out in discourses in each period. As a design document, we may use Wölfflin’s classic *Principles of Art History* (1913), which plotted the differences between Renaissance and Baroque styles along five axes: linear-painterly; plane-recession; closed form-open form; multiplicity-unity; and clearness-unclearness. Another excellent design document is Michel Foucault’s *The Order of Things*, in which he analyzes three epistemes: Pre-Classical, Classical, and Modern. I would like to see an interface based on Classical episteme, for example.

You presume here that software and interface designers know these texts, have “conceptual access” to them, and are able to freely use and manipulate them, in order to integrate them in their own environment. Do you think it is realistic to expect that? I doubt it. We are talking here about a high-level synthesis of the arts and technology disciplines. Only a few closed institutions can attain that level, whether in Europe or in the United States. Consider Bauhaus, Moscow in the early 1920s, and MIT from 1968 to 1973?

Well, in the United States, all art students during the 1980s (although less now) were required to read Foucault, Barthes, etc. How much they understood and whether this led to better art is another question. In the 1990s, the United States saw a certain antitheoretical turn in the art world; but at the same time, I have started meeting Ph.D. students in different disciplines such as communication or film studies who also are quite proficient with multimedia and Java programming. I would hope that they will be able to

synthesize theory and new media. Do you see any such turn of events happening in Europe? What is the relationship between "theory" and art schools, or theoretical departments and new media?

The specific balances between living theory and true, embodied practice is exactly what makes Europe such an interesting place. It can be fundamentally different every few hundred miles (or less). I do not see this rich culture of confusion (called "difference") diminishing. I am a biased lover of German-speaking countries (as some might have noticed) and rather skeptical about my own country (as are most Dutch who work abroad). I see plenty of possibilities for Central and Eastern European cultures, and not much coming yet from the Nordic and Anglo-Saxon regions (when it comes to theory practice). I don't know enough about Southern Europe to talk about their potentials when it comes to developing a particular theory and practice.

In general, I prefer melancholic attitudes about and around such slips into solid modernity—let's say, a profound ambivalence combined with a clear, decisive expression. A sense of a cultural elitist knowledge with a mission, not the banal and rude style of people who anyway already know the tastes of the masses. This vulgar market way of thinking is mostly anti-intellectual, something I really detest. I can critique conservatism and elitism, but not populism; but it's not clear that it's a sensitive enough approach.

Now, for cultural differences: What would French or Italian or Dutch interfaces look like? One glimpse of this is provided in the works of St. Petersburg neo-academist artists, headed by Timur Novikov. They reject twentieth-century modern art and return to the nineteenth-century models in order to reclaim beauty and academic ideals—but they use computers. Thus, Olga Tobreluts's films superimpose nineteenth-century neoclassical visuality and digital compositing to create a distinct aesthetic that can be called "neo-classical digital."

Well, first, this presupposes that there is in fact a genuine Western American style, which, second, is embedded in and embodied by the Windows (and Macintosh) user interfaces. We tend not to think that way. The operating systems, icons, menus, and interfaces are regarded as somehow "global" elements, both omnipresent in the interface and ubiquitous in computing. That is in fact how the software and hardware is produced: in India, Malaysia, Ireland, Mexico, China . . . Intellectuals, myself included, are often suspicious about a global culture, whether "really existing" or

even possible; I—and I'm far from alone—make a hobby of recognizing which elements in any given situation are local and historical, and the dynamics those elements suggest.

Your point is well taken. But what is local? We can, for instance, postulate a certain “Silicon Valley culture” that extends beyond Silicon Valley itself to crop up in certain places in India, Malaysia, and so on. Would this be a global culture or American culture? What I am really interested in—and I don't care too much how to get there, through theory or history—is seeing really different ways in which people imagine a computer can exist and function; not just different flavors of the same interface but fundamentally different constructions (my call for “national” interface was one way to approach this problem).

In my own teaching, I tend to rely more on history—history of media, art, architecture. For example, we look at nineteenth-century precinematic technologies to think about new ways to do multimedia; we look at the history of twentieth-century architecture to think about new ways to construct virtual spaces; we look at early twentieth-century modernist literature to think about new ways to do interactive narratives.

Next semester, I will ask my students to do a multimedia “translation” of one paragraph of Proust. If different historical periods, different cultures, and different artists had their own worldviews, their own response to the world, how can we achieve this in new media? One way to start, in my view, is by simply copying the best examples from the past, recreating them in new media. In order to reach the future we need to go to the past. This is an area where Europe can in principle lead: It has all these museums, people are surrounded by history, they live—very literally—amid different epistemes, manifested in architecture, town planning, landscape . . .

So do you believe in formal structures, metaphysical constructs that might even exist outside of the technological realm, which we only have to uncover, assisted by (trans-) European intellectuals and artists? Most people would argue, to the contrary, that culture compensates for ugly, work-related technologies. There is a huge gap between these two views. “Only Proust can save us from the Internet”—that's the dominant view within Western elites. But instead of a real fight between these schools, I see a lot of ignorance, arrogance, confusion, and misunderstanding. Aren't you a bit too optimistic about the synthesis of the artist-engineer-intellectual?

The human-computer interface is a cultural language that offers its own ways of representing human memory and human experience. This language speaks in the form of discrete objects organized in hierarchies (hierarchical file systems), or as catalogues (databases), or as objects linked together through hyperlinks (hypermedia). Just as any real artist or artistic style models the world in a particular way, existing human-computer interfaces offer a particular model of the world. I think that in order to imagine really different models we need to go to artists who have already developed such models—such as Proust. Proust also seems appropriate because of his obsession with memory. Obviously, this is closely related to computers, particularly as they are used in our society: The computer is mostly a memory machine that stores our records, our “old media.”

Another reason I would like to see this is the high-culture/low-culture split. Until recently at least, intellectuals and the art world were suspicious of new media because they saw it as low culture. So let us serve them multimedia Proust! Despite new media’s “postmodern” technology (for instance, hyperlinks that appear to deny closed text and final signification), new media are, artistically, completely premodern. Compare, for instance, characters in the nineteenth century with characters in computer games. The latter have no psychological depth; all they do is act—like heroes in fairy tales and myths, the ancient forms of literature. New media still need to “go through” modernism.

Computers make it possible to combine written word with audio, stills, digital video, and even three-dimensional (3-D) spaces—so how can we take advantage of these new abilities to surpass the achievements of modernism? This is just one (negative) connection between new media and (European) modernism. We may recall that, to a large degree, this European modernism in the 1910s and 1920s was a response to American technology. For example, Mayakovsky, the Russian futurist poet, was fascinated with New York skyscrapers; and then there are the Bauhaus artists. Is there something similar happening today, in the way Europe approaches new media and the Internet?

No, Europe is still in an early stage of awakening (see Sloterdijk, Enzensberger, and so on)—it's still obsessed with its own history and inferiority complexes. Economistic views have taken over; culture in general is in a defensive posture, lacking the resources to defend itself on this terrain. All cultural expressions, even the most marginal and

contemporary ones, are in immediate danger of being absorbed into the museum and transformed into "heritage." Intellectuals are way behind in all the urgent current political and economic topics. No one knows if the European Union, the Euro, the immigrants, or the integration of Eastern Europe will work out.

There is a strong sense of irony about failed technologies that are exclusively European in origin. The French sense of superiority toward the United States is so sweet, so cute (and so deeply touristic as well—and irrelevant). Two World Wars, the Holocaust, Stalinism, the process of decolonization, and the Cold War have seriously weakened Europe's ability to come up with any radical concepts that would combine negative thinking and utopian designs. Much too much is still about containment, regulations, the ballast of the past, whether it is fascism, the burned-out sixties, or the divestitures of the neoliberal 1980s and 1990s (a period whose damage still needs to be investigated).

All we can do for now is profit from all the failures and miseries of the past and the present. I strongly believe that we have a period of (digital) modernism ahead of us—if we approach it positively. We have to try; I'm not afraid of avant-gardism. It's time to close the chapter of postmodernism. Everything has come to an end, even the twentieth century—that was never a secret. Still, the world keeps on turning, and we have numerous new recessions and crises ahead of us. So let us welcome them and sharpen our analytical tools so that we can act accordingly once the "integral accident" (Virilio) happens. What we need is an early warning system, built into the systems and architecture—a scanner program. That would be postideological Euro-software.

Do you mean "scanner" in the sense of scanning for the future, or in the sense of scanning and filtering for U.S. biases in the software? A kind of ideological filter through which you can put, say, Microsoft Office, and get back to Amsterdam coffee-house culture? But what would this filter do?

I meant scanning in the sense of detecting, with a built-in critique mode. Suspicious of any sort of "goodwill," exploring and testing all sort of bugs and holes in the system, enjoying all forms of imperfection, silly sales talk, and the poverty of office culture.

Like you, I also believe in digital modernism or avant-gardism. Let me try to explain how I understand it. I'll begin with a question. To what extent

can the computer revolution be compared to the modernist revolution in the beginning of the twentieth century? During this revolution, all key modern visual communication techniques were developed: photo and film montage, classical film language, surrealism, the use of sex appeal in advertising, modern graphic design, new typography.

But no fundamentally new approaches emerged after the 1920s; we are still using the same techniques, and the shift to computer media has not brought with it any new ones. Why? More generally, if historically each cultural period (Renaissance, Baroque, and so on) brought with it a new expressive language, why is the computer age satisfied with using the language of the previous period? Part of the answer is that with new media, modernist communication techniques acquire a new status. The techniques developed by the artistic avant-garde of the 1920s became embedded in the commands and interface metaphors of computer software. In short, the avant-garde vision was materialized in a computer.

All the strategies developed to awaken audiences from a dream existence of bourgeois society (constructivist design, new typography, avant-garde cinematography and film editing, photomontage) now define the basic routines of postindustrial society—that is, the interaction with a computer. 3-D visualization, windows, “cut and paste,” and hyperlinking: These are all examples of the transformations of avant-garde techniques into the techniques of human-computer interface.

Does new media, just as postmodern culture in general (such as MTV), simply naturalize the old, modernist European avant-garde? No, but it does introduce an equally revolutionary set of communication techniques. The new avant-garde is quite different from the old. The old avant-garde came up with new forms, new ways to represent reality, and new ways to see the world. The new avant-garde is about new ways of accessing and manipulating information. Its techniques are hypermedia, databases, image processing, search engines, data mining, and simulation. The new avant-garde is no longer concerned with seeing or representing the world in new ways but, rather, with accessing and using previously accumulated media in new ways. In this respect, new media is postmedia or supermedia: it uses old media as its primary material.

Aren't your California students protesting when they hear you making these statements? Do they believe in the “digital revolution” and all the Wired, Third Wave,

Long Boom talk? It seems rather confrontational to admit that the entire U.S. computer industry is merely a child of the European crisis of values that occurred during and immediately after World War I. Isn't the twentieth century the "American century"? Isn't its "genius" to use some odd ideas to make a quick buck? Why is the (secret) history of concepts so important? Why not admit that there is indeed an American hegemony, or imperialism—especially in the military and finance, two fields in which computer networks play such a key role?

I would not say that the entire U.S. computer industry is merely an extension of European modernism—I am merely drawing a connection between modernism and the features of human-computer interface. The industry as a whole of course came about in the course of the Cold War, and most computer technologies were developed for military use (this is documented in Paul Edwards's *The Closed World*, The MIT Press, 1996). In my own forthcoming book, I will also be discussing the military origins of computer imaging: image processing, computer vision, 3-D graphics.

In a recent conference I organized at my university, I juxtaposed Dziga Vertov's *Man with a Movie Camera* with a tape of real-time computer graphics for military simulators (Evans and Sutherland, United States, early 1990s). Military and flight simulators had been one of the main applications of real-time 3-D photorealistic computer graphics technology in the 1970s and the 1980s, thus determining to a significant degree the way this technology developed. One of the most common forms of navigation used today in computer culture—flying through spatialized data—can be traced back to simulators representing the world from the viewpoint of a military pilot.

Thus, from Vertov's mobile camera we move to the virtual camera of a simulator, which, with the end of the Cold War, became an accepted way to interact with any and all data—the default way of encountering the world in computer culture. This is just one example of how the European avant-garde, the Cold War, and current human-computer interfaces can be linked together. Why not say that the trajectory that leads to Silicon Valley begins at Bauhaus, and that in this sense all software is European software?

Isn't that a very bold Eurocentric idea? Wouldn't it be better to be radically different, to not imitate America and instead work with different premises?

When I arrived in the United States from Moscow in 1981, I soon discovered that there are basically two cultures here: mass culture, which follows scripts and stereotypes, and a small, academic, New York-based high culture. There was very little in the middle. In contrast, my sense of Europe was that it had a much larger middle stratum.

So what happened over the next two decades? It is often noted that the 1990s have been a decade of global business, of corporations—that's where all the cultural action seems to be. At least this is the view one gets from the United States. Does this mean that experimental highbrow culture is over, and that clichés have triumphed? I don't think so. What actually happened during these decades is that mass culture became much more sophisticated: It incorporated much experimental energy. From editing music videos to Baroque aesthetics of graphic design to Web sites, contemporary mass culture is not what is used to be. When Peter Greenaway's *Pillow Book* plays at your local multiplex, you have to realize that something very fundamental has happened.

So how does this relate to software? This is an interesting moment because computer products are finally beginning to follow the logic of the rest of consumer culture. In other words, product differentiation now relies on styling. Presently, this is beginning to happen very explicitly with hardware: If you pay \$2000, you are going to get pretty much the same system, regardless of the manufacturer—so styling has to be the key. The success of Sony laptops and the iMac illustrates this very well. But this process hasn't happened to software yet. However, it's not hard to imagine that in a few years I will buy a particular word processor—and will pay extra—because of the styling of its interface.

Can this be an opportunity for European software? Imagine interfaces designed by Scandinavian designers or Italian industrial designers. Or an interface by Prada! On another level, as software becomes an important part of culture, are we going to see the emergence of "middle culture" software based in Europe? Today we have "mass culture" software (Microsoft Office, etc.) and maybe "high culture" software—for example, tools used by hackers and programmers. Can we imagine "middle culture" in software, an equivalent of "art house" cinema? Just as Europe gave us Fellini and Greenaway, can it give us "art house" interfaces and programs themselves? (I'll be the first one to buy them . . .)

Sure—I could see that happening under the rubric of a “democratization of software.” Let’s think about the dynamics we now see, and how they could feed into such a development. For example, people find meeting and negotiation culture disgusting these days—consensus is tired as hell. There is an organized and staged willingness to do anything, something, a simulated decisiveness. But at the same time ambivalence is on the rise. We can overcome both bold gestures and numbed consumerism.

I strongly believe in public-access initiatives, a lot of small, diverse media labs and a high dose of activism, craziness, and freedom. Business will not provide this, and neither will big, lame institutions. Perhaps something might change through the magical word education. Still, most creative energies are being absorbed or sublimated into fashion, techno, image-driven industries, these kinds of things. It’s only a matter of time before it jumps on software itself. And I can’t wait.

Yes, that’s a very good way to put it. I do hope that the new generation of students who are growing up with computers will use them as a true medium for the cultural expression of the generation—but not simply to make videos, arrange music, or design clothes—but, rather, to design software and interfaces themselves. In other words, they might express themselves through software design the way previous generations expressed themselves through books and movies.

Lev’s Postscript: Human Computer Interface and Contemporary Style

In my exchange with Geert Lovink, I called for Europeans to bring high style to the human computer interface (HCI), creating Prada and Versace interfaces, and/or “art house” interfaces (Fellini, Greenaway). This was a mistake! Let me try to correct this. The current HCI is really three generations behind other areas of consumer culture. So we are not ready for Prada on the desktop yet. Let us review the history of modern design (and society) to see why this may be the case. This history can be conveniently narrated as three dialectical stages.

Stage 1 [Thesis]

Modern design is born together with a consumer society in the 1920s. It was also the way to let the people swallow the ugly but economical industrial objects. “Form follows function” was the ideology to do this. At the same time, the 1920s and the few decades that followed were characterized by mass societies: uniformity in ideol-

ogy, lifestyle, ideas. Ford car in the West, Red flag in the East. In other words, every citizen got the same design (both for her objects and ideas). As Henry Ford put it, one can have a model T in any color as long as it is black.

Stage 2 [Antithesis]

Breakup of mass societies. From a single choice to multiple choice. Individualization that begins in the 1960s and reaches its extreme in the 1980s. By the 1980s we got designer labels, extreme individualization, theatricalization of subjectivity. In short, everybody trying to look different. In fashion this is Gucci and Versace (the latter, not surprisingly, is the darling of Russians, who are still psychologically recovering from the mass society era).

Stage 3 [Synthesis]:

The previous stage got too much, so the 1990s brought “no-style” style—a refusal to wear recognizable labels, to stand out, to be a [consumer] subject. As the article in the (December 13, 1998) *New York Times* magazine puts this, “they [the new generation] reject exposing the subjectivity that is revealed when one piece of stuff is preferred to another . . . The private living space has taken on the guise of objectivity: neutral, value-free, as if this were a found space, not an impeccably designed one. The world outside, meanwhile, has become subjectified, rendered into a changing collage of personal whims and fancies” (66). Nicely put. (Although in theory one should not wear designer gloves at all, third stage does have its own designers such as Helmut Lang. Or look at the postindustrial, post-hi-tech, post-cozy interiors promoted by *Wallpaper* magazine.)

Now let’s apply this to human computer interfaces. They seem to belong to the era of mass society [1920–1950s], before the 1980s and the 1990s: General Electric TV soaps, Communist Party logos stamped everywhere. Every computer user is looking at the same icons and is greeted by the same Windows logo every time the machine is started. The little customization you can do (“Customize my Desktop . . .”) only renders the monolithic design more obvious. Sure, in communist high school the girls could vary the length of their skirts a few inches.

So, when I called in my dialogue with Lovink for Prada interfaces I wanted to bring HCI into the 1980s. But the real question is: Just as communists thought that it may be possible for a society to jump from a feudal

system into communism, bypassing capitalism, can HCI design jump directly from the 1930s into the 1990s? Or maybe even 2000s?

What would a “no-design,” antisubjectified interface look like? Like Shulgin’s and Jodi’s Web pages from the “golden era” of “Net art” (1995–1997)? Yet, the Jodi interface pretty quickly became a label, now to be found on Web art sites everywhere. Shulgin almost became a label with Form Art, although recently he took a dramatic route escaping from net.art into music. And while we are on the subject, what is this business with everybody having their own *individual*, subjectified Web page? 1980s resistance to 1930s Microsoft Empire? Can’t we do better?



“We no longer collect the carrier but the information”: On Movements, Archives, and Media Memory

An Interview with Tjebbe van Tijen

In Amsterdam, the archives of whoever ventures into the field of politics and culture will sooner or later end up with Tjebbe van Tijen. For many people he is the embodiment of storage mania. How the movements of the sixties stored their data and the consequences thereof for the current image generation are the central questions in this interview. Van Tijen was trained as a sculptor and took part in the happenings of the mid-1960s in Milan, Paris, and London. Later he was active in squatter and local community groups in Amsterdam, particularly in the Nieuwmarkt area, during the actions against the building of the Metro.

What sort of storage media did movements use in and around the sixties, and what is left of this in the archives?

In the more traditional club life, the secretary took care of the correspondence, the members' card index, and the financial administration and kept notebooks for checking the distribution; many of these have been preserved. Magazines have also survived, but other action-group publications will not be found properly filed in the archives from the moment they were delivered in banana boxes. And there are hardly any posters at all. Any surviving sound tapes were used for taking minutes, not for the radio. Photographic documentation is very rare. Printing photos was expensive, the possibilities of reproduction were rather limited. From the graphics point of view, a magazine like *Provo* was not quite what people led you to believe later. People attribute all kinds of qualities to *Provo*, such as fantastic design. It sounds like a sort of childhood memory, "this enormous tree in the garden at home."

What was really experimental in those days—for instance, *Ontbijt op Bed* (Breakfast in Bed) from Maastricht—is given less attention. The work of photographers involved in these movements could not be published by their own press facilities. Most of that work gathered dust on the shelves. Well-known was a *Provo* photo exhibition, with a riot breaking out and more photos being taken. Not until the arrival of offset printing did the quality of reproduction improve. Before that there was only lead type or stencil. A primitive intermediate form was the liquid duplicator on an alcohol base, with those blue letters.¹ The aesthetic style was largely determined by the budget.

Later came the photocopy, which originally was a real photographic process. Of course everybody kept newspaper clippings; that was regarded as documentation. Not the action itself, but the report of it made by others is preserved—and that still happens today. People do not seem to be aware of the nature of the source. The reflection of things in the bourgeois press is regarded as documentation on their own movement. But where is the primary source? The registration of the events themselves, that is hard to come by. Someone can write things down—journalists do that. Sometimes there are minutes of meetings, there might be literary impressions, photos, and sound recordings, and sometimes a drawing. Film was too expensive.

Cinéclub showed films, but only later did they produce films themselves. There were hand-wound cameras, from the time of the American army.

These films were almost always silent, because the sound had to be recorded separately. It was difficult and expensive to synchronize sound and image. The later advance of the tape recorder meant a breakthrough, but it was mainly used to record the proceedings of meetings. This kind of sound quality was not good enough for radio broadcast.

When did you start your collection?

In 1967 I started a project together with Robert Hartsma, for a "documentation center for art, technology and society." That was when I first began to record my own actions and those of others. We began with an investigation into what people were involved in that kind of thing in the Netherlands. With the arrival of the action groups, the idea of exchanging networks, addresses, and magazines, a federative alliance without organization from above, was also conceived. I called myself a "cultural coordinator" in those days.

During that period, when I was collecting material for the Stedelijk Museum, a movement sprung up in the United States, England, and Germany, for a critical university that distributed educational texts, reprints from magazine articles, on stencil. Theodor Adorno, Max Horkheimer, and Herbert Marcuse were not available in book form. Around that same time the first press analyses also appeared, the first individual attempts to do something with the clippings on, for example, Vietnam and the Olympics in Mexico. The Nieuwmarkt (Stop-the-Metro) actions brought about an organized form of information distribution. There was a stencil system so that pamphlets could be redistributed.

The more people became involved in this action, the more need there was to fall back on one of the hundreds of pamphlets, something which is now done on the photocopier. Other media were also used, such as pirate radio stations like Sirene and Radio Mokum, a Cinéclub film, or an answering machine that gave the latest news every day. We developed a love-hate relationship with the established media. Should we steer clear of them altogether and build our own structures, or join them?²

The time when the sixties were linked with political disillusion is over. Now it's the flower-power image that comes to the forefront. Was it typical of that time, that intermingling of politics and culture?

The movements of those days, such as Ban the Bomb, Provo, the Vietnam movement, cannot simply be pigeonholed. The same people were often involved in various groups at the same time. The Diggers, radical anticapital groups, set up Fantasio, which ended up a quarter of a century later in courses in "spiritual management" at the Kosmos building. In the summer of 1967, flower power was a short-lived melting pot in which politics and culture seemed to blend together. Provo, the political movement, was disbanded, there were speakers' corners, love-ins, and demonstrations against the war. You saw flowers drawn on Vietnam movement pamphlets, which was something new and which never returned, and the Young Socialists also replaced their clenched fist with flowers. Then came all those young tourists visiting Amsterdam, sleeping on the Dam and in the Vondelpark, all looking for a paradise that no longer existed.

For the media it is now too complex to visualize. People organized alternative kinds of concerts, with films being mixed up together, slide projections and acts, multi-media avant la lettre. Throughout the Netherlands there were Provadya clubs. There were liquid projections, an 8mm film was running, and people were fiddling about on instruments—all at the same time. There were no rules for happenings; everybody could join in, truly interactive events, totally different from the neat performance art at art galleries and museums later. The arrival of the first Sony portapacs meant a breakthrough, because you could immediately play back what you had recorded. Film was a slow process; moreover, copies were expensive. Before the portapacs, around 1968, this problem was solved by showing rushes.

An example of this is the French Film *La reprise du travail chez Wonder*, a discussion at the entrance of a battery plant at the moment when the workers went back to work after the great strike. Just one take, recorded on one reel of film, unedited. To us, this was a revelation. There had already been experiments with the medium itself, for example, at the Amsterdam Kriterion cinema during the Cinestud festival. In 1966 the theater showed a film made without a lens and scratched into the soundtrack. We knew about this from the Canadian artist McLaren, who painted directly onto film and went much further than action painting. This developed into expanded cinema. Toward the end of Provo, the happening left the street and moved into what was to be the forerunner of Paradiso, a derelict theater made available by the city authorities, the Apollo Cinema in the Haarlemmerstraat.

There, Remko Scha stretched pieces of string across, while I ironed law books and made a continuous drawing.

Not much later, art and politics drew apart again, and ideology took over in the various camps. Maoism had great appeal for many radical Catholics, because of its anticultural attitude. At the same time, criticism arose of the fast developing commercialization of alternative culture. From that time on, the discussion became mainly focused on the question of the price of tickets for the great festivals still to come. There were always groups trying to get in for free, and then the fighting starts, which is still happening today.

Who holds the copyrights from the sixties?

For the photos, it's the photographers, photo archives, and press agencies. There is still a lot of material with the makers themselves, and also partly in archives, notably the totally inaccessible broadcasting archives of the NOB (Dutch Broadcasting Facilities Company). I am now working on an inventory of photos from the sixties in the Netherlands. Not as a book, because that would only hold two hundred photos, but on videodisc, which can contain tens of thousands of stills. What is important to me is variety. But it is hard to get started. The copyright has become obsolete, which is why they are fighting so hard to hold on to it. They are selling photos of people who have no say in it at all. Thanks to one-hour [film processing] services, the volume of private photography has smoothly increased; yet the public photo is made impossible by copyrights.

It's a hopelessly schizophrenic situation. You cannot obtain video copies from institutions, but you can tape them free from the TV. It's a mystery to me why the broadcasting companies do not bring out their programs on video, at a reasonable price. There are all kinds of property restrictions and falsehoods about the money that programs could make, so that things stay on the shelves. We are cut off from a large part of our own culture, and we were already used to that from the museums, which show only about 5 percent of their collections. Curators, and that includes me, are prison guards who occasionally give some of their inmates an airing.

We are still living in the eighteenth century: Others are still making choices for us. The makers must be just as schizophrenic; to make a living, they have to defend their own copyright, while they have to undermine the copyright of others to make compilations. In this polity, the economy can-

not admit that it is unimportant that one specific person is the maker. After all, throughout the ages, a large part of the products of culture have been compilations and refigurations of earlier expressions. Admittedly, slowly you see a kind of proliferation taking place, a demassification of the media. From a sowing culture (broadcasting), we are moving toward an individual planting culture (narrow casting).

Do you think you can detect growing skepticism among the present movements about the overwhelming storage possibilities?

As it becomes easier and technically better, the number of people who register events is growing so fast that the moment itself evaporates into it; nothing remains of the thing itself. The staging serves the registration. It has to do with the ritualistic motions you have to go through to get into the media. You have to do something strange, come up with a twenty-yard loaf of bread, hang from a tower on a lifeline, to get your message on some social evil into the press. Later generations will die of laughter thinking of the way this worked. The information itself is not important, we have to come up with a deviant performance. This ceremony is so deeply rooted that it is also being used when media coverage is not the direct goal.

You can compare it to other cultures, where they have special dances to drive out evil. The difference is that we do not see the way we demonstrate, the places where we hang up our signs, our smearing things with paint, as part of our folklore. So the funny thing is that while the volume of equipment has increased, so have the restrictions. The cheaper the possibilities of registration, the more reason there is for it to disappear. As with other archives, the IISG [International Institute for Social History] was rather reluctant to collect material from the sixties and later.

Why do archives still concentrate on the period before World War II?

Cultural storage institutions, such as museums, archives, and libraries, are always based on existing categorizations, both thematic and geographical. What they do is to condense historical material according to conventional criteria. When society changes, these categorizations are no longer valid and new phenomena develop that do not fit into the policies and are therefore not collected. At the university library, I wanted a department that was not

tied to disciplines but concentrated on the latest phenomena. In the prosperous seventies and the early eighties I had such a department, but because it did not fit into the traditional UL [university library] categorization, it fell victim to the first round of cutbacks. While all manner of historical departments were maintained, the topical and future-oriented was nipped in the bud.

In the picture we have of the twentieth century, the sixties represent a crucial phase of change. Do you expect that one day there will be an institute that applies itself specifically to that subject?

All those documents of and about an era, made accessible by lists, card indexes, computer catalogues, together with material facilities such as tins, files, boxes and cupboards and all kinds of reading equipment, constitute a "time machine." This is where later generations will produce an interpretation of their past, which in turn will be added to the rising flood of information flowing out into an interminable ocean. The primary information sources from the era itself are always the most important. Retrospective reviews often reveal more about the time in which they are written than about the time they deal with. Most of all it takes detachment, distance, to summarize an era, to recount it, which is after all the essence of history. Usually it's distance in time, sometimes it's distance because an outsider has a refreshing outlook on things.

Most confusing is the period shortly after what is regarded as an era in itself, the obligatory retrospection, ten years, twenty-five years later . . . Everyone seems to be able to write effortlessly, with a minimum of consultation of primary sources, about events they have after all witnessed themselves, or about which a friend tells such amusing stories. So a wave of superficial reviews of the sixties should about now be upon us. Institutes involved in collecting material from the sixties are, for example, the American university libraries, with about ten special collection departments, the BDIC in Nanterre (France), the Biblioteca Feltrinelli in Milan, and Libri Proibiti in Prague. There are other specialized collections in the fields of pop culture, women's lib, and the peace movements. At the moment there are many small archive and documentation centers. We have recently conducted a study of them, and we counted an estimated five thousand archives of some substance and significance.³

Already in the early seventies, there were ideas about the desirability of the universal accessibility of information that had a direct link with underground media such as *The Whole Earth Catalogue* and magazines such as *Radical Software*. People are storing material on computer networks or parts of them, but without well-defined plans for long-term conservation. The fact that some documents are distributed collectively on the Net still doesn't mean that they will be collectively retrieved later. This is true of the block print bibles from the late Middle Ages to today's pulp literature.

Conservation is more than simply downloading gigabytes of information onto a more durable carrier; it also means finding solutions for the uncovering of hundreds of thousands of messages, so that the fisherman in this ocean of information can also catch something edible in his nets. Tools such asarchie, gopher, and veronica cannot cope with such quantities. It is a matter of applying the traditional methods of imparting information to these enormous digital information pools, by means of automatic and semi-automatic methods. It is no longer important by which carrier one generation eventually passes on its information to the next. We no longer collect the carriers, clay tablets, books, or floppies, just the information.

Notes

1. See *Jongeren en eigen pers* (The young and their own press), IISG Research Paper, 1992.
2. Tjebbe van Tijen, "A context for collecting new media." In *Next Five Minutes Catalogue*, IISG Working Paper 21, Amsterdam, 1993.
3. CATOE Project, *Cataloguing and Archiving the Other Europe*, sequel to *Europe Against the Current Database*, available from the IISG: Cruquiusweg 31, 1019 AT Amsterdam, tel. +31 20 6685866, fax +31 20 6654181. Available online at <<http://www.iisg.nl>>. See also <www.iisg.nl/~occasio>. 1994.



Bandwidth and Accountability

An Interview with Saskia Sassen

The global city is a concept unmistakably related to the urban theorist Saskia Sassen. In her work, she has connected the enormous growth of the cross-border networks of the financial metropolises with counterstrategies of urban social movements. Sassen is Ralph Lewis Professor of Sociology at the University of Chicago and Centennial Visiting Professor at the London School of Economics. Her most recent books are *Guests and Aliens* (New York: New Press, 1999) and the edited volume *Global Networks/City Links* (New York and London: Routledge, 2001). New, fully updated editions of her *Cities in a World Economy* and *The Global City* came out in 2001. Her books have been translated into ten languages. She is codirector of the Economy Section of the Global Chicago Project and chair of the newly formed Information Technology, International Cooperation and Global Security Committee of the SSRC. The conversation was taped during her visit to the Hybrid WorkSpace (Documenta X, Kassel, Germany) on July 11, 1997, where the Amsterdam-based Society for Old and New Media at that time was developing its "We Want Bandwidth" campaign.

Let's talk about the geography of cyberspace. We have a lot of maps on display here, in Hybrid WorkSpace, and they show the inequality of (the distribution of) bandwidth worldwide. These figures give a dry and precise picture.

Many people are, of course, aware of this basic architecture of the networks. But to have the data so precisely is extremely important. One of the concerns for me has been to understand the differences between private digital space and the public one. A lot of theoretical work has been done on public digital space like, for example, the *Digital City* in Amsterdam. I have been concerned with private digital space. And with what I see as a colonizing of public digital space by private (i.e., corporate) actors.

We have three phases of the Internet. The first phase is that of the hackers, where access was the issue, making the software available. The second one, when you begin to have the interest by private actors that did not quite know how to use it. It still was mostly a public space, in some ways protected. And now a third stage, the invasion of cyberspace by corporate actors: It's really combat out there. So for me, the Internet becomes a space for contestation. I am here not only thinking about multinational corporations. I am thinking of all kind of actors, including the misusers of the Net, which is something serious also.

The bandwidth capacity is always a very difficult issue. It is not clear to me if the capacity will be endless, like in the notion of the old frontier, where you had "endless land." But it is not really endless. It takes a number of events to discover that. Certain laboratory productions of capacity are enormous, in term of bandwidth. But I am not sure what happens once it moves from the lab to people and companies. There are two issues, the first being the economics of introducing the new technical capacities that are possible. And economics matters. We already now have poor men and women's email, where you wait forever. If you can pay, you will have a high-speed connection. The other issue is a "degreening" of the practices on the Net, which I find very disturbing: The issue of bandwidth-consuming multimedia, for instance, where things could also have been done via email.

In order to have a broad, general debate about the issue of bandwidth, it might be important to see how we can visualize this topic. Which metaphors do we use, what kind of images? How would you describe the bandwidth topic for a wider audience?

I grew up in Latin America. Anybody who has spent some time there or in Africa knows how difficult it is to place an international, long-distance call. You have to wait, sometimes for hours. You don't just get on the telephone and get access. Why? Because it is a question of the capacity. You will experience the notion of inadequate carrying capacity. Today, those of us who use email through institutions have also had that experience. In Europe, it is different in the afternoon than in the morning. Why? Because in the afternoon the United States has woken up and has invaded the Internet. You get to wait a much longer time. If you have a lot of money, believe me, you will have a fast lane. In Bombay or São Paulo, you will find different circumstances. For instance, there are poor and rich universities. Some universities in the United States, in order to save money, shift part of their bandwidth to commercial users after 5:00 p.m. And you will sit there forever to get a connection.

The "We Want Bandwidth" campaign at Documenta X's Hybrid WorkSpace could be part of a strategy to reimagine what the public part of cyberspace could look like. We could complain that the old parts of the public realm are disappearing. But we could as well start reinventing new public spaces.

It is not disappearing, it is being colonized. One of the key issues is to develop and promote more different subcultures. In Latin America there is a whole lot of Net activity in Spanish. The more diversity we have, the better. The colonizing of the space is going in many different directions. It does not only have to come from private companies. Even if it is just email. Whether it is poor women in India connecting directly with a group of poor women in New Jersey, or labor unions that are beginning to do more international organizing because they are on email, it is really a question of maximizing the activity on the Net, and militancy, if you want.

On the other hand, we have this economics of the networks, occurring simultaneously with stiff competition and a drive toward monopolization. Maybe this comes as no surprise. What may look like chaotic markets is in reality quite frightening, especially if one looks at the mergers between the telcos.

This is a very real story, this joining of large firms across borders. One of the ironies is that insofar as fiber-optic cables do remain a very important way

of getting the communication going, in order to provide global services, these companies have to cover the whole, actual geography of the globe. Hence the necessity of the mergers. In the end we will have a limited number of very large global companies. Going global is the name of the game. When we talk about regulation today, we tend to give it a narrow meaning, which has to do with the government regulating content. That is a totally different notion, compared to regulating access and accountability. We need to free the concept of regulation from what it is. We should innovate and start to think about how we can regulate those big conglomerates. They are reshaping the topography of communications.

What's the difference between the computer networks used in the financial world and the "public" Internet? Is it justified to make this distinction between this closed world of the banks and the so-called open networks that are shutting down in increasing numbers (such as intranets)?

They are two separate worlds. It's not that the digital networks of finance are secret. They are private, so they become inaccessible. But we have considerable information on volumes and types of financial capital that are moving around the world. We know that the overall volume of the global capital market is estimated at \$75 trillion, all of which at one point or another goes through digital networks. But we know these figures from the nondigital institutional spaces within which finance is also embedded. (That is one of the points of my analysis in *The Global City*.) Financial markets—Frankfurt's Deutsche Boerse, New York's Stock Exchange, the Paris Bourse, are "owned" and managed by firms—in Frankfurt, the owner of the stock market is Deutsche Boerse, in Paris the Paris Bourse, and so forth. These "firms" need to report their activities; they are accountable.

So we can get a lot of information on the transactions that take place in the private digital networks of finance through these firms that own the markets. So there is a vast digital work where we cannot enter, we cannot look into. But we can see, at least partly, what goes in and out. There are also "secret" flows of finance, networks such as the blacknets. The blacknets for laundering money and making illegal transfers is indeed "secret," but I would say that that is so because it is criminal and hence has to go underground. The key point about the private financial markets is that they are private and hence inaccessible and hence radically different from the Internet.

A second interesting difference, theoretically, is that the same properties that we see on the Internet—connectivity, simultaneity—lead to very different outcomes: on the Internet, access and the enhancement of “democracy,” if you will. In the financial networks they contribute to massive increases in volume and concentration at the top—hierarchy rather than openness, and concentration of power rather than distributed power, as on the Internet.

For instance, notwithstanding a massive increase in the volume of financial flows, concentration is enormous. London, Frankfurt, and New York account for an enormous world share in the export of financial services. London, New York, and Tokyo account for over one third of global institutional equity holdings, this as of the end of 1997 after a 32 percent decline in Tokyo’s value over 1996. London, New York, and Tokyo account for 58 percent of the foreign exchange market, one of the few truly global markets; together with Singapore, Hong Kong, Zurich, Geneva, Frankfurt, and Paris, they account for 85 percent. London is now the leading center for institutional equity management in the world, with over US\$1.8 trillion in assets as of the end of 1997.

Do these financial computer networks also need more bandwidth? In what way is the campaign “We Want Bandwidth” directly or indirectly, unintentionally perhaps, working on behalf of its own interests?

Yes, but unlike you and me who may have to fight for it, they just buy it. Today most big infrastructure projects—laying fiber-optic cable across the bottom of the oceans—are carried out by three major engineering companies who do it on “spec.” That is not because they were contracted to do so by a government or a company, but on their own because they know that there is a market of actors with very deep pockets, such as the multinationals and the financial services firms and the financial markets, which will buy the bandwidth. We fight for the right of access to use bandwidth because we are fighting around issues concerning the Internet—public space, a public good. It is like poor workers demanding public transportation to get them to their jobs. Internet activists and experts don’t usually recognize or often have not thought about the world of private digital space because they really are two separate worlds.

To me, someone who focuses also on finance, it is always astounding to hear generalizations made about the features of digital networks in general,

when what they are talking about is the features of the Net. I think this shows us once again that technology is, ultimately, embedded. There is no neutral technology. The structures of power also shape some of the decisive features of the digital networks as I compared earlier for the Internet and the private networks of finance. There is of course today also a growing level of activity by individuals especially using the Internet for financial transactions, but that is retail finance.

With the rise of e-commerce and the entrance of the big media firms in cyberspace, we are witnessing a closing of networks that used to be open and freely accessible. Cyber-activists and artists are pointing at a shift in the struggle from "public access" and "bandwidth" to "public content." Do you think that this new "public space" is indeed in danger?

This is a very important issue. I am convinced that we need to fight for free and public content. But bandwidth is the infrastructure that is intimately linked to the formation and multiplication of public activity on the Internet. Public space and free content have always required access to specific conditions, even if elementary. What looms ahead is a sharpening division between a slow-moving space for those who lack the resources and a fast-moving space (quick connections, enormous bandwidth) for those who can pay for it. Although it is really very different, for illustration we could say that this is a new version of an old syndrome: the public buses in poor neighborhoods are often of poorer quality than those for rich neighborhoods. It once seemed as if these forms of inequality could not be enacted in the Internet. Today it would seem that they are. That is why I argue that we need to advance our theorization about the Internet and recognize that it has gone through several phases and is today in a third phase.

Despite all the cybermalls, gated virtual communities, password sites, credit card content, webvertisements, and so forth, is the Internet (still) an interesting place for struggle and inspiration for you?

Yes, sure, there are many great things happening on the Internet, though they are increasingly swamped by the proliferation of pure junk, and increasingly by commercialization. An Internet forum organized by Jordan Crandall, *Blast*, turned out to be one of the liveliest and multifaceted,

argumentative, free-for-all kind of experiences of the public bringing together people from across the world. This is of course ultimately just one subculture, but that is fine, as long as there are many others. I participate in a series of activists networks that deal with the response of workers to the current crisis—for instance, support and information to the South Korean trade unionists who are putting their lives on the line in very violent engagements, or the worldwide organizing against the new Multilateral Agreement on Investment that is being negotiated at the OECD in Paris, or the rebellion in Chiapas.

I see a future politics that is this multiplication of intensely local engagements but with a strong connection to other such local engagements, in the community next door, the town across the river, or the town across the world. I do agree with what you once said that we need to defend the right of people to have access to the technology itself, rather than just inviting participation in established fora. That is what this network of municipal Web sites does. This is not about intellectuals but about people engaged in ordinary and not-so-ordinary activities. And yes, we need much more of this, all around the world. This is the great potential of the Internet for politics, a new kind of global politics embedded in a multiplication of a new kind of local—one that allows for transnational recognition, work, collaboration.

We are in the middle of an Asian financial and economic crisis now. Would you say that, as an effect, the ideology of neoliberalism ("globalism") is in crisis? Protective measurements (like those in Malaysia and Hong Kong) might point to such a direction. Are you in favor of these policies at the level of the nation-state?

Ooh, that is a big question. Let me just give you a few points. By now we have enough evidence that we can say that free capital flows across borders in the last decade or so have not brought overwhelmingly positive impacts to most countries. Today the IMF is under attack, and there is great interest in Malaysia's effort with controls. But I do not think that a return to the protectionism of the post–World War II decades is possible, because the dominant techno-economic systems are de facto global. This condition limits the shape of future developments. I must also say, that I do not think that the period of protectionism was so desirable—there were a significant share of people who benefited, no doubt, but there was also enormous inequality and many were excluded from the generalized prosperity. In Western

Europe this era worked better than in most other regions of the world. Still, it was better than what we have today.

I think we need to find new administrative and political forms to redirect the whole notion of what is desirable economic growth—sustainable environmentally speaking, equitable even if it fails to be egalitarian, with access by all, including the poor and powerless, to political processes—a new normativity. I discuss some of this in my book *Losing Control?* There is so much more to say here. My basic reading about what is happening to the state is that we are seeing an incipient process of denationalization of nation-states, national sovereignty, national economies. This means partly that certain parts of national governments are becoming the sites for agendas that do not have to do with “national growth” and “national strength.” We can say this about ministries of finance and central banks and their increasingly dominant role in most national governments. I like to think that this also offers us a possibility for a denationalized politics, linking people across the globe who share agendas—for the environment, for human rights, for equitable economic growth.



Building a Progressive, Pragmatic Futurism

An Email Exchange with Mark Dery

For Mark Dery, cyberculture is first and foremost a futuristic story we tell each other—myth, rhetoric, even an escapist movement. His writing is full of playful descriptions of what the “digital underground” has been tinkering with in the last decade. In his Open Magazine pamphlet *Culture Jamming: Hacking, Slashing, and Sniping in the Empire of Signs*, he used the term “culture jamming” to critique what has been defined elsewhere as “a combination of information warfare, terror-art, and guerilla semiotics, directed against the information society in which we live—an ever more intrusive, instrumental technoculture whose operant mode is the manufacture of consent through the manipulation of symbols.”

There isn't much "cyber jamming" going on, and even the myth of subversion seems to be absent. Are the 1990s really such a Dark Age when it comes to politics? And should we just wait until this naive techno-utopian storm is over?

It seems a little premature to be performing Last Rites for the myth of subversion, which is alive and well in heady subcultural dreams of Temporary Autonomous Zones, Islands in the Net, and other anarchotopias, online and off. For example, *Wired* conjures wild and crazy visions of "out-of-control" cybercapitalism to reassure the male, thirtysomething, \$81K-a-year knowledge workers who are its typical readers—Robert Reich's symbolic analysts, by any other name—that they're still teenage mutant ninja hackers under the skin. It speaks the language of managerial gurus like Tom Peters, who preaches a gospel of "atomized corporations" with spunky "subunits headed by disrespectful chiefs."

The very design of *Wired* plays to Boomer fantasies of what an MTV slogan memorably called "revolution without all the mess," reconciling twenty-first-century cybercapitalism and countercultural rebellion in Day-Glo graphics and Mighty Morphin typography that are equal parts corporate annual report and cyberdelic spin art. As Keith White noted in his *Baffler* essay, "The Killer App," the idea that "being a corporation isn't dull and conformist anymore—it rocks!" is soothing music to the digerati, "aspiring members of a new, socially insecure elite." So the myth of subversion survives, albeit drenched in irony, in *Wired's* turned-on, booted-up, jacked-in pseudo revolution for managerial professionals.

Of course, techno bricoleurs like Mark Pauline of Survival Research Laboratories (SRL) better embody what you probably mean by "the myth of subversion." The rogue technologist who wages guerrilla war on the military-industrial complex with robots made out of appropriated, reanimated technotrash has been enshrined, through William Gibson characters like Slick Henry in *Mona Lisa Overdrive*, in the cyberpunk pantheon, alongside the outlaw hacker. The problem with SRL (Survival Research Laboratories)-inspired fantasies of a technorevolution by garbage pail kids is that they're underwritten by an incongruously Weathermen-esque faith in the power of a well-placed bomb to "strike at the heart of the state," as the Red Brigades put it.

Obviously, it's a keystone assumption of postmodern analyses of the non-linear dynamics of power, from Guy Debord's *Society of the Spectacle* to the

Critical Art Ensemble's *Electronic Disturbance*, that power has etherealized—that control controls (to use a William S. Burroughs turn of phrase) less by corporal punishment than by colonizing the mass imagination with media fictions that manufacture consent. Pauline is all too aware of this; SRL's theater of operations is founded on the assumption that even ritualized resistance to technocratic power produces tangible effects, if only in the minds of audience members.

My critique of SRL in *Escape Velocity* ends with Pauline saying, "I believe in the political potency of the symbolic gesture"—a quote that could easily do double duty as the battle cry of the cultural politics theorized by Stuart Hall, Dick Hebdige, and their ilk. Unfortunately, symbolic resistance is just that: symbolic. It cedes territory in the larger cultural arena in the name of micropolitical resistance (an Achilles' heel it shares with virtual communitarianism, incidentally) and unwittingly lends itself to easy appropriation by consumer capitalism, which guts, skins, stuffs, and mounts "symbolic gestures," no matter how politically potent, with alarming speed. To invert Gibson's cyberpunk shibboleth, the strip mall finds its own uses for things, too.

Pockets of resistance that can't be malled beyond recognition may be allowed to function as petri dishes, culturing strange new memes in the consumer capitalist equivalent of a vaccine against more virulent political infestations. As Andrew Ross notes in *Strange Weather*, the cyberdelic counterculture championed by *Mondo 2000*, like the illicit enclave of Chiba City's Ninsei in *Neuromancer*, serves as an "experimental sounding board for legitimate industrial developers." Which brings us full circle to *Wired*, and its role as a cultural airlock for cyberlumpen in transit to Microserfdom.

As political tactics these rituals of resistance—"myths of subversion," to use your term—stand in relation to the raw power of nation-states and the multinational megaconglomerates fast rendering them obsolete as the Japanese stratagem of trying to start forest fires in the United States with incendiary devices made of paper and bamboo, floated over on the jetstream, stood in relation to the American atom bombs simultaneously falling on Japan. Does that mean that "all these weird desires just end up incorporated into the One Big Story of capitalism," and that we should "just wait until this naive techno-utopian storm is over?" Not at all.

While I'm leery of romanticizing postmodern primitivism, transgender activism, *Star Trek* pornography, or the Abject™ as our last, best hopes for

micropolitical resistance, I'm equally wary of the doomy tendency, inherited from the Frankfurt Marxists, to envision cyberculture as a panoptical nightmare of unrelieved domination. And I'm deeply suspicious of the dizzy dysphoria Arthur Kroker inherits from Jean Baudrillard—a profoundly dystopian vision that offers no way out of the socioeconomic and environmental problems all around us, but couches its pessimism in sci-fi jargon that turns those problems into a giddy apocalypse in an academic theme-park. This is what Walter Benjamin was talking about when he warned us that mankind's "self-alienation has reached such a degree that it can experience its own destruction as an aesthetic pleasure of the first order."

The "last" thing we should do is hunker down in our bunkers and wait for the increasingly Hobbesian reality of our two-tiered social reality to have the "naive techno-utopians" and their New Age dreams of Gaian groktoπia for dinner (an admittedly appetizing prospect). The first step toward finding a way out of this place begins when we take a flamethrower to Newt Gingrich cum Alvin Toffler style laissez-faire futurism, which entrusts our collective fate to the tender mercies of the marketplace, or New Age cyberbole that would have us pin our hopes to a millennial blastoff. We have to relocate our cultural conversation about the promise of technology in the noisy, dirty here and now and begin to build a progressive, pragmatic futurism.

"The Sacred is alive and well inside the machine" is the conclusion of your chapter on Northern Californian cyberdelic culture and its techno-transcendentalist fantasies. Apparently, cyberculture isn't criticizing its own religious aspirations. Feuerbach, Marx, and Nietzsche all wrote critiques on religion and its institutions, but there's no "Anti-McKenna." The New Age seems to be so deeply imbedded in technoculture that hardly anyone is questioning this unspoken consensus. Of course, one cannot expect the postmodern thinkers to do so. Could you imagine a radical, digital atheism that will counter these current belief systems?

Well, I'm hardly the equal of Feuerbach, Marx, or Nietzsche, but I'll happily cross swords with Terrence McKenna (who strikes me as vastly more original, and infinitely more eloquent, than other, better-known bearded prophets of millennial cyberhype). In fact, I do just that in a story for the Australian cyberzine *21C: The Magazine of the Twenty-First Century*, where I theorize McKenna's cyberdelic visions as bedtime stories for cyborgs, spun from Arthur C. Clarke-ian sci-fi mysticism, New Age millenarianism, and

the Dionysian “expressive politics” of the 1960s (specifically, of Norman O. Brown).

I’m not sure that a “digital atheism” is required to counter the neognostic or New Age techno transcendentalism percolating into cyberculture; the razor of logic, stropped on the whetstone of engaged, embodied politics, should work just fine. Frankly, I’m flabbergasted that “anyone” would possess the unblinking credulity required to swallow John Perry Barlow’s belief that the Gaian mind will “come alive” (whatever that means) when the online population equals the number of neurons in the human brain or Douglas Rushkoff’s assertion, in “Cyberia,” that “any individual being, through feedback and iteration, has the ability to redesign reality at large.” Don’t be fooled by the sleek new DataSuit: This is the same 1960s Oh-Wowism that P. J. O’Rourke memorably described as the notion that there is “a throbbing web of psychic mucus and we are all part of it somehow.”

In your genealogy of cyberpunk, you state that this (mainly literary) phenomenon is rooted in pop music, specifically punk. But historically, there seems to be no relationship between 1970s punk and technology. Also, punk seemed to lack the narcissistic individualism of cyberpunk.

Punk and cyberpunk share a romanticization of urban decay and scabrous lowlife, a flattened affect that is equal parts existential ennui and future shock, and most importantly a tacit faith in the politics of appropriation and the subversive use of refunctioned rubbish—the kitsch flotsam of consumer culture, the broken-down detritus of science and industry. In my chapter, “Metal Machine Music,” I quote a former writer for the legendary New York magazine *Punk*, who says that punk rock “was about saying yes to the modern world. Punk, like Warhol, embraced everything that cultured people detested: plastic, junk food, B movies, advertising, making money.”

This particular strain in the punk aesthetic—the robopathic blankness (reminiscent of *Mondo 2000* icon Andy Warhol’s expressed desire to be a robot), the smirking embrace of Stepford-ian suburbia, with its Tupperware consumerism and Space Age optimism—harmonizes with cyberpunk’s dystopianism, mocking the promised Tomorrowland that never arrived. There’s a deadpan, mordant humor to it that reminds me of “The Gernsback Continuum,” William Gibson’s affectionate immolation of the technocratic fantasies of pulp science fiction. This sensibility, which also overlaps with

the jaundiced modernism and fondness for junk culture of the Independent Group (whose 1956 ICA exhibition, *This Is Tomorrow*, was pure protocyberpunk), pop artists like Richard Hamilton, and New Wave visionaries like J. G. Ballard, reaches its apotheosis in bands like the Normal and Flying Lizards. No Futurism is still a form of Futurism.

After I read your critique of SRL, it occurred to me that you didn't frame them in terms of the much larger "industrial" movement (which is also rooted in music). The industrial aesthetic has a complex relationship with digital technology, which is typical of the 1980s. In anticipation of the coming of the immaterial, it celebrates the darkness of abandoned factories, the extreme circumstances of squatting and rioting, the material aspect of redundant, metal objects. Although it could also be seen as a Dionysian answer to the unbearable lightness of being yuppie (the dominant class of the 1980s), you accuse SRL of "macchinismo" and talk about their "repressed male sexuality." Perhaps their audience is attracted by the darkness and dirtiness of SRL's "lower-class" spectacles in an age of political correctness and overall transparency.

I'll plead guilty as charged, although in my defense I assumed that most of my readers would have read Re/Search's seminal *Industrial Culture Handbook*, which locates SRL at cultural ground zero for that aesthetic. There's no denying that the mythopoesis of cyberculture—SRL's mechanical mayhem, the cyberbody performance art of D. A. Therrien's *Comfort/Control*, industrial dance music, and science fiction cinema from *Tetsuo* to *The Terminator*—uses mechanical iconography as an ironic metaphor for an information society whose technological totem, the computer, resists representation. Its smooth, generic casing is too inscrutable and its inner workings too complex, too changeable for the imagination to gain purchase on them; only when it is imaged in the heavy metal of the Machine Age can this postindustrial engine be grasped.

To my mind, only the liquid metal T-1000 in *Terminator 2* (a sliding signifier, if ever there was one!) refutes this logic and thereby holds a truer mirror up to our moment: Liquefying into a featureless silver mannequin, it hardens into a flawless copy of anything it touches, bodying forth the disconcertingly fluid future promised by the computer. The T-1000 offers an uncanny incarnation of a cyberculture characterized by the dematerialization, via digitization, of labor, commodities, even the genetic code of living organisms.

As for your contention that SRL spectacles countervail “the unbearable lightness of being yuppie” by giving vent to chthonic or “Dionysian” impulses, an interpretation that would certainly cast them in a more liberatory light than accusations of heavy metal macho would suggest, I should say, first of all, that the charges you’ve quoted were leveled not by myself, but by SRL’s feminist critics. I merely quoted them in the context of a critical analysis of the gender politics of SRL’s avant-garde demo derbies.

I think SRL is a polyvalent phenomenon that wriggles out of ideological straitjackets: The group’s performances enact the cyberpunk fantasy of techno revolution and a black comedy about the arms race and the apocalyptic doctrine of Mutual Assured Destruction “even as” they play to the adolescent, putatively “male” desire (a charge whose essentialism frankly annoys me) to revel in orgies of destruction. In the BBC documentary on machine art, “Pandemonium,” I called SRL a cross between Peter Pan’s Lost Boys and the Baader-Meinhof Gang.

To be honest, I find SRL’s unalloyed joy in wanton machine carnage exhilarating—a bracing corrective to the frumpy, middlebrow morality of the mainstream art world. I wouldn’t call SRL “dionysian,” a word that reverberates with unfortunate *Mondo 2000* Jim Morrison Fan Club resonances in my mind; “adolescent” seems more apt. And as R. Crumb, Robert Williams, and John Belushi in *Animal House* have shown us, the adolescent, at his most transgressive, embodies Kristeva’s definition of the abject with a vengeance.

You take Stelarc’s notion of the “obsolete body” very seriously. You quote a neuropsychiatrist who says, “I look upon Stelarc’s fantasies as pathological; they’re in the general genre of world destruction fantasies—extreme, narcissistic fantasies of complete isolation.” Why psychoanalyze his philosophies? It’s clear that the internalization of technology and power is the theme of his work; one doesn’t need psychoanalysis to see that. If Stelarc embodies Foucault’s ideal subject of power—the analyzable, manipulable “docile body,” as you suggest—then he’s only showing us an aspect of our reality. What you’re actually questioning is the role of the artist in our society. Is technology art like Stelarc’s encouraging cynical, antisocial tendencies, and if so, should it be attacked for that?

Actually, my main intention in quoting Dr. Richard Restak, a neuropsychiatrist and professor of neurology at George Washington University, had less

to do with unearthing the psychological roots of Stelarc's posthuman rhapsodies than examining the nuts-and-bolts feasibility of the cyborg upgrades he proposes, which no critic has ever done (to the best of my knowledge). Although Restak takes issue with Stelarc's post-evolutionary scenario on psychological and philosophical grounds, it is on "technical, medical" grounds that he rebuts it. As for your suggestion that "the internalization of technology and power" is self-evidently Stelarc's abiding theme, and that I've somehow turned him into a whipping boy for the postmodern pathologies, or "cynical, antisocial tendencies," cultured by our ever more electronically cocooned, prosthetically enhanced existences, I couldn't disagree more.

Such points seem to be lost on Stelarc, who staunchly resists the mythographic or semiotic mining of his work, insisting that his cyberbody events be taken literally, as R&D for "post-evolutionary" human-machine synergy. He legitimates his posthumanist pronouncements in technical terminology and invokes a "context-free" scientific objectivity intended to foreclose social or political readings of his work. But the very notion of ideation unperturbed by ideology, of a social space in which the collision of bodies and machines takes place outside "the politics of power," is science fiction. The idea that truth is as much constructed as discovered—that is, that even avowedly value-neutral discourses are colored by cultural assumptions—is a keynote of recent critiques of science.

Am I "questioning is the role of the artist in our society"? Absolutely, in the sense that I'm challenging Stelarc to consider the stealth politics of cyberculture that are flying just under radar cover in his art. What's needed here, as I've said before, is a politics of posthumanism. Stelarc's art and thought do not exist, as he would have it, in the value-free cultural vacuum traditionally reserved for science. His SF vision of a body that is no longer "a site for the social" is hemmed in on all sides by feminist body criticism, the ongoing debate over the ethics of human biotechnology, and green critiques of capitalism's litanies of technological progress and unchecked expansion.

You note that the body has become a "combat zone for ideological skirmishes over abortion rights, fetal tissue use, AIDS treatment," and so forth. Cyborg enthusiasts, in your opinion, seem to be missing the vital issues: Orlan and the Krollers forget that there are "real bodies at stake," as Scott Bukatman puts it. Is it no longer possible to dream about strange, new body-techno connections?

This touches on a question Howard Rheingold asked me, in a *Salon* interview, about “the fun side of posthumanism.” The seductions of posthumanism, of which we can never remind ourselves enough is an altogether science-fictional notion (at least for the moment), are its promise of bodiless kinesis and info-vertigo, its Marvel Comics vision of massively parallel brainpower and cyborgian brawn. Who hasn’t dreamed of disembodied barrel rolls over the fractal geographies of cyberspace, reincarnated as one of the infomorphs envisioned by Charles Platt is his unforgettable novel, *The Silicon Man*? And what writer isn’t seduced by the idea of a cybernetically enhanced mind so vast that it sweeps the entirety of human knowledge into its compass, and can leap, in a picosecond, from the secret sex lives of Cheng and Eng to the diameter of JFK’s cranial exit wound to the number of glial cells in Einstein’s brain. I’m particularly taken by O. B. Hardison’s sublime, magnificently lonely vision, at the end of *Disappearing Through the Skylight*, of a human consciousness “downloaded” into a deep space probe, gliding past the rim of infinity on solar sails. But what price this sublimity? Platt’s aching painful evocation of the man, “downloaded” against his will, who realizes he is a cloud of electrons in computer memory who will never hold his wife and child in arms of flesh again has never stopped haunting me (leftist intellectuals can find a cloud for every silver lining, can’t we?).

Perhaps the problem lies in cyberculture's unclear social and economic position, neither part of mass culture nor in clear political opposition to the ruling class. This leaves space for an overheated economy of fantasies, the production of signs without referents. You seem unsure, yourself, whether to take the cyberdelic daydreams of Californian techno transcendentalists like the Extropians seriously. On the other hand, how seriously do you take the Wired visions of a Third Wave economy that form the basis of so many cyberpredictions?

I’m one of those unreconstructed eggheads who actually believe that ideas matter, and that the laissez-faire futurists fawningly profiled in *Wired* should be taken seriously to the extent that corporate power takes their Gingrichian-Tofflerian rhetoric seriously and plots its strategies accordingly. As policy is made, more and more, by corporate lobbyists (some of whom have literally been asked to “write” the legislation their slush funds—er, campaign contributions—bought, in recent years), the question of who’s whispering in the ear of corporate power is hardly irrelevant to those of us

who'd rather not entrust our futures to the paternalistic benevolence of multinationals, unrestrained by the token regulations of that inconvenient Second Wave nuisance, the nation-state.

Do I think *Wired* is a Murdochian MegaGodzilla? Hardly. But the managerial guru Tom Peters is singing *Wired* editor and memetic philosopher Kevin Kelly's tune these days, as is George Gilder (though in a different key), and their jaw-dropping lecture fees suggest that corporate culture takes Peters and Gilder "very" seriously. Clearly, *Wired's* laissez-faire visions of a nation-state downsized right out of existence have captured some ears inside the boardroom and the beltway. That, to my mind, makes such ideas worth taking seriously—as seriously as a retrovirus on the body politic, to use the genetic metaphor of the moment.



About the Brazilianization of India

An Interview with Ravi Sundaram

At the Fifth Cyberconference, which took place in June 1996 in Madrid, "Internet and the Developing World" was one of the main topics. It was here that I met Ravi Sundaram. Trained as a cultural historian, he was influenced by Ferdinand Braudel and the debates on modernity in Asia and in Europe. His topic is globalism and modernity in India. According to Sundaram, the Internet is becoming the crucial focus around which these debates organize themselves. Over the years we kept in contact, then met again in Amsterdam, New York. After a period of writing plans and submitting applications, he and a number of colleagues founded Sarai, a new media center in Delhi. Sarai opened its facilities in late 2000.

Could you tell us something about the political and historical background of the Net in India, also in respect to other media and especially film? In your lecture, you emphasized the specific relation between technology and modernity in India.

Modernity as we know it came to India through colonialism and is implicated in the history of violence. It is also implicated in the history of intellectual arrangement, where English became the language of the world economy and a passport to the world. Large sections of the intelligentsia and the ruling elite got access to world culture through English. After independence, modernity was represented through the issue of development, the notion that you can catch up with the West by reproducing certain models of industrial growth. Large-scale, centralized accumulation: the steel mill, the large dam, the long bridge, an accelerated notion of time.

Historically, modernity meant an exclusion of the village, of what was seen as tradition and ambivalent. The ruling class, after independence, very seriously distrusted the issues that Gandhi had raised. Rhetorically, the village was iconized through periodic references to craft, the peasant. But what modernity meant was a state-centered praxis of accumulation. Issues of science and technoculture, which are very current now, were monumentalized. They were completely abstracted from the everyday. The experience of modernism, which in the twentieth century revolved around the historical avant-garde in Europe, the 1920s, came to India in a very different form. What you have in India is modernism, which was centered around the monument. The dam, the steel mill, these fantastic sites that became icons of nationalism. It lacked the dialectical form of questioning and experimentation. The real experimentation lay in the ambivalent spaces that were ignored in the period after independence.

After independence (in 1947), intellectuals strongly identified with the national project, the state-centered development. Intellectual critique never questioned the borders in which it operated. They saw themselves, in the old Enlightenment sense, as being mandarins, as being the conscience of nationalism, and railed against tradition and backwardness. They were contemptuous of the village and the lower castes that lived there. So there was no genuine engagement with the aesthetically ambivalent issues of the space outside modernity.

Now this space for me is the space of the popular and, more specifically, of the popular cinema, which represented a series of contradictory strategies,

which spoke to the magical, the contradictory, the irreverent, the physical body, with which ordinary people identified. Indian cinema has been popular in the Third World precisely because of these issues. The intelligentsia has always been contemptuous of Indian cinema as not being real. Intellectuals followed the nationalist language of realism and Indian cinema has consciously ignored it and is in a true sense more “real” than intellectual strategies. Intellectual critique revolved around an alternative cinema, which was very limited, precisely because it tried to reproduce realist strategies.

Today, for the first time, and that is where the door to the Internet is opening, there is some engagement with the popular. This is because the national approach has collapsed and you have the emergence of a right-wing movement, which is trying to remap the popular, speaking aggressively toward new technologies. Ravi Vasudevan writes about popular culture and there are a number of younger writers who are emerging, but we must understand that we are in a space where the older stream of writers, who wrote on culture, are being actively delegitimized. At the same time, the far right, the Hindu nationalist right, is intervening aggressively in the sphere of the popular. For example, the groups that are the most active on the Internet, internationally, are Hindu nationalist groups, who are trying to recreate a new nation, based on a Hindu identity on the Internet, amid the ruins of the old-style nationalism.

As we know, India produces the largest number of films in the world every year. Music, which always played an important role in the dance sequences, is emerging in a very big way. India is soon going to be the largest market for audio cassettes in the world. You now get them in every small town and the whole culture of the everyday is influenced by this. Also there are shifts in the composition of music. Consider A. R. Rahman, for example, who writes film music in the South.

Movies now allude to a series of narratives. The space of the global has entered popular cinema. Of course it was always there, but today, in one very specific movie, the main protagonists are Indians who live abroad. In previous movies, whenever Indian characters went abroad, they always had to return to the homeland. In this movie, this issue is open-ended. However, we should not rush to reject current cinema as being nationalist, because the situation is very fluid and the viewers are very discriminating in what they like and what they reject. The marketing of films has become such a huge

affair that there is this aestheticization of everyday life. The innovations take place at the level of the image. The dance sequences now have bodies that are extremely fluid, that dissolve, which introduces an idea of virtuality into the dance sequences. It is not just novelty. The notion of the commercialization does not exhaust the issue of the popular.

Some of our readers may have heard about the recent rise of television in India, now becoming a real mass medium. How do you see this development from a social perspective and also in relation to the origins of the Net?

The television network really took off in the eighties. It was pushed by the state as a medium of development. The rise of private satellite channels, broadcasting from Hong Kong, now cover 7 percent of the population. It is not very large, but it does cover the cities. You may have one cable operator who gets the feed and then pipes it to various people, who pay up to \$3 a month. People often steal the feed, so this phenomenon is going to grow. But the problem is the elite culture that is coming into place. My greatest worry is this emancipation from the social and the problems of inequality that the elite is trying to obtain. A lot of television programs are trying to push this kind of ideology. It is therefore important to fight for an autonomous space within television, which is not controlled by the state or by big corporations.

What is going on in my opinion is the "Brazilianization of India." You have high levels of inequality, a spectacular film and culture industry, the proliferation of television, and for the first time in the history of India, you have the legitimization of inequality among the elite. Cities are being actively remapped, you have sections of the city that are meant only for the elite, with their own power supply, air conditioning, and private security. This space is generating an elite hybrid culture, an elite that is emancipated from any dialogue with issues such as public space and is securely anchored on the West.

In addition to the development of the television network, in the 1980s the state decided to set up a national electronic network, linking the state capitals and the district capitals. Under Jawaharlal Nehru, development meant that you had to reproduce physical instruments of accumulation such as steel and coal. What Rajiv Gandhi said is that the problem of development is a problem of communication. With accelerated communication you could obtain what was lacking.

Historically, social movements in India had always been skeptical of the monumental technology of nationalism, the large dam, the pollution of the steel mill, and deforestation. With the coming of the Net and also of local networks, activists are entering into a dialogue with techno culture and the rituals of initiation that are emerging with the computer. Perhaps for the first time, the sacral space of technology that was always central to nationalism is now receding. There are these secret pleasures, associated with the computer, that people don't talk about but they go through.

Bulletin Board Systems (BBSs) are spreading like wildfire. I have discovered BBSs in small towns, in obscure places. As in the West, BBSs began as cheap alternatives to Internet and the state network and now there are even the first underground systems. The Web is a monopoly of the elite. You need high-speed modems and good telephone lines, which is nearly impossible in India. Web access is for large companies and people with leased lines and direct satellite links. But most people use email, databases, and BBSs. There is a class difference in electronic space. 1 percent of 1 percent of 1 percent of the population has access to electronic space, a fact we must be aware of. At the same time, it is very important to develop cheaper networks, to argue for public access and public space where ordinary citizens can take part, which is distinct from the space of the state and the space of the market.

As a citizen of the Third World, I would not valorize the notion of private space and individual rights in the Net and exaggerate them. The American debate is excessively focused on notions of private access to the Net and the debate on multinational control of the Net is not very rich. One of the biggest threats in India is that once the big companies enter, ordinary people will get no access. I would not reject the electronic space as such. We have to fight for and create an egalitarian electronic space everywhere we teach and work and live.

In what way is this still small part of the elite using the Net, and can we already speak of an Indian Net culture?

What is of interest to me is how the elite has reworked the notion of the journey, in respect to the Net. The "journey" was always central to the iconography of Indian nationalism. As we all of us know, the most promi-

nent photograph and representation of Gandhi is Gandhi walking. He walked all around the country and also traveled by train to recreate a new space of the nation, to engage in a popular dialogue. Today, the elites of India are recreating the journey, but by accessing the West through the Web. If you log on the Web, the West emerges as a instantaneous presence. In the past, the West was always represented by a physical journey, you had passports, went there, and came back with tales and "phoren" goods. Today, the elite is able to experience the West within a new notion of time. Sitting in Delhi, you can log on to the U.S. Defense Department or the CIA, which are those secret nodes of power, of which the elite only heard about, while at the same time breaking loose from the social.

In this context, the city of Bangalore is actively being promoted as a major software site for export (hardware exports are still very low). "India's Silicon Valley," that is what the hype says. On the one hand, the United States does not want to import Indian software engineers. So this notion of territory (the Third World people invading our territory) is resolved by creating a space in India, which is linked through the network. Relatively low paid engineers (compared to the United States) who have their own autonomous space. There is a park called "Software City," which is completely cut off from the city itself, financed by a very fluid transnational capital, creating new forms of inequality.

Issues of authorship and copyright are of course being discussed worldwide. On the one hand, there is pressure by big companies on the Indian government to sign agreements. So the state has signed some and it will sign a few more. But on the ground the situation is quite different. You can purchase illegal software and computers that run quite well through the grey market; the service is very good. They also run well in respect to the climate in India and they are 50 percent cheaper, although the gap is closing. There is this huge alternative "technospace," which is not in control by the big companies. The multinationals only sell to bigger business houses and eventually there will be a big clash with the smaller businesses, which run the grey market. Microsoft has entered India in a big way, but it will not make money in a big way. This is a symbolic intervention, to put pressure on the state to crack down on software piracy. I personally do not think that knowledge is owned by anyone, and if it is sold at huge rates, people should have ways to circumvent it. And the flip side of this is that sections

of Microsoft programs were written by Indian engineers, but no one talks about this.

At the same time that the India government's ability to control its own territory is in crisis, a new territory is being mapped out on cyberspace and the initiative there is being taken largely by expatriated Indians in the United States, who are very sympathetic to Hindu fundamentalism. But these Web sites and Usenet groups dealing with India are almost never accessed by people living in India itself. They look for information regarding the West. So there is an India on the Net that becomes an artifact, that is riddled with ambivalence and has no concessions to a democratic spirit, and that has clear fascist overtones. So India is being reinvented, on the Net and in India itself. I am reminded of the old Marxian phrase "All that is solid melts into air, all that is holy is profane."

There seems to be a new "greyware culture" in India. Could you tell us more about it? All tech is said to be bridging the so-called Digital Divide. Is it?

Greyware in India refers to the preponderance of informal and nonlegal enterprises that supply computer ware to the vast majority of users in the country. This is a quotidian commodity culture centered on the locality and neighborhood, where the vast majority of sales are through personal contact rather than advertising. Typically, people would buy a grey market computer through a personal reference, the computers themselves are assembled with warranted parts and loaded with a large amount of illegal software.

The spread of greyware was the first intimation of the state's inability of deal with the technological proliferation of daily life in India in the 1990s. Unlike large public corporations, greyware culture is anonymous and local, and it militates against traditional control. But bear in mind this is a commodity culture, but one that has actually made media ware affordable to a growing section of the urban population. In India, nonlegality was never a performative or political stance, but a functional one. To be sure, there is a certain tactile pirate energy to greyware culture that disrupts all existing imaginaries. To the state it is a continuing problem of control, while to the new media empires it is a symbol of backwardness and a market threat. To the Left, greyware confounds all existing wisdom about globalization, unequal exchange, and "national sovereignty."

Are you in favor of the "creative destruction" of old media and their crusty bureaucratic structures? Could you sympathize with the old and work on tactical, even ironic collaborations? Or is this dead serious business in India?

I think after 1989 all claims to positivity obtaining in utopian, even millennial claims have been exhausted for a long time to come. The old media in India was always a complex one, with differences between cinema and television. The latter was always marked by interventionist state strategies and stricter censorship. The cable era from the 1990s marked a dissolution of this model, but today television is being reconsolidated by the media empires. Before the new media exploded, the map was depressing despite the increasing mediatization of daily life. What the new has done to energize the imaginative map is to pose agendas of collaboration and overlap between the old and new media. This is crucial in India where literacy levels are not high and the old media can still reach a majority of the population.

However, it seems to me that tactical strategies cannot start with Western-style avant-garde attacks on the "old" to pose an elitist counter-culture. To me a tactical media in India would deal with the sleazy, mobile forms of media practice in the everyday, which the old positivity rendered invisible. The old imaginary (common to both nationalism and the Old Left) also excluded all ironic possibilities; it was, as you point out, "dead serious," laden with a deep moral discourse. The good news is that the old agenda is completely exhausted with no possibility for renewal in the near future.

Is there an alternative here to the dogmatic Marxist criticism of global capitalism and its evil digital agenda?

At some point the state woke up to the fact that it had played no part in the media and software explosion in India. Since then we have seen the creation of a Ministry of Information Technology (MIT!), and the introduction of a repressive InfoTech legislation. The current consensus model of globalization is one where the state pushes the model of India as a global software exporter, with subsidies on taxes and infrastructure for IT companies. The latter have acceded to the state's effort to control the electronic everyday and now collaborate with efforts to track down hackers. This is a troubling scenario and

would have been terrifying had it happened in the old media landscape. In the new scenario, dispersed practices of freeware communities, hacker and youth cultures, and the slippery pirate modernity of greyware make old forms of social control difficult to implement. The stage is set for a new conflict zone in India, dispersed, tactical, and shorn of the old millennial allegories.

It's obvious that peasants will not benefit directly from an emerging capsuled virtual class. What role could state policies play here, if any? Where do you see spaces for action and intervention?

There is little doubt that India is a highly unequal society, with a large body of nonliterates who are concentrated in the rural areas. Here the Western model of privatized access (one person, one computer, one connection) will have little relevance. In fact the only way Net access has spread in India today is through shared spaces like cybercafés and phone shops. All statistics show a majority of Indians access the Net from these spaces, or from work. As for state policies, the motivation today in India is less to "remove" inequality but to resort to the moral policing of the digital everyday.

The NGO movement has taken up the banner of "socially relevant communication." Now there are a number of NGOs who are honest and committed, but if you look at their language carefully it seems suspiciously close to a Nehruvian statist model standing on its head. One of the big sponsors of NGO social communication in recent times has been the World Bank. My own feeling is that it makes more sense for tactical strategies to work with existing resources like the greyware community and neighborhood media practitioners who have been far more successful in expanding media access than the state or the NGOs.

What do you think of the brain drain of Indian information technology (IT) workers to the United States, Germany, and other countries?

In the Indian media itself, this migration of Indian IT workers to the West is often spoken in terms of nationalist terms; the recent race attacks on Indian IT workers in Germany was not even reported here. Nor is there any discussion of the conditions of Indian IT workers abroad, most of whom get extremely low wages. What is interesting is the prioritizing of the knowl-

edge industry by the West in terms of visa approvals. While unskilled workers are usually deported as “illegals,” new laws are enacted to allow for IT immigration.

Do you see any possibilities of initiating a dialogue with the venture capital IT firms in Bangalore and Hyderabad, many of which have set up firms in Silicon Valley? This Indian entrepreneurial class seems to fit perfectly in the American Dream of the New Economy. What is their social and political agenda? Cyberselfish neoliberalism Indian style?

IT elites in India have gravitated toward a meritocratic and Hindu nationalist imaginary within the framework of a globalized consumption regime. The idea of a civic or a public space between market and state is unimaginable for them. For most Indian entrepreneurs in Silicon Valley, investing back in India is really not an issue. The relationship to India is relayed through a typical mixture of long-distance nationalism and periodic opening addresses to IT conferences at home. Most of the interesting possibilities in India stem from the ideas of the elite IT visionaries who have little to gain from the entrepreneurial mode.



Cultural Imperialism and Information Inequality

An Interview with Herbert I. Schiller

Herbert I. Schiller, a distinctive U.S. critic with a clear political and social view on media matters, died in January 2000. One could summarize Schiller's position as a mediator between the U.S.-foreign policy type of media analysis done by Noam Chomsky (and others) and the more conservative, moral critiques of the media ecologists like Neil Postman. Schiller had elements of both. His last book, *Information Inequality* (1996), deals with topics such as selection mechanisms in the culture industry; the sellout of public properties like schools, libraries, and elections; "data deprivation"; special effects for capturing viewers; the global rule of American pop culture; and the Infobahn as the "latest blind alley." The interview was conducted in February 1997 in Munich, Germany, during the Internet and Politics conference.

Could you tell us something about the prehistory of cyberspace? When did you encounter the cyberideology for the first time?

One of the earliest was Daniel Bell, who wrote about “the end of ideology” and “the postindustrial society.” Production didn’t amount to much, in his view, and everything was services, mostly in various kinds of informational fields. He did not start discussing cyberspace. But others started there and began to talk about the “information society” being the postindustrial society. The other was Alvin Toffler, a popular writer, who wrote about these tendencies in the early seventies. Bell and Toffler became the unquestioned experts, and there was no remarkable criticism at the time. The elite criticized Toffler for writing in such a popular manner, but that was nothing serious. So these writers had the field to themselves.

The electronic basis of these writings is much more recent. ARPANET and the Internet as an academic communication network preceded without a great deal of attention. It is less than ten years ago that it burst out into a much more generalized public. My view is that this development has been very carefully cultivated by the standard forces, like governmental bureaus such as the National Science Foundation, which gave significant grants to individuals for the development of software. There was a very deliberate promotion and encouragement. It was not all so random and accidental or unplanned.

How does Marshall McLuhan fit into this picture?

McLuhan was taken up and given a lot of attention by the media itself. They liked that he emphasized the media issue, out of a narcissistic interest. They found somebody who was making them appear very significant. But I don’t see him as a prophet of cyberspace or in any direct line with the current business. In his early works, like *The Mechanical Bride*, he was somewhat of a materialist, a social critic. But then he got off into esoteric areas.

George Gilder believes that the old, mass media monopolies will soon crumble because of the empowering possibilities of individuals by the so-called interactive, many-to-many media. There is a certain similarity to your critique of the big media corporations. Can you comment on that?

All what one can do is look around. Do you see any indications? The monopolies are stronger than ever and the concentration continues. It now embraces a wide area, it is not just "media." All forms of communication are brought together in these unified corporate conglomerates. You have Time-Warner, which has assets of about \$20 billion and is operating radio stations, recording studios, film studios, television programming, and increasingly retail stores, where they sell the apparel that they produce in their movies. Disney is, of course, an enormous conglomerate. Then there is Viacom, which owns MTV and does a great job of selling pop culture and making these kids less and less capable of doing any thinking. But it also includes computer companies and telephone companies. The television networks are all owned by superconglomerates. CBS is owned by Westinghouse, NBC by General Electric. ABC was just bought by Disney, and Fox is owned by Murdoch.

To think that these are crumbling is like being in a fantasyland. We have to be careful in using the word *globalization* in this context. It may seem that everybody is participating in it and you will have to, and if you don't you will fall behind and lose, we have to be competitive, that sort of thing. Globalization is a direction of supercorporations. They are using the globe to market their products and penetrate every part of the world. But there is a big difference between what they are doing and the whole world population.

How do the broadcasting media relate to the rapidly growing, but still small cyber-media? Noam Chomsky does not seem to be very interested in the Net. Perhaps he does not see its strategic importance.

You have to examine this as things develop. It is an area of continuous scrutiny and monitoring. Everything you will discover in the areas of television and film will come back in the Net. The patterns are going to be very similar. We are nowhere near to what they like to call an information society. This term serves to camouflage what the current reality is. The talk about the "new" keeps the present level aside. We are living in a period of innocence and bankruptcy of values. People are desperately looking for meaning, identity, ethnicity, gender. All of which are legitimate, but when they get to be obsessive, they make it less possible to recognize what the underlying, fundamental forces are. There is a lot of escapism in the talking about "are we now in the information society?" But many of those people are sincere, so you can't make them seem as if they are fools.

What is your view of the role of cultural studies in all this?

For me it is very ironic because I have tried always to include the cultural component. I was aware about it from the very beginning when I wrote about the role of cultural imperialism. And along comes cultural studies and attacks the political economy approach as being too narrow and too exclusive. At least in the United States, the main current of cultural studies is to deny the legitimacy of the political economy of mass communication. As I see it, cultural studies has served the dominant ideology. Those who engage in cultural studies do not want to see the underlying reality of the images and messages they are looking at. "The act of the audience" puts people like myself in a curious situation. I am not saying that everybody is a cultural dope. But I do have to recognize where the cultural power is. I cannot accept it when they talk about the opposition and resistance of viewers. If they are reading women's books, romances, they are showing their resistance to their way of life . . . This might be the case, but I don't regard that as the type of resistance that will take us very far.

Where do you see the roots of such a political economy of the media?

It has not such a long history, a few decades. I am trying to indicate that the fundamentals of a materialist philosophy are crucial to an understanding. Students should have some sense of the social forms that have evolved, from early capitalism until now, in terms of labor and wage labor. These forms do not disappear. There is a great deal of materiality that can be pointed to, even in the case of the Internet. I don't think it is so remote. You can show how those big companies get involved in all these different activities. People themselves can recognize some relationships. You can show the connections to organized sports, to the apparel industry, which is producing baseball hats, football uniforms, and the rest. The cultural industry is so overt, so visible.

Do you see the Internet becoming a mass medium?

That might be the case. But this concept was mainly an oppositional idea of what was happening in the media industry in the late thirties and early forties. It was an elitist view, which looked down on the masses. So the term itself has to be looked at as an ideological outlook. Persuasion, for example,

was a big issue in the thirties, but when mass communication became a formal discipline, they dropped it, because persuasion would come too close to the nervous system. So they switched the topic to the effects of communication. But that is a very different question.

What do you think of the equation of the Internet with American imperialism? Certain forms of anti-Americanism in Europe are not very progressive. How do you look at this dilemma?

I have looked on the phenomena of cultural imperialism for a long time. This is not something of the nineties. Even before American imperialism, there was French, British, and Dutch imperialism. It is not a new set of relationships. But we do have to ask ourselves: Does the Internet undermine the old relationships, or does it reinforce them? I am only trying to suggest that there are key people, key levels in the United States who see a very practical utilization for imperialistic purposes. That could be an alert signal. If the Internet is becoming a major vehicle for transnational corporate advertising, you are quite justified in talking about the extension of cultural imperialism into the Internet.



Taiwan Media and Inter-Asia Cultural Studies

Interview with Kuan-Hsing Chen

Kuan-Hsing Chen is a central figure in the growing network of political activists and cultural studies academics in the Asia-Pacific region. I had never met him before when he picked up me and Toshiya Ueno at the Taipei airport. Chen is a passionate speaker, a radical critic, and a brilliant networker, both in Taiwan and internationally. And he is a serious political fighter. Immediately, we dove into the complex universes of the Tokyo academic Left and discussed its refined forms of non-communication, a special topic of Chen. Like few others, he has the capability to switch between theoretical debates and institutional politics of the global “cultural studies” tribe, and the political practices of radical trade unions, gay and lesbian groups, and media activists. A true revolutionary pragmatist, he is dedicated to all the actual movements fighting for social change. The interview was conducted in Taipei, on December 20, 1997.

Before we discuss media activism, can you tell us about the general media situation in Taiwan since the late 1980s?

Before the lifting of martial law in 1987, everything was controlled by the state. It was impossible to get a publishing license for print, not to mention radio or television. Right after the lifting, around one thousand new newspapers registered. The postwar era, with its accumulation of capital, has been producing classes of people with consuming power. That sort of energy demands a political democracy, lead by these people. The so-called democratization process was essentially a bourgeois democratic form, modeled after the Americans. Starting from there, the entire society was flowing, breaking the old boundaries. The political transition got in place, but in a completely chaotic manner. For one year there were at least three thousand street demonstrations. Each newspaper has its own, hidden affiliation with this or that political party. They cannot affiliate with the official party line; it has to go in an indirect way. We used to have the tradition of the literary supplements.

After 1987, cultural criticism emerged in the newspaper context. At that moment, the conservatives and even the liberals did not have much to say. The alternative radio movement started to emerge. But the most influential, transformative power came from satellites. Suddenly, the cable people built an infrastructure and in three years, the number of households with cable jumped from 15 to 70 percent. The original, state-connected television was losing control. Literally everything became satellized. Now there are around one hundred channels. This means a redistribution of advertisements and power. And it did serve as an alternative to the original power. The political control decreased, but never completely dissolved. The entire media landscape is now commercial. But from the late 1980s to 1995 a certain energy accumulated that is still moving on.

Internationally, the video activist group Green Team became well known. What happened to it?

Green Team was no longer effective by 1989. Their moment was from 1986–1988, the peak moment of street demonstrations. Green Team took the historical moment and recorded about 1,500 tapes, which are still available. One person is still running it. Later on, they switched to quick news

episodes. The problem with that is the distribution system. By the early nineties some of the members got really exhausted. There was a movement of alternative video, which followed the model of Green Team, trying to establish alternative distribution points. The former political oppositional party now has its satellite station. You need huge capital. A part of the critical energy could continue, but at the moment there is no space. There are alternative radio stations, but with limited power. In 1995, lots of the intellectual magazines ceased to exist. The younger generation was not able to emerge, for various reasons, so the energy died out.

Is the younger generation perhaps more into consumerism, which is producing other forms of subculture, than other generations are?

The consolidation of consumer society did not come into being until the second part of the 1980s. The local culture industry did not start until then. The accumulation of capital used to be export oriented. But suddenly people discovered the international market. In terms of music, our generation grew up with the American Top 40. Pop was dominant, not rock and roll. These songs were distributed via pirated copies. But since the 1980s there has been a balance between the Top 40 and the local music production, or a struggle between them. Today's students are going to karaoke and nobody sings in English. It is all in Taiwanese or Mandarin. From 1993 there has been a heavy-duty Hong Kong influence occurring. It became hip because of the 1997 handover to speak in a Hong Kong accent. This was a signal of the stratification of the cultural market.

From the mid-1980s that critical generation accumulated a certain authority and leadership. But there is indeed a generation gap. From 1994 on there has been a booming industry of queer writing, by authors who are still in college or graduate school. This explains why the gay and lesbian movement is so visible, partly through commodification. This is a different type of movement, unlike the late 1980s street fighting. The cultural atmosphere was mediated through commodity structures. The role of the student movement in all this is perhaps difficult to understand for outsiders. It completely died out. You cannot compare it to the situation in Japan or South Korea.

After June 4, 1989, students here also took over the Changkai-Chek Memorial for a week, protesting against the National Assembly. This ended

with a traumatic scene when fifty student representatives went into the presidential office. This cultivated a certain ego, a psychic “that’s something real.” The student generation activists moved into the political arena, with different factions competing against each other. So that generation is gone. In this context, it is a bit strange to use the term “new social movement.” Before the lifting of martial law, there were no movements, so everything is new. The younger generation still has a critical component to it. But it could not decipher which direction to take, so it is seemingly less powerful.

How would you describe the Internet generation?

The commercial Internet is not as big as elsewhere. It is still largely depending on the academic infrastructure. The Internet is a crystal light of society: Those with more power and resources will have a bigger space. The lesbian groups are an exception, not the gays, by the way. The younger generation of feminists are making an active use of the Net, mainly because of the commodification of queer identity. These are writers with cultural capital and names.

In the field of cultural studies, you seem to place much more emphasis on a better understanding of the political economy than on popular culture or the media in general. Why is that?

This is connected to a personal trajectory. I was educated in the United States during that booming, initiating moment of cultural studies. Now I would call this, within the Anglo-American context, an obsession with pop culture. It becomes something playful and fun to study. Superficial. Simply addressing something called pop culture becomes a formalistic categorization. It is a dead end. Nothing critically or politically is happening there. It is fun to read—that’s the end of the story. But I do not want to deny that. It documents certain currents of life. I do not want to kick anybody, but I think that the combination of political economy and history, together with cultural studies, is absolutely essential.

So where is this international cultural studies supposed to go? Globalization is only a buzzword. What is the hidden agenda? That is still unclear. But without these other elements and their explanatory power, including anthropology, we are losing the context. Coming home and talking about

cultural studies is kind of weird. We are writing in newspapers, and one could call that cultural criticism. In fact, in the East Asian context, cultural studies has a long literary tradition. You might not agree with its politics, but that form of writing has its own history. When you go to Japan you deeply feel that. When you read the critical cultural essays of Maluyama Masawa it is not academic writing, but it is powerful, expressive, and passionate. It is in tune with the social flow and the political reality. This is a tradition that has to be reclaimed or turned into something else. Even if we agree that the mythical history of cultural studies, coming from England, is now the dominant current, it also grew out of the New Left, by connecting with the colonial intellectuals. They were deeply connected to political and social movements. This gets cut off in the process of internationalization, especially in the United States. If we do not reconnect now, we will lose our political energy.

There has been a fascination and urgency from the West to connect to "Asia" and its "emerging markets." One could even call it an objective force. After the businessmen and politicians came the academics, artists, and intellectuals. Should we reject this fascination, which is gone now anyway because of the economic/currency crisis?

No. Fascination involves desire and even if you reject it, it will flow. I understand this objective condition to link up with this funny thing called "Asia." There has been the phenomena of the triumphalism of the rise of Asia: we are colonized, we were oppressed, and now we are finally in the center of the universe—without any critical reflection on that. This triumphalism is a result of the resentment policies against imperial power for the past four centuries. It is very much understandable. It is a sudden energy, a boom, but also extremely dangerous. I can understand the anxiety and fear, that you want to do business, but you do not understand.

In Japan, since the mid-nineteenth century, this process of Europeanization has been going on. Japan understands far more about Europe than Europe understands about Japan. So there is nothing wrong with the search for a new balance, people beginning to understand each other. But it is very dangerous to call this entire space "Asia." There is no historical, political, or even geographical unity to that. I rather prefer the term "Interasia," which comes from "Interafrica" or "Interamerica." There is a certain unity in East

Asia, brought together by Japanese colonialism in the prewar era and by American dominance after the war. But if you are situated in East Asia, you do not know anything about India. We do not even know our neighbor, the Philippines. We do not know Korea and Japan. Taipei is closer to New York and L.A. than to Manila or Seoul. That was the effect of the Cold War. The Asianization process that started after the Cold War came to an end and is only resuming now.



The Ins and Outs of the Soros Internet Program in Former Eastern Europe

An Email Exchange with Jonathan Peizer

At the end of 1993 Jonathan Peizer created the Network Internet Program for the Open Society Institute New York (OSI-NY), a Soros network affiliate, and assumed the role as its program director. He is also the chief information officer of the Soros Foundation, defining technology policy for the organization and managing the system operations for OSI-NY. Peizer traveled extensively in Central and Eastern Europe to set up Internet connectivity, training, and content development programs with the goal of supporting “civil society” and its “emerging” institutions. Peizer did not choose the easiest job—installing Internet facilities throughout Eastern Europe, then in Russia, Central Asia, and southern Africa. His Internet activity involved linking newspapers, schools and universities, NGOs, and cultural organizations, not general public access for individuals. Rather, his efforts focused on a civil society that consists of organizations, not individuals. This is opposed to the more anarchistic, libertarian strategy of hackers that concentrates on individual users and thereby promotes a very particular form of Western subjectivity. Our email exchange begins with a discussion of network strategies.

You have been responsible for the Network Internet Program. Can you give us a basic outline of the choices you have made? As far as I have been able to see, you gave priority to the networking of the Soros Foundation itself, including the affiliated NGOs, and not the general public. Network for us, not access for all. Tell me if I am wrong about this.

I would conservatively estimate about 750,000 people in the region have benefited directly from content, training, infrastructure, and connectivity projects funded by our network and local foundation Internet programs since their inception in the 1993–1994 period. The foundation network consists of approximately 3,000 people, so it's safe to say we have expanded outside our immediate constituency. We target institutions that are key to the development of civil society and, as such, benefit the population at large. The primary constituencies the Internet program supports are academic and research institutions, schools, NGOs, independent media, cultural institutions, medical institutions, libraries, and in some cases unaffiliated individuals.

From 1994–1997 the program concentrated on “survival connectivity”—just making sure access existed. From 1997–2001 it focused on content and training grants to targeted constituencies still lacking Internet support. Since 1997, the Network Internet Program no longer makes infrastructure and connectivity grants. The foundations are limiting their own local Internet grant-making activities in this area as well. The exception is Central Asia and the Caucasus where lack of infrastructure is still an issue. Even in these locations, however, we are more inclined to enter into partnerships than to “go it alone” as we did in the early days of the program.

In the CEE/FSU, the Internet program has always concentrated on satisfying public demand. In some cases we've had to create infrastructure, because meeting demand necessitated it. The foundations are not in the business of running ISPs, however. For that reason, they are in the midst of divesting most infrastructure created in the early days of the program by granting it to others or spinning off entities into free-standing NGOs or commercial ISPs.

Outside the CEE/FSU—in addition to working with our foundations in Haiti and Southern Africa—the OSI Network Internet Program does grant making focused on human rights and independent media. The program has

provided grants for Hong Kong, Cuba, China, Kurdistan, and minority human rights sites. It has also funded an independent Arabic news site. The program is a large funder of global Internet policy initiatives as well.

I did not want to question the benefits of the Soros Foundation and the Network Internet Program in particular. Everyone who has been to the former Eastern Bloc will admit the tremendous achievements of the Soros-sponsored media structures and initiatives. Here I would rather speak about the premises with which these media have been set up. You do not mention the public sphere . . . you speak about constituencies, communities, specific groups, not the public at large. Of course the channels serve the general population, when we think of all the radio stations, publications, translations, meetings, education, libraries . . . and the Internet. Still, the open society seems to be realized in steps, via specific groups and channels. Is this related to the still strong antidemocratic forces? Strictly "open" would mean to also give voice to anti-Semitism, racism, and nationalism.

The constituencies I mentioned do represent the public sphere. Making infrastructure available to the public at large without any focus or understanding of demand would have been a tremendous waste of resources. To create open societies when there were none before, you must concentrate on those sectors most involved in fostering civil society and give them the necessary tools to achieve that end. We focused on meeting demand, providing only what people were ready to use. On the subject of public access, however, many of our foundations do employ a "free mail" service as a component of their program strategy. They provide this service to literally tens of thousands of people.

The Internet is really nothing more than a distribution mechanism. Efficient, powerful, and literally society-changing, but a simply a distribution mechanism nonetheless. Once the wires were in place, the Internet program had as its main goal helping other OSI programs deliver content over the infrastructure it had created. This was where the real benefit of the Internet was realized in meeting our objectives to foster Open Society Institute societies. Naturally we targeted the constituencies and areas we were already working with, and where we had developed human networks. This allowed for the most efficient leveraging of funding and created a greater probability of success.

In the territories we are discussing, enough nationalism, racism, and anti-Semitism already existed without the Open Society Institute helping to foster it further. Rather we provided the alternative view, and since that was in short supply, we used the most efficient tool possible to leverage the message, the Internet. Let's examine one example. Albania, Europe's poorest country, having undergone a process of further decay and (self-)destruction, was in urgent need of communication with the outside world. The isolation, even at this moment, is stunning. The Soros Internet center, now running well, uses a satellite link and package radio connections inside Tirana to link university buildings. Still, one gets the impression there of a heroic project with little or no use for common people. For security reasons, such buildings look like fortresses. In such harsh poverty and such a politically unstable situation, how do you imagine the Internet will grow? And what will happen if, within a few years, there isn't any more Soros funding?

Albania is an extreme example of a country on the verge of economic collapse and civil war. The government's official position is to not allow commercial Internet access. The infrastructure is incredibly poor (and in many cases nonexistent); outside Tirana and between cities, travel to many parts of Albania (even for Albanians) is rather dangerous. That there is an Internet program at all speaks to the power of the medium and the success of the program. We managed to create an Internet link through affiliations with the UNDP that allowed us to avoid commercial restrictions. We then created a public access center and linked the program to our education and other initiatives. This provided access to NGOs, media, and students. Internet growth in Albania will be limited until the situation changes, but the important thing is that it exists now, and Albania is linked to the rest of the world instead of totally isolated from it.

Your countryman, Daniel Erasmus, astutely points out that if the ratio of the world's population were reduced to one hundred people, only two would have Internet access. Despite the incredible growth of the medium, the global user population is still very limited, yet this statistic does not speak to "collateral benefit" of the medium on the population at large. There is an oft-quoted statistic that 50 percent of the people in the world have still not made their first phone call. But just because everyone doesn't have a phone or make a call does not mean people don't benefit from the medium. Think of the village with one phone or radio or television in its community center.

Not everyone needs to have a phone or the Internet to realize a benefit from it. The rural villager or farmer in the field may not need direct access to the Internet—but if you give access to the medical practitioner taking care of that villager and his neighbors or the agricultural representative helping the farmer with crop data you are making a significant difference. Now is this the “ideal.” No, it is not, but it is realistic and it does create impact—which is the real objective.

The same is true as it relates to Internet in Albania; the people who will eventually change the situation in Albania are the people who are exposed to the Internet now. The same is true in Belarus, Yugoslavia, Burma, and so forth . . . In all these repressive contexts, access is limited but still exists. Let's not forget a couple of the most famous regional uses of the Internet in these restrictive contexts: Radio B92 during the Milosevic election annulments and the Gorbachev coup. It's worth noting that during the latest civil unrest in Albania, the local independent news was also placed on the Internet.

Using Bosnia as an example of what might happen in Albania in future—During the war, the Internet program provided first email and then Internet access through the Zamir Network of BBSs. After the war, people understood how Internet had helped during the conflict, and in fact the service flourished afterward. The seeds were planted during a time of conflict when the urgency of any type of reliable communication made the most impact on the minds of the people.

The reason the program does not provide equal access to everyone in equal measure is simply because it is not possible from a resource or reality standpoint. The reality is that some people are ready and willing to exploit the Internet in the region and some are not. Moreover, buying everyone a computer and modem for home, training them all and upgrading the entire phone system in a country to support Internet connectivity is beyond the means of the Network Internet Program, the Soros Foundation, and most national governments. . . . So what we concentrated on was creating core points of international access, public access centers, and connections to local institutions who could best exploit the medium in leveraging the concepts of civil society.

The really unique thing about the network is that it provides resources to people with vision and implementation skills who do not have them because the resources are so limited. Local institutions are loathe to provide funding for projects with no track record (e.g., new ideas) that could fail.

Once a project is a proven success though, we expect others to continue its funding if it is truly a priority issue. When projects have proven successful, cost effective, and/or more efficient to accomplish a given task, resources are usually found to continue it. We have experienced this reality many times with projects we initially supported. On the other hand, some projects that should continue to survive do fail for lack of funding, even though they are important priorities. Our focus is to give people the opportunity to demonstrate that ideas are good and workable in the first place.

How do you look at the development of the Internet in Central and Eastern Europe? One can expect that the "emerging markets" such as Slovenia, Estonia, Poland, and Hungary will, sooner or later, be integrated into EU/NATO networks, whereas the wild, abandoned regions will be monitored and contained outside Fortress Europe. Are you afraid of an increase of censorship and state control over media and telcos? And what kind of commercial culture do you envision? Many of the new Internet firms do not serve the population but merely represent companies on the Web and produce cheap code and interface design for the West. That would be a tragic result of all the efforts: training a young generation that will migrate to the West, to earn real money, or that will be forced to remain in their country, to do the job remotely, as a part of the 24-hour-a-day economy. What if the "open" society gets reduced to only that gateway?

State control and censorship is a real concern. The Internet is a double edged sword in this regard. On the one hand, states that try to control it have learned that it is very difficult, because of the chaotic, decentralized nature of the medium. It therefore functions as an excellent to bypass state control of information. Moreover, it's difficult for one state to legislate content and use because the Internet, by its nature, is not constrained by national boundaries.

On the other hand, because many of those who would seek to control the Internet don't understand it, it has a tendency to provoke fear and ill-conceived reactions when legislation is introduced to control or censor it. I refer to my own country's (U.S.) failed attempt to introduce draconian Internet censorship legislation through Congress in 1996 (the Telecommunications Decency Act). I am concerned enough about this issue to be currently funding a study analyzing examples of how (and why) countries around the world try to censor the Internet and detailing ways to get bypass this censorship.

Commercial concerns are going to have to come up with some pretty creative and innovative ways to entice and keep the “eyeballs” of savvy young consumers who can do more than just “change channels.” They can interact with the medium, quickly display their distaste or approval, and expect instantaneous results to their queries and concerns.

On the subject of the Internet fostering further migration to the West in search of opportunity, I would think it might have the opposite effect in that one can access and transfer the same information from anywhere in the world to do one’s job.

Coming from a country that was founded upon and literally renews itself each generation because of immigration, I have never viewed this as a bad thing.

All in all, you remain so optimistic! Is this your nature, or does the foundation leave you no other option? I mean, there is a war in Kosov@, numerous conflicts in Central Asia, and a crisis in Russia threatening the entire region. Is the Internet the solution to all this? Isn't the Soros Foundation, in part, creating a managerial class that further worsens the already existing social conflicts, maybe without you (or us) having this intention? Why not also consider proactive reflexivity when it comes to the Internet?

Actually I am optimistic by nature—anyone that knows me will tell you that. Part of it is cultural, I am sure. It’s a by-product of living in the United States with its overabundance of optimism. But the other part is that I believe personally, like Soros, that we influence our environments simply by being a part of them. When I am optimistic about a project, I subsequently influence its outcome in a positive manner. Fortunately, I work with a lot of committed people in the region who feel the same way as I do about it.

Sorry, I cannot resist using this metaphor to answer your examples—the Internet is not the magic bullet to solving the world’s problems. However, communication and information sharing can lessen conflict by eliminating the fear of not knowing. It also ensures that people who can make a difference have access to good and timely information. While it still took too long, what we saw on the news at night from Bosnia finally prompted the international community to act. Compare that to what happened in the death camps during World War II when only rumors circulated and there was no official confirmation of what was happening for years. Rwanda was

horrible, but can you imagine how much worse it could have been if nobody was watching?

Let's use medicine or education as an example of what I am getting at. Problems surrounding these two areas, like many other problems affecting society, have two major components: lack of resources and lack of information in equal measure. You could easily bankrupt some nations trying to obtain the resources (medical supplies, educational materials) to resolve their problems in these areas. On the other hand, for a fraction of the cost, you could connect people to the Internet so they could share information and best practices with each other, as well as communicate with people around the world. Think of what an individual Internet connection linking all hospitals and health clinics in a country could accomplish.

I always think about the German doctor, Mike Frank, who works in the hinterlands of Mongolia as a surgeon treating patients. He has an Internet connection and regularly confers with doctors around the world sending images and X-rays out over the Internet and helping others diagnose rare cases. Mike's patients, spread throughout the provinces of Mongolia, have access to the most important single medical resource in the world—learned and experienced medical practitioners. They have access to other human beings who share their information and experience through the Internet. If information is power, the right metaphor for the Internet is a cold-fusion-powered generator.

On the final point, you can't have it both ways. The earlier questions seem to suggest the program is not doing enough. Now I am being asked if the program is doing too much! As far as creating some type of Internet-elite in the region, I reject the notion outright. The program is demand-driven. We try to help satisfy the needs that exist. Fortunately for all of us, there are insightful, creative people on the ground who see the use of this medium as an effective means of resolving at least part of the problems affecting their societies.

These questions are perhaps important for all of us who share the same concerns and passions. It has been said that NGOs lack accountability. I am not so sure about this. What I do know is the big lack of vision that exists on the European side. Brussels can only interpret events in economic terms, without any sensibility about the importance of (independent) media, even culture in general, to say nothing of a comprehensive Internet policy (going beyond e-commerce). What we need is a much broader

awareness about the way in which Internet (and other media) will shape the future's structure of the "public sphere." I know, this sounds big and ambitious. In the case of the Soros Internet activities, I am never sure if you should just assist locals, working in the background, or if you have the intention, the drive, to address these strategic issues on a much larger, public scale.

The Internet is a grassroots phenomenon, so trying to organize it topdown and address the entire Internet does not work very well. The "broader awareness" you speak of is best fostered using the natural "character" of the Internet and its modular nature. I mentioned above that we sponsor Internet policy initiatives. These initiatives impact the broader Internet community at large. When the program first set out to do this in 1994, Internet policy as a concept was still in its infancy, with issues of privacy, encryption, and censorship not fully developed in the mind of the public or legislators. For one year I canvassed potential partner organizations, knowing we did not have the expertise in-house to develop the initiative. More important, I didn't feel we should develop it in-house in a kind of synthetic way. When a couple of organizations with expertise in this area interested in creating an international Internet policy initiative were identified, seed funding was provided to each to develop a project.

The next year was spent evaluating the results of these efforts. Further funding was finally provided to the organization most successful at developing the initiative and attracting other groups to the cause. This organization was the Global Internet Liberty Campaign—founded by EPIC and the ACLU with a membership now exceeding forty Internet policy-related organizations worldwide. GILC provides information, alerts, and advocacy. It acts as a natural resource to legislators seeking to approach Internet policy rationally. When we started this, the U.S. contingent was definitely farther ahead in experience and knowledge of Internet policy issues than most of its European counterparts. After a year of funding, however, the European contingency participating in GILC had gathered a tremendous amount of expertise in sharing experience over the Net with other members. It wasn't long until the more Internet-savvy European members of GILC decided to form a regional Internet policy coalition to address policy issues unique to the nature and character of the European community. I refer to privacy issues that are more developed in Europe, and sensitive issues like hate speech that we in North America do not have the same history with. My

program will fund this European initiative at the outset in order to nurture it as it did GILC. Other funding partners will be involved too.

The point is that our Internet program approached Internet policy and the means to tackle it using the nature of the Internet to guide it. We started with interested parties who attracted others, and we created a cascade affect rather than trying to address the problem of Internet policy throughout the world all at once. In Asia, Latin America, Africa, and so forth, Internet policy is still underdeveloped, but now at least there are tested models that can be adopted to address it—there are organizations that can be joined on the Internet. Soon two groups (one in the United States and one in Europe) with similar mandates but different priorities will exist. Other groups will have a choice as to which group to emulate. To create the public sphere and greater awareness that you speak of, sometimes you have to start small and let a solution develop further, in phases, rather than tackling the entire problem all at once.

I think this is the secret to the success of Soros Foundation programs. People are surprised we can spend a fraction of what government agencies and international organizations spend, and still be more effective. But the reality is that these agencies and governments have a restriction that we do not. They are generally mandated to approach the entire problem and solve it for the benefit of their entire constituency, whereas the Soros Foundation approaches a problem and simply tries to solve it by introducing successful pilot initiatives. We do not start out mandated to resolving problems to the benefit of the entire society, but simply in creating approaches to the development of civil society that work.

If you modularize a problem, and focus on solving a piece of it, many times that solution can be applied to other pieces of the problem to solve them too. Some problems are best not addressed trying to find a solution that is all things to all people from the outset. Unfortunately, this is not a politically correct concept and is the reason government directives sometimes fail. Many times the vision is grand, as is the resource allocation, but the impact is negligible. Approaching the problem of Internet in the public sphere may be an easier puzzle to solve if you create a viable example and propagate it using the strength of the Internet—its decentralized method of disseminating good ideas.



There Is No Information, Only Transformation

An Interview with Bruno Latour

Bruno Latour is a philosopher, specializing in the anthropology of science and technology. He is a professor at the Center of the Sociology of Innovation at the Ecole Nationale Supérieure des Mines in Paris. This interview was conducted together with Pit Schultz, during Latour's visit to Hybrid WorkSpace.

At the moment there are two concepts of the computer: an abstract, computational machine, based on mathematics and language. Opposed to this we have the future computer as an image processing device, an interactive television set. How do we look at this distinction between the language-based machine versus the image-based medium?

I do not believe that computers are abstract. There is a very interesting article, "On the Origin of Objects," by a computer philosopher called Brian Cantwell-Smith, in a book about digital print. He made the comment that the fact that there is (either) 0 and (or) 1 has absolutely no connection with the abstractness. It is actually very concrete, never 0 and 1 (at the same time). The distinction you suggested is slightly misleading. The origin of this distinction lies in the notion of information.

There is only transformation. Information as something that will be carried through space and time, without deformation, is a complete myth. People who deal with the technology will actually use the practical notion of transformation. From the same bytes, in terms of "abstract encoding," the output you get is entirely different, depending on the medium you use. Down with information. It is a bad view of science and a bad rendering of the contemporary critique of images, all this fight against naturalization.

Still there are the two views of the computer: either it is a machine that is still owned by the scientists, or it is going to be an image processor, which will soon enter popular culture.

I am not sure if I agree with the terms of the divide. To say that the computer is a scientific, abstract machine is largely misleading. There is a book called *The Soul of the New Machine*. That is the right expression. You can find that in the work of Brian Smith on the embodiment of the computer. After all it is made of silicon. It has its own embodiment on the level of digits and bytes.

The computer is not a reservoir of abstraction, scientificity, and technicity. Science and technology for me does not mean abstract. It means highly socialized, extremely embodied, and localized. There might be badly designed computers, or interfaces that are not ergonomic. But the idea of an abstract computer that, so to say, falls in a humane dimension that will be threatened by this eruption is absurd. Even since Pascal's first calculating machine, the socializing has been going on.

Michel Serres made the argument that all what we are talking about concerning computers is Leibniz's dream, materialized at last. The idea of a universal language that will code and encode everything, the idea of free accessibility to gigantic libraries is Leibniz's idea. So finally we are doing what Leibniz has proposed. But it became a machine that never works exactly the way we want and was dreamed of in seventeenth century. It is the history of what I call the "immutable mobile." The notion of the true contradictory function of immutability and maximum mobility. It is linked of course to the history of the West, to maximize these two contradictory functions.

Elisabeth Eisenstein makes this same point in her history of the printing press. Digital technology is an extension of the printing press, one step further from mobile types. It is not a revolutionary element. The moving pixel is added to the movable type. I always react negatively against the idea that technology is a foreign body inside the humane. It does not come from another planet; it is highly socialized and connected with a long history. Negating this typifies the danger of techno enthusiasm. I would add to the Peoples Communication Charter that is hanging here on the wall: "Do not believe that the computer has a short history." The computer is a perfect example of how unmodern we are.

The possibility of shifting boundaries among images, text and things, and virtuality is a completely classical anthropological feature. Now in Paris, people are using a visualized "Second World," where you can rent flats. People who are living in the drab *banlieues* at the periphery can now have virtual flats on the Champs Élysées. But that is nothing compared to what it is to live in this society, which is a virtual reality from scratch. It materializes on the screen, with the notion of avatars and second reality. But it is not a revolutionary break from being in society. My argument is exactly anti-Virilio, if you want.

At the end of your lecture here in Kassel you suggested that we should step back, out of the flow of images. Do you also think that there is the danger of information overflow?

My argument was always the opposite. There is a heritage of the iconoclastic dispute, which is nowadays renewed around this notion of the overload of images. Lots of images were destroyed because people were overloaded. That was exactly Luther's argument. Too many images that hide the important features, which is itself not visible. My argument is an iconophilic one,

which is always the opposite. One image, isolated from the rest, freeze-framed from the series of transformation, has no meaning. An image of a galaxy has no reference. The *transformation* of the images of the galaxy has.

So, it is an anti-information argument. Pictures of a galaxy have no information content. The image itself has no meaning if it cannot be related to another spectrography of a galaxy. What has reference is the transformations of images. Being iconophilic means following the flow of images, without believing that they carry information. Nor is it iconoclastic in the sense: Let us get rid of the image because what we want to access is the invisible, the ineffable. On the contrary, if we follow the logic of the images, they themselves pass into one other image. Images demonstrate transformation, not information.

But then there is the contradiction in the very daily practice of transformation and the talk, the hype about information flows, Internet universality, etc. It is the same with money. When you talk with financial specialists, it is highly localized, confidence-based, small networks of people calling one another by first name. Again, if we go outside, we talk about huge flows of money going from New York to Hong Kong in a second. We have a tremendous hype about globalization, immediacy, universality, and speed.

On the other side we see localized transformations, and there seems to be no connection between the two. Somebody like Paul Virilio is interesting because he, rightly, attacks the hype. This is good commonsense critique. But we never study the practice. So the computer is not an abstract machine. Everything is highly incarnated and situated in silicon chips. There is this bizarre love-hate relationship. Virilio is typical in this. He loves to hate the technohype. And the technicians very often hate to love. But there is another way, in between.

But there is the notion of secrecy and hermetism. Specialists and technicians do have secret knowledge about the implementation of the modes of transformation. Average people do not know how financial markets work or how currencies are transformed from one to another. But these transfers have a lot of impact on the society. The transformations become myths, which cause fear.

But is it secret or is it localized know-how? My feeling is that we should not add to the myth. No myths about local know-how! The notions of information, universal immediacy, and globalization add to the myth. It is not

very surprising for the common public that you need a lot of work in order to produce an image. Look at the cloud chamber that is here at Documenta X, or Hamilton's display. When you talk about particles, no one will understand it. When do speak about bubble trails in the bubble chamber, invented by Wilson to study clouds, it becomes extremely simple to understand. Secrecy exists in research labs for legal reasons, for patent reasons, but it is much less important than is usually being said.

A lot of mystery in the science practice, which I know best, comes because we render things more obscure. And intellectuals should not render things more obscure than they are. It is a mystery we like to have in order to debunk it. The notion of localized practice is so commonsense. I do not know how sausages are made. Sausages are obtained through a lot of transformations as well. And since I do not hype sausages, I do not see why we should hype computer images. Like what you do here in Hybrid WorkSpace: introducing groups week after week in the practice of technology. That seems a perfectly sensible thing to do. Nothing is hidden; expect through our love to hate.

Universities are now closing their public part of the Internet and are building up their own, closed, parallel intranets. A lot of data that were publicly available will be withdrawn. This goes together with the privatization and commercialization of much scientific research. How do you interpret these developments?

I am not enough of an expert in this. What I know is that you cannot ask scientists to work publicly, immediately connected to millions of people. The notion of openness and immediacy is a complete nightmare. But this is different from the notion of private knowledge. This process, again, has been going on for centuries in chemistry. One of the aspects is the legal one. How much is private and how much is appropriated? Openness is not very productive.

You need to have local niches. Isolated, provincial, unconnected disciplines have been shown very successful in the past. You need to have your own little corner, and we will see what the consequences of the Internet will be on scientific work. Scientists keep subscribing to very expensive journals because they need the stamp of hierarchical knowledge. As long as the Net does not find a way to provide this, it will not achieve the authoritative status with the scientific community. Publications on the Web are still very traditional. It has not moved much, with the exception perhaps of email.

How would you then judge attempts, like Nettime, to develop a so-called Net criticism, locating itself inside the technology, no longer judging it as an outsider, in order to overcome this phase of the hype, without going back to cultural pessimism.

If you find a way to deterritorialize, to dissolve localities and hierarchies, there might also be ways to reconstruct hierarchies with filters, tastes, judgments, and values. Everybody is complaining about the lack of hierarchy in the Net. The more unmediated access you have, the more closed and highly hierarchical and critical sites you will find. In our center we invented a system called "semiotext," which gives maps of Internet texts by clustering the words into a system called Leximap. It gives you highly hierarchized maps. This sort of system will proliferate. It gives you depth of vision, which can be given a critique. It will be a highly elaborate site if people know that they can find good critiques there.

Again, everything that runs against the notion of information will happen just by itself. Universality, fastness, immediacy will not suddenly be there, despite the hype. On the contrary, local transformation, hierarchy, taste, critique: that will happen. The idea of information as immutability and mobility being noncontradictory, being able to flow everywhere, does not work at the level of science, nor at the level of the computer or politics. We can make a safe bet that it will not happen.

How do you see the relation between real and virtual spaces, the ruptures and possibilities to connect them, like we do here, in Hybrid WorkSpace at Documenta X? Do you believe in the so-called synergy of all media? Here we work with video, the Net, film, and print of course. We have all these different media here. Should we encourage the hybridity of all these machines?

Hybrid is a word I like. But you know also there this no instantaneous access to these machines. You need to train people. It will never work exactly the way you want it. You need a lot of different cables. They are hanging on the wall here. Every time the hype is deflated and you say that you will locally connect media to produce a few new effects is a perfectly reasonable statement for me. To connect all with all is pure ideology.

When it comes to multimedia: I was in Colmar, looking at the Isenheim altarpiece by Matthias Gruenwald. It is hypermedia: The different panels open and close, depending on the days of the week and the

feasts. It includes painting plus sculpture plus the reading of the gospel, the mass.

The rule is: Whatever medium there is, you will always find someone to make a connection with them. But this is not the same as saying that there is an instantaneous connectability. The digital only adds a little speed to it. But that is small compared to talks, prints, or writing. The difficulty with computer development is to respect the little innovation there is, without making too much out of it. We add a little spirit to this thing when we use words like *universal*, *unmediated*, or *global*. But if we say that, in order to make visible a collective of five to ten billion people, in the long history of immutable mobiles, the byte conversion is adding a little speed, which favors certain connections more than others, then this seems a reasonable statement. To say that we are living in a cyberworld, on the other hand, is a complete absurdity.



Implosion, Media, and the Arts in Albania

A Series of Interviews with Eduard Muka

The Albanian art critic and curator Edi Muka is perhaps the person I have interviewed most. Here is a selection of these exchanges, made in the period 1996–2000. Our conversations followed the country's stormy transition: Albania first tried to recover from decades of isolation and poverty (1991–1996), imploded after the breakdown of the pyramid scheme (March 1997), again faced moments of civil war (September 1998), then had to cope with the influx of hundreds of thousands of refugees during the Kosov@ crisis in the spring of 1999 before finding a new balance in 2000.

I met Edi Muka for the first time in September 1996 during the V-2 East meeting, a part of the DEAF conference in Rotterdam. At the time, Muka worked as an artist and assistant professor in the Visual Arts Department of the Academy of Fine Arts in Tirana. As a curator, he worked with a group of young artists to promote the alternative arts movement. In 1990, while still a student, he took part in the movements that overthrew the former communist regime. In the confusion afterward, Edi spent some time in Italy, making money as a street painter, then returning to Albania to teach at the Academy of Fine Arts. He is a small, well-dressed, cool, and laid-back guy with sunglasses. He's not very loud, though he is excitable.

Interview One: September 1996

What happened within the Albanian art scene right after the changes in the early 1990s?

In 1992, the Soros Foundation organized an exhibition of paintings, because that was the only known medium at the time. This was the first moment where you could see some different tendencies (let's not call them new). There was this huge gap of information since the mid-fifties between Albania and what was going on elsewhere in the world. All these people were raised according to the social realist methods. Artists, who are supposed to be rebels, having suffered a lot under this cruel regime, scarcely dared to take the ship and get to Italy. So in 1992, in this first exhibition, artists tried to escape reality. Not escape from the country (because they did not have the courage), but an escape from the known schemes into formalism. It was a revival of abstract painting, looking outmoded, if you take it out of its context. Nobody thought about concepts and ideas; everybody fought against them.

At that time, being in Italy, I had to make my living as a painter, making portraits and landscapes. Besides this, I began researching conceptuality. When I came back after a year, I had a personal show, which included conceptual paintings and installations. It received a good reaction from the public, but a very bad one from the conservative side, which, unfortunately, is in power in Albania nowadays. The controversy started in the newspapers. They are not open-minded; they want everything to remain within the tradition of painting as a craft. Students have to become craftsmen; they are not interested in the artistic process. We just want to make the students able to analyze the situation in a visual way, with the medium he or she wants to choose.

But this controversy does not take place as an artistic debate; it is just a matter of power. You are not given the right to defend your ideas. In this respect, the help from foundations or other organizations is vital. Even if we lose one battle, we are going to win the war. Religious art is not involved, that is at least one good thing. What the current power promotes is the ability of the artist to move the brush in a certain way and create the surface. It is a very superficial, formalistic demand. They don't want to offer the students something they themselves do not even know. This is a pity because the school is the right place to do experiments. You better direct the

students in an unknown territory, and let them discover, even by making mistakes.

Under which circumstances does media art have to make a start?

The isolation is still having its impact. The information we receive about alternative media, including media art, is very limited. I share all the material I get with my colleagues and students. Only freedom is changing things. Media art has only just started. I can mention a young artist by the name of Anri Sala. He came from a painting background, shifted to installations, worked with photography, and has just produced two videos—a twenty-minute piece called *The Tongue*, which I showed here at DEAF. He also produced a computer show recently.

A problem here is the difficulty of linking with history. Regarding experimental film, it is impossible—there wasn't anything. But there is a famous dynasty of photographers in Shkodra, which is in northern Albania. There is a phototheque in this city with marvelous material, now being restored. It contains mostly documentary photos, done in an artistic way, landscapes, and family portraits.

The first Albanian artistic photo show was held in April 1996, in the Ernst Museum in Budapest. I worked together with Katalin Timar on this show and was amazed by the conceptual quality, despite all the technical problems that still exist. The students of the fine arts academy also did a first photo exhibit with the same conceptual cargo. In 1995 we were able to establish a photo lab in the academy, with the help of the Soros Foundation and the British Council. This year the school will open a computer atelier and a designers program. But the school abandoned all the programs we had prepared, due to the political changes after the elections in May. There will be no room for research.

A new project concerns building up an archive of Albanian art of the last fifty years, because it does not exist at all. We would like to interview and document the works and lives of older and younger artists, not only to conserve it, but also to build up our new experience, whatever our past experience is. We just cannot and must not deny it and make profit off it. Making it accessible through the Internet could be a first step of showing what media communication is.

We inherited a sort of hatred of the media. There were a lot of lies, nothing was exact—there was only propaganda. There is still only one state television channel and it is even worse than it used to be. I look at media as the highest degree of manipulation humanity has ever invented. In this sense, this could be really used, to fit the works of artists, raising social or individual imperatives. Nobody has any idea how it came to postmodernism and contemporary art. Everybody thinks that modernism is just abstraction, the fugitive way from the real image.

In Albania there are no rich people with access, and the poor cannot get to the information or technologies. Perhaps 5 percent made money in recent years—0.5 percent is middle class. To share information now is not so much the problem. What matters is how to fit the media psychology into the Albanian mentality of the artistic audiences. The controversy is not between the media and the audience, but between media and the arts. We have to force our way into the scene and to show what the possibilities are.

Interview Two: July 1997

Since this first interview, a lot has happened in Albania. In early March 1997 the country broke down into a state of anarchy, after pyramid schemes tumbled. Edi Muka made it to the Nettime meeting in Ljubljana, in late May, called “The Beauty and the East,” to report on the current (media) situation. Then, after the elections of June 29, 1997, he came to Germany and participated in the “Deep Europe” group, which took place during Hybrid WorkSpace at Documenta X, where we recorded the following conversation.

In the Western press, the events of March 1997 in Albania have been described in blurry and terrifying terms like “chaos” and “anarchy.” Some tried to explain it as a “civil war,” but it wasn’t quite like that. Are those terms appropriate? Should we speak of a “revolt”? Perhaps for the first time since Budapest 1956, an armed uprising of some sort occurred in Europe.

First of all, we cannot talk in terms of a civil war. It never took place. I am an anarchist myself, and I would never call this anarchy. The mess in Albania was caused by the leading force—the Democratic Party and its government. It was a people’s protest. The element of violence we faced was of a very specific nature. There was not any violence used during the time of the protests. All the protests were held without any arms, at least on the side

of the people. Of course the police were armed and shot in the air and sometimes into the crowd. At a certain point, the government surrounded the whole city of Vlora and intended to send the army there. But at that moment the army troops disobeyed and abandoned their positions. That is why we had such a mess. All the depots and barracks were left alone. The number of people going there, taking tanks and guns, was limited. In response to this, the Democratic Party made up this story of the South fighting the North, promising its supporters very good fees. But on the whole there were very few military actions, besides some incidents.

What happened to you in this period of unrest?

Basically it started last May, on the 26th, when we had the parliamentary elections stolen by the Democratic Party. On the 28th, they held a public beating of the opposition leaders in the middle of Tirana; they stated that this was going to be the way they rule. It became dangerous to speak out. Everything was controlled. I know it sounds ridiculous but they were even controlling the email. They were allowing only one server, the one in the UNDP office. They did not care too much about the press. There was the opposition newspaper, the *Koha Jone*. At a certain point they beat them up and closed their offices. I was lucky not to have suffered. I became scared when the students began protesting because I was deeply involved in that. By the time they got to my person the uprising in Vlora started so they did not pay so much attention to the capital. But our internationally well-known artist Edi Rama was brutally beaten by the secret police of Berisha. He survived only because of his physique—he is big enough.

How do you look view the international involvement? There is always the suspicion of (post-)colonial behavior of Italy. Again, the EU was divided about what to do, as in the case of Bosnia. What did you think of the late humanitarian intervention and the half-hearted attempts to restore order?

The Albanian case was about the ongoing failure of Europe to deal with the Balkans. This has to do with their strange attitude toward democracy. I would call it “context democracy.” There is the Dutch context and a different democracy there. And they say that this is the kind of democracy that fits the Albanians. This is how they ended up supporting Berisha to the very

end. This is horrible. He is a dictator. How could they close their eyes? The EU and all the rest are unable to predict events.

It is true that there is a strong Italian influence. Italy is forced to be involved in this because of its sea border. The Albanians would “attack” Italy with an exodus in case of big trouble. So for the Europeans, it is easy to delegate this case to Italy. Someone on the street was asked his opinion on the day of the arrival of the “multinational force.” He answered that it could have been done in a much easier way: just make a statement that Berisha should go away. Get rid of him and then things will start to improve. Why send troops? They were not really interested in helping Albanians. They wanted to forbid Albanians to take the boat to Italy. That’s all. Everybody was laughing when they heard about some “humanitarian” intervention. There was no aid coming at all. Albania did not need humanitarian aid. I know this because I went to the South to make reports. It was about four hundred tons of beans and six hundred tons of flour.

How do look back at the election of June 29 and the change of government? The situation seems to be stable at the moment.

I was truly amazed about the calm during election day. Everybody had expected a massacre, or at least fights between the different parties. But nothing happened, which means that the Albanian people had made up their mind. Of course, the balance changed in an extreme way. We could not have expected to have a more center-balanced, pluralistic choice. That is why the left-wing parties won the majority. There is a big willingness to end all of what happened. The same mistakes will not be made. On the other side, there are a lot of problems the government has to deal with. The biggest problems are the guns. It is estimated that there are about one million Kalashnikoffs around. Nobody was aware that there were so many weapons in the country.

You may have seen pictures on TV of Albanians carrying five or ten Kalashnikoffs. It was very easy to get them. The second problem is the losses to individuals in the pyramid schemes. The new government promised to give back the money. It was not realistic, but in a passionate moment they made this promise. What they could do is to make transparent where the money went. Berisha tried to avoid this by any means. I heard that they are organizing armed gangs to keep the situation destabilized. They sense that

if public order is restored, the money problem will not be so acute anymore. The people now only want one thing: to have the public order restored. What I feared most during the troubles was the impact that it will have on future generations. But the way in which the Albanians dealt with the elections was a very positive sign. Vlora was the first city to come up with the election results. No single incident was reported there. It is amazing how spirit can conquer paranoia.

What are your plans for the coming year? Do you encourage foreigners to visit you? A strange mix of fear of chaos and a curiosity about it exist at the same time, an exoticism among Westerners when it comes to Albania. How should an exchange be organized?

Relations have changed in Albania. I no longer belong to the group that was persecuted. This does not mean that I am in power. I do not like to be in power and prefer to be in opposition. I would like to see a professional debate between me and the people that think differently. Not that they are in power and can do whatever they want. Practically, I would like to build up a new *atelier*, an Intermedia Department within the Academy of Fine Arts. The potential is there. The students are there, but no equipment. I feel that I have a lot of support now from colleagues. It is the right moment to have a positive split of the arts community. Now it is moment to say: "I am like this and you are like that." We know who we are and what we are doing. In terms of exchange, we are very open.

There is a growing need in the West also to collaborate with the East. You can see it also in the different terminology like "Ex-East" or . . . "Deep Europe." Western societies are now in a crisis through the impact of technology. In the past, Western societies used their own points of reference in order to overcome these crises inside their culture. But now this has changed, and the West now looks outside its borders for new points of reference. That is the mechanism, and I also like it. Finally we will no longer be exotic anymore. I try to make Albanian artists aware of this and wipe out the inferiority complexes they have. There has been a projection on Westerners of your own desires. But Eastern Europeans know by now that the reality of their ideal looks different. This new consciousness should be used in the new forms of communication that now open up. The cultures of the Eastern European countries, or their potentials, can be used to counter-balance the technological nonsense.

Interview Three: May 1998

In May 1998 I visited Albania for the first time and made the following interviews with Edi Muka and the artist and minister of culture, Edi Rama. I found Edi Muka to look as cool as ever—his dress, sunglasses, the way he's got things in control (except when the lamp of the videobeam breaks, a major catastrophe that happened twice . . .). According to Muka, Tirana will sooner or later feel the impact of the influx of refugees in the North. But for the time being it is still recovering from the "anarchy" of March 1997, the few days when the state lost its monopoly on violence. Shortly after the incident, a commission of all the political parties represented in Parliament was formed to reconstruct and study the events. But within a few months, controversy between the members broke out and the final report is still pending. So the cause of all the destruction remains vague.

Can it be reduced to a plot or conspiracy? According to you, Berisha at a certain point decided to let everything go when he found out that he could not use the army to attack the city of Vlora. As you say—

He defends himself now by saying that he had to arm the members of his party in order to defend them. Maybe I am wrong. No one knows how reliable the data of this commission is. But a fact is that most of the town halls were set on fire. There was a lot of corruption under the Berisha government, illegal deals regarding privatization and real estate. A lot of them were done in favor of Berisha's Democratic Party members. So this was a good chance to wipe out the evidence. In Vlora, people initially burned the police office and the secret police headquarters. But the burning of town halls came later.

Culture lost too. Museums were looted, even worse than in 1992. Churches too. Most of all it blocked a process, several years of gradual progress. For example, after March 1997 students did not go to school anymore. It was impossible to get them back to the classroom.

When you see such destruction happening around you after seven years of supposed "democracy," it's not surprising that the already strong desire of Albanians to leave the country grew ten times.

Since December 1997, things have apparently changed for the better. Edi's students returned to their classes and a number of cultural events took place. In October 1997, eleven artists participated in *Reorientation*, an exhibit in a ruined factory, outside of town, curated by Muka. The show was

mainly installations, referring to the state of ruin, and was considered a turning point. Gezim Qendro, now the director of the National Gallery, participated, along with Edi Hila, one of Albania's modern post-1990 painters, and some young artists.

Despite the fact that it took place in a part which is full of guns, a lot of people showed up. They were eager to see something different.

Another landmark was Albania's participation in Ostranenie, the ex-East media arts festival that took place for the third time in Dessau in November 1997. Albanian video artworks were screened there for the first time, and an annual visual arts competition took place.

In the past, everybody just hung some artwork on the wall of the National Gallery, no curatorial work, no critics, just a big chaos. This time there was some selection. But there was still a lack of the ability to experience things. There were only few who reflected on what had happened in 1997. I don't think this is normal. There is the tendency to escape, the young generation leaves the country and the old ones do it in their way. I concentrated my work on a group of young artists, students who do reflect on the situation. In February 1998, a first show with them followed in the renovated gallery of the Academy of Fine Arts. It was really good and a large audience showed up. I gave some lectures about ready-mades and abstraction, which are still not well known here. Students have difficulties understanding what happened historically and epistemologically.

And Galeria XXI opened, which is trying to promote the art market in Albania because there is no such thing. The early revival is evident in other fields as well. The "Days of New Music" program a few months ago tried to open up traditional Albanian folk music and elaborate it in a "modern" way. A proposal to build and staff a new National Theatre was approved. But there is still no decision on the future of the International Cultural Center, the enormous white pyramid that once housed the Enver Hoxha Memorial Museum. In its most recent reincarnation, it is used for the Italian "Levante" trade fair, displaying trash consumer goods.

All this is now in Edi Rama's hands, the brand-new minister of culture. Rama, 34, is an experimental artist who played an important role in the student movement of 1990 and worked and exhibited abroad. Edi Muka has known Rama for years. "He

is a charismatic person with a lot of ideas, even though he might not have much experience with administration. He has already left some marks," Muka says about him. Rama's story is telling. In 1996, he was beaten up by Berisha supporters, and he then moved to Paris where he lived in exile.

This spring, when he returned to Tirana for his father's funeral, he was invited to replace Arta Dade, Minister of Culture, who lacked any vision on revitalizing culture-in-ruins with little or no budget. Rama immediately agreed. His first action was a radical reorganization of the ministry, the first one ever in fifty years. I managed to get an appointment with Rama on the fourth floor of the former Central Committee building, filled with a dark-brown atmosphere of bureaucratic power. Here is what he had to say.

I inherited an institution still based in the old structures. It is also important to change the physical aspect of the building. It was not functional, and there was a lot of dust that needed to be cleaned. The budget is low, but even that is misused. So the first step is to create projects that will make a decent use of the budget possible. Only after that can we increase pressure on the Ministry of Finance and start to approach NGOs.

Where are your priorities—in film, visual arts, and media?

Until now, the ministry worked as a sponsor of cultural ghettoization. It supported our self-complimentary attitude toward history and the related institutions that we inherited from the past. The Writers Union—in fact, all cultural institutions—these old structures are no longer a threat to democracy, but they are an obstacle.

Do you see a growing divide between the lowbrow media culture and the elite high culture?

If I can make a comparison. During the communist period we were living in a Jurassic Park. Now the dinosaurs have disappeared but we are still in a park where anything can happen. You never know from where the danger is coming from. In that respect, things are very disorderly. The new media situation is like a jungle. But I am convinced that the only support we can give to these newcomers is freedom. With the possibility to express yourself in a free space will also come a need to learn and how to deal with this space.

Nowadays people here are convinced that freedom is much more difficult than isolation. To administrate freedom means to administrate yourself. During the time that you had to pass on the shelf of totalitarianism, you were administrated by someone else. You were not an individual. There was no responsibility and no anxiety. In freedom, all these elements become part of you.

When asked about all those leaving Albania, Edi Rama extends a permanent invitation to all Albanians to do something for this country.

But it is pretty hard to make invitations because you cannot offer any guarantees. The problem with this community has been that it always worked against its own future. The most paralyzed were the young generations. They were marginalized by the gods of politics and culture. The big challenge now is to listen more carefully to their needs in order to make them feel at home in their own country. To a certain age, every Albanian is a refugee in his own country. It is felt as a transit station.

You are not a member of a political party. Is this more or less difficult than you expected?

I do not need to operate in a political field because my power is not political but cultural power.

Until now, local Soros Foundation officials have not felt the urgency to open a Soros Center for Contemporary Art. This might change soon. As in other countries, the leading "civil society" intellectuals, mainly writers, were not so sensitive to contemporary art forms, let alone "electronic art." But there is another, underlying reason for the low-priority status of new culture. Understandably, human rights violations, food aid, and the basic restoration of law and order take highest priority for Western governments and NGOs. But with this comes a very specific, subconscious definition of "democratic culture"—a formalistic, instrumental, and legalistic approach that defines democracy according to its institutional structures, not its actual lively elements. We can see a similar problem in the field of "independent media." What counts is the primacy of frameworks, not initiatives or individual modes of mediated expression. What has been the role of NGOs?

We can see a standardized way of thinking within these NGOs. They are working according to preestablished models, without paying too much attention to the local requests. It is definitely important what they are doing, to promote NGOs that develop democracy. But what is desperately needed in Albania is a “cultural revolution.” A large program to reach all generations, not only the young. Let’s take one example. The main support for translations comes, of course, from the Soros Foundation. They are now mainly doing philosophical books from the fifties and sixties (Nietzsche, Sartre, Camus . . .) and literature.

Contemporary books on visual arts, media, and cultural politics are a first requirement in order to spread a comprehensive understanding of the new (media) technologies, their internal logic, history, and potential. And this counts for many fields in culture. Otherwise, the existing divide between Western commercial media trash and post-communistic and nationalistic state-sponsored folklorism will establish itself, leaving little or no room for contemporary forms of expression. According to Muka, staying in cafés all day is nonsense—artists’ spaces should be created, giving people the possibility to prove themselves. Step by step this will bring the attention to Albania and will take away the desire to leave the country. International exchange also plays an important role in this. Soon, Soros won’t be the only source of money. Pro Helvetia (Swiss) is coming, a French Institute will be established, and perhaps also a German Goethe Institute will emerge. Regional exchange should also increase to avoid ethnic tensions like those experienced with neighboring Macedonia.

Interview Four: September 1998

Four months later, there is breaking news: fighting in the streets of Tirana.

How are you? Is everyone safe and alive? Did you go out in the streets last week? How is Edi Rama, the artist, now minister of culture? Is he in hiding? And the others?

Hi everyone. I am okay, and everyone is alive. Regarding safety, it’s become a matter of humor now (apparently it is the only way to handle the situation). Of course I was out in the streets last week. It’s impossible to stay inside (except for some hours when the streets of Tirana were under the control of gangs and thieves who first attacked the institutions and then turned back to loot the shops). Edi Rama is safe. He spent some time hiding because, as is well known, he is one of the main opposers of Berisha and also

because immediately after recapturing the TV he went online to give an interview, speaking clearly about what happened and who was the conspiring source. For this reason his life was in serious danger—there were telephone calls threatening to kill him, and so on.

In early June, when we had a joint Pyramedia and Syndicate meeting in Tirana, you told us that the Berisha gangs were operating in the South of the country. Back then Berisha tried to start armed revolts but they somehow failed. Now he almost succeeded. Do you think this is due to fact that the current government of Nano has been making a miscalculation concerning his intentions to unleash an armed rebellion?

This is due to many factors, not only because of miscalculations of the government. Of course, the government was really slow and not determined to fight organized crime and to have the situation totally under control. But on the other hand, there is a clear attempt to destabilize the situation in Albania, to bring back the chaos and distract attention from the massacres in Kosov@. These attempts evidently come from secret services interested in continuing the slaughter in Kosov@. This too is a minus for the Nano government, which wasn't able to control anything in these terms. This was very comfortable to the Albanian "plague" called Berisha, who seems totally out of his mind.

So the next morning, after the Democratic Party deputy's death, he organized the coup d'état, openly and in the middle of the day. What was this exactly? This was a very dangerous political game played by Nano. Because he didn't want to shoot at the crowd and because he understood that Berisha was out of his mind, he decided to let everything go and the institutions to be captured by armed gangs of the Democratic Party. After some hours of intensive danger, shooting, looting, dismantling of the state, police finally showed up starting to take the situation under control, recapturing the institutions. But in the meantime, we had experienced long hours without a state, which brought back the situation of the last year that nobody wants to experience again.

Berisha took over the television for several hours last Tuesday. What exactly happened there? What role does television play in the current events? And the other media—how do they respond? Would you call it a media(ted) "civil" war, as the Western reporters are saying? Who owns the power when it comes to guns and cameras?

As I explained above, it was part of the game so that Berisha could get the television. This was really dangerous because it is the only form of media that covers all Albania. Can you imagine seeing on television faces saying, "We won, television is ours now," and then giving only false news on the prison breakout, on the destruction of police, on the surrender of the national guard, and so forth. The fact that the situation of Tirana didn't have any resonance anywhere else showed that Berisha doesn't have support and that he cannot be successful with either violence or democracy. Regarding the other media, the independent ones, they simply transmitted everything—not live but by telephone service and afterward with images.

Of course they are important because with the national TV under control of armed gangs, what kind of news can you imagine getting? But the fact is that most of them do cover only Tirana and don't go much further, so the rest of Albania was just watching the national TV. One more thing—very important—there's never been a civil war in Albania. Last year it was masses of people fighting against Berisha and his secret police, while this year it was Berisha attacking the institutions with guns. So the term *civil war* is completely out of place. In the spring, the effects of the fighting in Kosov@ were hardly felt in Tirana. There were concerns, signs of solidarity, not much more. Now there are stories about the involvement of the Berisha gangs in weapon trading with the Kosov@ Liberation Army.

Did you see or feel any impact of this in Tirana?

Kosov@ has become increasingly important since last spring. Of course, the weapon trading reinforced Berisha and his gangs financially and militarily, but it wasn't only him trading weapons. Once more the Albanian government found itself in a difficult position. This is because they had to help the refugees coming from Kosov@ in the northern borders of Albania. For this they had to create some kind of free zone. But this free zone became free under every aspect, even from the government's control. The result of this is that many elements, mentioned above, interested in destabilizing Albania, could penetrate deeply in the territory, getting in contact with the organized crime and becoming dangerously active. Now the number of refugees is extremely high, and they have settled almost everywhere. The direct impact of this is, for example, that among the gangs that attacked the institutions

there were guys from Kosov@ as well. We still don't know what their involvement is, but this adds to the actual chaos.

Unlike the implosion of all authority in March 1997, this time a few Western "Eurocops" are monitoring the crisis in Tirana. What impact has their presence had? And how about that of the Italian army?

First I would like to emphasize that there is no foreign army in Albania. There are only some Italian navy ships with a crew composed of Italians and Albanians, fighting the clandestine traffic between Italy and Albania. Regarding Eurocops I still cannot say anything about their job. The fact that police disappeared for some hours is a hopeless sign. But if we view it as part of the political game, considering some very successful reactions of police stations toward armed attacks from criminals related to Berisha, I cannot say that their work has been totally ineffective. On the other hand, Europe is still bringing up their strange attitudes for democratic standards in countries in development. After strongly condemning Berisha's move as an attempt to win power through the force of guns, now they are preventing the Albanian justice from punishing him and the many others who inspired and organized that attempt. I wonder what would any of them say if such a thing happened in their country?

A few months ago, you developed an ambitious plan to open the Albanian Center for Contemporary Arts, inside the Pyramid building, the former international Cultural Center. Simultaneously, negotiations were under way to open a similar Soros SCCA branch. One can suspect a serious setback after all that happened last week.

Of course, yes. After being seriously under the threat of death, you can imagine that you cannot immediately start where you had left off. The contemporary art center was only one of the cultural projects in development. On the other hand, even if you are a superman, I don't think that you could resist and continue as if nothing had happened. Such chaos occurs once a year. This time I feel really tired and uncertain about my plans. As long as there is a monster like Berisha around, I'm afraid that all my energies be consumed by survival strategies—I don't like this at all. That's why I don't have any answer for you regarding the plans for the center of contemporary arts, and also I find it a bit ridiculous to say again this time, "I hope things will get better soon."

Interview Five: May 1999

Eight months later, with the Kosov@ crisis culminating in a period of chaos and despair, I corresponded again with Muka. Albania had just absorbed thousands of refugees from Kosov@.

Let me first of all congratulate you on your new job. Can you describe the Pyramid to us? I suppose there is not much yet. To what extent will it become a cultural center?

Thanks. Of course, it's a difficult task because it is coming at a very difficult moment for culture in Albania and because the pyramid building itself and its structure and infrastructure are in a pitiful shape. Also the corresponding legislation to the state of building is a strange one, with a lot of restrictions for a purely cultural institution. Anyway, like everywhere else, money remains the main problem. The building needs immediate intervention to be repaired and maintained, which would cost a lot of money. My project is to turn it into the Tirana Center for Contemporary Arts.

At the moment you are preparing the Albanian participation in this year's Venice Biennial. What is the history and context of this show? Does Albania have a pavilion? To what extent is all this blurred, or defined, by the (post/neo)colonial relations between Italy and Albania? And could you tell us something about your curatorial work? Which themes and which works of art are significant for this difficult period?

Of course, there's this post/neocolonial feeling and fashion as well, but things at the moment simply work like that, and we have to kind of follow the rules. There's one difference though that Politti didn't act like other Western curators, who come overnight and go away with some kind of pre-selection they already had in their minds, that doesn't have anything to do with the artists living and working in Albania.

As for my curatorial work, it is much focused on what is called "socially engaged art," which remains a very strong potential that cannot be ignored by the artist. It is strange enough though, but recently this has slightly changed toward a more aesthetic problematic. Maybe because the situation became very extreme and direct that art was at a loss to reflect upon it, so the tendency is to reflect upon itself. There are newer proposals in the academy. For example, video, even though it's not a trend, has become a clear and stable tendency with interesting and sometimes surprising results.

Let's talk politics as well. There seems to be a split between a national faction, which is critical of NATO, and the current government, which is supportive of the West. Some aspects of the mafia economy might be threatened by an increase of NATO-led military and police activities. On the other hand, civilians could also benefit from Western aid and basic security. But skeptical observers have already pointed out that will not be any substantial financial support to rebuild Albania. Do you think that the war in Kosov@ will be a turning point for Albania, or will it just be continuation of the permanent crisis? Will the country slip away into a post-apocalyptic state of even further decline? This is a really complicated matter.

To start, it is true that all political sides in Albania are trying to profit from the situation, but there isn't such a thing as being critical of NATO. If such a thing exists, it is not because of NATO bombing, but because of it's hesitation to give a solution to the crisis, even with the infamous ground troops. As for the mafia activities, at the moment they don't really feel threatened and are flourishing. However, there is a feeling in the air that if things start to change, like NATO control, the Marshall Plan, and so on, it will be over for them. That's maybe why there is this haste in making as much money as possible at the moment.

As for the people, they already saw a couple of examples of NATO control, like the airport of Tirana, the harbor of Durrës, and certain infrastructure points in the country. Everybody feels great about that, not only because there is real order in doing things, but also because they pay quite a lot of money for the services they obtain. Therefore, if there were any threat coming from NATO toward mafia activities, it will have the backing of the people, since Albanian politics would be totally out of the scene. As for the last point, it is very unclear how this conflict shall develop, but I do believe that this is going to be a turning point for Albania.

In the event that there is some dirty compromise, that would not encourage the hundreds of thousands of deported people to go back to their homes and land and make decisions for themselves. In that case the country would not be able to survive the grave situation it is going through. It would go into a postapocalyptic state, which would afflict not only the entire region, but also Italy as the first country of the West, which is already experiencing the huge wave of refugees. But if NATO will not give up and insist on its demands, then the result will be a real turning point, not only for Albania and Kosov@, but for Serbia even. Maybe it is precisely this that some do not

like, because judging from the strategic geographical position that Albania has, it means they would lose a lot in many directions.

We do not hear much from the Albanian side, apart from some Kadare remarks. How have you been discussing the current issues in the last two months? What does Fatos Lubonja (Perpjekja/Endeavour) say? And Edi Rama, your minister of culture?

It is true that the Albanian side is not heard much. On one side this is because we are not as well prepared to fight the media war as Serbia is. Second, in this respect we are in a situation that is even worse than the war. The situation is really grave and almost explosive. It takes much effort to handle it with the high degree of poverty in Albania, and there is so much to be done that there is not much time and space left for propaganda. Anyway, this does not mean that nothing has been done. Edi Rama has participated in several lively debates in and out of Albania.

In one, for example, he strongly argued with the Macedonian ambassador about the closing of the border to the deportees from Kosov@. On another one, carried live in the Italian TV, Rai Uno, he had an even stronger debate with the communist leader Cosuta, who is defending Milosevic and ignoring the tragedy of the Kosovars, for the sake of an "unjust war" that NATO is waging. Also all independent media in Albania continuously cover the crisis with nightly special editions featuring debates, discussions, and direct news from the Internet.

In Albania there are around eight hundred (wild) refugee camps at this moment. How would you describe the influence of this huge number on Albanian society? Do you already see some cultural activities in the camps as well?

At the beginning the situation was really an emergency one: how to feed and shelter more than half a million people who have gone through the trauma of seeing their relatives slaughtered in front of their eyes. Now it is a bit different, because you have to get used to the new conditions and life finds its way somehow. Of course there are several cultural activities now, and there is more public because of the many Kosovars that wander in the streets of Tirana. I can say, though, that the season took place this year even under very difficult conditions. I myself am working toward autumn. This is the chance to start working on exchange and collaboration projects.

Interview Six: July 2000

Tirana, Summer 2000. One year has passed. It is time to inquire how Muka is doing, what he and his center are up to, and what the political situation looks like.

For almost a year you have run the Pyramid as a cultural center. Could you describe the atmosphere inside the building? What is going on in the surroundings of the building? Is it still bazaar street economy style that dominates?

I have been running the Pyramid as a cultural center for a year now. I have to say that it took me quite some time to understand the Albanian state administration, which was a totally alien concept to me. Only after a while was I able to figure out what I wanted to do with the center and try to draw some general strategies for its development. In the beginning I had to introduce the way of working with projects, which was totally unknown to the staff. A general structure of the work was outlined, which consisted of covering the main artistic disciplines, like visual arts, performing arts, and music.

Since it was summer by that time, and indoor events are not attended very much in hot Tirana, we immediately started with an open air café, with a huge screen where we project lots of things, from documentary films to video art of young Albanian and international artists, as well as DJ music. Since the hot summer weather continued, we started a DJ exchange project in the basement of the Pyramid, which is a big space—presumed to be a discotheque.

When the cultural season started, the visual arts component became visible. Shows by young contemporary Albanian artists were followed by British-German contemporary photography. On the other hand, the first projects in music, besides the DJ projects, started as collaborations, because of a lack of infrastructure and experience in that field as well as in the performing arts was evident. Anyway, by developing good contacts with Albanian musicians and by using the foreign bodies that could help finance the projects, such as the British Council, the Soros Foundation, Pro-Helvetia, the German embassy, and good support from the Ministry of Culture, the center had programming almost all year round. We did the British film days, a clarinet festival out of which we were able to produce a CD, other shows with young artists, and what is more important, the center started its first production on performing arts.

The Soros Foundation approved two big long-standing projects: first, the building of an information center in the form of a mediatheque; and second,

the opening of the educational service atelier (mostly work with children). The second is a very important project, because it has to do with building infrastructure, something that is completely missing in Albania and other ex-communist countries. The thing with foreign donors is that there's quite a lot of money to develop projects, but there's no money whatsoever for building up infrastructure. This is very stupid indeed, since the ones who give money always ask for "follow-up." But how can you work like this on a project-by-project basis when you don't have the place and the means to follow up? On the other hand, even with financial restrictions, the center is financing the adaptation of the space where exhibitions are held in a permanent gallery for contemporary art.

As for its surrounding, even though we managed a grant to partly repair the building, which is very damaged, because of lack of grants for maintenance, it doesn't look very much repaired. But at least I am glad that people have started to know what's happening here. We have even had requests regarding "next projects" from the public. The implementation of the mediatheque and the educational atelier will turn the Pyramid into a functional and open space, open to the public for most of the day.

How would you describe the political situation in Albania in 2000? Is the NATO containment policy in Kosov@ and the Balkans spilling over into Albania?

There's a new exchange between Kosov@ and Albania, of course, which has to do mostly with trade from Albania into Kosov@. The interesting part is rediscovering each other after many decades without communication. It is for me interesting to see, talk, and work with Kosovar artists; and it is really impressive to see the work of some of them, especially if you consider the life they lived until recently and the "educational system" they had, if you could call it such.

On the other hand, it is frustrating for me to see that the same problems exist between generations, the same barriers of communication with the public, the same kind of resistance from the "elders" that had a name in the old Yugoslavia. This is because, not knowing the situation over there, I had always hoped they would have developed under totally different circumstances. This should have created differences—but it is not like that. It is true that Kosovars have a different working mentality compared to us in Tirana. They are not waiting for NATO or Europe to rebuild their country

(something I don't believe will ever happen), as we did. They are back to work—building a new life.

The problem, as everyone can see, is to establish some kind of order. I don't mean the public order in the strict sense, but the kind of order that somehow regulates daily life. This has to do with more than just revenge toward the Serbs, which is another phenomenon that needs time to be settled, especially if we consider the fact that recently most of the provocations and incidents come from Serbs living in Kosov@.

First, this is kind of a consequence of all these decades of “parallel economy and state,” which was legitimate as long as Milosevic was repressing Kosov@. But in the instant this frame is changed, the above structure proved completely unable to handle the situation.

The second problem is crucial, I believe: neither Europe nor NATO have made up their mind of what to do with Kosov@. I mean it is damned clear now that it cannot be given back to Yugoslavia. They have to start working building up its future as an independent society. Only in this way can it be multicultural and multi-ethnic in the long run. I don't see any sign of Kosov@ or Albania becoming some sleepy, lazy province of Brussels.

Concerning Albanian politics, there's one fact that we have to admit though: From a cold outsider's perspective, you can see some improvements. From an insider's point of view, you get really tired of the pace. Anyway, there's something I can tell you. As you might know we're having local elections in October, and the news is that Edi Rama, the artist you know, is going to give up his three-year job as minister of culture. He is now a candidate for mayor of Tirana. It sounds bizarre, and indeed it is an adventure. Only someone who has been to Tirana knows what it means to deal with this crazy city. I think it is because of the challenge that he is entering the race.

Recently, a few shows and biennials of contemporary arts included works from Albanian artists. All of them were well received. It looks as if you have managed to escape the status of total obscurity. What happened in the last year? Could you tell us about the new interesting works and artists?

Everything started happening after the first international show we did in Tirana in 1998. After that the Venice Biennale came and we had our “fifteen minutes of fame” in the world. Luckily, and because of seriously good work and presentation, we made the breakthrough. From that moment on

many shows started taking place internationally, while some of the artists could see the immediate impact of their work. This is the case with Anri Sala, for instance, and with Adrian Paci and Sislej Xhafa. The good thing is that there are still newcomers.

We have discovered and strengthened links with Kosovar artists producing extremely impressive work, such as Solo Bemire, Resin Shkololli, and Mehmet Behluli. The time is right for discussion and consideration of proposals, either for individuals or for group shows. All the above artists have produced new work that is not only raising interest in showing them, but has also conquered the art market, which is very important for the artists themselves. Therefore, there's a lot more work to do now, and I feel good about it. There's some solid ground, which allows serious work to be done.

Interview Seven: August 2001

It's been a while now since you were fired as a director of the Tirana cultural center, the Pyramid. How do you look back on that episode? At the time, in December 2000, it was not clear exactly who was behind your dismissal. Why would a person like you with so many ideas and motivation be sacked? What has happened to the Pyramid since then?

Well, it's history by now, and it seems far back in time to me. Maybe this is because life in Albania still has its ups and downs, which can quickly make you forget things. Furthermore, I feel sorry in a way for the entire project and I refuse to think of it any more. And what's more ridiculous is that the reasons for my dismissal were so banal, even though it included several interests. I was actually removed by the prime minister, not only because he's the one who makes such decisions but also because he wanted to do a favor for the guy who replaced me, who had done some mass celebrations on the occasion of some feasts just before the elections. Then the new minister of culture obviously regarded me as the black sheep in the crowd. I am not sure why because she had met me only once, on the day of her presentation, together with many others.

State jobs in Albania are still a good opportunity to make quick money through bribe and abuse, so such a position is very envied by people with clear intentions in that direction. There were some people who used to rent spaces in the Pyramid (that was a common practice, because it helped generate money and maintain the entire thing), that apparently wanted

more, but whose requests I had rejected, protecting the space in order to be used by the Intellectual Communication Center (ICC). Last but not least, there was no attempt whatsoever on the part of Edi Rama, elected mayor of Tirana at the time, to protect or even ask the reason for my dismissal, not as a friend, but as someone he himself had appointed, and whose dismissal was never explained even in the official newspapers.

All this was a pain, but the huge support I got through the Syndicate mailing list and through local artists, published also in the Albanian press, was a great moral boost for me. At the moment the Pyramid is dead; the exhibition space inside was used for only about five shows I was able to curate while I was there. After that it was turned into a storeroom. The mediatheque project, started with Soros Foundation money, stopped even though Soros people contacted me again afterward asking me to continue on that project, but not necessarily connected to the Pyramid.

After you lost your job, you were appointed immediately to the National Gallery. What have you been doing there, and how's the general climate in terms of cultural policy these days, since the national elections that took place in June 2001?

Actually I am in charge of curating at the National Gallery. By the time I was fired, I had already started to curate the annual show held in the National Gallery, and that was funny too, because it's being financed by the Ministry of Culture, but the minister won't receive me for a presentation of the project and a discussion of its budget. So the director of the National Gallery, Gezim Qendro, had to do this job. The show was quite good actually, and as we do every year we had a great time with the artists. A small catalogue was also published by Giancarlo Politi Editore. After this show, together with Giancarlo Politi and Edi Rama, I decided to start working on the first edition of the Tirana Biennale. That's been my main occupation since then, and it will be until the opening scheduled for September 15, 2001.

Regarding cultural policy in Albania things (policies) depend a lot upon individuals. If there's a charismatic organizer, with the good will to change things (such as was Edi Rama's case), then things start moving. The problem with Edi Rama was that he wasn't able, or stayed too briefly, to build a continuation of what he started. The very next day after he was replaced by the new minister of culture, everything went back to where he had started it, if not worse. At the moment the situation is still like that; there's liter-

ally no policy or at least no vision at all regarding Albanian culture. We'll have to wait and see, because the new government is not formed yet, so we don't know who the next minister of culture shall be, but I don't believe there will be someone exciting. That's what happens when one political side takes the upper hand; they usually don't care anymore who they appoint, especially in culture.

Although it has faced a few problems, the Tirana Biennale is coming up. What are your ideas and expectations?

Well, the Tirana Biennale is a serious problem (in good terms). I think that it is going to definitely be different, for many reasons. In Albania there is no infrastructure to handle such an event, so it is going to be completely informal. We're trying to bring in almost everybody as participants. This will produce a mess, but I hope a productive and energetic one. I also think that the biennale is coming at a very important moment for Albanian contemporary art. Some of our guys are really doing great internationally, being present and participating in some of the most prestigious and important events worldwide, as are Anri Sala, Sislej Xhafa, Adrian Paci, Flutura, and Besnik Haxhillari, and also younger ones like Alban Hajdinaj, Erzen Shkololli, and so forth. It is also very important public relations for the city and for Albania itself. Can you imagine that some of the participants still ask "How dangerous is it in Tirana?" because someone had read about a survey that ranked Tirana the eighth worst city in the world (in terms of danger). That's beyond the ridiculous. I think it will be great to have so many people here for a few days. It's going to be great for everybody: for the participant artists, for the young students of the academy, for the public, and for we organizers as well (even though it's unimaginably stressful).



The Computer: Medium or Calculating Machine?

Geert Lovink Meets Hartmut Winkler

This is an excerpt of an email exchange that took place in April 1996. It has been translated from the German by Ruth Schnabl. The media scientist Hartmut Winkler, who lives and works in Frankfurt, Germany, recently published a comprehensive critique of the current German media theories. *Docuverse* (1997) is the title of his Habilitation work (in the German academic system, the Habilitation follows the Ph.D). The book concerns the Internet and contemporary transformations in the media landscape, shifting from the image-dominated media to the computers, and Winkler investigates the social motives causing this change. He focuses on the concept of "wishes," the "reconstruction of the underlying wishes to which the data universe is the answer." The book's title, *Docuverse*, borrowed from Ted Nelson, is an especially relevant term for Winkler because it forces one to think of the data universe as a text-based, sociotechnical implementation complex. The term also allows one to criticize this idea as a fiction of theory.

Can you briefly outline what Docuverse is about?

In drafting the book, two of my interests came together. First, the anger about the huge computer-as-medium hype that emerged with the Internet and about the fashionable, precipitate character of the debate. Second, writing the book was a chance to recycle my past as a programmer. It was a challenge to confront the computer with certain theories developed in the field of classical media.

Then I wanted to see what happened to those categories everybody used to use. The issue completely lacking in the debate and yet worth thinking about is the theory of language. The Web is exploding as a medium of written texts, and nobody thinks about why media history leaves behind the technical images (photography, film, television), after a century of unquestioned supremacy, in order to return, as it seems, to writing and language. In the current debate, however, the “end of the Gutenberg galaxy” is announced which—if at all—happened already around 1900.

Your critique of media theory is aimed predominantly at a certain group of authors who have published a lot since the end of the 1980s: on the one hand, the “Kassel School,” including Friedrich Kittler, Norbert Bolz, Christoph Tholen, and others, and, on the other hand, the circle around Ars Electronica, Peter Weibel and Florian Rörzer. Would it be possible to describe this discourse a little more precisely? From my perspective there were very distinctive regional, cultural, and even historical conditions for this vital text production. The year 1989 comes to mind: climax of the 1980s, yuppie culture, and postmodernism, the fall of the Berlin Wall, the birth of techno, and the first appearance of virtual reality and the networks.

This group of theorists, now, can be characterized—in terms of an overall technology skepticism—neither as left-progressive nor as right-wing conservative culture-pessimists. Naturally you can always feel the spirit of Heidegger around, and one could name Lacan as a common background; the latter is even true for you. For a long time in Germany people who were concerned with the media were considered conformist. But I always thought of this as a disease of the “Ideologiekritik” (The critique of ideology). The sphere of the media, and this is evident, is very real and material (and gets so more and more). Have those authors anything left to say, or should we stop asking about sociological and ideological positions?

It's true that my book is mainly concerned with German theory and the authors you mentioned; it undertakes a critical revision and develops its

own interpretations and conclusions from this vantage point. That's the project. However, I would locate this debate differently; first, I don't think that the *Ideologiekritik* was hostile to media and technology in general. If the authors in question more than evidently distance themselves from the *Ideologiekritik* (and this also resounds in your presentation to a certain degree), I can see a whole bundle of motives: it is a well-justified interest in reaching a more differentiated interpretation of technology and also in overcoming certain *a priori* in the realm of the *Ideologiekritik*.

Taking distance, though, could also be considered an immediate result of political disappointments. Technology offers a way of escaping the complex demands of the social, and whoever considers technology the "a priori" of social development can stop caring about a lot of things. And above all, one gets around asking what it is that gives technology its drive and direction. Here I would clearly differentiate between Kittler and Bolz. While Kittler makes a real effort to develop a hermeneutics of technology (and tries to win back what the social process inscribed into technology), Bolz turns to an open affirmation with politically reactionary implications.

I think, like you do, that the debate is precisely located in place and time. But in my view the year 1989 doesn't stand for an awakening but for a doughy German chancellor and the potential immortalization and globalization of the bourgeois glory. If technology seems to be the only sphere where one can still find some kind of progress, it's no wonder that it's highly appreciated.

In my opinion the 1970s Ideologiekritik has indeed caused a lot of damage, first, by grossly neglecting the realm of the media and, second, by refusing to understand what is so attractive about mass culture, a question that was later taken up by English cultural studies.

Dealing with the seventies, you already focus on the followers, and they, I agree, seldom reached up to the prophets. For the classics of the Frankfurt School, however, your estimation doesn't apply; neither for Benjamin nor for Kracauer, who was very hopeful about mass culture; Brecht articulated the utopian idea of changing the monological character of the mass media, a utopia taken up by Enzensberger in the 1960s that became the basis for a number of practical-democratic media initiatives. The Communal Cinemas, financed by the municipal administrations, were founded in the 1960s/1970s, and so forth.

Above all, I think that the opposition critical attitude vs. sympathy/understanding/affirmation is much too coarse. If the “culture industry chapter” of Adorno and Horkheimer’s *Dialectics of Enlightenment* didn’t exist, it would need to be written right away—as a contribution to a debate and a very radical perspective that makes visible a particular side of the media. And Adorno’s book *Aesthetic Theory*, even if repudiating media, jazz, and mass culture, offers many criteria that, in a certain way, are more appropriate for the media than they are for autonomous art, which is so favorably treated by Adorno.

As I see it, contemporary German media theory is no longer rooted in the instrumental, rational, technocratic thinking of the last two decades (the affluent NATO-police-nuclear state). Working from neither positivism nor negation, it mainly seems to trace the inner voice of technology. The deanimated machines, worn by their commodity character, ought to sing again, since there are mainly people from literature, philosophy, and the arts involved. Such a constellation merely existed in Germany at that time (1989). In other countries, you have to look for media theory in the departments of sociology and communication sciences, and in the hard-boiled history of technology. Why is the attitude of the German media ideology and its “virtual class” (if one really wants to refer to it this way) so sublime, so poetic? Elsewhere, the media specialists do not invent such wonderful and complicated terms in order to describe the grey everyday life of the media. Is Germany, in the international division of labor, developing more and more into a country of datapoets and thinkers?

Gee, now I’m in the position to defend a particular German solution! Although many of the efforts, terms, and results of the debate seem very absurd to me, I feel very strongly that the more pragmatic approaches (“sociology, communication sciences, and history of technology”) miss their subject matter—the media. Concerning the media, we definitely don’t know what we are dealing with. We know that a more or less blind practice brings them into being, but we don’t know the implications of the fact that “communication” asks for increasingly complicated technical devices. The world of symbols melts into the one of technology. And as long as we don’t know, I believe, it’s important to work on the terms.

“Communication” is a very good example. You assume without questioning that living people communicate with one another (bilaterally), in contrast to the “dead” universe of writing. Is that plausible though? Isn’t

technology “dead” in the same way that writing is? And isn’t that the reason people want to make them sing again? And that is where my pleading for the “academic ways of thinking” starts. Certainly there are the “rituals of academic writing” that you mentioned. Yet this kind of writing opens up the opportunity to distance oneself from common sense and to talk differently—in a way that is unconditioned by the needs and pressures of practice.

I’m always astonished by how fast and definitely certain things become established as consensus: Multimedia is the natural aim of computer development, the computer is a universal machine, and so forth. If you want to oppose these kinds of consensus, you have to have either good nerves or good arguments (and probably both). In any case you need terms and tools that don’t stem from the debate itself, but from different contexts, and maybe even Lacan and Heidegger. And if the international division of labor assigns this part of theory to the Germans—that’s okay with me; they (we) did worse jobs in the past.

Hence, around 1989, in a time of rapid technological developments, a theoretical movement comes into being that doesn’t leave the Gutenberg-Galaxy behind but brings the whole knowledge of the previous centuries into cyberspace, tracing back the history of technology and connecting chip architecture and modern literature—though people outside that movement wouldn’t ever think that way. Doesn’t technology work brilliantly without Nietzsche and the humanities? Isn’t it only us, the intellectuals, who need the aid of Kittler and other theorists in order to cope with technology? Are we dealing with a media theory developed for a well-educated middle class that has a hard time with the titanic forces of the “techne”? Or do the heavy volumes of theory serve to give the shares of AEG, Mercedes Benz, Siemens, and Deutsche Bank additional weight? For all their power, it seems to me, the metaphysical insights of the German media theory aren’t very useful.

I very much hope so. And certainly technology works without Nietzsche. Generally the main problem is not just to cope with technology the way it is. If our society has chosen to inscribe its contents not in texts but in technology, the effect is that the contents aren’t visible and discernible any more. They appear as the natural features of the things, as a result of a linear (and necessarily single-track) progress, as unchangeable. It’s the same as codification. Things once encoded are the invisible precondition of communication. And whoever argues that a critique of technology is no longer possible and

that the times of critique are generally over is taken in by a strategy of naturalization.

Thus it would be the task of theory and of the hermeneutics of technology to win back the contents that the society has “forgotten” in technology. The decisions and values, the social structures and power configurations, the practice that became structural in technology. To show the transformation from practice/discourse into structure (and from structure into practice/discourse) is the main theoretical project of the book. Your “Internet critique” aims to do precisely the same, doesn’t it? The structure the Net has grown doesn’t depend on criticism in order to keep on growing. And if you don’t simply participate but think about the net in a different medium (writing and print), it won’t be far to Nietzsche anyway.

There isn't yet a media theory of the computers, not in Germany and not anywhere else, as you state in your introduction.. Isn't that mainly because the theorists don't yet live on the Internet and hesitate to settle there? Choosing Ted Nelson's term docuverse, I think, you indicate that cyberspace for you is mainly a sphere of texts and documents. Nowhere in your book do you mention that there are really people in the networks (and their artificial agents). You are talking of a “universe far from man (/woman)” and of the inadequacy of “communication” as a term. Isn't that because the Internet for you is a collection of “dead” information anyway?

Your major sources are Jacques Derrida, Jacques Lacan, Freud, Nietzsche, and so forth, combined with recent media literature. Why is your media theory of the computers so tightly rooted in the written knowledge of the pre-Internet age? Don't you have a lot in common with the people you criticize? Could it be that there is no paradigm shift at all and that everything new culminates in the return of the long established? In that case the well-known theory frame can remain!

Plainly spoken: There aren’t any people on the Net. Estimating roughly, there are 60 percent written texts in natural languages in the Internet, 20 percent programs and algorithms, 10 percent numerical data, 10 percent images, and 10 percent digitized sounds—110 percent in total. Ten more than one hundred seems appropriate for hyperspace! And some of the written texts—here you are right—are meant for direct use and are exchanged in real-time dialogues. As a whole, the Internet is a written universe, there’s no doubt about that. Asking what is new about all that, I don’t think it’s the bilateral communication of two partners (as a new version of telephone

or wiring logic) or the single documents, but the arrangement of those documents in an n -dimensional space, the material links between them, and the utopia of a universal accessibility associated with this construction. Nelson's term *docuverse* as an ingenious anticipation summarizes all those aspects, and that's why I chose it as a title.

Indeed, I rather believe we are dealing with a resurrection of the Gutenberg galaxy than with its coming to an end. After a hundred years' supremacy of technical images, an explosion of written texts is occurring, and in my book I ask why this is happening. I would discuss this thesis separately from the methodological problem of how to describe the new medium and which criteria to use. Talking about new subjects always means applying "old categories"—and usually the knowledge of the writing age—simply because language is always the language of the past.

Much more suspicious, it seems to me, is the current "rhetoric of the new," which by using the term of simulation doesn't recognize the time-honored problem of similarity, which in talking about virtual reality misses the assertion of realism, and which denies the ontological implications in the concept of data. The old theory frame cannot remain. But the people who claim to have torn it down will, to their astonishment, find out how much of it they carry along.

You often return to your thesis that the new media are based on language. Following Sherry Turkle's distinction, you certainly are an old-fashioned IBM-PC-modernist, not yet having encountered the blessings of the Apple-Windows 95-postmodernism: in other words, the traditional computer that must be treated as a calculator versus the new image-machine with the accessible, democratic user interface. Umberto Eco distinguishes the image-lacking, abstract, protestant PCs and the illustrated screens of the catholic Apple community. So, confess, you are a protestant modernist (as I am) who belongs to the Luther-Gutenberg pact! Officially you have to pledge allegiance to the printing guild; as a hobby, however, you like to go to the movies.

That's a great division! You read it: In the first place I criticize the media historians' habit of directly confronting the computer age and the age of writing, thus neglecting the long period of visual media. Isn't it surprising that the nonsensual computers (and even a few icons don't make them sensual) replace the overwhelmingly sensual universe of images? The frustration with the bugs replaces the "uses and gratifications" (those were the

categories people used to describe visual media!); and doesn't a newly arbitrary system substitute a motivated one, as semioticians would say? And these are, I suggest, the important questions to ask about the relationship of images and computers.

You are right: I don't think that writing was superseded because it was poor and not complex enough; or because it was outdone by other media. But that doesn't mean that, as you put it, I preach the return to disciplined linear writing. One has to distinguish three different levels of examination: first, the historical fate of writing; second, the question of images; and third, my concern with thinking about the n -dimensional data universe from the vantage point of language. I don't always come back to language theory because I appreciate language and depreciate images, or because there are so many written texts on the Web. It's much more important to me that there is a structural parallel between the Internet and language—perceived as two general, semiotic implementations.

The structure of the network itself—that's my major thesis—imitates the system of language or, more precisely, the semantic structure stored in our heads. The semantic system of language is an n -dimensional network of interrelated references, as language theory teaches us. Language elements become meaningful through differing from each other; semantic oppositions are created by repulsion within an n -dimensional space. My thinking is mainly about this parallel between Internet and language and the new perspectives opening up from there. Then there is the idea that technology in general can be conceptualized from language.

I'm sharing this approach with Christoph Tholen, who goes back to Lacan and Derrida, and I would name Leroi-Gourhan as a down-to-earth and more accessible witness. This thesis allows me to bring both sides of the media together. Looking at computers as symbolic machines, you cannot separate the symbolic from the technical, for both aspects are interrelated and it is the challenge of theory to describe this connection precisely. The discussion has not yet developed very far, but terms like *inscription* already bridge the gap and are therefore fascinating.

A part of your book that I like a lot is the description of Leroi-Gourhan's Le geste et la parole and the part on "machines of collective memory." These are connected to the concept of evolution and to a theory of technology that "locates technology in a triangle between natural history, practice, and language." In Leroi-Gourhan's thinking, social

memory (closely connected to technology and language) substitutes for the natural instinct and its bonds. Can you see a link to the theory of the "memes" developed by Richard Dawkins? How do you see the future of evolution in this context? Does it make sense to use a biological metaphor like "evolution" for describing the further development of technology and the machines of collective memory?

You are just detecting one of my knowledge-gaps: I never read Dawkins. If everyone using the term *evolution* reflected the fact that it is a metaphor, then the problem would be less severe. As I see it, it's necessary to consider that the history of technology is a huge macro process that—this is the main characteristic of evolution—escapes a conscious guidance and exceeds all human purposes.

Stupid, however, seems to me the conclusion that every guiding interference is senseless and every effort to take some distance (by means of consciousness, for instance) is doomed to failure. Here an originally skeptical argument—being made absolute—seems to turn into an affirmative one, with disastrous consequences for theory. Even the most naive ecological consideration teaches us that batteries may not necessarily be made from cadmium and that agriculture shouldn't be a subdivision of the chemical industry. Suddenly one is confronted again with those complicated and unattractive political questions that one was happy to have said goodbye to.

In any case, it seems important to me not just to account for one technology but for several competing ones. Then it becomes complicated using the term *evolution*. Reading Leroi-Gourhan illuminates one of Teilhard de Chardin's problems. Both of them start with the term "evolution," but while the latter aims for a unifying and necessarily religious apotheosis, Leroi-Gourhan focuses on the collective memory as a historically plastic structure, sedimented and of a considerable persistency, yet dependent on the course of concrete practices. Again we are dealing with the dialectics of discourse and structure.

You mention a "crisis of language around 1900," and you state that a comparable "crisis of the visual" must be acknowledged nowadays. But isn't it, above all, the (German?) authoritarian bourgeoisie who can't stand the flood of images, and who, as you say, is deeply irritated that TV doesn't speak in one voice anymore? Is it an older class of teachers, Die Zeit readers who also aren't able to enjoy zapping and who long for a quiet and orderly media landscape, who object?

If you want to analyze the present-day situation of media history, you first have to ask whether the computer is a new visual medium following the tradition of technical images (photography, film, TV), or whether it has broken with this tradition because of its specific characteristics. And my opinion is very definite. Computers can produce images, this is beyond doubt, yet it's quite a strongman act (considering the exorbitant use of resources), and it is not exactly part of their nature. My experience as a programmer tells me that the computer is a medium of abstract structures, of program architectures, and of algorithms that, in the end, govern the digital images too. The computer doesn't care whether it's pictures that finally appear on the screen. The computer doesn't know what to do with the image character of the images (there aren't any algorithms of Gestalt recognition or direct comparing and administration of visual contents); the two-dimensional output merely aims at the users' viewing-habits.

Therefore, I would say that the present hype about digital images and multimedia is a temporary phenomenon, a historical compromise between the universe of images, which has come into crisis, and the new, abstract, and structure-oriented system of computers. And if that is the case, I think we have to ask what happened to the visual. My opinion is that confidence has been lost mainly because the images have become so many, piling up in layers and increasingly revealing the hidden structures and schemes. Pictures lose their concreteness, which was their major promise and essential to their functioning. Everybody who zaps knows the phenomenon: No matter how many channels there are, after a while TV appears as a uniform surface of relatively few, often repeated clichés. And through the iconic surface of the screen, the symbolic skeleton of the images emerges.



Gated Communities, Themeparks, Youth Revolts

An Interview with Mike Davis

Unlike most writers on southern California, Mike Davis is a native son. He was born in Fontana in 1946 and grew up in Bostonia, a now “lost” hamlet, east of San Diego. A former meat cutter and long-distance truck driver, he now teaches urban theory at the Southern California Institute of Architecture. This interview was conducted in the summer of 1997 during Hybrid WorkSpace at Documenta X in Kassel, Germany, where Mike Davis was invited for the “100 Days–100 Guests” program. Shortly after, Mike Davis’s writings on the history of Los Angeles continued with the publication of *Ecology of Fear* (1998), which deals with a mixture of cinematic, urban, and ecological disasters and the ways in which public imagination has equated Los Angeles with the apocalypse.

In your book City of Quartz, you described fortified neighborhoods that are no longer part of the public space. You were one of the first to analyze this phenomenon. Is this trend continuing?

I tried to argue earlier that the militarization of space in the American city is being justified in terms of personal security. Increasingly, living in a gated community, behind walls, protected by a multinational security corporation with private police and the most sophisticated electronic gear, even to the point of having secret rooms where you can hide from terrorists, like what has now become popular in Beverly Hills; all this obsession with security is not about security at all. It has become a form of prestige. An assumption that a certain kind of lifestyle guarantees that you won't have uncontrollable encounters. Not just with people who are dangerous, but with people whose mere physical appearance is simply bothersome to you: the homeless, poor people, and so on.

The assumption that you can be completely insulated from that and the absurdity this reaches is probably best revealed in a housing project I saw in Las Vegas recently. Las Vegas used to be a kind of remake of Los Angeles, but it has become a demon seed on fast forward, with over one million people. A new, gated suburb, called "Lake Las Vegas," was built. Remember you are in the middle of the desert. There is no water here. Of course, a big lake had to be built, so that residents could have boats. It is a walled and gated community that has other walled and gated communities inside it, which are more prestigious. The momentum of this is now probably irreversible. But what is interesting is that all this protection and privatization of life of course creates a psychological crisis for the people who live within it.

The market is now beginning to tap into the huge need for the experience of space, of crowds. Middle-class people in southern California, now that they live in their gated communities and in their media rooms, suddenly realize that there is something else to human existence. So what is being produced is a kind of ersatz form of public space. The development industry will now tell you that the mall is dead. What it is being replaced by is a historic district of a city being turned into a themepark, with great concentration of media and entertainment, motion picture theaters, and stores that are usually branches of franchises of national chains.

All this is protected by a layered, invisible segregation and security. In Los Angeles, examples of this are Third Street Promenade (Santa Monica)

and Old Town Pasadena. Universal MCI has built a miniature version of Los Angeles at Universal Studios, called City Walk. Tourists can walk in complete safety and see fabricated or simulated pieces of downtown or Hollywood, without ever having to go to the city itself. What is common to all these areas is the sort of people being excluded from them. All of them have tightly enforced curfews. It is illegal for groups of youth to hang around. You cannot just sit by a fountain and play guitar. In fact, the city of Santa Monica has now ruled that the only legal activity for teenagers after ten o'clock is shopping.

The tendency over the last ten or fifteen years in America, to go beyond the traditional suburb, into this fortified, gated way of life, with private schools, private amenities, etc., becoming more and more self-sustainable, created this other need for space for people. But what you are being given is not real urban spaces, the spontaneity, the democracy, any of the dangers and pleasures of real streets. The city turned itself into a safe little theme park. You see people strolling down these streets, desperately trying to pretend that they are back in the city. There is something tragic and pathological about this.

Contemporaneous with this urban process has been the rise of cyberspace. A whole new discourse has begun in recent years about the encounter, or the clash, of the "real" and the "virtual" city. How do you look at the use of the city metaphor on the Internet?

This is and should be the great democratic battle about the nature of the new urban infrastructures of the twenty-first century. In the United States, there has been almost no debate about the nature and the allocation of investment in optical cables. In some cases, the leading utility promised that it would not discriminate against inner-city areas. In the last years, it totally reneged on this. It is becoming more visible that all the traditional handicaps of inner-city areas—the lack of jobs, investment in the physical landscape, the hollowing out of the arts, the decline of schools—is now being replicated on the level of electronic technologies.

But the key point is that this has not been an issue—let alone a central one—in politics. People are fighting against censorship and are trying to keep the Internet open, and obviously that is an essential and necessary fight. But there is not the same kind of attention to the plight of inner-city communities. The virtual ghetto of the twenty-first century will be the suc-

cessor to today's ghettos. But you cannot keep that stuff away from kids in the inner cities. If you go to South Central Los Angeles, you will see people in their garages with state-of-the-art equipment, not just Internet. There is also some progress concerning cable access on television. But so far, the big essential battle has been lost. There will be two totally unequal levels of society: one that has full access to the Net, and the other that only has a limited, episodic access.

Now the debate, at least in Europe, is about the design of the public part of cyberspace. Is it useful to continue to speak about the public sphere, or do you see cyberspace as such as a trap? Should we not focus in the first place on the reconstruction of the real spaces, the city with its real buildings and real people? One philosopher of the new media, Michael Heim, has stated that any investment in the inner cities is a dead loss and that all resources should go to the electronic infrastructure.

Obviously, simply as Democrats, as people who want to keep some human solidarity alive, we favor affirmative action in the construction of these new infrastructures. On the other hand, if you speak to people who design these new technologies, they will tell you that there are real problems in simply advocating more computers for poor schools. Public schools are becoming a huge potential private market. Disney, Apple, and other corporations are gearing up to create a virtual classroom—automated teaching technology, designated specifically for the most troubled schools. The danger is that you may get these computers, but in the end you won't have the teachers. In the American case, with the privatization of public education so high on the agenda, this is not only about technology and the public spaces of the future. It is also about salvaging democratic, public education, which is an endangered species right now.

What is the current status of the "ecology of fear," as you have described the psychological state of the ordinary people. Is it the fear of the illegal immigrant or is it about losing one's job?

It has become almost impossible in the United States to talk about jobs. If you were to talk about full employment in front of an audience, people would shake their heads and walk out of the room. Twenty-five years ago, this was the national program of the Democratic Party—that is, one wing

of American capitalism. Now it is utterly impossible to take it seriously. The roots of the problems and their actual solutions are not amenable to discussion anymore. On the other hand, two months ago, the governor of California sat down with the speaker of the legislature, a Mexican American Democrat, and had a reasonable, quiet, and serious discussion about whether they should execute sixteen-year-olds or whether it is permissible to send fifteen-year-olds to the gas chamber or give them a lethal injection. California has become a society in which this can be debated in all seriousness. But any debate on jobs becomes utopian, in a certain sense outrageous. Two drug specialists once told me that the best working drug treatment is the attention that people get. The best treatment for the problem of drug addiction is to give people a meaningful social role in society. Give them a job. I know this may sound old-fashioned and reductionist.

Last week, one of the biggest strikes in the United States, that of the UPS workers, ended. Were you encouraged by the results?

Like any strike, this was a complicated event. The union bureaucracy had one agenda, rank-and-file workers another. But when all is said and done, for the first time in fifteen or twenty years, opinion polls showed that an overwhelming majority of Americans sided with the strikers. So many millions of Americans are part-time workers. The real issue was the fragmentation of work. In terms of the public's attitude toward labor, it is a turning point, just as it was seventeen years ago, when Ronald Reagan locked out the air traffic controllers and started his crusade against trade unionism. What is slowly but finally beginning to happen now is a return to a different model of unionism, not the kind that existed in the 1950s and 1960s, but the kind of unionism of the 1930s that built the unions in the first place: unions as social movements that understood the importance of alliances with other groups.

Is it true that so many events, disasters even, have happened in Los Angeles and that all these spectacular events hide the fact that people are leading a normal life, like anywhere else?

Again, this becomes more complicated. If you would have asked me or any political activist from L.A. this a few years ago, our complaint would be that

if you turn on your television, all you see is the same thing, over and over again. Whether you are watching *Beverly Hills Cops* or *Baywatch*, what you will not see are the harder, more difficult realities of its streets and working-class neighborhoods. Well, our wish has finally come true thanks to Rupert Murdoch. He has now become the great media emperor. The reality TV series like *America's Most Wanted* and *Cops* are now being broadcasted worldwide. The wish of L.A. activists, to have all that bad reality depicted, has now come true.

We have to think of what this means. It is a kind of electronic version of the Roman gladiatorial games, where the suffering of people, the misery of our fellow citizens in our inner cities, has now become a spectator sport, in particular among people in the inner cities themselves who watch a lot of these programs. This exists in a brave new world where the mere representation and documentation of bad things no longer has any noble, political purpose behind it.

How do you regard Europe? There is mass unemployment here. Do you see a similar pattern?

In most of the former First World countries, the issues are very similar. One the most sinister things is how lookalike and indistinguishable all of our habitats have become. I just met the inner-city action group here from Kassel, and one of the things I was struck by is the supreme irony that a political party like the Social Democrats, who had to spend most of the nineteenth century fighting for the rights of free speech and free assembly, themselves are so enthralled by ideas of law and order. The very oxygen, the air that workers' movements need to exist, which is not regulated, circumscribed free speech, not an official program on television or a chance to speak at the university, but all the wonderful chaos in the free and democratic use of streets.

What you also see happening everywhere is that measures that were once directed against racial groups or minorities will sooner or later be extended to the youth. All advanced countries are criminalizing their youth. Even the richer kids in L.A. experience police repression too. They cannot go out and sleep all night at the beach. They get their boomboxes taken out of their cars for playing the radio too loudly. That is interesting because we might be accumulating some of the conditions for a youth revolt, of which we have seen

some signs of in Paris over the last couple of years. This attempt to control and police space may reinvent youth as a political category.

What are your future plans? Will a new book come out?

I am just finishing a book on disasters in Los Angeles, which I will speak about tonight. It covers riots, earthquakes, fires, and floods as well as all the imagined disasters that destroyed L.A. in hundreds of novels and films. I am also working with a group of people in Las Vegas, producing a documentary book about America's fastest growing city. Las Vegas is usually written about from the standpoint of people like Hunter Thompson, who, upon having swallowed an immense amount of drugs, come up with a very male, exaggerated way of talking about the city. On the other hand, you have the postmodernist view that pays only attention to the neon signs and does not understand that all these casinos are actually factories.

One of the oddities of late imperial America is that Las Vegas is the last union town in the United States, in which unions organize the majority of the workers. It is a city in which waiters and waitresses can actually afford to own their own homes because they belong to a strong union. We want to talk about the social relations of reproduction and daily life that creates this neon hallucination in the desert. And finally, I am also working on a more academic book, which is about the environmental history of war.



Art in the Age of the Mobile Phone: Text Messages from Finland

An Interview with Marita Liulia

The Finnish multimedia artist Marita Liulia once described her country of origin as a one idea nation—with one company, Nokia, now bigger than the Finnish state; with one giant telecommunications firm, Sonera; with one media company owning the only daily national newspaper, the *Helsingin Sanomat*; with its one art critic, and so on. Isolated and colonized in previous centuries, and squeezed between Sweden and Russia, Finland is now going through its golden age, a period of unprecedented prosperity, at least for those who own Nokia stock or work for Nokia, which is an increasing number of people. The process of urbanization and post-industrialization is vibrant, with people and resources concentrated on the South coast. A member of the European Union, Finland has recently introduced the Euro. It even has a growing population of immigrants and refugees. But Finland still has only five million citizens who continue to suffer from cold, dark, lonely winters and celebrate the long warm days in summer. Its population is less than that of North London, as one critic used to say. Or maybe Greater Berlin. In either case, that is a small number of people for a country of this size. How do these demographic, political, and economic facts affect the cultural climate in this country? I met Liulia briefly in 1996 and got to know her better during my two-month stay in Finland in 1999 when I was working on the Temporary Media Lab at the Kiasma museum (<http://www.kiasma.fi/temp>). During the winter of 2000, I conducted an online interview, which resulted in the collaborative text that follows.

How do economic and geographic conditions determine your work? It seems as if you are being pulled by the village type of cultural policies on the one hand, and the unique opportunities of a five-year state grant for artists on the other. Please introduce us to your version of Finland.

Finland is a nation where only one idea rules at a given time. We are just five million (and not growing). Our history is a long story of self-defense. The Russian bear has always been a threat, but the Swedes are not so loved either. Finnish are not conquerors but defenders by nature. So we turn the new millennium page as a pure white, deep clean and nature-loving, extremely well-organized country with straightforward, rather equal people who just have one big problem: long and depressing winters. Maybe that is why we have such a bad record in committing suicide. Since the Second World War, Finland has been culturally surprisingly Anglo-American. Before World War II the third language after Finnish and Swedish, which was compulsory, was German. Now since we are a member of the E.U. and our standard of living and degree of democracy is in top league worldwide, we could loosen a bit our “only one idea at a time” policy. After the war we had proportionally the largest migration from the countryside to the cities in Europe. Spiritually, Finnish culture has not yet arrived from the countryside to the city. Our cultural people gaze backward. Just think about those nostalgic Aki Kaurismäki films (*Juha* was a silent one!). The 1950s are still considered to be the Golden Era of our culture. It doesn’t mean we don’t have good and original artists. It is just difficult to find (popular) art connected to contemporary urban life.

New media haven’t (yet) brought very much change. It is surprising. The Finnish are not at all the technophiles they are made out to be. They are just keen users, which is what you told me about that other techno nation—Japan. The generation that will slowly change this attitude is still in its early twenties. But we are getting closer. Mentally, I fit better into that generation than in my own. Therefore my audience in Finland is rather limited. In recent years I have mainly focused on issues in contemporary (fe)male roles and identities. My work is not tied to Finland per se. I could have done it anywhere. Actually I did. I am constantly on the move. At the end of the 1980s I was very frustrated about the art and media world (I worked years as a journalist/photographer and traveler) and—more than anything else—about my own ideas of arts and the media. I grew up with Marx, Hegel, Kant, Dostoyevski, Marcuse, Sartre, Nietzsche—thus in a company of rather

gloomy men, plus artist bohemians, from Baudelaire to Burroughs. Very inspiring for a young and passionate woman artist, isn't it? In the late 1980s I started to study postmodern and gender theories with great appetite and ended up combining my old skills to new ideas and new technologies. It was a moment in my life when I finished writing the concept of the *Jackpot* CD-ROM installation in 1991. After discussions with technicians, I suddenly realized there is no other way—I had to start to work with computers. I used computers in the 1980s already while making sound and light installations. By the early nineties, I had started to direct a team of professionals. Production of large multimedia programs started. Now I have a fourth one in process, working new wireless platforms like GPRS.

Both of your CD-ROMs, Ambitious Bitch and Son of a Bitch, deal with (female and male) sexuality.

Sexuality is just one of the issues including changes in feminine and masculine identities, excerpts of recent discussions about (fe)male gender roles, psychoanalysis, social relationships, biological discoveries, and fashion. I am interested in changes. And I am fascinated by the ways in which people express themselves, by words, by body language, by thoughts, by clothes. As an artist and a researcher, I want to know what kind of ideas lurk behind these images.

I know you do not like to be identified as a feminist, because of its limitations concerning the fixed and narrow identity politics that go with this term. Still, it would be justified to say that sexual politics of art and new media play a dominant role in your work. Do you consider yourself a cyberfeminist?

Me, a cyberfeminist? Why not! It depends what you mean by this. Does it mean one is a feminist? For me it simply means a person who wants equality. Even in cyberspace. Let's add cyberspace to the list indeed (laughter). Some feminism is needed there, too.

How are these issues played out in Finland? Your country is indeed well known for its strong women, and perhaps also for its slightly tragic and disaster-prone male culture. How do you turn your explicit theoretical and political (psycho)analyses into a sexual aesthetics?

The field of the new media developed simultaneously with the high tide of feminism. Lots of (young) women got involved—expecting to avoid patriarchal hierarchies typical of the “old media”—like film. I considered studying film in the 1980s but quickly realized I will be fifty before the guys in power will allow me to make my first feature film—before that I would have also run out of ideas, I thought. None of my female film director friends ever made a feature film. In the multimedia nobody knew much about how to play boss. These days I think a female director is not a strange creature from outer space . . . but you have to be “a bulldozer,” as you put it once. No mistakes allowed. Since this promising start the number of female students in technology has declined rapidly. The field of the new media is heavily engineer oriented. Even in Finland where the whole state (our new president is a woman), the bank system, and the cultural sector are run by women, we have to be worried again about the fact that girls do not find information technology a very seductive perspective. I have worked together with engineers for about twelve years now, and I take care that my teams are built up so that both sexes feel comfortable and safe. It is a hard, sometimes full-time job but I enjoy it. The more people are mixed, the fewer prejudices there are. When I was researching and writing the manuscript for the *SOB (Son of a Bitch)* CD-ROM, I wondered how I would realize it in rather homophobic Finland. If a woman creates a work about men with such an outrageous name, the consequences are obvious. I took a risk and operated with a sense of humor. I guess in Nordic countries women can afford to laugh about dumb blonde jokes, but male roles are surprisingly rigid. Male identity is not something to poke fun at. It is possible that the timing for *SOB* was wrong. It was too early. I had to do the work anyway. In general sexual and gender identities have been a popular issue in Nordic (cyber)art and culture over the last ten years. But not so in popular culture. If I compare Holland and Finland, our popular cultures are quite apart as far as sexual/gender issues are concerned.

Throughout your art career, you have kept coming back to your own body, visualizing it, taking pictures of it, morphing it through Photoshop, dressing up, metamorphosing into other faces, other personas. What makes you so fascinated by this? Your biography seems to be full of big changes. You have gone from journalism, through performances and installation works, to multimedia, and now onto the Web—with projects becoming ever larger in scale. How would you describe these phases, this drive to move onward, the cycles in your works that lead you into a creative crisis in order to reach

the next, higher level? Where does this capacity to change, to transform into somebody else, originates from?

This is a very simple and therefore tricky question. It is curiosity that is driving me. I want to see what is behind things. I have always felt that the only real limits I have are body and time. I have spent my childhood in hospitals reading and making plans about what I would do if I survived. When I got better, around the age of fifteen, my hunger for life didn't know any bounds. I wanted to see and experience as much as possible. I might call that my artistic-intellectual role as a hunter of hidden meanings behind self-evident truths. I am constantly playing around with ideas and testing them. I also play around with myself. In a way my body is material, a model, and it is always available. By changing styles and characters, I find out different attitudes. I also change my character according to my work. Projects naturally grew bigger because with more experience I could handle more demanding projects. I need challenges. I cannot repeat myself—I feel like dying and drained out if I have to, so my next project always differs a lot from the previous one. My art projects are research projects as well. That is why it takes three years to finish a project.

You have been part of the multimedia industry from its very beginning in the early nineties. You have founded your own company, Medeia Ltd., employing a flexible number of freelancers, depending on the project. So far you have very successful in this. Still, there is this fundamental problem of the distribution of multimedia titles, especially when these are artworks. You are now setting up a Finnish version of the Paris-based Möbius prize for multimedia, the Prix Möbius Nordica. How do you look at the recent developments in this industry? It looks as if it is a tough business for artists with ambitious ideas about interfaces, complex content, and nonlinear ways to tell stories. And where does the Internet fit into this story? Much of the money these days is going into e-commerce, not so much to (CD-ROM-based) multimedia. The CD-ROM production, with its rather large budgets, somewhere in between a thick catalogue and a film, might be too difficult a proposition in the long run, with little return on sales. Or do we just have to be patient and speculate on the ever growing number of computer users?

I am operating somewhere between the art world and electronic publishing. My main problem during the nineties—and I am not alone in this—has been (international) distribution. The art world lives still in video time

(even today many big museums are not equipped to deal with computer-based art!) and the electronic publishing companies are still building up their systems. Also, high-quality content is expensive and demanding to create; thus it never holds much appeal to cash-crazed marketers. At the moment I am preparing my next multimedia project called *Marita Liulia Tarot*, which will be produced for four different platforms: printed cards, CD-ROM, Internet, and wireless mobile format. *Tarot* was first published for mobile phones in 2001 in Finnish. By now it has been translated to Dutch, English, and Italian. It was quickly adapted in countries like the Philippines and Singapore.

I am interested in current developments in telecommunication systems. I believe in multiplatforms at the moment. We go on working with CD-ROMs and DVDs because the Internet's development of multimedia is slower than I thought it would be four years ago. And audiences want their techno utopias to be fulfilled at a push of the button, just because some salesman told everything was going to be possible . . . I am dreaming of distributing my works for free—but who will pay the high costs of production? It might be a nightmare—or a real challenge for a producer. Somebody said that future audiences will not be willing to pay for content. That would be something the advertiser would take care of. Will commercial companies control the content in future? Will a banner on a Web site pay for the content? What kind of critical, intellectually demanding, challenging stuff could that be? It raises many interesting questions. (Noam Chomsky's lurking behind these lines). The best solution for the distribution problem is located on the Net itself; those who produce content should build up a network in order to distribute the works. First steps in that direction are being taken today.

Can you tell us something about your way of working? To what extent do you think artists have to become engineers and technicians? What is your relationship to the computer software and to the programmers you work with like? Do they influence the final result, or are you in control during the whole process? How would you describe the digital images and the interactive environments you design? It seems that you are still "drawing" images, in the handicraft way, only this time with a computer.

I am doing my best in order to bring such members to my team who are going to be genuine contributors. For years I have been looking for an outstanding programmer who also has a degree in philosophy. Seriously. Many

programmers I have worked with tend to be too young, nerdy types with too little experience in other necessary fields (those legendary social skills . . .) to work on a team for a long term. But then I have worked with so many good ones recently that I should shut up. In a team I am the director and sometimes also producer, so I always carry responsibility for the project as a whole and I am the one responsible if somebody's not able to do the work or has problems on the team. And once you have a team, you've got problems too! I have written a minimanual of sorts for my students about the main problems they might encounter. One has to foresee upcoming problems. Often they are linked to the team members' personal difficulties and are therefore difficult to solve but they're nonetheless very disturbing to the work atmosphere. Male and female roles are an endless source of problematic situations. Creating a good, respecting atmosphere seems to be essential—and that is my main job as a director. No wonder I feel like an alien when the work period is over. I have to leave the studio for some months and get really pissed off in Paris or Bangkok or somewhere else far enough. I cannot afford to bring my moods to work. All my works are based on photography, even *SOB*, whose interface is realized with QuickTime Virtual Reality. We manipulate digital photos or video images (we might even paint them one by one, and there are 24 images in a second!) The amount of stills I have to work out is so large, approximately four hours to browse in one program, and body and mind really do have their limits. By now both my hands have had to be operated upon. But I really adore working with images. That's my greatest enjoyment. I could perhaps manage without writing, but I really would suffer if I could not create images. It is a basic need for me. My works are based on (manipulated) photos because of the quality. And there's the prize aspect of it.

Maybe later on I will start to work with 3-D and artificial graphics. I like to combine real images with artificial ones, and the result should not be documentary. The way we work in a team is as follows. First I present my idea (manuscript) and my (philosophical, aesthetic, and political) goals to the team. I would also have prepared images and some examples of multimedia realization. Then we start working together and I do my best to motivate the team to bring their own ideas or criticism to the fore. It is sometimes hard work, especially if people have been employed in companies where they are not expected to have an overview of all aspects of the work. It is extremely difficult to generalize, but I have noticed that women have to be

encouraged to defend their ideas whereas young men . . . well, I mentioned the lack of social skills before. What I like best is to work with multiskilled, hard-working people who are curious about their own capacity.

Can you say something more about the relation between the artist and the engineer? This relation does not seem ideal at the moment. Is the only solution for artists to become technicians of sorts? If not, what are their skills then—to tell stories, draw, imagine? It seems as if artists these days have to be more than ever project managers, administrators, therapists, and PR strategists to operate successfully in the market.

To be successful in the market has always been demanding. It helps a lot if one is multivalent—and also an attractive person. Artists have always worked with other professionals (though their names are hardly ever mentioned). Also engineers. I am aware of the deep divide between artists (or people from the culture field in general) and engineers. The problem is how artists who are interested in technology/new media will manage to find engineers who have a desire for art and culture. It depends on one's contacts in general, and on one's attitude. I think we have to cooperate and learn to communicate with different professionals. Situations force artists in that direction. One can not handle all the professions that are needed to realize larger multimedia works.

The relation between so-called contemporary artists and so-called electronic or new artists seems complicated. Over the last decades these tribes, or rather these universes, have become separated from each other. Due to the rise of the Net and the arrival of computers in artists' studios and at the art schools, we are now heading toward a clash. I am not sure if it will be a productive "accident." You are active in both worlds. Would you like to see the electronic arts ghetto disappear? In the Kiasma event these two schools of thought seemed to coexist, and also elsewhere in the Finnish arts world.

In my surroundings, in Finland and in France, these universes are not so far apart. The number of artists who have started to operate on the Net is growing fast, as in many other professions. The computer is just the tool of this epoch. I think zapping and personal presentations of artists help to demystify the tool. The audiences and the art people need smooth guidance in the electronic arts. The main problem is one of availability—how to distribute

and present the works in the art world. The time we live in now is a time of images. Artists should benefit from that instead of being afraid of the new professional tools. Then again, younger generations have different attitudes but their encounter with the slow and conservative art world has not been a very successful one. They have to make their own rules. I expect that the new crop of curators, organizations, exhibition spaces, magazines, activities, and even schools will make the change—but it is a slow process. This is partly because commercial image making, the advertising business, and TV have succeeded in monopolizing the pool of young talent for a long time now with money.

What do you expect of new media critics? Can you remember a good piece you read recently that would indicate the way to go? Should criticism be based on hypertext or should we rather work toward the level of the “Tres Grandes Theories” (to become the Sartres and de Beauvoirs of the Internet, as it were . . .)?

Maybe the speed of technical development has been so breathtaking that grand theories are still to come. It always takes time to build up a comprehensive view of a period in history, but I’m eager to see it after all the hype. In this era sociologists (Castells, Bourdieu, Žižek) and linguists (Chomsky) seem to do the most interesting job. Last year I concentrated on gender issues in order to understand what was happening to concepts like “woman” and “man,” but my need to understand rapidly changing conditions in society and economics is growing. The consumerism (which has replaced former ideologies) we encounter in our everyday life doesn’t hide a revolution that has been going on for some time. Nokia’s yearly budget is bigger than the government budget of Finland. Who controls Nokia? The main shareholders. But who are they? What is their interest? Who controls a country, we could as well ask. Intellectuals have been surprisingly silent on these issues. For a long time it has not been fashionable to criticize society, the media, or individual companies. What was fashionable was to choose between brands. There is so much to observe and analyze. Media critics could offer interesting views.

How do you interpret the mobile phone mania, and where do critical and artistic content and interface design fit in the current explosion of telecommunication? Will everyone be a mobile artist during the time it takes to make a telephone call?

I find it interesting how our ideas of communication are changing so rapidly. Availability and accessibility are changing our “art of existence” faster than we care to notice. We want to be anchored in time, which is why we buy the latest tools. The drive of the market is absolutely amazing. Wireless communication creates an odd combination of distance and intimacy, which seems to be immensely seductive. Especially among youngsters, SMS text messages are extremely popular in Finland, as are mobile phone desktop images. If it will bring new art forms, I don’t know which ones but I am interested in that code language too. Artists can use whatever medium they choose, but the medium itself doesn’t make art. It has been always difficult for the art world to accept new mediums for artistic expression. It is again a question of power, as in any human system. Those who have it tend to keep it out of reach of others. Newcomers have to prove their plausibility. But if I were a poet, I would immediately start a Poem Phone where one could get max four-hundred-character haikus to the screen of one’s mobile phone and the money would go into the poets’ own pockets. No publisher necessary. I am planning to use the wireless “third generation” technology as one of the four platforms of my next work. My reasons are merely experimental. My reasons to use wireless GSM/WAP were experimental but then they turned into a real product. Nowadays I turn my gaze to digital TV and wonder how to make it interactive in an intelligent way and how other media, like Internet and mobile phones, could be connected to TV. If the manuscript I’m working on at the moment fits a new platform, I’m curious to see how it functions and what the audience response will be. The most attractive thing new media offers an artist is the ability to find new, unexpected audiences.



Media Wars and the Humanitarian (Non-)Interventions

An Interview with Thomas Keenan

Tom Keenan was co-organizer of the conferences on "Humanitarian Intervention in the Media Age," at the American Center in Paris in 1994, and "Data Conflicts: On the Geopolitics of Cyberspace in Eastern Europe," in Potsdam in December 1996. A first version of this interview, conducted in July 1997 during Hybrid WorkSpace at Documenta X, was updated via email in September 2000.

What is your opinion about media rights formulated in terms of the right to access and in terms of bandwidth?

It is a good idea to stress the topic of the politics of cyberspace. Not merely the ritual formulations about the need for universal access, which has become a slogan in the United States. Not just "We Want More Bandwidth" but a claim for bandwidth as such as a right. When you and I met at the Hybrid WorkSpace at Documenta X, Saskia Sassen had spoken about electronic space and the formation of new claims. She talked about a host of new political actors, both of the corporate multinational type and the local disadvantaged groups. I was troubled by her notion of presentation, which seemed to suggest that the public space, the city, was somehow effectively a space of presence, a space into which actors enter and present themselves. But the idea of "self-presentation" brings with it the concepts of the Self, identity and essence, foundation, which seem to have become increasingly questionable, even unreliable. "Because I am who I am, I make this demand for articulation, expression, access . . . bandwidth."

After thirty years of philosophical criticism, the fabled deconstruction of the metaphysics of presence, maybe we have developed new ways of thinking and practicing what a claim is. Cyberspace, because it's not something simply present, makes this clear. For me, calling something a "right" means: precisely because I don't have and cannot take for granted something that is mine as a naturally given possession, precisely because it is not here now, I claim it. That is a claim without any ground or basis in the present. It takes place in public, but the public is the space of appearance, of persuasion, of force and argument—not of presence and grounds. That's what a claim is: baseless, in this sense. It is a projection, a desire, articulated in relation to something absent.

This does not mean that I just want it for me. It would be an achievement, an attainment, a conquest to get bandwidth. It will be the object of political struggle. It will be a creation, not something that was already yours, but that you just did not have yet. It will cause trouble, it will invent something, disrupt; it will fabricate something new. And maybe it will sound a little strange. As we are editing this interview, CNN correspondent Satinder Bindra is reporting on my television from New Delhi about the "digital divide," and a "lobbyist" identified as Dewand Mehta tells him: "There should be a constitutional right that every adult citizen

should get two Mbps of bandwidth, and this is the vision we have for the next five years."

What was the topic of your "100 Days–100 Guests" lecture at Documenta X?

I spoke about the role of television news media, and a so-called crisis in the public sphere, during the conflict in the former Yugoslavia, and especially in Bosnia. We now understand that fighting takes place not just on the street, between bunkers, with artillery, but with the "artillery of the press," the media as weapon. I was trying—I still am—to understand two conflicting interpretations of the role of media in contemporary warfare. If we look at the history of traditional humanitarianism (intervention against famines, for instance), or the Gulf War and the conflict in Somalia, we might delight in or worry about the causal power of images, but we can say with some confidence, as Kouchner said, "without media, no humanitarian intervention." If something shows up on television, then something is bound to happen. Starving people and dead soldiers in Somalia did indeed get things going. Sarajevo seems to present the counter to that argument. The more things were shown on television, the less anything happened.

Hence the notion that television induced a narcosis, a stupor or voyeurism, which deprived us of the capacity for action, rather than spurring us. I spoke about an example from Snipers Alley in Sarajevo, where cameras and reporters of the international news media waited for people who were almost certain to be shot if they walked across this street in daylight. I was particularly interested in one analysis, by a reporter himself (Roger Cohen of the *New York Times*), which suggested that this voyeurism became somehow generalized in Bosnia: the camera team, the United Nations, and the victim who had a videotape of his attempted murder were all in more or less the same voyeuristic position—as were we. There is a generalized pleasure in viewing. A strange kind of intervention. One has a sense here of an omnipresence of media as entertainment, even for the so-called victims.

The war in Bosnia did not have a mobilizing effect. People could not identify themselves with any one of the parties. They all seemed to be victims and oppressors at the same time. There was a similarity between the "passive" behavior of the television viewers and the incapability of France, the United Kingdom, and the United Nations to stop this war.

There is a direct analogy between the semidistant position that defines that of the news media, and what seems like the nonintervention of the "international community." That is part of a "journalistic" ideology and self-understanding: not to get too involved. Certainly in Bosnia journalists played with this. A lot of them became less than detached. A feeling of involvement emerged, but structurally the position of the media remained analogous to a military force that intervenes on humanitarian grounds alone, claiming strict neutrality between all the so-called warring factions. We treat this one the same as that one, which is exactly the structure of the camera that looks at all potential subjects with a leveling force. It does not distinguish between the images that it presents.

But, that said, I think we still need to refine the notion of passivity. There is no such thing as passivity or inaction. The arrival of the cameras, like the arrival of thousands of soldiers, hundreds of NGOs, relief agencies, Red Crosses, does something, like it or not. All of those interventions transformed the situation on the ground and on the screen in the same way as the presence of the camera induces certain events. There is a magnetic appeal there, drawing out speech and performance, helping things to happen. Likewise, the passivity of the humanitarian, inadvertently, leads to a transformation of the situation.

Still, we have to face the fact there was no large antiwar movement as there was in the days of Vietnam.

The outcry did not occur. What energy there was, was largely—sometimes almost immediately—rechanneled into a humanitarian response. Rather than saying "We need to intervene, we need to stop the genocide," we said "Poor, suffering people need food, help, shelter, convoys, blue plastic sheeting." Humanitarianism was an opportunity, a vehicle of expression, to resist injustice, but in Bosnia it inadvertently allowed itself to be enlisted in aggression, even genocide—somehow a pro-war movement, a movement that prolonged the war by rewarding the aggressors.

This is the great insight of analysts like Rony Brauman and David Rieff. The humanitarian intervention came in fact to prolong the war by stabilizing certain zones of conflict, by rewarding the clearing of populations on ethnic grounds. By financing and feeding, the humanitarian efforts rendered unnecessary a military and political intervention and offered an alibi.

The situation in Bosnia is contained now, but a lot of the issues are still open, not only the media question. New facts are being brought up, as in the case of Srebrenica, where the Dutch battalion "witnessed" the slaughter of thousands of civilians.

You are certainly right about the unending character of Bosnia. The catastrophe of Srebrenica, the roundup and execution of so many thousands of men, under the extremely watchful but utterly helpless eyes of the Dutch peacekeepers, is a rebuke to us all, and one that will stay with us for a long time. The memory of Rwanda should stay with us even longer: the most temporally concentrated mass killing in recorded history, in a place (again) watched over by a UN peacekeeping force.

I do not think we yet know how to address the problems inside the conceptual and practical logics of peacekeeping and humanitarianism to prevent this from happening again. The UN may try to reform the way it operates—and certainly the interventions in East Timor and in Kosov@ represent new steps—but until we confront the irreducibly political, and not simply humanitarian, character of the actions that are called for we won't get very far.

The NGO branch in many countries is booming. Should its growth be cause for worry? Critics complain about a "lack of accountability" on the part of the civic sector—and you are one of them. Is a legal framework missing here? At the third "Next Five Minutes" conference, in March 1999, we discussed this topic in relation to the Post Governmental Organization, which is focused more on the level of global networks than on the ruined bodies of the nation-state. Obviously Greenpeace, the Soros Foundation, Rockefeller, and numerous other funding bodies with grassroots affiliations can set the agenda in certain fields. Yet, their size is tiny compared to that of global corporations. What are we talking about here? Please put this phenomenon in perspective for us.

One place where some of that new thinking about politics is happening is, as you point out, in and because of the NGO movement. Today, it is not an exaggeration to say that international politics can be and are conducted by nonstate, civil society actors. Foreign relations are no longer the province only of states, diplomats, militaries, or of transnational corporations. Other parties can cross borders in an organized way and intervene. The risk that this brings with it is the ideology of humanitarian neutrality or nonpartisan-

ship: only the properly unbordered can cross borders freely, it seems. But when they intervene, these would-be neutrals, they always take sides, they are helpless not to, and that gives the most aid, material or spiritual, to the dominant regional force, the bad actor.

The logic that intertwines and divides humanitarianism and politics is amazingly complex: James Orbinski of *Medecins Sans Frontières* (MSF) [Doctors Without Borders] charted it beautifully in his speech accepting the 1999 Nobel Peace Prize: "Humanitarianism occurs where the political has failed or is in crisis. For MSF, this is the humanitarian act: to seek to relieve suffering, to seek to restore autonomy, to bear witness to the truth of injustice, and to insist on political responsibility." But along the way, especially if you are unarmed and bringing only food and medicine, you must make arrangements, even compromises, with the dominant power. So, no neutrality, in fact, but also no accountability.

What is astonishing is the profound immunity of these agencies from critique. If there is a contemporary sacred cow, it is humanitarianism, or civil society, or conflict resolution and human rights organizations. Almost the only ground, at least in the United States, for criticizing a humanitarian agency is that it wastes money. "For every dollar we gave to Save the Children, 50 percent of it went to pay staff," or whatever. That's not the point. In fact, many organizations are too effective. Their effectivity consists in handing over relief goods to the parties that are by and large responsible for causing the shortage of food and medicine. And they answer, most of the time, to no one—only to the "facts on the ground," not to those they seek (honestly, I believe) to help, not really to their donors, not to any organized or transparent political process.

Obviously, I don't think they should be reabsorbed by the nation-state organisms they quite properly displace and challenge (and one worrisome tendency is in fact the transformation of many NGOs, particularly relief agencies, into subcontractors of big governments), nor by the logic of representation (for instance, parliamentary) that they by definition break with. (Michel Foucault already pointed this out in June 1981, at a press conference for the *Comité International Contre la Piracie*.) But new mechanisms of response, responsibility, new kinds of contracts need to be invented. That is where a critique would have to begin.

To their credit, some human rights organizations have begun to question the new politics of humanitarianism and of the human rights movement. I

would mention African Rights in London, which published in November 1994 an important and still underrecognized paper called "Humanitarianism Unbound," which tries to understand the lack of accountability of NGOs in crises like Bosnia or Rwanda. This critique is expanded in an important book by one of the paper's authors, Alex de Waal, called *Famine Crimes*, which begins to elaborate a logic of "contract" that might take us some way toward an answer.

We could also begin to invent this critique, and to imagine responses to the bind it articulates, in the case of the thing called "independent media." We have inherited the notion of independent media from the campaigns against communist dictatorships, where the state was seen as absorbing or preventing the creation of any public sphere or civil society. What was privileged, and supported by Western or transnational agencies, was the notion of independence in relation to the state, which was seen as a totalizing force. Independent media were, simply and powerfully, the antistate press, voices of an alternative that could not but be an opposition. Now the number of nonstate actors in the former communist states has multiplied in a way which is hard to calculate. The UN, European Community, or Soros Foundation have a very hard time understanding what "independent" might mean in relation to a state which is no longer simply totalitarian.

We spoke about this in Potsdam, especially about the case of former Yugoslavia and projects like Zamir, which as successful as they were in opening channels and getting people talking, and as important at the microlevel as they were, never quite achieved their objectives. Communication, open channels, alternative voices, are necessary but not sufficient conditions for democratic or antinationalist political action. This is also, strangely, the lesson from the big media in Bosnia too: Dead Sarajevans in the street don't automatically generate political responses, even if dead American soldiers in the streets of Mogadishu seemed to.

Media, and especially independent ones, are critical for "transitions," but they are no substitute for all the other necessities too, most notably politics. And simply supporting other voices for the sake of their otherness can become quite politically dangerous, now that the threats to freedom do not stem simply from the state. In Rwanda, one of the outcomes of the 1991 Arusha peace agreement (between the Hutu government and the largely Tutsi Rwandan Patriotic Front), was a considerable amount of

international support for independent media, especially radio. Much of the money went to extremist political media—very successful from a pluralist point of view, lots of independence from the state, many voices represented, and so forth—and when the radical parties and their militias were ready for the “final solution to the Tutsi problem,” the independent radios were the primary means of organizing and mobilizing the population for the most concentrated and swift experiment in political killing we have ever seen.

The general mood on the Internet has been very tense during the months of the Kosov@ crisis, in the March–June period of 1999. We both were heavily involved. How do you look back on the media aspect of this conflict? It all seemed so different compared to the Gulf War. Yes, there was propaganda, from both NATO and the Milosevic regime. What surprised you?

Has enough time passed already for a “look back”? It feels as if Kosov@ is not quite over yet. But, to precipitate things: what surprised me was the excitement about the “first Internet war,” and the hopes it raised. First, I really liked your insight (in the Bastard special issue on the war) that everything’s different in wartime. You wrote, “It seems hard for the advocates of independent media and free cyberspace to acknowledge, that in times of war there is little or no role for this famous civil society to play. Obvious, one would say. But we still have rather high expectations of, for example, B92, the independent radio station in Belgrade, or even from Kosovar Albanians hiding in Pristina.” Why do we have those expectations?

First, as you point out, because we still tend to amalgamate “the media,” and fail to distinguish between big and little, global and independent media, which, we should add, is also a difficult distinction to make in wartime, when those rare pieces of camcorder footage smuggled from Pristina or Izbica are broadcast virtually unedited on global satellite networks, and when the Web sites of NATO, B92, the KLA, and the BBC are effectively interlinked. And second, because we still hope that the independent media and especially the Internet will do for us what politics seemingly will not: connect people, open channels, promote understanding, tell the truth, raise awareness, create solidarity and consensus, induce responsible action, and so on.

But as long as we keep expecting that the media will replace politics, and replace it wisely, cleanly, and efficiently, which is to say, as long as we

keep hoping we can get rid of politics, we're bound to be disappointed. Here's where the distinction between propaganda and free media is especially powerful and difficult: The more we keep defining free media as nothing more than not-propaganda, the higher our expectations for it rise and the more bitterly we'll be disappointed. It was as if people thought, on the model of the adage that the Net treats censorship as damage and routes around it, that we could simply treat war as damage too, or imagine at least that the primary thing war did to information was censor it.

The Internet didn't stop the war, nor did it win the war. It emerged as a conflict zone itself—what we called a “data conflict” at the Potsdam conference some years back—and that is, in a sense, what and how it should be. Of course the mood was tense: There was a war going on. Advocates for the combatants, and sometimes the combatants or at least the targets, were exposed rather directly to one another.

What we were doing on the Net—whether on big lists like Nettime and Syndicate or on smaller ones like JustWatch—was, as the Nettime motto has it, “filtering”—selecting, interpreting, reacting, commenting, recycling and amplifying, interrupting and diverting—words and ideas, stories and positions, and not merely from outside the conflict. No war is fought, at least not today, without those words and ideas, justifications and challenges, and their meanings are never given in advance. So the Internet emerged as a new space in which those contexts and meanings could be argued over, addressed, and redistributed.

It was also a space, and a time, in which the war could be, not just overheard or watched, but witnessed. And engaged in. Whatever else was conventional about the war, the emergence of hackers, which is to say a proper information battlefield, was new. The Net was not only a space of representation and dialogue but of action at the level of its own language, of its framing devices, instructions and addresses, its mode of presentation, before and sometimes at the cost of the “information” that was presented.

Of course, a lot of people and buildings and data went missing in the war, and a lot of messages were not returned or even received, but there were few mysteries in Kosov@. Pretty much everything was entirely predictable, predicted, and still the political response was late, slow, halting, high-altitude, not quite finished. On the ground and overhead, technical

means were necessary, but they were not sufficient. I don't think that the technologies of virtuality converted us into voyeuristic spectators, but neither did they solve our political problems for us. Is this a surprise? Media and new media, free information, even with their unprecedented opportunities, are never enough for politics. Perhaps we need to radicalize these information flows, not in the vain hope of replacing or circumventing the political, but in order to discover it.



Audio Freedom

An Interview with Zina Kaye

Zina Kaye is a new media (sound) artist, based in Sydney, Australia, who uses the Net to “muse on the nature of metaphysical boundaries and the secret life of the air-waves.” For her, the Internet is the “new radio,” and she has begun broadcasting surveillance exercises that use Cold War technologies. In this interview, conducted in January 1998 on her balcony overlooking the beaches of Clovelly, she spoke about her interest in airports, surveillance technologies, the ins and outs of sound art, and the latest development in net.radio. Every now and then, a plane flew over and we had to stop talking.

Tell us about your fascination with airports.

Airports are places of departure and you can be seduced by the glamour of a new destination. You put all your emotional baggage on the plane and believe that it is going to be different when you get "there." But the moment of transformation actually happens when you enter the terminal. You become ghostly, maybe even psychic! The airport does not allow you to contemplate your travel. You have to go shopping and browse some boring computer magazines. It has the same kind of lighting everywhere, with generic carpet, the security systems make it even more generic while also shielding you from what might happen. You are not supposed to contemplate being in an aircraft. Martha Rosler spoke about this in her essay "Observations of a Traveler."

So I guess it's this place, the airport/changing room that interests me, and I have the opportunity to insert art into the structure of the airport and make the whole process a momentous and strange experience. I made a work that was a homage to the Sydney airport over the period of a year. It is called *The Fantasy Lounges Online Catalogue or The Chronicles of Agent Green*. It is all about a company called Fantasy Lounges that "represents the lost airport in the parallel universe." I went around opening gates as a kind of ritual, putting up signs that say Enter. A colleague of mine, a performer, had a green dress and a big green bag, which he made from cloth, and I filmed him walking around the airport for a twenty-four-hour period, visiting the business lounges, strange tunnels, and so on. The security guards were acting very strangely, and this was the only way we could get some kind of reaction. The performance ended at the edge of the airport, which faces onto a big rubbish dump, one of the biggest landfills in Sydney. Supposedly there is a curfew from 11:00 p.m. on, and airplanes are not allowed to take off. Every time they did we lit up a green firework. I wrote texts based on my impressions and included an answering service within the work. I collected this material into a database and put it on the Web, and parts of it are still there.

Sydney airport is not a normal airport: it's so close to the city.

It is a big bone of contention and sits right in the middle so people have to move around this great big wasteland of prime real estate. It is just too close

to residential areas. I have done some research about the history of the airport. Documents from the fifties and sixties do not talk about its location in any serious way. It just wasn't a consideration. Interestingly it has been one of the biggest sources of public activism: it has inspired lots of demonstrations, arguments, and bits of paper. People are constantly fighting to get the flight path moved away from their neighborhood. Part of the problem is fuel dumping before landing: That practice seems to happen over residential areas. It really permeates cultural life and affects people's health.

There is a game that kids play: Every time you see an airplane you clap your hands three times and make your fingers into a hash and look through them, to the airplane, while making a wish. One kid told me that he had made hundreds of wishes every day. And there is a theater under the flight path called Sidetrack that at least once a year features a show about the air traffic. But the irony is that the performance has to stop when the plane goes over because it's impossible to hear anything!

What does "sound art" mean, compared to music making or radio?

Well, it's hard to define it, because sound art has been around for so long and mutated quite drastically in that time. That phrase "sound art" is a large set of parameters, but not a genre in itself. Unfortunately, many writers and theorists do not consider it like this; it is expedient for them to generalize. To me, sound art is everything, from experimental composition, dance music, radio, installation, and voice work. There are not many formal opportunities to see the full range of it outside broadcast and performance. There are so few works presented in the gallery context because curators believe that it takes up a lot of room. That sound will pollute this painting. It is considered unstable. It doesn't last forever or archive like a Rembrandt: Its market value may fluctuate.

By which sound artists are you influenced or inspired?

Bill Seaman's work *Passage Sets/One Pulls Pivots at the Tip of the Tongue*, which came in a number of formats, but my favorite is the most formal: a spoken poem recorded at the ABC [Australian Broadcasting Corporation]. I listen to it over and over because the textual rhythm is incredibly sexy . . . sort of undulating. Overall, the work goes through some distinct emotional

changes and within the onomatopoeia and alliteration Seaman expresses the rhythm of life. I appreciate the style of language and Bill's beautiful voice. Joyce Hinterding's poetic approach to electronic minimalism is inspiring because of her exploration of invisible sound. She spent a long time researching and building electrostatic speakers that played very low frequencies, basically electrical disturbances in the upper atmosphere, and prerecorded inputs. Before that came a giant work called *siphon*, the sound of hundreds of beer glasses, filling up with electricity and unfilling. I appreciate the meditative space that such minimalist sound is generating: the space between what it is and what it sounds like. I think there is also a wonderful humor in her work.

DJ Gemma from the Sydney scene because she has a freedom and roughness, which is marginalized because we are too used to the process of production. I must say that I respect anyone with a good record collection: in a world of collage and cut-ups, a resource like that is liberating. The jungle scene is a fantastic example of audio freedom. It started off very grassroots. There were limited editions of acetate recordings, going to a few DJs, and playing on pirate stations. Now of course, everyone is compelled to throw out a compilation. Even though some DJs might toast over the top of it, it is still a more produced, more carefully articulated sound. It can become repetitive. The record labels are curating, deciding what the sound is going to be to lithely tailor it to their environment, and the impetus for experimentation is lost. I love creative uses of home technology, like Aphex Twin and the *Star Wars* soundscape that is composed of samples that started off as Hoovers and blenders.

Another part of your work is dealing with surveillance, of not being seen . . .

You mean the Anti-Destination Society, which is in fact a construct my father invented. He says that the Anti-Destination Society changes all the traffic lights to red so that he can't get anywhere in a hurry. A few years ago I brought it back into being and made it into a proper organization. My ideal was that everyone can become a secret agent. You can do what you like with it, just use the name. I was looking at what happened when the Cold War was supposedly declared "over." MI5, MI6, the CIA, etc., had to reconstruct themselves. They had, and still have to, reestablish themselves economically and as a power by creating new enemies. The enemy can be the

people, activists, perceived communists, anarchists, anybody with chewing gum, etc.

I recently gave a talk at the Center for Contemporary Art in Warsaw, and there were big problems with talking about secret agents. People defaced the posters advertising the event, and my text went through several rewrites, because first it was translating into something a bit unpleasant, and then I had to break the idea of “secret agent” into some Lego-like components, such as virtual community avatar, nonbinary coexistence, and the concept of maintaining face. Surveillance art deals with public spaces more than private spaces, but there might not necessarily be any viewer. It might be narcissism that perpetuates some form of surveillance, normalizing it, like that young woman with a Webcam permanently switched on in her bedroom.

My favorite example of this genre is a recent work by Dennis Beaubois. It was a three-week performance that he began by standing in front of surveillance cameras around the city of Sydney. Just standing there. The next day he would come with some signs that read “You are being photographed while reading this sign.” He himself would be documented by a still photographer and also on video camera. The video shows how the surveillance “business” deals with “suspect” people and artists. The next thing he did was hold a camera behind his back while facing a wall, the same sign pinned on his back. Being a trained Butoh performer, he stood stock still, secretly smiling at the simple fact that the spectator was becoming the spectacle.

At some point I began collecting the technologies that surveillance organizations use. It is often quite highly sophisticated, not readily available. At the moment I specialize in listening to spaces, listening to the vibration of buildings, using Cold War technology, a microphone that CIA agents used to stick to windows. I started building my own version of the microphone, listening to what was going in Backspace, a cybergallery collective in London. Then I found a device called an accelerometer, used by acoustic engineers. You can highlight various frequency bandwidths and magnify them, as you would do in Photoshop, and listen to the pixels of sound. I want to do that in airports. I want to reveal the shape of the noise you feel if you put your hand against the window. It is vibrating in an extreme way. I think it is part of the traveling; it hits you in your core. I have tried out this installation in the Code Red show, which took place in Performance Space in Sydney (November 1997). I broadcast that sound via

the Internet so that people could maintain surveillance of that space, a sort of abstract, instant atmosphere. It is about hot pixels of sound, an underlying smear of rumble. It is beautiful, but I discovered that listening to low sounds for too long can make you sick.

You have been using computer networks for quite a while.

My father had one of those handset modems and I used to play around with it because I heard about hacking. I wasn't very successful at all. Then I started experimenting with telnet and MOOing communities like LambdaMOO, which are quite special because they are built around skill sharing and the space is documented so it is always there and anything you build has a kind of ghostly permanence. A lot of social friendships arose from there. I did a performance called *MOO*, inviting people to a "performance space" that I built in LambdaMOO but also projected out into the real performance space. At that point I do not think that the audience was particularly prepared to participate in the *MOO*. It was too far removed from the average frame of reference, and people tended to shout vehemently at the screen, wanting us to type in obscenities.

These textual environments are spaces where delightful poetic combinations happen, and terrible misunderstandings occur. Big assumptions are made on very few words. Then came Mosaic, and playing with that code, the error messages, fooling people that they were being watched and so on. Eventually I got a grant to do a CU See Me performance, called *Lift_World*, together with a group of performance artists in Sydney. It was a research project based on an idea to make an international lift, an elevator that mysteriously joins Sydney and Warsaw together, in association with Martha van der Haagen from the Center for Contemporary Art in Warsaw. It was hard because there was an invisible proxy-server so that we could never communicate directly live.

It taught me a lot about how we could fool an Internet audience into thinking we were filming from a number of remote spaces, when we were in fact in a small studio. There are strategies to maximize the medium, and it's curious that although digital broadcasting is considered to be a big thing, not many people are really exploring the technique. Most recently I have been experimenting with Real Audio. There are big broadcast communities now, whether it be Chinese nationals in South America watching

the Hong Kong handover, David Bowie's exclusive Internet album launch, or radio pirates in Europe. Free audio for the cost of your Internet connection! But I cannot say what will happen next. People of Progressive Networks (who own the Real Audio software) are talking about Real Audio Walkmans, plugging into mobile phone networks. There will be associated commercial tie-ins, but honestly one of the greatest things in the world would be a portable computer that works on voice commands, like a car computer. Imagine being a blind person with that kind of technology! Free from the tyranny of that ridiculous seeing-person creature . . . the mouse.



Enemy of Nostalgia, Victim of the Present

An Interview with Peter Lunenfeld

Peter Lunenfeld lives in Los Angeles and is the author of *Snap to Grid: A User's Guide to Digital Arts, Media, and Cultures* (The MIT Press, 2000). Lunenfeld uses “snap to grid” as a metaphor for how we manipulate and think about the electronic culture that enfolds us. In this book he snaps his seduction by the machine to the grid of critical thinking. Lunenfeld hardly ever addresses the insider. As a contemporary cultural critic, he manages to contextualize the somewhat self-referential, isolated new media art works. A good example is his essay “Demo or Die,” included in the book. This email exchange took place after a series of public and private conversations in 2000–2001.

In which direction would you like to see new media culture go?

I don't think there's such a thing as a single new media culture. There may have been a decade ago, but by now digital technologies have so infiltrated advanced industrial societies that we have to speak of new media cultures. What I see today in all facets of cultural production is a kind of ferocious pluralism.

The subtitle of your book is A User's Guide to Digital Arts, Media, and Culture. Imagine if someone were indeed to read it as a manual for an Internet startup? What recipes and tips do you think he or she would come up with?

I can't say I wrote *Snap to Grid* (S2G) with the thought of someone else taking it as a manual for a start-up, but that's provocative. So, what might the entrepreneurially inclined get out of the book? For one thing, they could get a deeper understanding of the aesthetics of demos, of how to communicate in real time whatever it is they've invented or decided to bring to market. By running through some of the myths about interactivity, connectivity, and virtuality, S2G might help them craft things and systems that people actually want. There's quite a bit in the book that amounts to what I'd call "understanding now." I don't know if understanding one's moment actually contributes to the bottom line, and in fact it may be the exact opposite, with those who most willfully ignore the present making the most money off of the future. Be that as it may, S2G does try to discuss emergent technological aesthetics in the light of the historical importance of the end of the Cold War.

Do you see any possibility of a critical art praxis and the profit-driven network economy shaking hands?

Art and economics are symbiotic, even when they are seen to be in opposition, so I can't see why a networked economy shouldn't spawn networked art. I think that this is a fertile time for those with visual skills to be handsomely remunerated for certain kinds of design work, to take ideas, images, and sounds and build products out of them, and even to create lasting equity in commercial enterprises. On the other hand, I've never thought that info-tech capitalist enterprises would enter into a direct payment system for artists' personal explorations—except, perhaps, as isolated public relations

efforts—much less support fully politicized critique. Getting back to your earlier question, *S2G* offers a way to think about culture in general after the wide spread of information technologies.

It strikes me that we are all forced to engage with vastly broader ranges of reference than ever before, and that part of what we expect from the next generation of digital appliances is precisely the tools and methodologies to help us render meaning from the flux of information. Artists working in these areas may well be able to shake hands, as you say, with the dot-com billionaires, but I'd recommend that artists bring intellectual property attorneys along with them to the meetings.

In one of the best parts of the book, the chapter titled "Demo or Die," you portray digital artists being crushed between their machines—inherently unstable digital platforms—and their clients—ruthless transnational corporate capitalists. Instead of dismissing the demo as an unfinished attempt, you argue that "the demo has become an intrinsic part of artistic practice." Have the art establishment and their critics discovered this genre?

I think that artists understand better than one might assume the intrinsic importance of the demo aesthetic today. The demo is closely aligned with the "crit," that staple of art school instruction in which students have to stand up and "defend" their work to colleagues and instructors. The contemporary art world has been dealing with the impermanence of performance for years, since at least the Happenings movement of the 1960s. As for design culture, I think that the expectation for commercial messages is so short that a demo aesthetic is almost built in: if the message sells, it stays, if it doesn't, that message is gone. Commercial culture has always lived by the Oulipian motto "prove motion by walking," even if the average advertiser could care less about Parisian literary experiments.

Could we compare the status of the demo with, for example, advertisements and other commercial short films? What happened to Web design?

I think that Web design calcified incredibly quickly, but that had a lot to do with bandwidth-backward compatibility. Once an entire generation gets online with DSL or better connections from the home, I think you'll see another surge in Web design. I'm usually not so technologically determin-

istic about aesthetics, but in this case I think that the linkage is so strong between vision and bandwidth that the broadening of the pipe will bring about more design innovation. One of the utopian hopes that we all had for Web design was that the huge number of new voices entering the media would engender radical stylistic departures. On the other hand, the fact that so many of them are new to visual culture's rich and dense history means that too many of them are repeating—often pallidly—other people's proven strategies and successes.

Criticism and texts in general could as well have reached a "concept or die" level. Perhaps all texts are de facto hypertext, because they are read as such. Could you talk about this disintegration into "nano thoughts"?

Like almost everyone who comes out of any kind of sustained discursive tradition, I'm wary of the ever more amorphous nano-thoughts that fill the infosphere. But I strive to see if there is something to do about this besides keening for the lost era of 400+-page books and well-crafted essays. The Latin rhetorical term *multum in parvo* (much in little) seemed to be one place to start. Like so many of my generation, I saw myself as a rediscoverer of McLuhan in the 1980s and 1990s, after his fall into obscurity in the 1970s. He was fascinated by aphorisms, seeing them as probes that the reader needs to unpack and as vastly more active than essays. It takes a sure hand to craft a compelling *multum in parvo*, though, and as I note in the book, even McLuhan—who was a master—flopped at least as often as he soared.

You read this development in two ways: The first is the potential for increased density, as demonstrated with the aphorism or directed slogan, but the flip side of this is the rise of vapor theory. Can you say something about the danger of vapor theorizing and at what point texts transform into neologism and sales talk?

The failed aphorism is only one small part of the overarching category of what I came to call "vapor theory." Vapor theory is a gaseous flapping of the gums about technologies, their effects and aesthetics, usually generated with little exposure, much less involvement with those self-same technologies and artworks. Vapor theory is one result of the historical condition in which new media emerged. There was an almost fully formed theoretical context for digital art and design even before they were fully functional as

media technologies. This certainly did not happen with film, radio or television (though there are some parallels with artists' videos of the 1960s and early 1970s). The late 1990s moment of overwhelming, and overweening, hype for the Web seems at last to have subsided, so perhaps that will temper the vapor theory as well. The increasing institutionalization of "cyber-studies" may sustain vapor theory, though, due to the ever increasing velocity of academic job hunting and publishing for advancement.

In your writings, body-centered bioscience metaphors are remarkably absent. Nor do you criticize them.

I'm one of the few people I know who doesn't want to live forever, so the central attraction of bio blather—immortality—leaves me cold. I don't want to have an endless dialogue with Extropians and associated noospheric hangers-on about the religious fervor that they bring to these issues, nor have I been particularly impressed by the work that artists have done in these areas. Too much of it falls into the "when we have the tools, the work we'll make will be wonderful" school of mediocre art/technology.

Why do you think so many electronic artists are fascinated by this "arts meet science" discourse?

I'm wary of the notion of the artist as research scientist prevalent in new media circles. At conferences, I hear artists going on about how they are now validated in their choice of art as a profession because scientists and engineers respect their "research," and the fact that they are getting money from Intel. This attitude is incredibly odd. Collegiality is a wonderful thing, but in the final analysis, why should artists give a damn about what engineers think about them? This "scientific method" is growing rapidly with the "megaversity" structure, in which artists who can create a practice that apes the forms of scientific research get hired and funded. They hire and fund others like themselves, and thereby build a peer network to evaluate the "results" of their work.

This has gone hand in hand with the development of the arts practice-based Ph.D. in the United Kingdom and other parts of Europe. Most artists have some sort of "research" component to their own practice. But this research is generally only important as it relates to the work to which it con-

tributes. There are some select artists for whom the research is the work, but quite often they are working within a specifically conceptual framework and what they tend to explore ends up being the idea of research itself, rather than a specific topic (a metacritical project that is more ontological than empirical).

Is this then just opportunism, an attempt to bring the artist to the level of the so-called neutral laboratory engineer/inventor, in effect to “increase” the perceived utility of art in an ever more technologized society?

This gets straight to the heart of the matter: Art can be “useful,” but the glory of it as a sphere of cultural production is that it does not have to be. Researchers and scientists are trained differently and have a different set of expectations for their work—there is an expectation of utility, and often of clarity (avoiding the detours of postmodern science wars for a moment). This whole artist-cum-scientist confusion reminds me of the 1980s when what we saw, especially in the United States, were artists-cum-social workers. For every innovative effort like Tim Rollins and KAOS, there were a thousand dreary “community-based collaborative projects” that existed for one reason and one reason only: to get money from the National Endowment for the Arts (NEA) or local funding agencies.

Originally, by putting in some vague prosocial rhetoric, artists could get some support for the work they really wanted to do, but then they came to see the funding scam as their whole reason for being. What began as something of a scam turned into an entire aesthetic. Then, during the “culture wars” of the late 1980s and early 1990s, conservatives in the U.S. Congress neutered the NEA and this entire brand of practice died out—though now I see some of the same people who went after the social work funding going after money and technology from hardware and software companies.

Now that we’ve covered some of the movements you don’t like, what about the ones you do?

I’m very careful about using the term *avant-garde*, even as I spend a great deal of time looking at what other generations did indeed term avant-garde art and media. The very phrase avant-garde needs to be given a rest, like a good horse that has been ridden too hard for too long. When stylistic and technical “advances” come from all spectra of digital media production—

commercial, artistic, scientific, academic, etc.—the notion we have inherited of a singular, oppositional avant-garde serves little purpose anymore. If our software, music videos, computer games, and WAPs are all to be termed avant-garde, then that phrase has indeed been reduced to a marketing phrase like “revolution.” I do not see the digital artist as being an avant-gardist in any classical sense of solidarity or shared artistic destiny; and, in fact, too many mediocre talents have hung on to just such exhausted tropes to support their own, weak brands of practice.

I like the way Snap to Grid treats 1970s structuralist films as central to contemporary media art. One chapter is devoted to the work of Hollis Frampton. Do you see any continuity twenty-five years later? Or similarities compared to current digital media developments?

I wrote about Frampton for a number of reasons. The first is simply out of admiration for his life's work. He was able to meld rigorous art practice with far ranging and vital theorizations of his media, from photography to film to video to digital media. Like his contemporary, the protean conceptualist Robert Smithson, and those who followed this path like painter Peter Halley and video maker Gary Hill, Frampton offers theoretical texts that are supported by, and support in turn, a body of important artwork. These kinds of artist's writings offer ways out of and around the dead ends of too much mainstream, contemporary media theory. One of the things that drew me to digital media in the 1990s was that same sense of artists creating the contexts and explications for their own works, on listservs, in catalogues, on conference panels, and—perhaps most of all—in bars around the world.

Can we talk about the preoccupation of new media theory with “the” future? One thing I’ve noticed about your writing is that it tends to be encapsulated within existing reality. Is there such a thing as “California dreaming” which would take us to yet unknown places?

I don't think I'm preoccupied with the future. I know I'm an enemy of nostalgia, and I'm pretty sure I'm a victim of an obsession with the present. My first “User” column for *art/text* magazine was called “Permanent Present,” and concerns the way in which—for all the hype—our visual culture is not that much different than it was in the mid-1980s, after the advent of the

Mac's GUI and the impact of *Blade Runner's* retro-deco aesthetic. I happen to loathe the idea of "futurism" as a discipline and find myself much more interested in explicating "now" rather than the "next." I prefer to encounter other people's fantasies of mutable environments and interactive nanotech in science fiction rather than science-fictionalized discourse. I tend to keep my daydreams to myself.

With Kodwo Eshun you are saying: everything still needs to be done. What is the role of the critic in all of this?

I approach criticism as a way to elucidate that which I admire about art rather than simply trying to fit it into a preconceived straightjacket. I'd like to think that I've been able to explore that ferocious pluralism I mentioned earlier that so characterizes our era. This is disconcerting to those who pine for the certainties of movements, schools, or avant-gardes that marched in lockstep, one after the other. These days, you're on your own; it's up to the individual user to craft his or her own frameworks. Part of the job of the critic is to offer models for this process.

One way that you have been working to develop context is by establishing Mediawork pamphlets, a new book series for The MIT Press. You're pairing writers with designers to create what you've called exines for grownups. The first title is Brenda Laurel's Utopian Entrepreneur. Is Laurel saying that access to venture capital is the latest human right?

Not at all, the focus is less on how to get funding than what you should do after you've got it. Laurel's trying to carve out a space within capitalism for social aspirations that go beyond personal ambitions. She's proposing the term culture work as a description of the socially positive activities that take place in the huge chasm between the autonomous artist and the anonymous corporate hierarch.

As I remember, Laurel was involved in more than her fair share of beautiful failures, but maybe that's the utopian side, making the book an obligatory dot-com statement about the right to bankruptcy. In what sense do you see that new media artists' involvement in tech venture has changed? Isn't the well-praised synergy between "industry and the arts" a bad New Age dream?

Utopian Entrepreneur wrests the language of commerce away from business people, who tend to write that turgid, self-promotional prose that we associate with management manuals like *Who Moved My Cheese?* She discusses culture work as an antidote to precisely the fuzzy thinking that allowed us to imagine that there was so much surplus in the “new economy” that industry and the arts would become the same thing. This bad dream, as you call it, manifested itself in lots of different forms during the 1990s. Within the technology boom it was indeed New Agey, but in the art world, it had a distinctly Romantic flavor. A “beauty camp”—led by Las Vegas-based critic and curator Dave Hickey—began to demand that artists should embrace entertainment and turn away from the mandarin complexities of conceptualism and theory.

I feel that new media discourse is really at the crossroads now. The tech-driven downturn will force the emerging forces within new media culture to come up with sustainable models, beyond all the ups and downs of the IT industry. What can we mine from the past decade of thinking about these issues to move forward? Are there aspects of “technorealism” that we should embrace? What elements of Wired’s cowboy philosophy should be defended?

It’s almost an exercise in mid-1990s nostalgia to discuss “technorealism”—I can barely remember who went to what conference in which city to sign what document to decry what excess. As a movement, it offered neither the adrenaline rush of the machine fabulists nor the humanistic reassurance of the neo-Luddites. Technorealism was simply inert. Talking about the *Wired* cowboys after the dotbust moves us from trivia to forensics. Rather than pick through the corpse, I’ll focus on one positive impact the magazine had: *Wired*’s founders looked at the media sphere and decided that none of the magazines they were(n’t) reading featured the people they were interested in, so they set out to create their own celebrities. They established an alternate world in which roboticists, game developers, and even Extropians were the “commodities” that drove the magazine.

What about the libertarian dot-com philosophy? Is it still intact after the bubble has burst?

Technolibertarianism was never intellectually robust enough to merit being called a philosophy; it is more of an attitude. As long as there are successful

loudmouths who believe that they owe nothing to the infrastructures by and through which they develop and market their products, we'll have libertarians bloviating on talk radio. In 1994, Kim Stanley Robinson wrote *Green Mars*, the middle volume of his magnificent *Mars* trilogy, and offered a pointed description of libertarians as "minimalists [who] want to keep exactly the economic and police system that keeps them privileged anarchists who want police protection from their slaves."

What do media theorists in recession do?

I see the big tent metaphor dissolving. In flush times, there's always the possibility that money alone will paper over fundamental differences. So artists and intellectuals did a kind of dance to get money from chip makers and design consultancies, and industrialists kept hoping that an "aesthetic dividend" would accrue to their bottom line if they let artists hang around. The big tent is seductive while it lasts (I'll admit to succumbing to more than a fair share of junketeering), but when the circus moves on it encourages people to relinquish their fantasies of mutability and omnipotence. By this, I mean the way in which during the boom people began to believe the hype that the computer allows everyone to become everything. Under this digital alchemy, only those fools who don't "get it" discuss limits.

Do you see any countercyclical activities being spurred to action?

The most important social movement of our time—the protests around globalization—is precisely an attempt to come to grips with limits while at the same time encouraging hope for the future. The culture in general seems to be more aware of the need to support infrastructures of all kinds. For close to three decades, people were promised that privatization could solve all their ills, but many of those ills still exist and new ones have emerged. I was impressed by a recent proposal by Rana Dasgupta to develop a public domain audit for various countries, a counterpoint to the obsession rankings of GDPs and GNPs. We need precisely this kind of alternative categorization of "the good" in order to move beyond the myopia of markets.

Let's go back to California dreaming. What about the specifics of southern California? Is there a critical mass of new media theorists, artists, and critics in the

L.A.—San Diego region? If so, how are they supporting themselves? Is it mainly through institutions?

Southern California has a tremendous wealth of resources for both the creation and the investigation of visual culture, especially as that visual culture becomes more involved with electronic, digital, and networked technologies. Southern California has three of the top five film schools in North America (USC, UCLA, AFI); three of the top five places to study animation (Cal Arts, UCLA, and USC); three top-rated architecture departments (UCLA, USC, Cal Poly Pomona); the best independent architectural school in North America (SCI-ARC); and North America's most concentrated high-quality training in design and the fine arts (including the Art Center, UCLA, CalArts, UCSD, UCI, Otis, and UCSB). All these institutions are within driving distance of each other. There is, therefore, already a body of visual intellectuals here—people making, thinking about, and writing on visual culture.

Even more, these institutions and those who work in them are engaging ever more seriously with the relationship between the technologies of media production and their aesthetics. I founded mediawork: The Southern California New Media Working Group back in 1995 to enable theorists—Lev Manovich, Norman Klein, Phil Agre, Steve Mamber, Vivian Sobcheck, and N. Katherine Hayles—to come together with scientists—Ken Goldberg, Danny Hillis, Paul Haeberli, and Mike Noll. Architects—Tim Durfee and Marcos Novak—mixed it up with curators like Carole Ann Klonarides; and graphic designers—including Rebeca Mendez and Somi Kim—shared a space with industrial designers like Lisa Krohn and artists ranging from Bruce Yonemoto to Jennifer Steinkamp to Diana Thater. L.A. is a place where you have to plan spontaneous events, so it's both more complex and more rewarding to spark such interactions.

In the context of discussing digital media, could we then speak of a renaissance in southern California?

Naissance, rather than renaissance, perhaps. When Richard Barbrook and Andy Cameron wrote "The California Ideology," it was a bang-up analyses of a certain brand of Silicon Valley technolibertarianism and the mush of ideologies offered up in the pages of *Wired* (remember when that magazine

mattered?). But for some of us who were working here, the tone of the article rankled: "So far, the Californians have proved to be better at making virtual machines than social analyses." This is a typical European attitude—the New World makes, the Old World thinks. This is as ridiculous coming from London as it would be from Paris (though I always felt that Barbrook and Cameron had a better sense of humor about their characterizations than did many of their readers, both in Europe and the United States).

You've talked in the past about the emergence of a SoftTheory in southern California. Can you explain what you meant by that?

SoftTheory attempts to build a methodology that critiques and explicates the present and that grounds its insights in the limitations as well as the potentials of these technologies. SoftTheory is the product of and producer of a high electronic culture. It engages with popular culture in all its forms but does not attempt to become popular culture. It builds a fluid discourse about visual culture that is broad but rigorous, that has shared concerns but no totalitarian central metadiscourse. On the other side, this is not a high electronic culture built entirely around renunciation. SoftTheory lives in, with, and through these technologies in a particularly immersive Californian way. We are not deluded into thinking that nineteenth-century analyses of industrial capitalism are sufficiently supple to engage with the postindustrial, interconnected world.

How exactly is SoftTheory particularly appropriate for the West Coast?

It allows us to preempt both the European criticisms of theoreticism and the East Coast's condescension toward us as entertainment-addled victims of the spectacle. I'm hoping that a few years down the line, people realize how remarkable the body of work coming out of Southern California is. In addition to Heim's prodigious thinking on virtual reality, Agre's monumental *Red Rock Eater* news service, and Hayles's already renowned *How We Became Post Human*, look for Sobchack's collection *Metamorphing*, and forthcoming volumes from Manovich on the language of new media and Klein on scripted spaces.

How would you summarize your approach?

What I try to do is combine the object- and artist-specific discourses we inherit from the criticism and history of art with the more systemic analyses that developed in the study of media like film and television. When I was a kid, I read a series of tall tales about a small town boy named Homer Price. In one story, a nefarious con man comes to Centerburg to sell an invisible powder that when sprinkled on anything made it “ever so much more so” whatever you liked about it. Donuts would taste ever so much more so like donuts, bikes would ride ever so much more so like bikes, etc. (I was too young at the time to think about its immediate application to sex, but that’s another story). I always loved that powder, even though, or perhaps precisely because, it was bogus.

Paul Foss, who publishes my “User” column in *art/text*, has said that there is an underlying theme of faith to them—faith in art, faith in faith, faith in something, even if as ineffable as the invisible powder. Overall, my work runs counter to the nostalgia of both left and right. I prefer to spend my critical capital figuring out what makes right now so compelling. I am forever in search of the strategies, media, and artists who will make what I think of as our future/present “ever so much more so.”



National Heritage and Body Politics

An Interview with Mongrel

This is what Mongrel has to say about its activities: “Mongrel is a mixed bunch of people and machines working to celebrate the methods of an “ignorant” and “filthy” London street culture. We make socially engaged cultural products employing any and all technological advantage that we can lay our hands on. We have dedicated ourselves to learning technological methods of engagement, which means we pride ourselves on our ability to program, engineer, and build our own software and custom hardware. The core members are Matsuko Yokokoji, Richard Pierre-Davis, and Graham Harwood. The group Mongrel started out of the now closed ARTEC school, where Harwood was teaching new media. The interview with two members of Mongrel, Yokokoji and Harwood, was recorded during the 1998 Ars Electronica Festival in Linz, Austria, where Mongrel presented its National Heritage project.

What is your heritage?

Graham: It is mongrel. The first category is “don’t know.” A bit of Irish and English. My granddad is a bastard. People think he might be a bit Jewish. Then there are a few incestuous births. My dad really did not know who he was because he got thrown out into the “care” of the authorities at the age of four. His parents could not feed him. He did not know until he got shot in Korea, so after that he went to find them. They were more or less peasants. Heritage in the wider sense meant poverty. My parents taught me that we could be proud of having nothing. To come from nothing is a fine place to be. I come from the land of fiddling. You can always fiddle, get away with it. My family was involved in a lot of gambling. We never had a place in society. They always had illegitimate children. My niece just had a child at fifteen. There are five generations of women that are, more or less, close to each other. They support each other, and the men are there to make some fertilizer.

Matsuko: The national heritage of Japan, what it did to other countries, and my own, personal history are inseparable. There is an interesting period, during the last century, when surnames were being introduced. At that time people “bought” their heritage, so to say, by choosing a name associated with a wealthy family.

Could the history of the working class also belong to the national heritage?

Graham: It is an anti-heritage. It was a way of existing outside. In the United Kingdom there is very much a collective identity. England is 007, James Bond, the crack of leather on the willow of the cricket bat. Strawberries and cream. If that image is not yours, then it is there to exclude you. It is a bit loose because there is no monolith. There has never been a single nation or grouping in the United Kingdom.

You recently published a poster/paper. Along with a black and white insert with material related to the search engine project, which we’ll talk about later, there are forty full-color heads, organized into some kind of grid. It’s almost like a database with two available gender categories and four racial “types” and with what appear to be racialized masks actually sewn into the faces below. The paper also has a large logo that reads “National Heritage” . . .

Graham: This aspect of our project is a reference to the Department for National Heritage. It allocates all the arts funding in the United Kingdom. We decided to make a project with that name, in order to make a direct reference to where the money comes from. Seventy-six percent of all that goes to class A and B, people earning over £30,000 a year. That tax money only goes to that wealthy class. The reason we have the white face with a black mask, covered in spit on the poster, with the words "National Heritage," points directly to this particular department. A revised version of their logo is on the poster. This racial dichotomy is the heritage of the nation. We make them complicit with us.

Do you want this department to become "multicultural"?

Graham: That is their excuse for keeping power. Multiculturalism is their method of classification, to maintain identities that are long since gone and not useful anymore. They would like to keep a binary authority, which no longer works. Recently, a think tank close to the Labour government issued a statement, saying that embassies abroad should no longer have any politically incorrect pictures. Cover the walls with Britart and remove the portraits of old colonial rulers. Remove all reference to British colonial rule. Do they really think that people in Egypt or India can be fooled, by thinking that the British empire never existed? Such emphasis on image! Art is not that useful. But for them it is seen as a major prize.

How did you construct the images on the poster?

Matsuko: Out of a total of one hundred faces we made eight faces and divided them into four colors: black, brown, yellow and white, both men and women. It is all montage, digital photography. We tried to construct a white male, or black woman, according to what we think these categories look like. We can never prove that somebody is a white male person. How would you define a black person? There are no characteristics according to medical terms. There are no "real" categories, only stereotypes.

Graham: On TV there was a program about people of mixed race, let's say—or one-eighth black. They were complaining because for them there

is no classification. One of their grandparents is black, but most of them do not even know.

Matsuko: I had never seen a Western person, for real, until I was eighteen. Only since the beginning of the eighties, when many people from all over the world started coming to Japan, did I start to recognize people of different color in the streets. Only then, we became aware of the problem of racism. Before, the Americans were only on television.

Graham: These days, many young Japanese do not show much interest in where they are from. They see themselves as the future, not the past, the old Japanese culture. They live in the future. Any return to the past is horrifying because you will hit the brick wall of the Second World War. Japanese are good at hiding. The society can leave unresolved problems.

It sounds liberating, to leave the Benetton identity politics behind. ("I am from Ethiopia, look how beautiful—and pure—I am.").

Graham: In the sixties, my parents used to say things like "Don't touch it because a black person has had it, you will get ill." At the same moment, they would say, "Martin Luther King, he is a great bloke, he is going to free black people." Two complete opposite views expressed at the same time. We are moving from that level of confusion. I grew up with ska music and black friends—and this black music was being sold to us, white skinheads. So, the level of confusion concerning race is OK. The single thing that seems to categorize white people was fear. The fear to even talk about race. Or to express difficulty about it. We clearly come out as antirace, not so much as "anti-racist." We are against the classification of race. That's what a mongrel is—somewhere between two things, someone of mixed blood. Or it refers to a dog that has no category. Dogs in the United Kingdom are very much a class issue.

Matsuko: I lived for the last twelve years in London, so culturally I am mixed now, always fighting between Japanese and English. So I suppose that I became a mongrel. Since the eighties more and more Japanese have started living abroad and have brought their mongrel culture back to Japan. That's the positive side of the use of technologies.

Graham: Matsuko and I are the same age. Despite all the differences, much of our media references are the same. *The Thunderbirds*. We both grew up under the imperialism of the United States. But then, Richard brings a lot of different elements into the group! He is a Black-Indian-Welsh-French person from Trinidad. He is not as confused about his identity as perhaps others are: He is a black cockney—much more so than me. Compared to him, Matsuko becomes an honorary white person.

Matsuko: In 1987, when I visited South Africa, which was still under Apartheid back then, and showed my passport, I was being treated as white. But if Chinese people went there, they were categorized as “colored.”

Natural Selection is another project by Mongrel, an Internet search engine. Did you come up with this idea because well-known search engines, like AltaVista, are no longer useful because they always come up with thousands of references if you type in a keyword?

Graham: We are looking at classification from another point of view. We created a search engine that sits on top of other search engines. We strip out what they are saying and return the URLs. If you type in any word which has got to do with race, eugenics, or sex, you are dropped into our content. This means a whole load of Web sites being produced in collaboration with a variety of people and groups from a lot of different places: in London, around the world and from different situations which they bring in to flavor the work—academic theorists, street activists, poets, artists, nutters, whatever. If users look around carefully, they will find the right keywords to access these sites—or they might do it without realizing. On the other hand, you might end up in a “real” Ku Klux Klan site, but you will not find out anyway whether you are reading one of our constructions, or not. You need to be alert all the time as to where all the information you are reading is coming from.

Matsuko: We are not judging what is good or bad, we are trying to provide information. We don't say, Killing life in this or that stage is justified, or not. There is no answer. We do not value life or race. We are showing that it exists.

Graham: We are struggling to find images that deal with the complexities of the kind of lives that we are living now. There is no longer black and white. There are no longer binary arguments. So the right wing can jump on us and say: So you are confused. We are just struggling to find images. Sometimes they are complex and take a long time, like those faces on the poster. It is much harder to think about the same problem from six, maybe opposing, points of view, and hold them all equally. For me, all of this comes from Matsuko's influence, from Japan, where you are able to accept something before you judge it. In the West, I have been brought up to judge something before I have accepted it. One could even say that of antiracism and antifascism. A lot of the identity politics were useful, at the time. But the holding on, imagining the problem would be solved, instead of it slipping it through, like water through your hands, is what actually happened. That antifascism no longer works. It has become a way to sell a product, not a way to deal with complexity in society. At the same time, I have absolute admiration for people who sleep on the floor in the homes of immigrants in trouble, defending them with their bodies when the fascists come around. We engage in the imagery that forms around these topics. We are in the realm of producing troubling images. Often our actual enemies turn out to be politically correct people. The very name "Mongrel" is too difficult for them, let alone our intentions.

You've also produced some software—let's see how it works. Here we've got a package called Heritage Gold on the screen. It is an ironic, bastardized version of Photoshop. We have imported my image into the system, and now you are going to give me a new heritage. It's a good idea, let's go for it.

Graham: This is family-oriented, heritage-changing software. You need some blackness and femaleness. You can invent a new family. You can have a bastard birth, revert your genes, you can have immigration, repatriation, whatever. I am pasting the new color onto your skin. It reminds you how easy it is to manipulate all this data from other people. There will be a huge demand in the West for this software when it goes on full release since people feel a general discontent about their heritage. It will become important to have racial mobility. This menu allows us to add more Chinese and African into your makeup. You never have to have a sun tint again. In order to make you even darker, we go to the "flesh tone adjustment" dialogue box.

We will extract some of the Aryan elements—and you are really beginning to show through now. We will add some social elements too. We are offering a social filter of “police.” You look a bit more criminal . . . We also add some historical relations. A bit less imperialism. Put in some more Afro. We can resize your family by a certain percentage, raise your class consciousness. And then there are the different file formats in which we can save you: genetic index, pixel punish, raw, regressive . . . There you are—here, you got your brand-new heritage.

Mongrel has been working on different projects related to openness and access. For this, the Linker software has been developed. Can you tell us something about your experiences?

Graham: It’s impossible to have good access even in Linker if you don’t cultivate a sense of openness. This does not mean letting everyone do what they want. The first version of Linker was formally very tight, so you could explain it in ten minutes. Open for us means that we and the organizations need to change form and function to accommodate the cultural and social variety of the groups we encounter, such as families, older individuals, youth, ethnically diverse groups. After all, technology—whatever the media hype—is not inherently open. In a Mongrel workshop the social structure and the architectural space must actively be made available to people, while having specific social and technological skills on hand to inform the new initiate or maintain equipment or constantly rethink what constitutes openness in a project space.

The Net had this utopian promise of giving access to all. We can see that aspect happening all over the place. But access to what? Only to downloading? Will other interface cultures be uploaded? And if so, will they just be tolerated, just as subcultures of previous decades have been?

Graham: The curiosity we see is with ourselves and others. We think about history together, both ours and theirs, the material world as well as the realm of the imaginary or drug induced. As for dot-coms and software, in this unequal world, the struggle around the question of who is able to make themselves visible and who is not, and for what purpose, is central to any good reflection on how we see the world and what representations of the world we are fed. A good Mongrel workshop tries to ask those of us involved to look again at what is our capability in representing ourselves and for what

reason and how those representations may come to act on the world. I think the Net subcultures will act as R&D for the major online players, but in the slippage good things will happen.

Can you give us a definition of antiracism in London? Where does Mongrel fit in all the institutional forms of multiculturalism? Or don't you fit into it at all?

Graham: We see progressive antiracism as experienced in London, as one that admits that racism is multifaceted and not the preserve of any one social group or another. Addressing the current manifestations of racism is certainly not about shaming, blaming, or being guilty. These sensations or tools generally belong to a time in which an aspirational group of black peoples was yet to be established. These sensations or tools were primarily used in the United Kingdom of the 1980s to establish a new black social elite that would act as a reliable buffer zone between the have's and have not's. It became a matter of urgency to have an acceptable black face sitting on municipal authorities after the economically costly riots in London, Manchester, and Liverpool in the early 1980s.

The standard view of social racism is that it manifests itself formally within the structural leftovers of European colonialism, statistically proven within economic and culture power. This structural inheritance, because of its formal nature (within legislation and the inability to control the reproduction of one's own self-image) can be addressed "easily" by rewriting the rule books and helping a few "intelligent" blacks to get into business.

Mongrel, on the other hand, sees racism through a bruised experience of the world, seeing it essentially as migratory and multifaceted, offering no promise of ending. We witness racism in individual indifference masquerading as tolerance, in absence masquerading as the others' disinterest, and in individual geographical and economic limitation. This complexity requires an individual to search for specific lines of cultural, personal misinformation and how this data forms into images of the others' intelligence and accordingly how this image acts on the social, economic structures of society locally and at large. The individual uses this criticism for personal escape from their social, geographic, economic isolation inherited from a colonial past. This is seen as useful for the self-interest of all peoples including white as well as black peoples.



“The insider is curious, the outsider is suspicious”

An Email Exchange with Boris Groys

Art critic Boris Groys has taught philosophy and aesthetics at the School for Design in Karlsruhe, Germany. The following email exchange took place in response to Groys's latest work titled *Under Suspicion: A Phenomenology of the Media* (2000). His books are published in German by Hanser Verlag, Munich.

Strategies for cultural and artistic production, in your view, seem to go in circles. All forms of expression, media, and aesthetic experiments have been polluted, corrupted, played out. The pressure of globalization, to join the free flow of opinions, styles, and meaning is high. There is no other option than to join the info market. In opposition, you propose to describe the media as an ontological question. The overall presence of empty signifiers is flattening all creative or subversive efforts, and one of the few strategies left, you suggest, is to question what is behind the world of the spectacle. Wouldn't it be better to remain silent and disappear altogether? In your analysis, all imaginable answers seem to be caught within the system. There is nothing left that cannot be deconstructed. Not even Boris Groys. If neither elitist avant-gardism nor cultural populism shows us a way out, what does? Should your readers give up all hope and surrender to good old European negativism?

You are probably right: It is better to remain silent. But, unfortunately, there is such a thing as curiosity. And I am, personally, always very curious. In the first place, about how and why cultural phenomena like theories, art movements, certain fashions, are emerging, moving, spreading around—and disappearing. The question is not, Are they good or bad? Or, Are they true or false? But, rather, Why are these cultural phenomena present in the social space at a certain point in time?

It is being said that cultural products are spreading because “people” like them. Or, they say, cultural products are reaching mass circulation because there is some power, money, and influence behind them. But it is also possible to say that certain cultural products are multiplying and spreading merely because of their viral nature. It is also possible to say that the fate of cultural phenomena is determined by history, by being, by language, by writing, and so on. Or, it is possible to develop a sociology of culture as represented, for example, by Pierre Bourdieu. But all these theories and explanations are themselves also cultural phenomena. So we still have to ask ourselves how and why these explanations are spreading in their turn.

It seems to me that some cultural phenomena are spreading around precisely because the people believe—in one way or another—that these phenomena are not just phenomena but that they give a deeper insight in the space and in the interplay of forces behind the scene. If a cultural product is in circulation, it is already an explanation in itself. And if this cultural product is not getting any distribution, then there is nothing to explain. This is why I do not try to formulate a new explanation. I am trying to describe the

conditions under which some phenomena thrive, as explanations of their own cultural success.

The subtitle of your latest book is A Phenomenology of the Media. I was surprised to read that you are working toward a philosophical program for the media, in rather traditional terms. You do not touch upon new-fashioned topics such as transhumanism, transgenderism, or any body-machine matters. Which role do you see for the traditional discipline of philosophy? Should reading of classics be encourage, or would you rather push new forms of cultural criticism, which are not so concerned with the rewriting of the few dead white male thinkers?

The word *phenomenology* in the title of my book means only that I do not attempt to give any new, different, personal, additional kind of theoretical, scientific explanation of why certain cultural movements are spreading. Instead, I try to show that every cultural product is an explanation of its own presence and multiplication in the first place. It is a very traditional gesture, indeed. But this gesture seems to me to be most appropriate for the investigation of the cultural movements in the open space.

Until recently I was preoccupied with the processes taking place in closed spaces like the museum. In that case, it is possible to formulate a theory because there is an institutionally secured position for the external observer of the cultural processes. In open spaces, there is no such secured position. This is why the “phenomenological epoch” becomes necessary. It is a way to introduce the position of a spectator into a field where this position is not given from the beginning.

Topics like transhumanism, transgenderism, or body-machine matters do not interest me in this particular context because these discourses believe they have answered the question: What is behind being human? in a very traditional way by “crossing the borders” between the human and nonhuman. But the question of the spectator remains open here. Is this spectator human, or nonhuman, or placed beyond this opposition? And in any of these cases—how does this spectator know about his or her own position in relation to this opposition between human and nonhuman? The only way to know such things is to believe in your own theoretical discourse. But I cannot believe in my own theoretical discourse. So the only way for me is just to investigate why, how, and under what conditions other people believe in various theoretical discourses.

How then do you write a sentence, or make a statement in public, if you do not halfway accept it, at least as a temporary thesis? Bringing up an idea does not automatically mean that it is turned into a hermetic belief system.

Of course, if somebody says and writes something, it can always be seen as a thesis. But, in reality, it is not always effectively seen in such a way: Very often the people just don't react, just don't take you seriously, just don't see that there is a thesis. So I am interested in the question: What makes somebody's thesis look like a thesis? My guess is that you have to propose some insight, something that "goes deep into the heart of the matter" to be taken seriously. Or, to put it in another way, your discourse has to conform to certain expectations having to do with the phenomenology of suspicion, for example, with the reader's wish "to go deeper," to "get an insight." By the way, if my discourse eventually turns out to be a hermetic belief system for a greater public, I would have nothing against it. Rather, I would find it very flattering.

Can you explain the title of the book? For me, personally, Under Suspicion has a somewhat dark, continental European connotation. You are stating that it is the Other and its subjectivity that makes me suspicious. Why is the Other associated with danger and a possible crime? You are rejecting the "atheist" position that the world merely exists of empty signs, with nothing behind the profane space of the media. Why does this attitude result in paranoia, and not in curiosity? Suspicious of what? Looks like a weird mixture of Calvinist and Stalinist cultures of guilt to me, or like Catholicism during the Inquisition. Or leftist circles, where every act or expression might be in danger of being appropriated by the system.

Actually, I wanted the title of my book to remind the reader of crime fiction, Hitchcock movies, or spectacular journalistic investigations. Our media always tries to bring an "inside story," to allow us to look behind the scene, to show us the places where "the fate of the world is determined." This is the context that is interesting to me—not so much Catholicism and Stalinism. But, of course, religious or leftist, or, for that matter, rightist conspiracy theories are also relevant in this context. And atheism? The atheist believes that there is nothing behind the signs. That is okay. But for me atheism is merely one religion among many others.

Everything is ideology. There is no science. Facts don't exist. But which crime has been committed? I agree with you that the method of deconstruction is based on the implicit presumption of a committed crime. I like the idea of the media critic/theorist as a private investigator. The fact is, though, that most media and communication students are not trained to do this job. Media studies, as well as media art, focus primarily on the (historical) structures of media technologies and its ever changing platforms and standards. Information equals noise, that's the consensus. Who is doing qualitative content analysis, apart from a few linguists, activists, and investigative journalists?

That is precisely the point that I tried to make in my book. The technological characteristics of the media bearers, like TV, computers, the Internet, etc., are taken generally as a completely satisfactory explanation of what the media are. This faith in technical know-how is produced in people's minds by a combination of a very naive interpretation of McLuhan's "The media is the message" and a very naive interpretation of Ferdinand de Saussure's "The language precedes every individual speech act."

But how do we know in advance what can be said? We have to explore, investigate, and use TV, computers, or the Internet to find out what their media possibilities are. We can only know after the fact how certain media operate—and only in a very preliminary, incomplete way. The technical description beforehand does not tell us anything meaningful about it. Nam Jun Paik used TV in a very idiosyncratic way—not as it is "technically" supposed to be used. And that is why his work is so instructive. But I must confess here that my book was severely criticized by almost all its reviewers precisely for "concealing the fact" that the public already knows very well what the inner core of the media looks like—because it has all the technical instructions how to use the computer, Internet, etc.

For decades now, cultural studies has emphasized the "construction" aspect of news, information, and images. They neither represent Truth, nor are solely made with the purpose of fooling their audience. Media analyses are more complex these days, and so is the perception of the audience. Do you see the playful strategies of irony, difference, and multilayered meanings and interests as a useless, failed project? Your statement that media are, in essence, always lying seems to be a somewhat populist, regressive step back. Perhaps the cultural studies discourse has not yet been successful enough? Or at least in your circles, on the European continent.

Well, it is not so important for me if the media are lying about the “reality” or not. Let us suppose that they are telling the Truth, only Truth—and nothing beyond the Truth. Also in this case, they are still concealing how they do it—how they tell the truth. Every truth presupposes a scene of its appearance—and conceals this scene at the same time.

The “constructivist” theory is incredibly naive because even if it no longer believes in the accessibility of the world outside us, it still believes in the possibility of explaining how we construct the truth about the world. But that is precisely the problem: We have neither access to the world nor to our own construction of the world. We don’t know and we cannot know how we construct the world.

Of course, we know—at least since Magritte—that a painted apple is not a real apple. I guess that is what you mean by irony, difference, and cultural studies. The problem is only that we still don’t know what is the painted apple per se. René Magritte, Paul Cézanne, and many others tried to clarify that but they failed. My book is not about the relationship of the painted apple to the real apple. My book is about the relationship of the painted apple to the painting. And the book states that this relationship is and must remain forever unclear—even if we know what the “painting technique” is.

In your previous brilliant work On the New (Über das Neue), you have described the way in which new ideas and concepts are being developed and launched. Under Suspicion (Unter Verdacht) could be read as a follow-up. Have you indeed developed “new” ideas about the laws of cultural production, if I may ask?

Our cultural space has a complicated topology: there are closed spaces, open spaces, and mixed spaces. In my book *On the New* I tried to describe how the closed spaces, like museum, library, and university, are functioning. Being caught in the closed space, the people are interested in the open spaces—in crossing the borders, breaking the rules, discovering the new. But being left in the open spaces, the people get more interested in the closed spaces—in getting the insight, discovering the hidden, getting access to the forbidden. The closed spaces are the spaces of curiosity directed to the outside. The open spaces are the spaces of suspicion directed to the hidden inside. The insider is curious, the outsider is suspicious. In our mixed reality, we are, of course, both because we are always insiders as well as outsiders.

New media, for example, can easily be deconstructed as a repetition of the same old mechanisms. Still there is a lot of excitement, debate, and (don't forget) economic opportunities for a great deal more people than previously employed in the old media (and arts) sector.

Well, but my question is, What do these old mechanisms look like? It seems to me that the people working in the media—people like you and me—are, as I said, insiders and outsiders at the same time. Now, the things are moving all the time and, therefore, we are also changing our places all the time—yesterday we were insiders in one respect, today we are outsiders in the same respect, but maybe insiders in some other aspect, and tomorrow? Who knows. But this permanent topological change of our cultural space seems to me to be the reason for the permanent activity you are speaking about. Every morning we wake up on a different place in the cultural space because this space somehow moved overnight. And, of course, it makes us nervous.

Anxious too, perhaps? Change as a danger, not a challenge? One can even get used to permanent change, I suppose. Our globe is indeed going through rapid, radical transformations. For example, one can easily accept and deal with the fact that the nature of media these days is lying in their ability to (digitally) manipulate. There is no “natural” image anymore. All information has gone through the process of digitization. We just have to deal with the fact that we can no longer believe our eyes, our ears. Everyone who has worked with a computer will know this.

I think I am not so much anxious about what I am looking at. I am rather amused by that. And, of course, looking at the things around me, I am not so much interested in whether they are true or not. And I feel no angst about them. And I am very little interested in the “real.” Actually, I am only anxious about how other people look at me. And if I speak about the changing world, I don't mean the spectacle of permanent change taking place before my eyes. I am perfectly comfortable with this kind of spectacle. But I am not so comfortable about the possible change in my own position in the eyes of the others? Am I still an insider? Or have I already become an outsider? I guess it is just the inner voice of my Jewish ancestry: The way the others look at you is changing permanently—and this change may be dangerous.



Urban Techno Tribes and the Japanese Recession

An Email Exchange with Toshiya Ueno

Toshiya Ueno is a Japanese sociologist, media theorist, and critic. In May 1990, when I was introduced to Ueno in Tokyo during my first visit to Japan, I could not quite make out who he was. His English was poor and so was my Japanese. I had heard about his institutional involvement and his career as a popular columnist for fashion, design, and computer magazines. In 1992, when he came to Amsterdam for the first time we slowly got to know each other, and by the mid-1990s our friendship was established. He returned to Europe frequently and became a regular visitor to the Ars Electronica Festival, reporting for Japanese magazines. At that point Ueno's English skills increased dramatically and a fierce dialogue about media theory issues and the state of new media culture worldwide started between us. A few times a year, Ueno would stay in the tiny guest room of my former Amsterdam house. He gradually left the official Japanese new media business and started to investigate Amsterdam's free media scene, drug culture, and the (Goa) techno-trance scene in particular. Through the lively refugee tribes from former Yugoslavia based in Amsterdam, Ueno came in contact with techno-trance rave scenes in Croatia where he made his debut as a DJ and TJ (text jockey), a passion he continued in Japan. Our collaboration took us from Internet conferences in Europe, to an annual teaching project held five times at Osaka's Inter Media Institute (IMI), to a common trip to Taipei, to coproducing a television show about Amsterdam's subculture. In this email exchange, we focused only on a few aspects of Ueno's work: the notions of urban tribes and digital diaspora, the use of technology in subcultures, and the need in Japan to cross boundaries and start a dialogue and exchange between various scenes.

In retrospect, how would you describe the 1990s in Japan? It seemed like such a strange period, when not that much seems to have happened. It looked more like a never-ending mild recession. A sweet stagnation without brutal Thatcherism. No crucial decisions were made. No drastic cuts. No equivalent of the fall of the Berlin Wall. No uprisings. There weren't even dramatic political and economic changes following the 1997 Asian financial crisis and countless bank scandals. The cultural climate seemed dominated by an ongoing consumerism, yet in a less ecstatic way compared to the bubble years of the mid to late 1980s. A sophisticated numbness and joyful innocence could be found among youngsters. How could this odd mix of technological speed and pop fashion during an ongoing recession result in such an amazing soft stagnation? Please tell me if I am wrong. If this model is running out now, do you see any signs of discontent or even protest?

Your description may be right until the mid-1990s, the days just after the collapse of the speculative and "bubble" economy. But around 1999, a drastic storm of "neoliberalism" set in. Ordinary people were seemingly not aware of this crisis in their everyday life. However, if you turned your eyes to the micro level you could find lots of symptoms of a collapsing corporate welfare state. There have been many lay-offs, "restructurings" of businesses, and various cases of "privatization" of the public sector such as museums, institutions, and state universities. Until 1995 people did not feel these measures and were by and large unaware of the coming crisis. For the last three or four years, however, we have faced a "secondhand" version of "populism" in the U.K. style. Politicians have been quite influential in this process. It did not matter whether his or her political standpoint were left or right, liberal or conservative, global thinking or nationalistic. These days novelists and TV stars are capable of winning an election and become president of a local prefecture or win a seat in the national parliament. Some of them are significant figures in Japanese subculture.

During the recession the cultural or expressive sector of society was deeply damaged. It has become difficult to find a publishing house for books that have a theoretical or political content. I was saddened by the absence of uprisings or riots, yes. But I also have to say there have been numerous revolutions, even though most of them came from the conservative and reactionary side. "Revolution" is the very nature of neoliberalism. Japanese society is following the same process that the United Kingdom and United States experienced earlier. On the other hand, one has to see the

singularity of the Japanese 1990s. We could for instance point at the transversality (a notion of Deleuze and Guattari) and singularity of the economical, cultural, and even political crisis.

Is it useful to integrate the notions of subculture and media as developed by U.K. cultural studies into your research on Japan?

Cultural studies U.K.-style and its versions in other Asian regions are of importance to me. I do not want to reduce cultural studies to political and theoretical reflections on Japan's imperial and colonial past, nor to a sociology of popular culture. In the United Kingdom, cultural studies has also been tactical criticism and a theoretical weapon against populist neoliberal politics within everyday life. Cultural studies were not just an analytical tool; it was also related to real micro and cultural politics against the populism sprouting from neoliberalism. I am referring here to do-it-yourselfers, Rock Against Racism, the movement against Criminal Justice Act, and so on.

Until recently I have also been thinking about why we did not have protest movements in Japan. But now I am more interested in doing something real and responding to the seemingly invisible and intangible crisis. We can make something happen in this situation. Although neoliberalism is really shit, it is also true that it can also generate forms of resistance against itself. A few years ago, in Germany and Amsterdam, I came across the rave party phenomena. I discovered music-based subcultures even though rock had long been a part of my life. Rave culture has got something for me. Rave is based on hedonistic desire and fun, but at the same time it can also be connected with environmental awareness. It is a movement in itself with its own anarchist politics. For instance, pirate radio is often used these days to broadcast from rave parties.

In the early 1990s I used to be a critic of contemporary art, music, film, and all kinds of expressive cultures. Those were the so-called postmodern days. At that time the Japanese economy was still a powerful force. The speculative "bubble" economy needed, even preferred, "speculative" essays and articles. Under those circumstances I wrote a lot of papers and essays for a myriad of magazines. However, when I came across rave I realized that music was the most important thing for me and my critical interpretive ability was most suitable for the music and its cultural and political implications. That's when I stopped writing about other fields such as new media

theory and the arts. Within the rave movement I found a lot of elements I was interested in and involved with before, for instance, free radio, techno music, ecology movement, quasi-squat activities, anarchism, dissident politics, and also visual designs of party gear—decorations that are related to contemporary and electronic arts. All the elements I had been interested in so far were coming together in rave. I started to elaborate my own theory based on everyday experiences.

Do you think that technoculture is part of the leisure industry, designed to help people forget daily boredom?

A party is not a festival or carnival to forget the routine of the everyday life. A party is a critical part within the everyday. Sometimes people think of a rave as a unusual event that is opposite to the everyday life as a “temporary autonomous zone” (Hakim Bey). For some scholars raves are conceived and interpreted as disorder, chaos, a marginal experience, frequently depending on *communitas* and liminality arguments as developed by Victor Turner. Theoretically speaking, these arguments are rather banal. Raves or parties are not liminal or marginal. One can bring in elements such as the gift economy, openminded communication, abandoning the sexual “pickups,” environmental consciousness, and so on. Even though it seems that rave and party can occur beyond the everyday life, beyond the border between order and disorder, the usual and unusual. Because of my involvement in rave culture, people in liberal and leftist academic circles in Japan have started to criticize me. They say: “Toshiya has changed a lot. He abandoned social movements, cybercultures, and media politics.” But that’s not true. These days I am much more involved in cultural politics, the politics of the everyday life, than ever before. Through rave culture I am encountering a variety of urban tribes.

Aren’t you overestimating the political dimension of the rave phenomenon?

Most of the ravers are apolitical and lack consciousness about political issues. For instance, they don’t care about Japan’s colonial and imperial past. On the other hand it is very interesting that some young trance tribes are negotiating with capital or globalization in their own way when they have to manufacture fashion gear. They don’t have a political agenda, but they somehow have tactics to survive or to make money in their relationship with

Japan's former colonies such as Korea and Taiwan. They don't deny their eventual political agency concerning topics such as ecology and the pirate (gift) economy. As a dissident sociologist, I would like to construct a political practice with these urban rave tribes in order to develop tribal solidarity in Inter-East connections through various subcultures and build bridges between countries such as Japan, Korea, Taiwan, and even China. In other words, rather than being crazy about a reflection and redemptive consciousness on the Japanese colonial and imperial past, I would like to create something positive together with ravers, urban tribes, and also youths and people in ex- (or post)colonial Asia. I have to say that the leftist "authentic" and "liberal" position in Japanese academia is failing to grasp such alternative possibilities. They tend to be too "moralistic" by seeing history and the past only in a regrettable way. I am sure that there is a similar pattern in former Yugoslavia. If the Croats, for instance, insist on their "most-victim status" then you can not invent something positive or productive in tribal solidarity with others, for example, with the Bosnians or Serbs.

What do you think of the current i-mode fashion in Japan? Is there any reason for westerners to be excited or even jealous about the Japanese wireless phone craze and DoCoMo in particular?

Certainly all of my students and the party tribes are all using mobile phones to communicate, make appointments, and sometimes get a bit of info. But I can't find any reason why westerners should be jealous about their Japanese counterparts. Concerning the tactical use of mobile gear, I can point to more interesting and crazy usage in Europe. Nowadays even for most dissident punks and squatters, handies are really helpful technological tools. Some DJs and organizers in Japan started to distribute tracks via wireless networks. At the same time they are also thinking about how to hook up mobile phones with MIDI instruments. Even though all this supports capitalist telecom corporations, these experiments could be really revolutionary.

How would you describe Internet use among young people in Japan? It is being said that they're not so interested. They are much crazier about wireless applications and more protected, intimate BBS systems. Is the English language an obstacle to communication? Cybercafés and public terminals aren't as popular in Japan as they are, for instance, in Australia, Asia, or Latin America.

Japanese youth are not so crazy about the Internet, as far as I see, certainly not my students and the tribes around me. The aim and the way of using the Internet are quite different. They are net-surfing all the time but mainly visit Japanese sites. They are also quite skillful using computers to edit sounds and moving pictures. The Web design scene is also powerful but always lacks content, especially a political and theoretical one. So it is relatively true that they prefer “standalone use computers” to the Internet. There are only very few students who visit English-based sites. Language remains an obstacle for me as well. There aren’t so many cybercafés in Japan because most people already have their own computers in the office or at home. Of course tribes in the party scene are more active on the Net in order to organize parties, wary of the local authorities and police finding out.

Where does the “urban tribe” concept come from? Don’t you see it as a setback to return to such an anthropological term, so close to ethnicity where there no longer is any ethnicity? Why would rave cultures be best described as “urban tribes”?

The term *tribe* was not invented by me. For this I have to go back to the Japan of 1955. Shintaro Ishihara published a bestselling novel titled *Season of the Sun* that told the story of hedonistic subculture youth and caused a sensation in those days. A film was later based on the novel. Increasingly that type of youth style depicted in the novel could be found everywhere because youth were trying to imitate the style and fashion described in *Season of the Sun*. Of course, this novel was inspired by the real youth of these days. And then a term was invented: “sun tribe.” People used to call the dissident, hedonistic youth during the 1950s the sun tribe (*taiyo-zoku*). After that in each period, the 1960s, the 1970s, and the 1980s, mainstream press and parent cultures always used the term *zoku* to describe unknown youth subcultures. For example *otaku-zoku*, crystal-tribes (Japanese yuppies in 1980s), or the speed bike tribes.

Japanese are crazy about the generation gap phenomena, perhaps because we don’t have visible markers among people. Five or six years’ difference is already important for people. Japanese youth are very sensitive about age. Since the 1990s this symptom is slowly changing. Maybe the otaki-zoku was the last tribe in Japan. Because people tried to use another term, *kei*, it is very difficult to translate—system or series. So, for instance, in the

Shibuya-kei (*Shibuya* series in English), Shibuya is the name of the district of Tokyo, one of the youth centers in the city. So people would like to call the music genre and the fashion based on the Shibuya youth Shibuya-kei. Nobody these days uses the term *tribe* anymore. But at the same time there are a lot using the term “tribe” or “tribal” in flyers for club and rave parties to connote new types of music genres and a specific atmosphere.

Another interesting point is that the author of *Season of the Sun* later became a politician in the parliament in the LDP—the dominant liberal-democratic party. He is now governor of the Tokyo metropolis and perhaps the only mayor who rejected extending human rights to gay people and voting rights to foreigners. He’s a real fascist or at least can be called a fanatic nationalist and historical revisionist. He constantly denies Japan’s colonial violent past. He once called Asians “third people.” Japanese would be first, Americans and westerners second. According to him, people from other Asian countries such as migrant workers or students should be discriminated against. This is a really crazy situation. Why did this man become so powerful? Because people supported him. In that way *zoku* and the story of tribes is not only based on subcultural studies, it is deeply related to Japanese politics. Recently the son of Prime Minister Koizumi, who is also a populist and neoliberal, started appearing as an actor. Although he didn’t get a part, he auditioned using a piece titled “21st-Century Yujiro” (Ishihara’s dead brother). Such phenomena are interesting, ironic, and crucial for Japanese populism and conservative cultural politics.

In Japan the term tribe has had a specific meaning. In the late 1940s in Osaka, the second biggest city in Japan, there were squat villages, squat towns of Korean residents. They were very much discriminated against. In those villages, many scraps of steel were underground. They tried to dig up these scraps and get money by selling them. But these scraps were the national property of the Japanese national government. And then the conflict between the police and the Korean residents started. It made a sensation in those days. These Korean residents called themselves the “Apache tribe.” They compared their position to that of Native Americans. Numerous authors and novelists wrote novels featuring this Apache tribe. One of them was a work of science fiction called *Japanese Apache Tribe*, written by Sakyo Komatsu, in which the Apache tribe appears as a mutant with an iron body, something like a cyborg or T-1000 in *Terminator 2*. It is a well-known fact that this novel influenced the underground cult movie

Testuo. I am sure that some SF freaks or club techno tribes regard this film as a legendary piece.

You have been working with the “digital diaspora” concept. Can you explain this? To what extent would you support a withdrawal into the Net? Can we speak of productive monads, and where does this looking inward become eccentric and obsessive otaku-ism? You have been critical of the figure of the otaku and the Western fascination with this so-called typical Japanese obsessive behavior of the otaku data collector. Where does a subculture in Japan have possibilities for resistance, and at what point do “temporary autonomous zones” transform themselves into consumer-driven lifestyles?

By using the term *digital diaspora*, I don't mean the disappearance of human lives and bodies into the Net. Rather, I use it to talk about a diaspora within the Net (or generated through the Net). Historically diaspora cultures can be found around the world. Some theoreticians working on the diaspora topic have used the term of *web* or *network*. The term *diaspora web* was introduced by Paul Gilroy. These days this terminology is no longer a mere metaphor but rather a sort of allegory for the reality that we are facing. We now face broader cyberspaces through network technology, not only due to computers but also via radio or telephones by which the information “seas” have been expanding. Nor is this occurring only through the power of Internet; actually some refugees and people in the diaspora have begun to keep their lives in the diaspora through video distributions or computer networks and other electronic technologies. One could mention refugee communities in Perth (Australia) coming from Croatia or Macedonia. They are using VCR technology to maintain the relationship to their original place. And one could also use, as an example, some independent media in Amsterdam to support people coming from the former Yugoslavia [as described in Dona Kolar-Panov, *Video, War and the Diasporic Imagination*, Routledge, 1997]. Information technology and telecommunications are taking the diaspora notion in new directions.

Diaspora in general is connected to moving and migration forced by some power relations including economic, political, religious, and so on. To describe the things and the cultural elements moved, like dreadlocks, T-shirts, and music, etc., one can appropriate the term *cultural diaspora* to interpret such a circulation. Certainly diaspora is a sort of cultural traveling

and causes traveling theory, but it should not be confused with globalization in general or postmodern pastiche eclecticism, which is based on the “anything goes” parameter. But on the other hand, it is becoming difficult to maintain the dichotomy between real refugees, illegal migrants, asylum people, “suffered diaspora,” ravers, hooligans, travelers, tourists, and the “cultural diaspora.” It is becoming difficult to distinguish forced settlement from voluntary migration, dwelling from traveling. We, I mean critics or intellectuals in the “first world,” are between the “suffered” and the “observer.” Diaspora is a crucial tactical tool and even medium or space with which to analyze this situation.

What does the diaspora condition have to do with the specific Japanese otaku phenomenon, the manic collectors of, for instance, records, magazines, and games?

In the past I have criticized the term *otaku* but not the otaku people themselves. I am criticizing the cultural condition of otaku and its political context. I myself am an otaku of sorts, being crazy about Japanese animations and psychedelic trance techno. I am skeptical about Japanese art based on otaku-ism. Western people are fascinated by otaku culture and that's why it can be marketable. Some even try to emphasize the cultural traditions and history of otaku. They say Japanese culture has always been dominated by collectors' infomania. For them Japanese history has been postmodern and eclectic right from the start.

Where does the difficulty to communicate among scenes, movements, and disciplines within Japan come from? It is striking to see how many useless frictions and anxieties there are, between artists, scholars, institutions, activists. This makes it rather difficult, I suppose, to set up networks in Japan. The only communication that seems to work are the very private, intimate channels on certain bulletin board systems (BBS). There seems to be a form of competition, not related to work, money, or income. This fact has made it difficult to set up a halfway independent and interesting new media arts scene in Japan. Japanese we get to meet in the West do not collaborate in Japan. It seems much easier for them to meet in New York, Amsterdam, or Paris than in their own country. Do you believe that this is simply cultural (a “second nature”), and therefore next to impossible to change? Isn't it interesting that this overdose of communication devices hasn't had a significant impact on this specific aspect of Japanese society? Or should we view this observation as yet another culturalism?

Well, I don't want to say that there is particular inability to communicate in Japan. I am indeed highly skeptical about any form of culturalism or cultural essentialism. But to be honest, I have also have felt the useless frictions among the different urban tribes in Japan on numerous occasions. I am fed up with that situation. That is the reason why I frequently stay in Europe. Maybe others also feel like that. For instance, in Japan, media artists are generally not interested in politics and especially not in Japanese politics. On the other hand, most of the leftist intellectuals have never heard of media art or media activism. Tetsuo Kogawa and Toshimaru Ogura are great exceptions, of course. The former was founder of the free radio movement in Japan and is still very active for experiments of streaming and developing critical media theory. The latter is a radical media activist and theorist organizing anti-wiretap and anti-echelon movements. In fact, I myself have not met them for a long time. Tokyo is too huge to see each other. Toshimaru lives far away from Tokyo. There is a deep gap, both cultural and political. Cultural studies has become increasingly popular in leftist and liberal academic circles. But most scholars reduce cultural studies to a method for criticizing the notion of the nation-state. Their arguments have never reached younger generations or urban subcultural tribes on the streets or scenes such as hip-hop or rave, even though they could easily be against the nation-state and its cultural hegemony.

Take the example of LETS (a local trading system) in Japan. That's a popular concept at the moment among critical intellectuals. Koujin Karatani and partly Akira Asada, who always prefers the "safety zone" to the real "critical space," are at the moment involved in organizing NAM, the New Associatist Movement, which is a network of LETS in Japan. I support LETS, its theory, and especially its practices. Being one of the ravers and organizers of small illegal parties, I respect every form of gift-economy style and reciprocal symbolic economy. So why don't I join NAM? Despite Akira and Koujin's nasty and cynical gestures toward social movements during 1980s, it is good to see what they are doing. But there is an old type of politics at work within NAM. Karatani and others are putting out the theory, and then allowing people to do LETS activities according to the theorists' system. Volunteers work within the structure elaborated by intellectuals and theoreticians. This, in my opinion, points to an outdated and unnecessary contrast between theory and practice. Their classifications of some parts in the movement are very ironic. They call their small groups "kei," meaning

series or system, in contrast to tribe. So you have *bunka-kei* (culture series), *lilon-kei* (theory series), *undou-kei* (movement series), and so on. It sounds like a bad joke to the subcultural urban tribes. Karatani and Asada's take on social movements is to ignore and neglect the organic and transversal relationships among different scenes.

What I am trying to do is set up small pirate radio stations and flea market activities during open-air raves. Indeed, there is a difference in understanding between tribes such as rave and punk and hip-hop. But that's a much better situation than the classic binary opposition of theory and practice. Karatani labeled NAM a new type of communism. That's probably right. But he does not think about the people's reaction. By using the term *communism*, NAM is losing interesting people and tribes. Their way of communication is using classic leftist language in an almost tragic-comic way. I am familiar with it, but most people are not. I wish NAM and various urban tribes and subcultural scenes would shake hands and build an affective and effective alliance. For that vision a cultural politics is crucial, a politics that communicates within the scenes rather than mere political rhetoric. It can be called cultural politics. Technology can change the way of communication in each cultural and political context. That is why I restarted the pirate mini FM free radio idea during open-air parties. I would like to create hybrids among different urban tribes such as techno, punk, eco, anarcho, rave, New Age, otaku, the Left, and other dissidents.

What is the current level of media theory in Japan? We don't hear much about it outside Japan. I can't think of any Japanese contemporary theory being translated. We actually only hear about theory import into Japan, not the other way round. Is this because there's nothing going on? This can hardly be the case. Is the produced theory only of local interest? What's the reason for this theory deficit?

There are a few tendencies in Japanese media theory. The first is mainly developed in the academic field and is called media studies. There are some layers and the spectrum goes from audience research to more positivist methodologies. Basically researchers don't want to go outside universities and academic circles. Most of them are not enthusiastic about using media technology themselves. There are a few translations or papers available in English.

The second tendency is a form of criticism to be found within new media art, connected to the Internet hype and early- to mid-1990s media tech-

nologies. That is why it used to have financial support from big corporations but that's fading away. Unfortunately new media arts lacks the vision on the broader political economy of its own field. That is why corporations can safely speculate their money into "speculative" media theory.

The third tendency is the activist "tactical" media. But that stream is very micro and weak in Japan. As I mentioned, Tetsuo and Toshimaru are active in both theory and action. They pay attention to the economy and politics of the media and the Internet. I am not that satisfied with the theoretical level of the three currents. Most of the time, I move among the three and take difficult in-between positions. What is crucial in this context is how we can build bridges between the different media tribes.

Over the last few years, you have been going to a wide range of raves, from illegal parties in German forests, squatters' parties in Amsterdam, and raves in Zagreb to solar eclipse parties in Hungary and Zambia. You have also attended a variety of raves in Japan, from expensive Tokyo club events to informal events in parks and in the mountains. Do you see yourself as a modern anthropologist studying rave culture? Have you encountered any problems with this form of "participatory research"?

There is a "belonging without identity" as described by Gorgio Agamben and Lawrence Grossberg that goes beyond the usual definition of community as a social entity with shared values. Without identification of fixed and stable positions, it is possible to belong to a tribe. Tribal formations are not one. Within one tribe we can find diverse styles, differences in taste, and even conflicts over how to live one's life. When subculturalists say "(s)he is tribal," it means that there is an open group-minded feeling, a solidarity and tolerance for other tribes and different styles. It points to a consciousness of mainstream civilization and globalization. For example, tribal cultures within the rave scene show respect for so-called traditional tribal or quasi-premodern cultures and their "indigenous" way of living. This respect is so distant from the way in which journalism and political science talk about "tribal wars." The position of the DJ in all this is highly significant. The DJ functions as a mediator and catalyst to both inform and transform people who enter other dimensions of the world. They could be considered the shamans of the cyber age. But this shaman is at the same time an "organic intellectual" in a Gramscian sense, organizing people to get to other horizons of society through "partying."

Becoming a DJ has influenced my way of writing in many ways. Both positions, the sociologist and the DJ, consist of a cut'n'mix of materials produced by others. Usually a DJ does not compose or create the music tracks him- or herself. The DJ cut'n'mix is "(re)inventing" and (re)elaborating already existing sounds. The same can be said about the work of the sociologist or theoretician as a TJ (text jockey). We can no longer pretend to create "theory" out of the blue. We always collect material, texts, and resources and then start quoting, editing, and appropriating passages from past works. That is do-it-yourself within theoretical practice. Kodwo Eshun's notion of "remixology" is quite suggestive. Sometimes I ask myself, Am I a sociologist or just a tribal raver? It is a really difficult question to answer.

I don't want to merely celebrate rave culture. There are a lot of problems such as hedonism, consumerism, drug issues, frictions among tribes and organizers, negotiations with local authority and police that have to be made, and so forth. I have never faced any problems during my "participatory observation" or fieldwork research. Maybe this is because of my enthusiasm to join the party. The difficulty is lying somewhere else. I do not have the proper language yet to talk to both academic circles and party tribes. It might even be impossible. I would like to invent a different way to theorize everyday life.



Intermedia: The Digital Bauhaus

An Email Interview with János Sugár

I met János Sugár in Budapest during exciting, somewhat tense preparations for the conference “The Media Is with Us” in late March 1990. Amid the first free elections in Hungary, a group of artists and curators is still busy with the aftermath of what had happened two months earlier, the so-called “television revolution” in Romania, the bloody and mysterious ending of the turbulent year 1989. Sugár, film and media critic Miklós Peternák, and others had just established the Media Research Foundation and were preparing for the launch of the Intermedia Department at the Hungarian Academy of Fine Arts. Besides his work as a conceptual (performance) artist, for which he gained international recognition, he produces films, writes essays, and even wrote and directed an opera. Sugár is always on the run: teaching classes, keeping appointments, doing paperwork, organizing exhibitions, and so on.

Can you describe for us the way you encountered the media in Hungary during, let's say, the late eighties? In my view, you started working with film and video at a time when the dark period of the early eighties was over and a new era was about to begin.

I started to work with film in the beginning of the eighties. Parallel with my sculptural studies at the Hungarian Academy of Fine Arts, I worked with the Indigo (interdisciplinary thinking) group and we did shows, happenings, films together. Since the leader of the group was Miklós Erdély, himself a filmmaker (conceptual artist, writer, painter—the most influential artist of his time and since), he pushed the group a bit in the direction of filmmaking. He did his films in the Béla Balázs Studio (BBS), and so in the early eighties I started to visit the regular Tuesday BBS meetings.

Filmmaking at that time was still had some revolutionary romantic appeal and the most exciting and authentic place among the Hungarian film studios was the Béla Balázs Studio. The BBS was a strange phenomenon: in the ocean of counterselection, it was a little island of (state-sponsored) experiments in the sense of expression and political tolerance. The studio produced strong documentaries and strange short films that were rarely shown.¹

Concerning the dark period, I have to say, it wasn't so dark. Only access by the general public and mainstream media was censored, not production. Public culture was strongly controlled: censorship, bans, but a vital underground art scene (the "secondary publicity"²) existed, and maybe that is most important. Having no space for the ambitions, no practical perspectives, we had lots of time. For me as a young artist, it was an idyllic training—everyone was approachable, ready for dialogue.

A couple of years before I joined BBS, I started to view films consciously, for I had seen the basic works. My father took me to see Antonioni's *The Night* when I was sixteen. And after this, the biggest impact was Godard's *Masculin Féminin* which I saw in the late seventies and which changed my view about film and filmmaking. Later, I made a few super-8 pieces, worked in films (as an actor in several of Ildikó Enyedi's films and even in her diploma work). Finally in 1985, I made my first film, a fifty-minute 16mm piece, *Persian Walk*, which caused such an unprecedented scandal in the BBS that I had no chance to make anything there for years (and only 4 years later could I obtain a final print of this film). I had some experiences in video, but

except for a few narrative pieces I didn't do much. I couldn't have a daily experience with video because access was very limited.

What about computers—do you recall your first encounter with them? Was it in an artistic or academic context?

In the mid-1980s, computers appeared on my horizon. In 1986, I was given (along with other young artists) some computer time to produce works for the first Hungarian computer graphics show. The officials wanted a computer graphics show, or at least some smart people sold them the idea. The only problem was there were no computer artists, because there were no computers available—for long years—because of the rigid regulations. You saw only hardware parts, and even then they were sold mostly secondhand.

Anyway, they managed limited access to some IBM PCs in a room in some state computer research institute and the invited artists worked according to a timetable. The only software was "PC Paint," and I never heard this name again. Then, I nearly bought an Amiga, but for a long time, the only computer around me was a C-64 I used with a TV and an external drive as a typewriter. Actually, this was my real experience with a computer. I realized that using a word processor changed my attitude toward writing totally. Maybe toward everything.

Still, you had little access to machines and perhaps also to the current media theory of the late eighties.

No real access to video, that's what I really missed. That's why I didn't do any real video art work, which requires in my view a sort of daily practice, a kind of coexistence with the medium. I didn't really miss the computer. Regarding media theory, the situation wasn't so bad; at least we knew that something called media theory existed. Miklós Peternák published some good essays, and he had a rather different voice from the others. There were some rare publications, monthlies, small circulation textbooks, and Benjamin, Barthes, Baudrillard, Virillio, and Paul Feuerabend were somehow present.

In the second half of the eighties, Peternák and I started lecturing on film together, and we did it for a few years. There was a so-called Free University, offering a broad choice of evening courses anyone could enroll in, lots of language courses, and courses in popular science, art, traveling (the expert lec-

turer showed slides of his/her journeys). In 1996, I did a work using this organization's slide archives—an enormous, unorganized 35mm slide archive of everything, from the AK 47 to sex education. So, one day while walking downtown, I bumped into Peternák, who told me he was on his way to give a lecture there on film. We started to talk and I went with him, and when the time came he asked me to take part in the discussion.

The next year we announced the Alternative Filmschool, which went on for three years. We were paid and we could order films that even we ourselves hadn't seen. The audience was very mixed—a bunch of young people, elderly people mainly napping, and some knitting ladies. We always showed two films and finished with a conversation between us. Sometimes we changed the order of the reels.

How would you now describe your media awareness during the period of transition, let's say during the period 1989–1992?

This was the time, I had real-life experiences in media theory: the early years of typical East European spindoctorship, watching the soap opera of changing political rhetoric. First political, then financial fight for the mass media (the word “media” first appeared in Hungary as “media war,” and the general use of the term was/is “press”); the increasingly conscious use of TV medium by the politicians; the Romanian TV revolution; and the increasing financial difficulties of the BBS. Altogether, this produced a mixture of anecdotes, shocking experiences, and lots of incredible examples.

Before 1989, things like political commercials or massive ad campaigns were totally unknown in Hungary. And in 1991, in the summer, I was commissioned to complete in a few months a five-part series for (state) TV. A very courageous producer, who (for a short time) had relatively large broadcast time, started to work with outsiders, visual artists. She asked me to do some four-part series, and with Gábor Bora I made a proposal for *Misunderstandings* which she accepted. I could work according to professional TV techniques, and (because everyone was busy with politics) not even my own producer saw it before it aired.

We felt a growing competence and there were lots of opportunities to explain our approach, like inviting people and organizing events such as the conference “The Role of TV in the Romanian Revolution.” This led to lots of contacts and information from abroad. And somehow this activity led us

to establish the Intermedia Department in 1990 at the Academy of Fine Arts (from which, by the way, I was kicked out in 1984), the first program of its type in the post-communist region.

Do you think that there was a dialogue with the early avant-garde, or with films of the sixties? Or is this just a reconstruction afterward, to build the story of the successful Hungarian video school around Gábor Bódy?

There is always a dialogue in art. The hardcore avant-garde was somehow still present. Lajos Kassák died in the late sixties. Moholy-Nagy became a national pride. But the films of the sixties were more or less under the strong influence of the zeitgeist, and for young people poetry was out and filmmaking was in. The film medium represented something very important for this generation, who met the reality of World War II mainly through films. (Nowadays we meet irreality through special effects in the movies.) Film was the top medium: expensive but efficient and glamorous, the dream of every modern artist. Gábor Bódy was very literate even in an academic sense and represented a very strong intellectual but revolutionary attitude in the filmmaking. His innovation was linking *techné* with philosophy, which appears in a very consciously controlled visuality. And maybe because of this, he understood best what video is.

You are not making a clear difference between the second part of the eighties and the early nineties. Is this really the case, despite the 1989 fall of the Berlin Wall?

I think for Hungary, the watershed was 1956. This was a longstanding trauma even for the politicians too. After 1956, they had to give some perspective, optimism, to the people—and for themselves as well. It's interesting, how a so-called unsuccessful revolution like this, killed by the Yalta Treaty, can be successful in a sort of long term. That's why Hungary could become a bit more liberal as the other East Bloc systems became more rigid. Later, I guess, this somehow became the role of Hungary in the Warsaw Pact.

Censorship was based on three principles: support, tolerance, ban. Practically, the communists used the system intelligently—banning a few, tolerating a lot, and continuously playing with dissolving previous bans. The heavily banned intellectuals were harassed less than in the other countries and were mainly forced to emigrate. People were allowed travel every

two to three years; information traffic was relatively strong, and cultural life in general was not bad in Budapest.

There was also the so-called underground or “second publicity” (art shows, pop and contemporary music, performance, *samizdat*, etc.) with real personalities and with a strong moral position. Looking back, for me it was like an incubator or a natural park: it wasn’t difficult to survive; lots of time for talks, meetings, discussions, intensive contacts, partying; and of course in most of the cases not the slightest hope for a practical result. No contacts with the so-called first publicity, which was the realm of general or mass society or however you want to express it.

The single most cruel restriction for culture was blocking avenues to reach the broader public. No competition between the old and new, no aggressive cultural memes, no random spread of cultural inspiration. Only insiders knew about the best things going on in art. It’s somehow like a philosophical problem: can anything be valid if no one knows about its existence? I think of Schrödinger’s cat in the art world. This situation caused serious damage, not just in the art (which became hermetic and context bound), but also in the general public. People couldn’t know anything about this booming period, about this creative capital. If you go to a library and look through the papers and magazines of that period, you won’t find any reference, news, or mention of what was really happening, what was important for us.

Nowadays, people tend to think it’s just well-known general nostalgia for the good old past, but it’s not: That cultural “second publicity” produced the most important solid values. Since Hungary was the most liberal country (the weakest link), there was great attention from abroad, lots of visitors, curators, and artists. With the dismantling of the Iron Curtain, it has changed: A sort of cultural protectionism emerged between the former Socialist countries and Western Europe. We are no longer piquant easterners but weak competitors with a bad infrastructure. I don’t agree with such an argument; I think the fall of communism changed the total situation, not just in the former East. In other words, the Cold War deformed the Western cultural infrastructure as well.³

Can you tell us about your specific way of making films? It is not exactly experimental (in the technical sense), nor does it follow the classical way of narration; it is also not video art. Perhaps you are making a kind of fictional art documentary, trying to undermine all the existing genres . . .

Fictional art documentary, thank you, I accept that one. The category I like the most is introduced by Miklós Erdély: “cognitive film.” The notion originates from the total competence consciousness of avant-garde, which I experienced within the Indigo group. This total competence is linked more to the opportunities (site-specific—one would say today⁴) than to one or another particular medium. It felt natural to use film, but of course I had no idea for what. So all my films are different, like a different construction, I would say, singular solutions. For me the thought, a sort of hermetic dramaturgy, is essential; if it’s somehow complete, then comes the execution, which sometimes results in the humiliation of tradition. I am proud that my film *Persian Walk*, in 1985, caused such an outcry in the BBS. Even two years ago, I was asked by a renowned colleague to remove the BBS logo from the credit of my latest film, *Ambiguous Window*.

I cannot accept the notion of experimentalism, because such a thing outside film doesn’t exist in other genres. I believe that even within the film medium an intensive dialogue should go on between tradition and progression as in literature, painting, and so forth, where maybe innovation receives less attention but is not barred from the mainstream. This separation in film makes any innovation more or less a political question. Nowadays the once “most important genre” (Lenin) has become a well-integrated part of global entertainment. Big-budget cinema is the best vehicle for the subliminal education (of the proletariat). It is very exciting to analyze the hidden messages of Hollywood movies, such as cooperation, partnership, respect, love.

I think it is already beyond film, because with its complex ties to merchandising it became the social medium, with basic but irresistible messages. Making film is expensive, and that’s why a film should be immediately understandable in the present; otherwise the high production costs will not be recouped. In other mediums, working artists shouldn’t necessarily place importance on instant success; the artwork has time and can wait until the proper perception. Art history is full of (“time is on my side”) examples. That is my basic position.

You spent a lot of time building up the Intermedia Department at the Hungarian Academy of Fine Arts in Budapest. There, you have taught for many years. But exactly what you have been doing with the students somehow remained a mystery to me. Tell us something about your methodology and your conclusions.

The starting idea was to create a media faculty, which we did with Peternák using our strong Indigo (interdisciplinary) experience, connecting art and thinking, in the sense of total competence. Art, technology, science with an undefined outcome. We used the word *intermedia* as in “interdisciplinary plus media.” Just afterward, it became evident that Dick Higgins coined it, in opposition to what multimedia meant at that time. For Higgins, intermedia was the positive pole. I am really pleased we are linked somehow to the flux that is still in flux.

My goal is to enhance the consciousness of the students, to be able to go radically beyond their own unconscious sympathies and choose unpopular, less easy solutions. I think the presence of the unprecedented, referenceless media, and the emergence of the work-entertainment-education conglomerate manifests itself more in a general media consciousness than in the use of one or another so-called new medium. Its social impact is bigger than the cultural. With this new experience, we can see and treat the other genres as a medium.

The first thing students have to do is write a fictional biography; then I ask them to collect analogies. Then, there are various exercises in video such as analyzing a real-life action by montage; making short video pieces using text, shortcuts, raging on the mixer; a series of irresponsible plays with the equipment. It is like teaching a language. In the meantime, we watch and analyze classical video art and anything else they bring—works, objects, collages—to discuss. To exercise control over the image, they have to create a narrative black and white photo. I require them to make three-dimensional (plastic) scripts or models in addition to the classical storyboard for their videos.

Last year, in the spirit of “tactical media,” which I was lecturing about, we staged a media event. Since the most popular evening news uses a live background image of the city, we defined a point within the range of this backdrop camera and gave flashlight signals, and this was broadcast throughout the TV news. Along with these studio exercises is a weekly lecture on media theory, where I begin with Adam and Eve (share of work, specialization, secularization, etc.) and later touch on photography, film, video, computer, hypermedia.

What should a new media education in an art context look like, and do you have any inspiring models? How should a digital media Bauhaus look these days?

I think still deep in the core of any art education is the good old *nosce te ipsum*. For the Bauhaus technology that was a metaphor, the zeitgeist. But for today, we are learning how arbitrary a so-called functional design can be. Nowadays, technology is fast moving, constantly upgrading, and development is a continuous act, like an open language whose grammar always changes with usage and whose new idioms evoke new syntax and new grammatical rules.

The result is an endless spiral, a language that wants to tell everything but is actually falsely transparent. Technology needs instant and powerful demonstration and promotion to evoke demand among buyers. Using artists is the cheapest and most efficient crash test for the software and hardware manufacturers. But art cannot really function in a mediated form. We can alienate form and content but not in art. That's very good news for the visual artist.⁵

We teach the practice and the theory of the so-called new media, but we encourage the use of old or traditional techniques too. In the case of new media, it's very difficult to forget the tools—they are sexy, and more and more capable—but the message is more an attitude than an immediately profitable limited expertise. Today's digital Bauhaus should be dirty. I don't really like the hospital/airport atmosphere of media labs, which suggest a sort of neutrality, distance—the ideology of design.

We have all seen you running around in Budapest, switching from one medium to the next all the time, several times a day even, alternating among installation art, writing, teaching, theater, film, and video, and increasingly working with computers. And organizing events like the conference series "MetaForum" we organized together with Diana McCarty. In a way, you embody the whole idea of intermedia. But your surroundings are perhaps not so fast, not so flexible . . . You must have seen a lot of mistrust and misunderstanding. Is intermedia a kind of utopia for you?

It's not a utopia, but it's not something I am concentrating on either. I would rather say I am working along the maximum action freedom radius. It forces you to connect things, because of the lack of time, to solve one problem with another. There is no time to worship the medium, just to use it. In such a multitude, only the simple models can survive. It's like laying a very complex pattern whose regularities or laws are discoverable only much later. Living without feedback. That's the game.

In making art, you can experience doing or executing something that isn't based on any practical demand. No one knows about it, only you. It is your sole personal responsibility to realize/not realize if you have an idea. No one knocks on your door and says, "Comrade artist, hey, where is the painting?" If I have an idea, it's a big thing—let's say the most difficult part of the case—and the realization is much easier because it's just practical. I learned how to forget the practical difficulties because they are not communicable, they are not convertible.

It is a very good strategy in Budapest, because even now there is little public attention to art, but the creative possibilities are big. I like to be in people's blind spot. This situation keeps me incognito. I could and still can work with great freedom. For me it is the highest level of luxury. The rigid surroundings are sometimes very useful to enhance and refine your radicality.

Notes

1. Done, finished, executed but not shown publicly. This was, for instance, the total opposite of the GDR practice of censorship where projects were stopped before start. Once I visited with Miklós Peternák and Ildikó Enyedi in East Berlin, and we asked in the most natural way about the banned films—in Hungary, it was normal to show such banned films to a so-called expert audience—and we were told that such a thing didn't exist in the GDR. There were no banned films, because they were stopped much earlier.
2. "The second publicity" is a sociological notion, a common term that is used for the cultural underground in repressive societies.
3. Culture was a very important field (theater!) in the Cold War; recently published documents showed how art magazines and contemporary art shows were supported by Western state information agencies (Serge Guilbaut, *How New York Stole the Idea of Modern Art*, University of Chicago Press, 1983).
4. Being "site-specific" nowadays is in fashion; the attitude I am referring to is something like being site-specific in a total sense. If there is a chance to publish, you have to write; if there is a possibility to perform, then you have to stage a performance, etc. In a repressive situation, the form of expression is flexible and depends on the rare possibilities. This is the "site" in a complete sense. It's more a reaction to the outer world than an earlier, conscious artistic decision.

5. We alienate through mediation in form and content. If one reads an article in a newspaper, it's not an immediate but a mediated information and the form and the content are separated in order to mediate. In art one cannot do this (publishing a reproduction or a slide on a Web site is not art. Those few real Web artists—Olia Lialina, Alexei Shulgin, Jodi—are using the browser as material, so in art it's impossible to separate form and content (without losing the art-character), a very fortunate situation. We are entering a monomedial age when anything can be stored digitally; therefore, a magnetic bomb or an electric power cut could literally stop everything except those things that cannot be mediated (art, metacommunication, etc.). I think this situation for an artist is very pleasant—the importance of art, as a unique “only in real life” experience, is growing.



Demystifying the Virtual Power Structures

An Interview with Susan George

Susan George is a well-known critic of the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and has published several books on the debt crisis. The interview was conducted in the Hybrid WorkSpace at Documenta X in Kassel, Germany, where she was invited for the “100 Days–100 Guests” lecture series.

I was surprised by the opening statement of your "100 Days" lecture. You stated that economy and ecology are at war. Here in Germany, many from both the corporate world and the ecological movement think in terms of collaboration and harmony. Influenced by the New Age, they think that the two might go together in the end. You called yourself an "alarmist."

For the first time in history, we do not have much time ahead of us. If New Age people think that everything can be made into sweetness and light, they have not examined power relationships very carefully. I fear that if people can be persuaded that these two paradigms can be made to match without deep changes, it will distract them from the kind of politics that we have got to do. You are speaking from a very German point of view. Germany is at the very forefront of ecological awareness. Where I live, in France, people are way behind in such things as recycling. The kind of radical politics that I was trying to talk about has not yet reached any kind of level where major changes are going to come about. Many of these changes are taking place at the international level. And that's where it is going to be most difficult to act. Many of the destroyers of the planet are acting with impunity, because they are acting at the international level. They are not transparent and are answerable to no one.

You have been on the board of Greenpeace for many years. Are you optimistic about the growth and strength of the ecological movement?

I left the board at the end of 1995. The new administration tends to engage a lot less in confrontations. Personally, I think that is a mistake. Confrontation and exposure are still very much needed. There are areas where one can cooperate with businesses. Yesterday I mentioned the insurance industry, which is getting knocked out. They incurred \$50 billion of losses within the last ten years. Why? Because of global warming and the increasing frequency of storms. Even if George Bush and Bill Clinton were not convinced of global warming, the insurance companies are. And they are listening to Greenpeace and teaming up.

The case of the Greenpeace refrigerator has been overblown badly. It was clear that the manufacturers were not interested in listening, or in doing any research about new technologies that would not destroy the ozone layer. What Greenpeace did, with a couple of scientists from East Germany, is

simply to show that it can be done. The same holds true for a car engine that would use much less gas. But who wants that in the oil industry? That is what I mean by confrontation: embarrassing the decision makers by showing the consumer that it can be done. These products are also coming to developing societies like China and India, highly populous countries, where a substantial middle class is now in a position to buy refrigerators. If all of China is going to have refrigerators with CFCs, we might as well put on our hats and sunglasses and hope for the best. Not all manufacturers have switched, even in France. You live in a paradise here.

In your lecture you did not mention the Third World debt crisis. Can you give us an update on this topic? How do recent developments look, since you've devoted more than ten years of research to it?

I only mentioned the debt crisis in relation to the ecological crisis in the South and the East and the capacity of the World Bank and the IMF to impose neoliberalism. As soon as a country has no other source of fresh cash, it has to go to these international institutions. Then they are in a position to say, We'll lend you money, but on the following conditions. That is how they have been able to forcibly integrate into the global economy of close to one hundred countries. I published my first book on the topic in 1987, having worked on it for two years. There comes a time when you have to leave a subject alone. In the last year, I have prepared a report on Mediterranean debt for the Italian government. Most activists are concentrating on Africa, as well they should. But what I discovered in the case of the Maghreb countries, Egypt, Jordan, etc., is that the scale of the problem is much greater. The impossibility of this debt ever being paid back is exactly the same as for black Africa.

Within circles of cyberculture, money has been examined in relation to virtualization. Most capital is now virtual, no longer related to the realm of the production of material commodities. It is seen as a closed, "other" computer network, next to the Internet, in which money circulates constantly, all over the world.

The existence of this financial electronic network is not a secret, but it is difficult to gain access to it and knowledge about it. Without electronics,

economic globalization could not have happened. In the foreign exchange market you've got \$1.2 trillion circulating every day. Less than 5 percent of that represents actual cash transactions. Most of it is just making money out of money. When I looked at the quite boring annual report of the Bank for International Settlements, a serious institution, the central bank of the central banks, in Basel, I detected a note of utter panic. What they are saying is that the financial markets are inventing new instruments, much faster than we can get a grip on them. The IMF stepped in when we had the crisis in Mexico, in Russia, and now in the Philippines. My question is, When we have the big crash, as we are going to have quite soon, where is the IMF that is going to move in? There is nothing big enough to counter an accident like that. When it comes, this crash is going to create tremendous suffering, as it did in Mexico in January 1995. Workers lost their jobs, malnutrition rates immediately increased, and suicide and crime rates went way up. The effects of electronic markets actually fell on society.

In his article in the Atlantic Monthly, George Soros has also warned us of this impending global economic crisis. He supports a lot of NGOs worldwide. How do you look at the growing importance of the NGO sector?

I am not aware of growing power of NGO's. I am not well informed about the activities of his foundation, but I would love to meet him. I think he's got the right attitude about the stock market because he does not follow the herd. He also proved that central banks are totally powerless when confronted by a determined army of speculators. I want to say here that these people are perfectly identifiable. One should not treat this market as something mysterious, like dispensing the law on high, like God speaking to Moses, and then assume we all have to follow it. This is thirty to fifty major banks, about the same number of brokerage firms, and a few, mostly U.S. pension funds, which are in on this. Two hundred fifty major players doing all this. There is no reason, in my view, why, if governments got their act together and were a little bit less cowardly, these transactions could not be taxed. The money should not go to the UN. But there is no reason that one could not constitute international funds that could be democratically managed. One could palliate the debt crisis and write off debts with that sort of a fund.

This campaign here in Hybrid WorkSpace deals with bandwidth. We are trying to map who owns the cables. What are your experiences in visualizing those abstract structures?

To be honest, yes, I was able to name the major players in the debt crisis. I began to do work on those emerging markets. I could not carry it out because it was too expensive. I was able to interview people in South Africa because I was there for a conference. The same thing for the Philippines. That is another reason why Soros is important, because he is demystifying a lot of what the markets are doing. Being one of the players himself, he certainly is not down on his knees, worshipping them. That is one of the dangers. Capital is like a religion. The anthropologist Fabricio Sabelli sees institutions like the IMF depending on belief systems, with the World Bank as the medieval church with its heaven and hell. The same thing is true for the market. There is a good deal of popularizing to be done, in this case, to demystify the Internet. And do remember that half of the world has never made a telephone call.



Media Philosophy beyond the Dualism of Image and Text

An Interview with Frank Hartmann

Viennese media theorist and Internet critic Frank Hartmann recently published a book, in German, with the ambitious title *Medienphilosophie* (Media Philosophy). In an email exchange he told me, in moderate terms, that readers should first of all perceive the work as an academic book, written for educational purposes. Published in the prestigious “red cover” UTB series, *Medienphilosophie* seems an ideal title for media theory courses. In a few months the book has become a bestseller, Frank proudly reported.

Hartmann is neither a member of the school of German media archeology (Friedrich Kittler), which argues from a techno-determinist position, nor does he want to come up with an ethic of what to do with the human in the age of technology. Instead he likes to present an “integrative approach of media evolution,” bringing together technology and society. Drawing on the work of Vilem Flusser, Hartmann further develops “communicology,” an analytical approach of the “medial turn,” in which categories such as knowledge, textuality, and language have become inseparable from the technologies in which they are expressed.

Written as a chronological overview, *Media Philosophy* starts with Descartes’ imaginary space and the birth of the modern scientific author, moves on to Kant and his notion of the reflexive subject and the need for publicity, and concludes with Herder and Humboldt, Husserl, Heidegger, Benjamin, and so forth. Each chapter ends with a neat summary. Interesting chapters, beyond the usual thinkers and references, for example, deal with Fritz Mauthner, an early twentieth-century German philosopher who tried to deconstruct the “logocratic regime” of language. Unknown to me were attempts of Gottlob Frege, at the end of the nineteenth century, to develop a new logic sign system—a pure script of concepts, not contaminated by the dualities of meaning. Another well-written chapter interprets Otto Neurath’s system of icons as “universal code.”

It is not an exaggeration to say that continental media theory, once it has positioned itself within the tradition of philosophy, begins and ends with a critique of language. It is only through language that we can access the image (Mauthner). A similar argument can be found in contemporary writings on the history of computing and the Internet, in which code-as-language forms the basis of all computational commands. Hartmann is not just a Eurocentric. He is well aware of the Anglo-Saxon traditions, from Charles Pierce to the Canadians Harold Innis and Marshall McLuhan, who both developed a "media theory of civilization." The last chapters are surprisingly up to date and deal with Internet culture, the notion of the virtual class (Kroker/Weinstein), the emerging genre of "Net criticism," and the topology of electronic space. It is time to ask questions about the motives behind the making of such an ambitious overview.

In your opinion, what does "media philosophy" have the potential to be? Are you the first to use this term? Can this new discipline be studied in Vienna? Writing about technology and philosophy already has a tradition. Would the philosophical approach of media and the Internet, in particular, start from there?

Of course there is a tradition in reflecting on technology, although continental philosophy, especially, tends to purify thought from all materiality. Academic philosophy never bothered too much with media, while language always was present in its discourse. Media would be the realm of aesthetics, of what affects the senses only and not logical human thought. There is this clear obsession with language, with the logocentric tradition, which also reflects the predominance of abstract codes—and therefore text—in Western culture. I started to be fascinated by the critical approach of Horkheimer's research group (later called the Frankfurt School), which in the 1930s made the press and audiovisual media an object of study. This social and cultural studies explicitly was held up to Heidegger's approach, which concentrates on the single human situation and which is set within a rather pessimistic "logic of decay." By the way, this was about the time when, as an undergraduate, McLuhan studied New Criticism in England, which is the second trail leading to media philosophy.

The insecurity of Western culture that intensified at the beginning of the twentieth century has a lot to do with the fact that people started to be aware of how mechanical devices like the camera not only enhanced human perception but also conquered it. With media restructuring the cultural

forms of communication and the forms of reproducing knowledge in society, we witness the rearguard actions of philosophy, like analytical philosophy. As I stated in the opening passage of my book, philosophy should come up with a new approach to reflect all those changes that led to new media, and the changes induced by media as well.

Concerning the term “media philosophy,” I think it has been around since the 1990s, and it should not point to a school of thought or the canonization of an academic discipline, but rather follow the order given by Vilém Flusser, who saw the need for “communicology” as a supplement to our culture’s obsession with “technology.”

Besides the critique of language, there is a branch of theory that argues from and with images. Coming from art criticism and art practices, there is a less verbal approach that is focused on the haptic interfaces, on the way in which graphic user interfaces are working, and how advertisement and images as such seduce the viewer/user. Does this fit into your definition of media philosophy?

Yes definitely, but it is always a matter of how this criticism is done. There is the tradition of Warburg and Panofsky, relating artistic styles and cultural traditions in a new interdisciplinary framework, and there are a variety of semiotic schools. Yet something seems to be missing. Did you ever notice how a lot of the semiotic interpretation presented at conferences stays purely descriptive? How all analysis ends in abstract categorizations? Or how film theory imitates the strategies of philology in an obvious urge to be academic? In most cases, no insight is produced that would go beyond the commonsense of any witty consumer of media products. So what is really done here is not producing theory, but recoding information, such as transcribing visual information into an academic script. These mostly ridiculous texts, squeezed between two covers, promise to provide access to knowledge otherwise not found. The questions underneath are not answered: How does an interface work? Is there an intuitive interface beyond all the conventions? A perfect language, maybe?

I believe that the text, and classical texts at that, represent but a small fraction of what former cultures dealt with as knowledge. These small textual fractions nevertheless are being fetishized as philosophy, which also faces a problem of transmission within book culture. The discipline of media

philosophy has to deal with two crucial points: first, modernity produced scientific knowledge that is too complex to be represented by texts alone. New forms of social information processing request new forms of encoding/decoding to stay functional. This is why in my book I consider Neurath, who visualized informational relations, a pioneer. Second, new media has already started to remediate the academic discourse.

Remediation is a term used by Jay Bolter to express what is happening when new media form meets the content of older media forms. We have to take this very seriously, because the computer currently is recoding the cultural codes of reading and writing. That is to say, under new semiotic constellations, we cannot produce theory in an authoritative way any more, as the academic tradition wants (and sometimes forces) us to do. New media is definitely going to break up the guild principles of knowledge reproduction within academia.

For Gilles Deleuze, the philosopher works "alongside" the cinema, reordering the images and signs for new purposes. Can we say that today's philosophers are, though sympathetic to this patchwork point of view, actually more interested in working "inside" the media?

The problem I have with Deleuze is that he tends toward rather enigmatic writing. When I tried to read his book on Spinoza [Gilles Deleuze, *Spinoza et le problème de l'expression*, Paris, 1968] and, as the author put it: "le problème de l'expression" within philosophy, I comforted myself with a sociological interpretation of this kind of writing. The exciting thing about Deleuze now is that especially with the cinema text, he was working toward a breaking point within philosophy. This has to do with the medium of philosophical expression as well. The move is documented in "Rhizome," the popular first chapter of *Mille Plateaux* (A Thousand Plateaus) but also in the *ABCdaire*, a video interview series on philosophical questions Deleuze did shortly before his death (see <[http://www.langlab.wayne.edu/Romance/FreD"G/ABC1.html](http://www.langlab.wayne.edu/Romance/FreD)> for the transcriptions).

This philosopher knew that one cannot go on just by "raping" dead authors to produce a new text. Immersion truly is the issue here. Anyway, the most interesting texts were not written by repeating what is already there, but by a certain hybridization. Alas, it still is a text. Flusser, at one

point, talking about the telematic society, apologized for still using words instead of images. This apology would not have been necessary if we had interfaces according to human thought, associations, and feelings, and not just to technological frameworks and restrictions made by programmers.

You produce Web sites yourself and do a bit of programming. I would not call you an outsider, quite the opposite. Is there an imaginary outside position, and if we could think the unthinkable, would that be a favorable option for you? What will happen after the closure of the Net? Should we start thinking about going beyond the Internet already?

This is a tricky question. Basically, I do not quite believe in this inside/outside dualism that is fostered by technology-oriented media services. There, everything has to be so very hip technologically to be worth mentioning. I am fed up with this kind of hipness when there is nothing else to say than what results in a momentary journalistic surplus value. The prostitutes of cyberspace are to be found everywhere, in all the e-zines and future-zones around the globe. They are insiders in their own way who will swiftly jump on the next train, which probably will be biotechnology.

My guess is that nowadays, people want to have some "essence" of cyberspace and be as close as possible to the imaginary "operating system." See the Linux mania, in all its melancholy—to start all over again, in a clearly protestant move, if not to say a movie in the making, for which Linus Thorvalds took up the role of the big salvationist against the big and evil pope of our sour desktop world. Is this revolutionary now, or rather pathetic?

Sorry, I got carried away a little bit. Let us step back and ask what we are talking about. The Internet? A thirty-year-old construction of a new infrastructure for the communication of people and machines. The Web? A ten-year-old interface solution for exchanging scientific documents. Are we really in a position to ask what is next? Then we would reveal ourselves as the avant-garde elitists, which we unfortunately are, never being there for the revenues when business takes over. The possibility of thinking beyond the Internet does not work for me at the moment.

Bruno Latour published a book that carries not a title, but a thesis: *Nous n'avons jamais été modernes* (We Have Never Been Modern). We cannot afford to be postmodern and ignore the nonmodern world around us. There is a

vast territory out there that does not wait to be cultivated in a traditional way. Maybe the answer to the question of what comes next is not up to "us" average white middle-class nerds. I do remember an interview with Michel Serres, "Knowledge's Redemption" (*Revue Quart Monde*, 1997), which contains some of the relevant questions. The text was recycled on mailing lists like Nettime but never discussed. Information wants to be free, but in the world today, knowledge requests consumer spending power. To quote Serres: "Knowledge is the realm of non-scarcity, as opposed to the economy. But who says that the knowledge necessary to fix a scooter is less important than knowledge about quantum physics? In a society where garbage-men are more in demand than natural scientists, knowledge is on an equalization trajectory." So while we think about going beyond the Internet, we maybe should listen to some garbage men. They are the ones who clean up after the party.

What is your interpretation of the German media theorist Friedrich Kittler? There is no separate chapter in your book dedicated to the so-called Kassel school of media research (Tholen, Bolz, Kittler, etc.), which was so active throughout the 1980s. They now seem to be the dominant discourse, even though they might not like this, a position that is anyway quickly being eroded by the rise of the Internet (generation) and the cold pragmatics of cultural studies that seem to fit much better in a climate of budget cuts and the commercialization of universities. You share your criticism of Kittlerian technological determinism with Hartmut Winkler and others. Is there a debate about these controversies in the German-speaking countries?

May I stay brief in answering this? Friedrich Kittler is a well-respected theorist and an exciting author. Within the German theory tradition, he made the necessary and liberating move from hermeneutics toward the technological approach. It is the first time that I am hearing of a "Kassel school." Let's forget this very quickly. A research project does not make a school. With all respect to the research probably done, this is a wrong categorization. Texts by the Kittler group do not do much more than to fetishize the technology approach as such and foster a very German obsession with war. And this is simply not enough, because, whether they like it or not, social innovation is the clue. No technological innovation was ever successful without its social acceptance (human factor alert!).

Another aspect you do not address directly is the question of the (virtual) body and consciousness. What is your opinion of transhumanism and extropianism?

The times we live in made us forget to think about how the individual can be an asset to the collective, something essential to traditional communities. Online communities work differently than traditional ones do. The community does not exist but as a projection. We witness all forms of media-induced escapism. Our perception of the self changed, yet all the technologies of the self, according to Foucault, have never been steady but changed with the change of times and the influence of cultures. Cultural techniques have changed our physical bearing, for example, as we sit at a desk for reading and writing. Now we wear glasses and stare at screens most of the day.

But there is something more to it. Who said that changing communications would not alter the body? Culture always meant to shape and form the individual and the social body as well. Genetic engineering is one of the consequences; chip implants are only a matter of time. A collection of perfect individuals now does not make a society work better. Extropianism is but one restricted way to think about the future of enlightenment. I do consider it a very pathetic way of Western thought. You may fantasize about the future by reinforcing the power of the individual with biotechnology, which certainly is the next topic for Internet hype. The future of communication is more about developing the social interface, I think, not the individual body.

You are someone who would love to promote the creative destruction of postmodernism, are you? Can you imagine a techno enlightenment that would be aware of its own power as well as its own limitations?

Techno enlightenment is what happens all around us right now. Or should we call it "the wit of advanced technology"? Let me relate some personal experience here. When I took my daughter Melissa to a movie in her preschool days, I had a big laugh when she yelled for the remote control, as soon as some Disney characters who were not hip enough for her appeared on screen. She has her own Web site and her current mode of being is a power pop-girl (<http://www.medienphilosophie.net/melissa>). This is great; everything is expected to be disposable at the click of a mouse, but I would

not call this a classical enlightenment move now. A six-year-old does not really make a Web site herself, but she managed to ask me the right questions. This is the new media generation. There is this nonverbal, yet articulate cultural protest of an unruly performance as opposed to the old-time rage against the machine. Our generation had this idea of sending the right messages through the proper channels. For the media generation, this difference of truth is not of much relevance; moreover, intelligence does not necessarily mean verbal articulation.

Intellectuals feel very uncomfortable with this, because their role in the social setting is being questioned, and generally people (i.e., ordinary folks) just do not follow their pathetic *Bilderverbot* (iconoclasm) any more. Let's face it: We are living in a society in which people not only put webcams under toilet seats, but others actually watch these images on the Internet. In a very blunt way: Before enlightenment, people thought their actions were determined by transcendental acts of god and possibly enabled by contingent authorities within this world. Enlightenment told them to refrain from all kinds of images and to not make an image of God, namely, of any transsubjective matters. Techno enlightenment still has to show that we can go beyond the overused dualism of text and image. Paradise now. One problem stays: We do not believe in God any more, and we still want to enjoy Sunday. Where is the party, and who serves the drinks?

The media philosophy that you are proposing, and practicing, has a tendency, in my view, to seek legitimization within the heavy tradition of the philosophy discipline. A considerable part of your work concerns the making of such a framework in which contemporary thinking can then thrive. I suppose that's a long and tough fight. The isolated position within society of philosophy, and intellectuals in general, has been a topic for decades now. You must sense this as well because you are building Web sites yourself. We could complain and condemn the existing sites. We may as well come up with unlikely proposals, big sketches for a worldwide Internet-based and driven philosophy praxis, cybernetics 2.0, entire new fields of research. Tell us all about your dreams!

Cash your dreams before they slip away? Whenever one wakes up from a dream trying to put it down on paper, one will find out that there is no definite form to fix a dream. Maybe this is why there is art. Philosophy now tried to find the one-and-only fixed form, a nonhistorical vision of human

existence—the “a priori,” laws of thought, eternal truth, and so on. What happened, is that our society and culture(s) exploded on all levels. This requires new forms of telling the story, beyond the exclusive world of printed texts. I find it very agreeable when Richard Rorty says, to give up canonic philosophy—the writings from Plato to Kant, etc.—does not necessarily mean to give up philosophy.

I always was interested in the social context of philosophy and—after my thesis on Max Horkheimer—I published a collection of essays on philosophy and Nazi politics. This shows my interest in contextualizing abstract thought. Then I moved on to topics such as media philosophy. There is no intention at all to legitimize this project within a tradition of canonized thought that is becoming more and more irrelevant and sometimes simply boring. What I have tried to show is that while our technology is new, our discourse is not. Now what we really do not need as an alternative is any coquettish “epistemology of the Net.” Ask me what else, and I have to say that I don’t know but am still struggling, what else.

But it does not make sense to simply relate to something that was written by someone we consider a classic. I believe that bit mapping and all forms of computing that lead to forms of visualization already were steps into new forms of awareness. And yet, the so-called information society realizes communication is a form of control over the resources. The challenge is to cope with an immersion into media reality, without falling for its claim to explain any kind of essence or “truth.”

There is something I would like to call the “Nietzsche paradox”—knowing that the old cultural values are lost, we cannot come up with new ones so far. I just hope we don’t collectively start to kiss horses now. The future of this discourse probably means a complete remix of the codes—further to McLuhan’s suggestions of hybridization as “a moment of truth and revelation” and contrary to the philosophical tradition that meant a remix of the texts. Maybe I would feel more comfortable not calling this philosophy anymore, exactly because of the traditional connotations of the concept.

And yet, cybernetics 2.0—as you call it—should not stop at the conspiracy level of the Barlows, Negropontes, or Kellys. Technology culture at the turn of the twenty-first century just managed to realized what a scientific manager like Vannevar Bush envisioned in 1945, when he made a

significant distinction between creative and repetitive thought and designed the MEMEX machine to automaticize the latter. This also was a dream, fulfilled half a century later by the globally networked desktop computers. Now we should ask, Where the hell is all the creative thought that was set free? Where are the social innovations in our technically revolutionized society? The Internet set a new frame, not a new form for thought, and a lot of misunderstandings (as well as hopes, illusions, and fears) derive right from here.



Real and Virtual Light of Relational Architecture

An Interview with Rafael Lozano-Hemmer

Light—the symbol of physics, rationalism, the spectacle, of heaven and eternity—is a funny substance to play with. It is abstract yet visible, bringing clarity while retaining its religious dimensions. Mexican Canadian Rafael Lozano-Hemmer is a media artist who chose to use light as a material and topic in his interactive installations of relational architecture, technological theater, and performance art. His best-known achievement was a project at one of the world's largest and most lively squares, the Zócalo in Mexico City. Via the Internet, participants were able to direct searchlight beams installed on the roofs of buildings around the square, thereby orchestrating and creating their own light patterns and movements. *Vectorial Elevation*, set in this grandiose urban space, took place during nothing less than the symbolic weeks of the millennium celebrations. The response of both Mexico City citizens and Internet users was overwhelming. The installation won the Austrian Ars Electronica Golden Nica award. *Vectorial Elevation* was also shortlisted for the 2000 Webby Awards.

You work with light. Can you tell us something about the relation between "light" and the artistic discipline of interactive works? My first association would be Albert Speer and Pink Floyd light shows. Who are your colleagues in this field? What are some of the latest technical developments?

It is an interesting exercise to review the history of visual art in relation to different dominant scientific perceptions of the nature of "light." For example, Barbara Stafford's excellent book *Body Criticism* does this for the eighteenth century when she examines the impact that Newton's view of light as a stream of corpuscles had on the Enlightenment. Other art critics have done this for Romanticism making a parallel to the Young/Fresnel demonstrations of the wave nature of light, or for Modernism with Chevreul's research into chromatic composition and perception. Today, quantum physics is comfortable with a flexible understanding of the phenomenon of light: interpreting its behavior as both waves and particles in relation to Heisenberg's uncertainty principle, under which the instrumentation or experimental methodology used for observation is complicit with what is observed. This acknowledgement of the performative role of the observer, which Duchamp nailed with his maxim "*le regard fait le tableau*," has been the basis for most explicitly interactive art, electronic or otherwise.

An alternate operation to contextualize the visual arts with regards to "light" might be to trace technological developments rather than scientific models. Many texts have already done this, going from the magic lanterns of Della Porta and Kircher to the HIT and Lapis labs' display devices that bypass the eye in favor of direct stimulation of optic nerves, what William Gibson called *Virtual Light*. But, of course, the latest, and perhaps the final, technological development is that light is no longer fast enough, as described by Jean Baudrillard, Martin Jay, and other theorists who have noted the cultural consequences of being bound by a physical threshold with no event horizon.

The wait for light to arrive is now a major consideration in most telecommunications events as well as a major design problem for the next generations of computer processors that want to run at a faster clock rate than light can travel through their millions of transistors. It is ironic that living in a fully electromagnetic culture will mean adapting to permanent delay, to lightlag, perhaps by developing an "asynchronous body" which can process in parallel the different speeds of teleperceptive senses, as distant data

packets arrive. (Technical note: It takes light 67 milliseconds to go halfway around the world, which would allow an off-the-shelf 300 MHz micro-processor to execute twenty million cycles, more or less enough for two million calculations. Our telepresent culture will always be two million calculations behind itself).

Historically, Thomas Wilfred is regarded as one of the key pioneers in the explicit use of light for creating artworks, in a new discipline which he termed "lumia." His first performance is thought to have taken place in Greenwich Village in 1922. Wilfred invented the "Clavilux," which was an organlike console that allowed real time or prerecorded control of light parameters such as intensity, color, movement, and focus, and which he used extensively in performance and exhibition settings. As early as 1929 Wilfred patented lumia projectors to be used on the top of skyscrapers; years later he created lumia "Opuses" for General Electric's and Clairol's buildings in New York City. Other lumia artists that followed Wilfred include Tom Douglas Jones (inventor of the Symphochrome in 1938), Jackie Cassen, Rudi Stern, Robert Fisher, and Christian Sidenius (who in the early sixties built a "Theatre of Light" in Connecticut with several lumia projectors).

Albert Speer and Pink Floyd shows are definitely important precedents to a performative architectural utilization of light. In both cases, however, the main operation was one of "cathartic intimidation": The message was "This is big, you are small." Even my favorite projection artist, Krzysztof Wodiczko, used that strategy to deconstruct the master narratives of power-affirming buildings. One could argue that the contribution of personal interactivity is precisely the transformation of intimidation into "intimacy": the possibility for people to constitute new relationships with the urban landscape and therefore to reestablish a context for a building's social performance.

You speak about light in a very playful way. Is it so flexible? The way you use it is very high-tech. For me it is almost an abstract category. Very metaphysical, holy, it is the sphere of the gods. You seem to be able to use it in very different ways, to make historical and political references, as you did in your installation in Linz (Ars Electronica, 1997) and for the media and architecture festival in Graz, which was about projection, colonialism, and interaction. Both were technically and narratively complex installations. And funny too. How do you put these stories together, and what is the role of light as a virtual reality (VR) element in this?

My installation projects, done in collaboration with Will Bauer, are within a field that I call “relational architecture,” which can be defined as “the technological actualization of buildings with alien memory.” Here alien memory refers to something that does not belong, that is out of place, while technological actualization means the use of hyperlinks, aliasing, special effects, and telepresence.

In relational architecture, buildings are activated so that the input of the people in the street can provide narrative implications apart from those envisioned by the architects, developers, or dwellers. The pieces use sensors, networks, and audiovisual technologies to transform the buildings. In particular, light projections are used since they can achieve the desired monumental scale, and can be changed in real time, and their immateriality makes their deployment more logistically feasible.

I like to make a clear distinction between work in relational architecture and virtual reality pieces. For me, virtual architecture could be differentiated from relational architecture in that the former is based on simulation while the latter is based on dissimulation. Virtual buildings are data constructs that strive for realism, asking the participant to “suspend disbelief” and “play along” with the environment; relational buildings, on the other hand, are real buildings pretending to be something other than themselves, masquerading as that which they might become, asking participants to “suspend faith” and probe, interact, and experiment with the false construct. Virtual architecture tends to miniaturize buildings to the participant’s scale, for example through VR peripherals such as HMDs or CAVEs, while relational architecture amplifies the participant to the building’s scale, or emphasizes the relationship between urban and personal scale. In this sense, virtual architecture tends to dematerialize the “body,” while relational architecture tends to dematerialize the “environment.” This is not to say that virtual and relational architectures are opposing practices, or that they are mutually exclusive.

Cicero, Churchill, and a dozen others have been quoted as saying “We make buildings and buildings make us.” This is far from the current urban situation; buildings no longer represent a city’s inhabitants. As Rem Koolhaas and others have noted, most new architecture consists of generic, defeatured buildings that reflect market forces and not local specificity (I call these “default buildings”). A housing project in Kuala Lumpur is bound to be quite similar to one in Mexico, Cleveland, or Athens. On the other hand, we have what the Spanish architect Emilio Lopez-Galiacho calls “vampire

buildings," which are emblematic buildings that are not allowed to have a natural death, that are kept alive artificially through restoration, citation, and virtual simulation. Vampire buildings are forced to be immortal due to "architectural correctness," a culturally, politically, and economically conservative tendency to assign a representative role to a select number of buildings. Vampire buildings, while culturally incestuous and necrophilic (or perhaps because of it), will always remain protected from erosion, gravity, war, crawling vines, graffiti, and the like.

So, one important aspect of relational architecture is to produce a performative context where default buildings may take on temporary specificity and vampire buildings may experience a declining role in their established, prevailing identification.

Having said this, I am interested in distancing my practice from the notion of the "site-specific," particularly from the postmodern attempts to find and deconstruct essential constituent characteristics of a particular space: I am very committed to the idea that a site consists of an indeterminate number of intersecting imaginary, sociopolitical, physical, and telepresent spaces. Therefore, I like to use the term "relationship-specific" to describe the uniqueness of a discreet interaction between participants, different planes of experience, and the relational building(s). What is specific is the new behaviors that might emerge during interaction.

Yes, let's go to the messy reality of Mexico City, in this case, where you have just finished a pearly piece of relational architecture. Do you see the high-tech equipment you have been using there clashing with rampant poverty, a low-intensity civil war in Chiapas, and in general the huge social divides in Mexico, or this is just another Western cliché?

The piece in Mexico City was commissioned by the National Council for Culture and the Arts for the millennium celebrations. The President of the Council saw my work in Austria, which questioned the notion of heritage and "cultural property," and asked me to use Mexican history as a departure point for a spectacular installation in Zócalo Square. Now, most Mexican art this century has had a very didactic, historicist bent that is clearly evident in the Neue Sachlichkeit work of the muralists. Modern masters adopted a "revolutionary" aesthetic that was characterized by a problematic romanti-

cization of indigenous peoples, a militant patriotism, and a fascination with linear models of history. Perhaps what could have been expected is to have a new kind of virtual muralism, consisting of projections of parading national heroes. The last thing I wanted to do is to repeat these monologic mantras. Fortunately, contemporary Mexican art has departed long ago from this vision, starting with Octavio Paz who challenged the concept of “progress” almost forty years ago and José Luis Cuevas who denounced muralism as a “cactus curtain” that was blocking the transit of ideas in and out of Mexico.

In any case, the problem of large-scale monologic representation is not only a Mexican phenomenon. Most millennium shows throughout the world consisted of *son et lumière* spectacles that defined a linear historicist narrative of “representative” moments or actors in history. Each of those narratives must be analyzed in terms of their exclusions of so-called minor histories, because there can never be a comprehensive, exhaustive, or neutral representation, and what is shown is always a profile of the current elite. There is a very close connection between representation and repression, particularly when it is applied to what Edward Said calls “identitarian” narratives. Elites have always used such narratives to homogenize and control what are otherwise complex, dynamic social fabrics. The millennium was the first chance to see the widespread impact of new technologies of representation on the scale and insidiousness of identitarian power affirmation (although it could be argued that they were already evident, for instance, in Pokemon consumerism or in the “special effects” capitalism of dot-com corporations).

From the very beginning of the design process I knew that the piece had to incorporate interactivity as a way of avoiding historical representation and Lurçat- and Spcer-like spectacles. I wanted the main protagonist of the piece to be the participants themselves. Since the minister had asked me to look at Mexican history to find a departure point for the piece, I investigated the largely undocumented history of Mexican technological culture. I found several useful precedents, which serve as a legitimate backdrop for electronic art projects, from the research of Gonzalez Camarena on color TV to the popularization of electronic music by Luis Pérez Esquivel. One discovery was incredibly useful: the theory of cybernetics was postulated by Norbert Wiener and Arturo Rosenbleuth at the Mexican Institute of Cardiology to explain self-regulation in the heart. Since I became aware of this, I have joked that cyberart is a native Mexican practice!

But seriously, to answer your question regarding the potential clash between high-tech equipment and the appalling economic situation of many Mexicans, I have to say that Mexico is a very complex, heterogeneous society that is full of contradictions. There is an almost feudal society in regions of Chiapas that continues to systematically impoverish indigenous people; at the same time, Subcomandante Marcos is a networked revolutionary leader who understands and uses the subversive power of "high technology." This is not to say that social inequality and technology do not clash; of course they do, for example, in the high-tech maquiladora factories in the border towns where management and technology come from the United States and the underpaid workforce, raw materials, and space come from Mexico. My position is that technology is an inevitable aspect of society, and it is a key challenge for the media artist to develop it or misuse it to break the stereotypes and create new technological languages. One of the reasons I like to quote the precedents of Mexican technological culture is precisely because I like to think that technological development is not necessarily exclusive to "developed" countries. Think of the software industry in India or the Nortec electronic music movement in Tijuana.

The piece was done in the Zócalo Plaza, which is the world's third largest square, measuring 240 by 220 meters and holding over 200,000 people. The Zócalo's monumental size makes the human scale seem insignificant, a fact that some Mexican scholars consider an emblem of a monolithic political legacy; there are almost one thousand protests a year at this site and yet its scale drowns most of them. In order to have an impact on this square it was necessary to deploy very powerful equipment: We placed eighteen robotic searchlights with a total of 126,000 watts of power on the rooftops of surrounding buildings like the National Palace, the city government headquarters, and hotels. On a clear night the searchlight beams could be seen from a 20km radius and covered the entire historic center of the city, including landmarks such as the Metropolitan Cathedral, the Supreme Court of Justice, and the Templo Mayor Aztec ruins.

Despite the power of the installation, my intention was not to do a cathartic millennium show but a quiet, slowly fluctuating space for reflection. The concept for the piece was for people on the Internet to design light sculptures using a 3-D interface, then submit them to Mexico where they would be queued, rendered by the searchlights in the plaza, and finally documented in a digital archive. We connected the searchlights with hundreds

of meters of data cable and measured their location with GPS trackers. Custom software was written to interface a VRML simulation of the Zócalo to the servers that could control the searchlights. Three Webcams placed in the National Palace, a hotel, and a skyscraper would document participants' designs and also stream live video feeds. As with any event that I have ever done in public space, the logistics were intense: We filed several reports to the Department of National Security, obtained permits from air traffic control, installed coaxial Internet feeds through the hotel's bathroom ventilation, stopped street traffic while cranes lifted the searchlights, and so on.

I have seen the video you produced that documents the Zócalo installation. It is truly amazing. What struck me in the video was the poetry of the searchlights, which are usually only set up to mimic military searchlights, scanning the night sky for suspicious objects. The movements of the ever changing grids seemed so elastic. This must be a visual trick because the hardware and software you managed to bring together looked so massive. The scale of work you are doing really has transcended the museum and gallery to large-scale urban spaces. Did you run this art project as a military operation, or rather like a business, a theater show? Does the virtual spectacle you staged resemble some elements of the big, orchestrated fireworks, pop concerts, and rave parties?

The elasticity that you are referring to is in fact the effect that I was looking for the most when designing this project. The smooth morphing between different submitted designs was crucial to evoke a sense of constant transformation and flow. The transitions between positions were as important as the positions themselves.

My original notion was for the searchlights to render a new design every second, both to fit as many participants as possible and to match the tempo of a slow heartbeat. In the end six to eight seconds were needed per design to allow the searchlights to position themselves and for the three Webcams to take pictures. In retrospect I am very glad that we used this slower pace because it invited contemplation and anything faster would have been too aggressive in a city that does not need any more aggression.

As you mention, historically searchlights have been used for military anti-aircraft surveillance and their vocabulary of movements have been limited to coordinated "sky scanning" patterns. These patterns have a very different interpretation in Europe, where bombings wiped out entire cities, than in America, where they became associated with celebration, thanks in part to

the use of searchlights in World War II victory parades. Once searchlights were adopted by Hollywood-style events, the movements became largely randomized. The searchlights were used to attract people to a single point from which the light beams originated.

In *Vectorial Elevation* the lightbeams were always in a coordinated state of mutation as they positioned themselves to render participants' designs. The movement was "purposeful" in that every six seconds a unique static pattern would emerge and then dissolve into the next one. The theatrics of power used by Speer and others was also avoided to an extent by the lack of linear narrative: The piece was in operation from dusk to dawn for two weeks, becoming more of an urban fixture than a time-based event. Although I am conscious that the scale was "spectacular," I am happier to compare the work to a public fountain or to a park bench than to a "son et lumière" show.

The piece was developed by a large number of programmers, designers, and technicians in four countries. Even though I was commissioned to design the project in March 1998, we only got to work a few months before the opening. The Internet connection in the control room was installed four days before going live! So it was a pretty tight development schedule. The physical setup was done by a Mexican company that normally presents large rock concerts and musical theater, so to them the scale was not a problem. Logistically, I have always thought that my work is more akin to the performing arts than to the visual arts. The installations tend to be ephemeral interventions where the public becomes an actor through interactivity, and they are closer to perpetration than to preservation. I am also particularly interested in the fact that theater, concerts, and performance art are direct, shared experiences where people actively assume different roles, thanks to the "wideband" feedback that is possible with collective closeness. Composer Frederic Rzewski called this essential pleasure of the performing arts "coming together."

Can you tell us about the special software that has been developed for the Zócalo? Will there be any spin-offs, used in other installations? Will the software, for example, be available as open source? If you work at this level, what experiences do you have concerning innovative and creative further development of certain technologies? Are you optimistic about the role that such kinds of new media arts can play? Through your work within the Spanish telecom giant Telefónica, you would probably agree that "digital art is the product of transnational corporate capitalism."

Could this type of work possibly influence the direction technology is taking? Or shall we, with Peter Lunenfeld, say that the Demo or Die essence of electronic arts is to perform corporate technologies?

We had twenty computers in the control room running mostly custom-made software: Linux/Apache servers, video reflectors, watermarking processors, DMX control boxes, etc. The main design specification was that the interface should be accessible across platforms, across browsers, and without the need for any plug-ins. We turned to Java as the solution but even it had to be tweaked heavily to achieve this goal. Most of the software is too specialized to be useful in other contexts, but now it will be very easy to make new versions of *Vectorial Elevation* for other cities. The only piece of software that may find itself repurposed in some form is a video streaming system that the programmers called “kyxpyx” and that is released as open source. We wanted to have a cheap (free!) alternative to the current video streaming solutions from Microsoft, Apple, and Real, and that worked without plug-ins.

I agree that digital art is the product of transnational corporate capitalism. So is the environment we live in and our identity itself. Many years ago I wrote an essay for the journal *Leonardo* magazine called “Perverting Technological Correctness” where I outlined some strategies artists deploy to corrupt the inevitability of corporate technologies. Among them, I included the simulation of technology itself, the use of pain, ephemeral intervention, misuse of technology, nondigital approaches to virtuality, and resistance to what I call the “effect” effect. I believe that artists have been and can be at the forefront of technological development.

For media arts, the usual example that gets cited is the development of the data glove by Dan Sandin, Tom DeFanti, and Gary Sayers under a grant from the National Endowment for the Arts in 1977. But there are many other examples. Will Bauer, my collaborator for the past twelve years, has been developing a wireless 3-D tracking system that we have incorporated into many of our pieces. This integration has been very beneficial to both the artistic and technological developments, and we find it hard to distinguish what comes first, if anything. Of course I am aware that most technology is developed for and by the military-economic complex, but I am enamored of the romantic illusion that if art had the military’s budget we would create more jobs than they do and develop more interesting technology (including great art bombs)!



The Power of Multiplicity and the Multiplicity of Power

An Email Exchange with McKenzie Wark

The Australian media theorist McKenzie Wark and I have had a number of exchanges over the years, ever since we came across each other's work, around 1995 when I read his first book *Virtual Geography*. Our topics of conversation ranged from "Englishes" and the role of language on the Net, to German and Anglo-Saxon media theories, to the changing role of cultural studies. Most of the material we compiled has not been published. The following dialogue, which took place in January 1999 and was updated in November 2000, centers around abstractions such as the masses (I studied "mass psychology" in the late 1970s), the media, and the position of intellectuals.

You seem to be attempting to redefine our relation to the masses, the everyday day, normalcy, indeed, media. These things are related in such an odd, new way, so complex, so banal at the same time. Words do not fit together anymore. They do not belong to their original, common meaning. They start drifting. Take my favorite punching bag, the concept of "masses." They're not grey anymore; they shine, in flowery colors, silver (for the corporates), and green/yellow for the sporty types. Masses celebrate; they no longer bow to the ground.

I don't know that I'm attempting to redefine our relation to the masses, rather it's a questioning of whether there ever were masses for us (whoever "we" are) to have a relation to. The idea of the mass has a particular history, going back to nineteenth-century concepts of the mob and the crowd, which were supposedly domesticated by "mass" media. The postmodern narrative about the breakup of the mass seems to me to rest on the fantasy that these prior concepts described something real.

What I think makes more sense is to question whether there ever was a mass, other than as a fetish object via which communication professionals—in public relations, advertising, spin doctoring, or mass communication studies—could claim to have an object of expertise that was amenable to analysis and control. The idea of the mass assumed an object on the other end of a technology, via which the expert, who has knowledge of the object, can assist power, which owns the means of communication.

Look around, however, and what do we find? Not masses, if by masses we mean something that is homogenous, but distinct from the media technology that instrumentalises it. We find a patchwork of intersections, or more interestingly, nonintersections. Often media and people just share the same space, having nothing to do with each other. Often it seems we are looking at what Guattari calls "subjective machines," in which it is impossible to unscramble the flesh from the tech.

There was a moment when English-language cultural studies, in its revolt from the old communication paradigm, reversed the poles, saw the people as active and sovereign users of media, rather than media as a technology via which the powerful caused something to happen to the powerless. "The people make meaning, but not with the media of their own choosing." Rather than a tool of domination, media became a tool of "resistance." But what if it isn't a tool at all? What if, rather than reversing the

relation between media object and human subject, one considers the two together as a productive machine?

One way of describing the field in which technomedia and human culture coevolve and coproduce is “everyday life.” Everyday life might be a site where the “second nature” of our built environment is traversed by media vectors—our “third nature.” An environment which we come to think of as “natural” out of the habit of inhabiting it. My first book was called *Virtual Geography*, a term that might be another way of describing this zone of potential events and relations within which the subject experiences its distinctness out of its struggle to cohere amid the lines of force that produce it.

Both “us” and “them” (whoever we are, whoever they are) are all always situated in this same virtual geography. There’s no outside. So in terms of method, we proceed empirically, inductively, within this material immersion. There is nothing outside the vector. There’s no way to separate us from them. No “intellectuals” versus “masses,” other than as a fantasy. A fantasy in which intellectuals receive their identity out of their resentful hostility to the masses, who appear as a homogenised “other.”

But this is just a pathology of subjectivity. A fetishizing of the self. The masses, it turns out, are not homogenous, but come in all colors and flavors. So while I agree that “masses celebrate,” it may be not that “they no longer bow to the ground.” Maybe they never did. The perception of this change may be derived from the mismatch between a previous theory and a current reality, rather than between a previous reality and a current reality.

Because one thing that has changed is that “we” (whoever we are) see and hear what these people who are (not) masses see and hear. It’s no longer the case that the media are stratified into different environments—one for us, one for them. The vectoral property of the media means it traverses every fence, every wall, every skin. Second nature is everywhere doubled by a “third nature.” It crosses all boundaries and borders, including those of self and community, of self and other.

There is, I think, a real phase-shift in media history, and it is signaled by the telegraph, telephone, television, by “telesthesia,” or perception at a distance. Since the telegraph, information moves faster than people or things. It changes the potential shape, the virtuality, of everyday life. It reverses the poles, making third nature a power over second nature, and indeed over the extraction of resources from “nature” itself, which henceforth appears as a

resource. Even “green” politics, ironically enough, emerges from this movement, as total media awareness of “nature” as a resource.

But that’s just a theory. It has to be tackled from the other end, from observation, and from conversation. It’s about geography as experience, knowing the lay of the land that the masses do not inhabit, because there are no masses, but in which rather the everyday exists, as a virtual world of potential interactions. By identifying the contours of the everyday, a space is defined within which it is possible to experiment with new kinds of liberty. We no longer have roots we have aērals. We no longer have origins, we have terminals.

The masses never existed, one theory says. They have always been phantoms, or rather Projektionsflächen, objects of common fears and desires. But this also means that they have never disappeared, or can be reinvented. The same can be said of everyday life. I am not much of a supporter of this idea. Of course, all concepts lack reality and can easily be taken apart into numerous smaller parts, which again fail the reality test.

Perhaps, but I think Marx was right to counsel us to look always for the line of abstraction that is at work in the world itself. Abstractions are not just concepts in people’s heads. Abstraction is a force at work in the world. Modernity is the will to abstraction made concrete. Marx identified commodification as one abstraction, made possible by the general, quantitative equivalent, money, by its accumulation, as capital, by the relations of private property that underpin it.

But I think there is another abstraction, what I would call vectoralization. Relations of production can become more complex, spatially disaggregated, because of communication vectors, particularly in the era of telesthesia. What holds it all together is not just a quantitative equivalent, the circulation of money, but a qualitative equivalent, the circulation of information. And information, no less than land, labor, and capital goods, has become a form of property.

I think those are abstractions that are at work in the world. Our understanding of them is always imperfect. Third nature reads second nature as imperfectly as second nature grasps nature. With neither mouth nor hand, language or action, can we really know the world in itself. But one explains more phenomena with fewer concepts if you follow the lines of abstraction that produce the experience of modernity itself in everyday life.

Marxists say rather, Classes, not masses. I have not heard that for a while either. Masses must have become unpopular somewhere in the 1970s. Classes actually disappeared not much later, in the mid-1980s. It was a courageous act from Kroker and Weinstein to come up with the term "the virtual class" (in their book Data Trash, 1994). Of course there were some Marxists still using the term, even refining the terminology (within their system of scientific socialism). I can also think of diverse Germans such as Robert Kurz, Joachim Hirsch, Elmar Altvater; the Frenchman Etienne Ballibar; and of course the Italians around Antoni Negri. Still, they have not come up with a dynamic, actual image that would fit into the academic-artistic circles of the 1990s (an exception would be the concept of "immaterial labor").

In much of the "overdeveloped" world, the labor movement cut a deal with capital within a protected national market. While the envelope of the nation appeared relatively secure, people worried instead about the envelopes of communal or self-identity. But media vectors have gone beyond troubling the boundaries of self and community, and now trouble national boundaries just as much. The proliferation of ever faster, cheaper, more flexible media vectors with a more and more global reach makes possible the colonization of more extensive spaces by commodity relations. The national space, and the national compromise between labor and capital, has come undone.

This shifts the anxiety toward one of two options: a resurgent nationalism, or a resurgent class composition. Either one tries to fend off one's anxiety about the permeable borders of the nation, community, and self by hardening the national boundary against the other. Or one follows the vectoral line that traverses self, community, and nation and discovers the class interest that potentially forms along it. One either demands more boundary, or one starts to contest the ownership and control of the vectors that both traverse and incite the boundary.

This is the problem that bedevils the "anti-globalization" movement that, even on the left, falls into anxiety about borders rather than seeking a new deal for the vectoralization of space, one that abandons the dialectic of self and other and takes up instead one based on embracing the vector but seeking a global, vectoral world with plural forms of ownership, not just private ownership, in which justice and well-being have a place alongside profit and "productivity." The break-up of the Microsoft monopoly by court order could turn out to be much more important than the well meant but confused protests against the World Bank.

But we need a new concept of class to grasp vectorialization. Marxists still think only of the force of production, steel and concrete, as being material. The forces of communication—media vectors—are also material. And like the forces of production, they and their products can be turned into property—intellectual property. If capitalism starts with the enclosure of land, continues with the accumulation of capital goods as private property, its next phase grows out of intellectual property. I would explain it in the following fable.

First comes the first, who work together to wrest a space of free action and the possibility of free time from the earth. This class builds a second nature out of raw earth. Second comes the second, who quantify and profit by the labors of the first. This class organizes the tyranny of second nature over the earth, and over the first, who make second nature. Third comes the third, who qualify and interpret the actions of the others, creating a terrain of referents for every action, a third nature that exactly covers second nature, which rationalizes, justifies, questions, idealizes, condemns, and interprets its instrumental relationship with the earth.

This is the class to which we belong, but we are drawn again and again to identify with the others: with the nobility of the first class and its labors; with the power of the second and its property. And why not? The third class creates the image of the others' loves for themselves, and even of their relations with each other. (It is for this that they keep us.) We are always a class for others, we intellectuals (or "symbolic analysts," as Robert Reich calls us), for we make every myth of a group's roots and origins—even this one. We were never yet a class in itself, and certainly not for itself. We are the class that exists, not by taking the earth as its object, and not by taking another class as its object, but by making subjective all that the other classes have made and apportioned as object.

Time to get over our crush on the noble worker, or of the bold entrepreneur—for that is simply to love in the place of the other the image we put there for the other, whether they want it or not. We must become the very rifts that traverse us, for we are nothing but the conscious and creative form of relation-to-the-other itself. And there is nothing "immaterial" about my labor, thank you very much. Infinitely less suffering than a factory job, but it's still work. Work that never ends—there's no knock-off time for the third class. It's all work, work, work. Was it Verlaine who, when sleeping, put a sign on his door that said "poet at work"? It is precisely because the third

class suffers less that it quite often ends up leading the charge against capital. In Marx's day, it was the printers who wore the Jacobin's red cap.

Like the first class, the manual workers who transform nature, the third class has to sell its labor and ends up dispossessed of the product of its labor—the information we transform. It belongs to the owners of the means of communication—to publishers, universities, networks, dot-coms. Class is all about property, not status. The third class is all about intellectual property, which is why struggles around copyright on the Internet need to be put in a class perspective. It's the enclosure of the commons all over again. And one strikes this enclosure in everyday life: the court cases against Napster, the contracts that force us to assign "electronic rights" to publishers, the worthless stock options of sacked dot-com employees along Silicon Alley.

What is the social structure within the wider framework of new media? Are we allowed to use, and introduce, such terms as "cybermasses"? How about Richard Barbrook's emphasis on the guild system, when he speaks about the rise of the "digital artisans." The only term that is widespread seems to be the "community." The term has by now been misused in such a way that we can hardly use it any longer, even pronounce it. In some cases, however, it might be useful to use it: chat rooms, avatar worlds, mailing lists. But then I doubt whether ten thousand plus users can be a community. I wonder what social term exists for us then, within the framework of a political critique, and what useful and lively concepts exist. They can even be potential constructs that expire after a while, like "everyday life."

As Guy Debord says, "But theories are made only to die in the war of time." One theory that won't lay down and die, the vampire of the left, is its crazy notion of opposing the market with something else. Stalinist bureaucracy, the gift economy, anything. But these alternatives all come with their own terrors. I'm not arguing that there is no alternative to the market. There are lots. They are ways of *escaping* from capital, rather than *opposing* it, however.

It's a question of a diversity of kinds of diversity. The market is good at diversity—there's no subcultural kink it can't assimilate to its axioms, as Deleuze and Guattari say. The market chews through radical fashions like any other junk food—it's a myth to think of opposition to capitalism as outside of capitalism. On the contrary, the oppositional movements merely confirm capital through their resentment of it.

The irony is that it is capital that succeeds in subverting the market, not its radical opposition, which end up being commodified. Through concentration and monopolization, capital attempts to escape the competitive pressure of the market, as Manuel Delanda shows. Whatever its limits, the market does allocate resources better than monopolies, be they corporate or state bureaucracies.

There are limits to what markets can do, however. This is the real, ongoing political struggle—to affirm the inadequacy of the market, to affirm the plurality of ways of allocating resources, of existing collectively or autonomously in the world. Not all differences can be reduced to a price. As Lyotard says, justice does not have a common measure. As a card carrying social democrat, I believe in a diversity of kinds of diversity—a “mixed economy.” Not the fantasy of doing away with the market. To replace it with what?

Take open source software: Free source code—that’s the commons at work. But an open source operating system like Linux still needs the market. Programmers make high-level tools for each other based on the source code, and exchange them in a gift economy, earning kudos and building a resume with which to get a well paying job. Meanwhile, if you want to actually use Linux, you’re better off with one of the cheap but still commercial versions. Programmers have to be paid to do the dull stuff like build an installer or some tools for the mere hapless “user.” So at its best, open source as a hybrid—gift economy plus commodity economy—that’s what a bazaar is.

The third class has to struggle for both the solidarity of the commons and the liberty of the market, which puts it only partly at odds with the second class, the owners, and partly in collaboration. It’s better that there’s a bazaar, a hybrid of gift economy and market, than that cathedral to greed, Microsoft, which uses the privatization of the source code of the operating system as leverage for a monopoly. Like all monopolies, it works by roping off territory. In this case, the territory of the desktop, although most monopolies rope off national territories, like the monopoly phone or broadcast corporations.

The paradox of globalization is that corporations suffer from it to the extent that it exposes them to the market, breaking open their neat little national monopolies. So you see them all scramble to make deals to recreate their monopoly power. We’ve seen a great wave of this in communication

industries in the 1990s. Ironically, the progressive policy is sometimes to insist that capital work within the market, rather than subvert it. That, and setting limits to market-based resource allocation in the name of justice, equity, liberty—other kinds of good besides “efficiency.” Here the third class aligns in its interests with the first.

Some business interests resist globalization—and oh how they talk about “community” when it suits them! They’re all for the national community or the regional or local community when they don’t want to face competition, and of course the workers stuck with some half-assed deal with these local monopolists can easily be persuaded that it is in their interests to put the rights of the local community over the rights of workers elsewhere to get jobs, make a living. They stick to the old boundary, rather than creating their own vector. And the “new conservatives” on the Left join the racist, nationalist Right in cheering them on. This is where part of the second class coopts part of the first and aligns it the third.

If Marx teaches us anything, it is that there is a little bit of us, our labor, in every commodity, and there is a little bit of every commodity that goes into our own makeup. The myth of community is one that severs these connections. It just groups the people by the fetish of their apparent sameness—ethnicity, locality. It does not deal with the real, abstract force of sameness in the world—the rendering of diverse things equivalent in the commodity form, the rendering of diverse spaces traversible by the communication vector.

Everyday life could be a way to retrieve an awareness of this abstract force—which is what Henri Lefebvre was trying to do when he coined it. It’s also a way of perceiving that shifting, conjunctural space of vectors and boundaries, where different fractions of the three classes align and conflict over the ways to secure the forms of property and forms of relation between forms of property that secure their material interests. The stake is of course the future shaping of everyday life itself, the degree to which it will remain heterogeneous, or become homogenized under the reign of the second class and its quantifying logic of managing all resources.

I started to reconstruct the original fascination and (re)discovery of the everyday life in the seventies. There must be an old anarchist/dadaist saying: “The enemy is the Public.” It was on a poster I had in my room from the Berlin Tiamat publishing house. Similarly, one could state for the sixties: “The enemy is Normalcy.” The hatred

of the boring, petty bourgeois lifestyle of parents, and society in general, must have been unbearable in those days. Perhaps it still is. In this view, normalcy is a void, a black hole, a desert of some kind.

Now how can this despicable realm ever have turned into some mystique? What is the secret of the everyday life? And are we really sure that we want to reveal its mystery? And does it have one in the first place? Studying the everyday life, we will find out how power functions, right? We can thereby understand why resistance and alternatives do not have a real chance. But why not stick to the outside-alien-outlaw position?

I don't think there's any mystery about how we got from the outlaw 1960s to the celebration of everyday life. The outlaws got tenure. They got elected. Danny "The Red" Cohn-Bendit in the European Parliament! The German Greens are in the federal government. This just shows how the outlaw margin is within, rather than opposed to, the everyday. It is a differentiation within, not a dialectical other outside it. The interesting outlaws reveal what kinds of tactics already exist as a potential within everyday life. Radicalism in art and politics is about the virtuality of information or action in the everyday. It is an experimental, empirical way of discovering possibilities. Who knows what the everyday can become? Nobody knows, until the art outlaws, the style avant-garde, the sex freaks, the theory wranglers, and vector hackers invent new possibilities.

I'm fond of outlaws. I lived through punk. I grew up on the myth of the Surrealists, the Situationists, Fluxus, Warhol's "silver factory." I wrote a tribute to the Sydney Libertarian "push" of my hometown in my book *The Virtual Republic*. But I'm trying to shake off a bit of old-fashioned "bourgeois" culture in myself, in my belief that the Big Name Authors in these movements are the sole creators of their own radical otherness, as if it were their own private property. I think the everyday culture they work against (yet within) deserves a bit for credit for creating them. Which is why, in my book *Celebrities, Culture and Cyberspace*, I cojoin everyday life, popular culture, and social democracy—all the "common" things, the plurality within which the extraordinary emerges.

The idea of the mass conveniently presupposes an oppositional minority. And it sees these as opposed "communities." But the everyday is all about difference, diversity, multiplicity. Ironically, I think that's the "radical" position now. Not making a fetish of your semiotic difference, but

rather intuiting the vectoral relations that produce the possibility of identity in the first place.

If you grasp the relations of production that give rise to identity, both the production relations and the communication relations, then you can see a whole universe of possibilities for envelopes within which to live, rather than just fixed identities. You see, rather than *this* self, *this* community, *this* relation—the “virtual republic” of multiple differences that could be in negotiation and relation. To me that’s social democracy.

The 1968-post-leftist-green-social-democratic-realo-pragmatists, now in power in Europe, can no longer deal anymore with today’s outlaws. What they formerly took to be subjects for them are now mere objects of “policies.” Warhol became high art, expelled to museums and private collections. Or don’t you think in those terms of “fatal” decay?

Oh, yes, what the band Devo called “de-evolution,” the accommodation of the marginal within the axioms of capital, or the capture of difference as something to be administered by the state. But why should this surprise us? It’s only a certain romanticism that leads us to think one can escape the banality of the everyday flux of market and state, society and culture. It’s the most “radical” movements in art and politics that become pure signs, pure spectacle, pure commodities. The Situationists are nothing but intellectual property now—for books and documentaries, for building academic or curatorial careers. The digital underground is already entering this de-evolution.

What is less “soluble” in the waters of the marketplace, ironically enough, is social democracy. It is a tradition that still functions in terms of organization, that can still get its hands on the state, that can still open little spaces for culture. Meanwhile Che Guavara’s picture is used to sell products. Gramsci is a publishing industry. Punk is a back catalogue. Revolutionary romanticism is just the R&D of commodified desire. But while it is the role, I still believe, of radical art, theory, politics to be exceptional, to escape the common order, everyday culture and politics are really something else. It’s their business to be mundane. But there’s work that has to be done there. One has to work within everyday life for a culture that doesn’t polarize into an us and a them. Which doesn’t stigmatize or attack the other. Which doesn’t forcibly homogenize those who imagine they dwell within its envelope. One has to work for a majority who believe in a

politics that respects liberty but uses state resources to create a commons, that makes possible a diversity of forms of economy, that is committed to the step-by-step overcoming of human misery.

It's a question of accepting the modesty of one's role as a member of the third class, within the space of the everyday, not in totalizing—and totalitarian—otherness to it. It's a question of overcoming the theology of negation—the priestlike power of moralistic refusal. One becomes, yes, an artisan. Selling one's labor to owners of the means of communication, but also working in a gift economy, in forms of solidarity and exchange that are not commodified. Creating tools, vectors, concepts, narratives, images that affirm the power of multiplicities and the multiplicity of power.



“I am a believer in the symbolic aspect of culture clashes”

Interview with Călin Dan

Călin Dan is a Romanian art critic, curator, and artist, now based in Amsterdam. To me he is an individual who embodies the post-1989 circumstance of Europe. Dan is equipped with an enlightened form of nihilism (to be found in E. M. Cioran—a cult figure for the Romanian intelligentsia); he practices black humor (like Caragiale—another cult figure for the same); he has a vivid interest in anthropology (see Eliade) and sometimes in metaphysics (Noica/Liiceanu). Born in 1955 in the Transylvanian town of Arad (close to the Hungarian border) to a middle-class family, Dan had a mixed career under the Ceausescu regime, managing to achieve a reputation in the art circles while keeping a low political profile, and he survived the dark eighties as an art historian and journalist.

He was therefore well trained to enter the chaotic period after the bloody “television revolution” of December 1989. Together with the artists Dan Mihaltianu and Iosif Király, he formed the art group subREAL in 1990 and started to produce conceptual installations. Their style was dirty and minimal, full of ironic references to Romanian history and to the political moment—the dubious post-communist leadership of Ion Iliescu. In 1992 Dan was appointed director of the Soros Center for Contemporary Arts (SCCA) Bucharest. In that position he initiated the first media art event in Romania, *Ex Oriente Lux*, which opened in November 1993. As a somewhat regular visitor to Bucharest, teaching media theory and video at the Art Academy, I was part of this event, working together with Dan on a special issue of the journal *Arta*, on the catalogue of the show, and on the program of a two-day conference. During that intense period, I conducted my first (unpublished) interview with him.

This conversation was recorded in Amsterdam, in February 2000, and edited by Dan in the months that followed. A lot had happened in the six years since we first collaborated. The government withdrew all funding for *Arta* in 1994. The same year, Dan produced another mega-event, the exhibition *01010*. . . , using for the

first time in the Romanian context features like community-oriented projects, interactive displays of content, and online communication. The event generated an important body of work produced in collaboration with fourteen artists, a documentary film, and an impressive catalogue. In 1995, Dan and Király (the only members of subREAL) were invited for a one-year residency in Künstlerhaus Bethanien, Berlin. They traveled there with the photo archive of *Arta*, practically saving it from destruction by neglect from the part of the authorities.

As a result of the works produced there, subREAL became almost synonymous with “artists & archives.” Unlike in other cases originating in the Former East, subREAL did not intend to reveal any scandals about compromised artists or alleged secret agents, working for the powerful (at the time) Securitate. The 600kg archive consisted primarily of material illustrating art history as a concept. Nevertheless, this was the archive of a communist, state-controlled art magazine, closely tied to the rich and influential Union of Artists, an organization embodying the official ideology as far as the art scene was concerned. In 1996 Dan established himself in Amsterdam as an artist. After working for years in video, using the computer mainly for word processing and email, he abruptly entered a media recuperation phase and produced a lot of graphic material commenting digitally on (again) art history (mainstream Western art this time). After that, he became interested in the exciting world of 3-D computer games.

In collaboration with the newly established V-2 Lab for the Unstable Media, Dan developed the interactive installation *Happy Doomsday!* in 1998–1999. Dan chose for this purpose two fitness chairs used for training arm muscles, and interfaced them with the computers through sensors that read the movements of each user. The machines perform the functions of joysticks, generating navigation/participation in a multi-user 3-D environment, which is a simulator of European war history based on the political map of the continent.

The complete version of Happy Doomsday! was shown in Vienna's Museumsquartier, in ZKM–Karlsruhe, and at the Rotterdam Film Festival. How does it feel to have completed such a big project, which is also, if I may say so, your first as an interactive media artist?

Basically it feels good, if I look at the people crowding to work out on my machines. I am happy mainly because this gets my initial hypothesis confirmed: There exists a possibility to communicate with your public in a way that is both enjoyable and serious. That was the main expectation behind

my choice for the computer game formula: to get an entertainment tool that leads the audiences somewhere else. That is why I put my trust in interactivity and in the pop culture formats.

Budget-wise, working at Nintendo must be different from working within the structure of a media arts organization such as V-2 Lab, even though you received very generous support. How would you describe the aesthetics of computer games in connection to these types of technical and financial limitations?

Building a computer game starts with decisions painters have to make when buying the canvas, the brushes, and the colors. If you are rich enough, you go to the best shop. If not, you end up with a piece of cardboard. It happened to Van Gogh. So, in the end much depends on what you are able to use it for. In bigger words—what kind of visions haunt you. You do not need the latest version of Maya or a super-computer in order to develop a good piece. Mind you, I am not necessarily in favor of the poverty approach. At least not as far as the knowledge of the field is concerned. You have to understand what is going on the market.

Only after having your research done, knowing what is on top and below your capacities, you can position yourself properly. We ended up in the medium-lower scale. We worked with 3-D StudioMax, and we used World Tool Kit as game engine. It is fine compared to older software, but it's kid's stuff if you look at what is used now in the commercial world.

On the other hand, I do not see yet enough authoring knowledge enabling people to contain the illusionist powers lying in high-end software. Without that knowledge, generated in a thin zone between technology and cultural tradition, we are easily carried away by the fascination of the new, sometimes in unknown directions, but mainly in versions of a Barbie environment. That kind of knowledge is a delicate product and needs time to develop and mature. When working with lesser tools, you are on the familiar ground of poverty and therefore forced to be inventive.

Is this the distinction between the workshop-based digital artisan, as Richard Barbrook has described it, and the industrial method of game production?

I do not see a structural difference between low- and high-scale production, if the production mentality is there. As soon as you leave the studio and start

working outside of the art system, you are forced to abandon artistry. If you run a project like *Happy Doomsday!*, with a staff of fifteen, or Super Mario with—I don't know, a team of two thousand maybe?—it burns down to the same thing. You have to meet deadlines, generate ideas at high speed, keep your drive. And mainly, work with people, know what are the limits of your decisional powers, when to force into a certain direction and when to give up, when to accept failures and when to fight beyond.

Speaking of deadlines, maybe that's where the differences occur. In low-budget projects, deadlines are basically impossible to meet. Not necessarily because of bad planning, but because we talk here of a domain where process control is very limited and where we practically do not know what we are dealing with. You cannot quantify the work and drop deadline dates unless you have an open pocket. And even then. At Nintendo, the above mentioned Super Mario (a drag content-wise, if I am allowed an opinion, but an ambitious experiment in interaction and in physical responses of the interface) was delivered with two years' delay.

What is the relation of Happy Doomsday! to the present situation of digital art?

The game was designed for two users who meet in a real-time-rendered 3-D environment, a feature that implies quite a lot of work. I think the public likes it, not necessarily the critics or the digital arts community. *Happy Doomsday!* is not trendy enough: not enough techie stuff in it, not enough play with randomness or with any other imports from the surface of scientific research. Besides, a strong physical interface grounded in a specific location is different from a permanent web presence. That's also not cool enough in these times of high-bandwidth propaganda.

But more important to me, there is a mutual distance here, based on different visions on the functions of art. I personally don't believe in Net art as a distinct visual territory, and obviously Net art sets a tone in today's digital discourse. I appreciate Net art for some ideological stand points, but I am not sure that the methods to fulfill them are appropriate. Net art looks very much like an in-house product, with solutions easy to absorb in mainstream Web design. I sometimes have problems in drawing a clear visual distinction between a Net art product and a smart commercial Web site—not enough resistance there, I would say. Next to this, Net art raises an interesting marketing issue: if you don't try to reach out with intriguing,

interesting physical interfaces your Web site will be lost in the electronic void. Getting into the public sphere needs more than a URL printed on a T-shirt and much more than obstinate promotional campaigns. Unfortunately, or luckily so—I am not sure.

An exception in my view is Shu Lea Chang's *Brandon* project, due precisely to the fact that it is interfacing with people, with institutions, and with the city at the same time (<http://www.waag.org/brandon>). *Brandon* provides an example that interfacing with the public should not be just a metaphor, since your audience is not just a matter of speech. An interface is also a sculpture, and the social body you aim to work with is fluid material that can be modeled. Beuys had some good visions in that direction. But that is ancient history—before the Net ambitions. I think we should be more concerned with the expectations of the audiences. People are very simple but very sophisticated at the same time. This ambiguity makes them so hard to catch and then hold, since it is so difficult to stir both aspects: their simple curiosity and their deeper needs as well.

Before Happy Doomsday! you worked mainly as an editor, critic, and curator. Your work as an artist member of subREAL was never that technical. What skills did you learn in the process of putting together such a big interactive computer installation?

Not very much. I started my high school education in computing and did some programming in Pascal when I was a kid. I left that track very early and studied art theory. Afterwards I always worked in teams, as an editor, curator, manager. What the 1990s brought in my life was the discovery of today's neo-pop culture: advertisement, clubs, fashion. That was totally different from what I experienced before the TV revolution allowed me to both travel and zap. My option for the fitness machines as interfaces and for the game paradigm as a support for my discourses come from this. If you want attention you have to use attention-tested techniques. But for the rest, *Happy Doomsday!* came very much along the line of other big projects I did back in Romania in the early 1990s, *01010. . .*, or *Ex Oriente Lux*.

Could you describe the Happy Doomsday! environment for us? Is it an ironic experience?

First of all, *Happy Doomsday!* is definitely not an information space; it started that way, but it then became a narrative (after all, I am from the Balkans, where people love to tell stories). HD! is a game that deals with enormous issues—(political) history and war—in a ridiculous way. Starting with the fact that you have to pump up your muscles while impersonating a country which tries to destroy another country: it's grotesque! On the other hand, you have topics like money, vampires, nano-technology, urban guerrilla, wars of the future. The method is self-ironic: I am constantly deconstructing my own thinking processes, which is good, since I am a trend-determined animal. The topics are real, but also media-induced, and therefore vain. The situation is open, non-oppressive.

To me you are very much a post-1989 artist, a New European, not anymore from the East or West. You moved from Bucharest to Berlin. You are based in Amsterdam and have recently spent three months in Vienna. How do you look at Romania, ten years after the Fall of Ceausescu?

The more distance I get from Romania, the more interested I am in it. Which is a normal process, I think. Besides that, I developed a conviction that local circumstances considered, each and every different country in Eastern Europe is a very interesting lab of the future. The conflicts between various coexisting historical times are much more violent there, compared to Western societies, even though these conflicts exist here as well. The welfare state is dragging the foot here as it tries to survive, if not in the governmental budget policies, then at least in the mentalities of the people. The transformation from a welfare to a neoliberal system is implying a jungle of legal-to-personal changes, impossible for individuals to follow, even if information would be totally transparent. That is because psychologically speaking we are living in a cotton environment and do not necessarily feel what is being decided in Brussels, Strasbourg, and elsewhere.

While in Eastern Europe the impact of the so-called globalization, new economy, and so on is much more drastic and more on the surface, precisely because of the specific conditions, which leave those countries more vulnerable to changes. What makes the situation there more challenging for the researcher and the activist is the relative innocence of the local populations, which is usually misinterpreting the painful collapse of the local economies as a transition toward the vanishing welfare state order. Which is of course

a procedure of political mythology: There is no such a transition there, just a fall into the reality of neoliberal disorder. One has to admit that this is a most interesting dynamics.

Do you have any plans to do work in Romania in the future?

I am a believer in the symbolic aspect of culture clashes. Not because they seem so trendy now, if we look at the inflationary ethno-anthropo tendencies in music, fashion, art. But because working with remote cultures can still provide us with a lot of information about who we are and where we stand. This is certainly linked to my personal experience but also to the strong traditions of anthropological research that Romania developed in the last century. I would like to use this scientific tradition by working in Romania or elsewhere, but always in a remote area, using wireless technology. To build multiuser computer games for peasants and hunters, with customized content, and interfaced with household tools. We still have the chance to grab there a fundamental way of understanding the world and to give it a voice. In a few years from now it will be too late.

People in the Romanian countryside watch TV and meanwhile they still believe in vampires; sometimes they even act accordingly, sticking a piece of wood through the heart of deceased people suspected to be werewolves. You can offer to those neo-peasants Internet culture as a shamanic mirror. Not for bringing new belief systems into their lives, but for analyzing old ones; also for checking once more if there is real magic in computer environments, which I think is the case.

Let us go back in time a bit, to Berlin in 1995–1996 when you started to work with the photo archive of the former art magazine Arta. You went way beyond the reworking of communist art history, didn't you?

The “Art History Archive,” as Iosif Király and myself baptized the project, became so successful basically because we avoided at all times and sometimes against the expectations the obvious political connotations the material had. It is significant that one of our works, dealing with an omnipresent official artist of the time, is called “The Man Without Qualities.” In the context of power, art people become shadowy figures, they start to look alike, no matter the political system or its economic infrastructure. Men without

qualities gravitate in the high circles of Western cultures and in the shadow of corporations that play the game of art investment and public spending. In the AHA projects, we always started by looking first at the historical data. From there on we extrapolated to a symbolic level. And then we looked for similarities in the art of today.

In the beginning of the nineties when we started working together we denied being artists. It was commonplace then to hate art. Recently we got back on this issue. We use art as a platform for meeting people, for surfing different cultural communities. The quality of communication and information is higher there, less tough if compared to the technology or to the business sectors. subREAL's new series "Interviewing the Cities" is precisely about that: meeting people on the basis of their trade as artists, curators, collectors, architects.

Can you tell the story of the negatives you found in the archive? You started working with them at Akademie Schloss Solitude; part of the work produced there was exhibited in the Romanian pavilion at the 1999 Venice Biennial.

In Berlin we worked with an archive of black and white photos. After a year of research we knew it almost by heart, and therefore had no curiosity for the negatives in the collection, thinking we knew what the prints would be about. There were dozens of boxes with negatives. In the end we decided to have a look at them any way, and that was a moment of revelation. The images in the black and white archive were cropped from 6 x 6 negatives. Artwork is usually long or wide, never square. Therefore paintings and sculptures were just one part of the image, while a lot of things were happening in the picture around them. It took us two years to process this source material in various formats. Its powers of connotation looked endless.

After that, in the fall of 1999, we went further and started a new archive—ours—by taking photos of people from the cultural world. The new project, called *Interviewing the Cities*, started in Vienna. The procedures are standard: We go into the studio of a person we do not know. We introduce ourselves, with a display of books and images of our work. Then we look at the work of the person we visit. We talk about it. It is a complex therapy of mutual interrogation. After that we take two photos, one of the person, another of a piece of the work. Király and I are always in the picture, waving a black dropcloth behind the subject, precisely as in the old

negatives of the *Arta* archive. Some people find this cynical. I think it is just matter-of-fact and somehow humble: an old technique created through the objective need to give a profile to the subject in an environment full of accidents. We are there as the “servants of art,” no more than that.

The portraits of the city series have got something extra, something timeless. They do not have that harsh, almost alienated brightness displayed by most of the contemporary photography you see in galleries.

subREAL uses old aesthetics. There is no relation to commercial photography in our work. Handmade photography becomes more and more an old medium. In the future it will be praised or despised like painting is today. Because it is handmade, precisely. Today’s digital mass photography is completely different. We believe in old photography because of its rhythms. We are actually interested in moving the universe of our photographs in sculpture and painting.

Does Interviewing the Cities have an anthropological aim? You have now finished two series, Vienna and Amsterdam. Do you intend to give an overview of the cultural scenes in such places?

It does not offer the context for a systemic approach. It is not a scientific research tool, but a diary where events are provoked, if you like, while a lot of room is given to chance. The series will gain anthropological value in time, I am sure. That is already obvious after just two layers of experience: The images from Vienna are so much different—in a subtle way—from the Amsterdam ones. But I think it is too early for me to elaborate on the topic of difference in an interesting way. I am now looking forward to work in the next town—Helsinki.

In October 1999, ten years after the fall of communism, the Moderna Museet in Stockholm organized a survey show on Eastern European contemporary art. Is there something like a post-1989 conceptual/media arts generation?

Exhibitions like *After the Wall* are always good because they bring topics together. The art there, in what I would call “the region,” is very diverse, and the differences kept working despite the political unification of the

Cold War era. Russian artists are still very interesting, while Russia is a miserable country. We, the Balkan people, are not the top of the pop; there is something divisive and small there. The weaker part of subREAL comes from the Balkans, whereas the better part is Transylvanian. I must admit that I have a special interest in Hungarian art, probably also because as a Romanian I should not like it. I find the Slovenian environment smart and sophisticated. Things are happening in the Baltic states also. Certainly the cultural borders within Europe are blurring. There are artists who are already absorbed by the international scene, while others stay local. They are not lesser artists, they just have another destiny.

Can we now stop using these regional labels that people always feel slightly uncomfortable with? Parts of the former Eastern bloc are already members of NATO. Some of the countries will soon enter the EU, whereas others are fresh battlefields, poverty zones. Belarus is still a post-communist dictatorship. And then there is Russia, which seems a case in itself.

As far as things develop normally, which is hard to believe, art will go its way. People from the region can focus now more organically on the region's needs and figure out wider strategies. Local and regional networks are slowly building up next to Western influences and policies. Also, a shift seems to be operating on the periphery. This buzzword from the beginning of the last decade starts to be operational now, and the connections on the North-South axis became suddenly real. This is an extremely interesting period, also a somehow naive one. In perhaps thirty years from now, we will have a very different look at the turn of the twenty-first century. We will not understand why things were not moving faster, and why were we so enthusiastic about the wrong things. But that happened before, didn't it?



Cyberselfishness Explained

An Interview with Paulina Borsook

During the memorable year 2000, with markets going from the euphoria of the AOL-TimeWarner merger to the NASDAQ dot-com crash, my personal bible was Paulina Borsook's critical anatomy of Silicon Valley high-tech culture, *Cyberselfish*. For me it's a classic must-read for anyone interested in the origins of Internet culture. Unlike most academic cyberfeminism or Richard Barbrook's provocative California ideologies, *Cyberselfish* is a hardcore account from inside the belly of the Beast, a razor sharp critique of U.S. techno-libertarianism written by a female journalist who was very much part of this culture. Borsook's position of high-tech essayist is a unique one. Some say she used to be the token Luddite while working for *Wired* magazine, but I don't buy that. Borsook is part of a growing discontent within high-tech circles, an unease about the infrastructure breakdown and the general lack of social and political awareness. Curiously enough, *Cyberselfish* does not deal with the late 1990s dot-com phenomena. Instead Borsook looks into the emerging ideology of the Gingrich era (1993–1997) in which George Gilder, Kevin Kelly, Esther Dyson, and other *Wired* front-page heroes were setting the cultural-political agenda on which the speculative Internet boom was built.

Cyberselfish is advertised as a book about people and culture, not about computers and markets: "It is about a set of beliefs well known inside high tech, but little known outside it. It is not a get-rich-quick guide nor about the ways scary hackers are going to get your momma." Written in Susan Sontag's essay tradition, *Cyberselfish* is a theory-light analysis of an engineer culture teaming up with business. Within the history-of-ideas genre, the book is free of political dogmas or regional essentialism. Not touching the big philosophical issues of freedom and liberty, *Cyberselfish* is rich source material for those who want to gain an understanding of techno libertarianism. Borsook, speaking in Toronto, remarked: "Libertarian comes as close as I can think of to describe a culture that is lunatic anti-government, that romanticizes itself as outlaw, and, more than ever, is in bed with Wall Street and enamored with those with elite establishment credentials. It is a culture that has been present in Silicon Valley since its beginning. It flourishes in Bay area high-tech

society to this day and differs significantly from other technology cultures, and distinguishes itself from other robber baron nouveaux riche cultures in some meaningful ways."

Back in 1996 there would have been a great need for such a book. *Cyberselfish* has been criticized for being outdated because it stops around 1996–1997. But Borsook denies that her object of study has changed all that much over time. "The culture that I am documenting existed long before the Netscape IPO and will exist long after folks will be embarrassed to admit that they bought shares in pets.com." With techno-libertarianism facing one setback after another, this ideology has by no means lost its influence on and appeal to the rising class of young male programmers, which is why *Cyberselfish* will remain a first-class reference work for understanding contemporary technoculture. I spoke with Borsook in a back garden of a friend's house in San Francisco's Mission District, a once colorful Hispanic district that quickly gentrified during the late 1990s dot-com mania, driving out migrants and artists.

Where would you start if you had to trace back the libertarian high-tech culture to its origin? Would you go back as far as 1950s cybernetics or hippie culture in the 1960s?

I have been into high tech since the early 1980s. A lot of what I have been writing in *Cyberselfish* has been based on what I have been observing for years and years. It took me a while to figure out what it was I was seeing. You can talk about the cuckoo-ness of the dot-com world, but that's a very particular bubble. The culture I am describing goes back to Silicon Valley in the early 1980s and even before, which I do not really see changing. This is a technology culture that grew up post-Vietnam and post-Watergate and admits a deep disillusionment with government. There is wonderful book, *Regional Advantage* by Annalee Saxenian, on how Silicon Valley rose and Route 128 outside Boston died. In it, she talks about all the complex private-public partnerships and all the information sharing that went on. There was a real communitarian culture. But even they had the fantasy of being the lonesome cowboy. It is a fantasy that all their success in high tech wasn't depending on a complex mesh of things.

Can you describe the difference between Wired in the beginning and what the magazine eventually became?

I had a love-hate relationship with the early *Wired* that I wrote for. It was wonderful because it was about technology as culture. I saw the early *Wired* in the American tradition of magazines such as *Hound and Horn* and *Horizon*. They were intelligent and smart and dealt with society and culture and had a definite point of view. Gonzo! Irreverent! Hard-charging, paradigm-smashing! The later *Wired* turned into a business porn magazine. Nowadays there is little you can read anywhere that is not about business. I was looking into an in-flight magazine last week. American Airlines always had the best, a general-interest magazine not just for sales people. They gutted it. It even had an excerpt from *Fast Company* in it (one of the post-*Wired* New Economy propagators). All of American society has become corporatised. The business culture touches everything.

Business porn magazines are driven by the Ayn Rand idea of the entrepreneur as hero. It is like pornography because it's got a very predictable story line. You read it over and over again and get the same climax, like sex manuals: ten ways to do it. It's extremely formulaic; your readers are living vicariously through it. Nurse novels are emotional porn for women, while Tom Clancy is action porn. You never want to deviate from the formula because otherwise people get upset. Business porn taps into the human need for glamour and importance, to be a hero and have other people regard you as a hero. *Business Week* and *Forbes* have been around for a long time, but they didn't always have the self-glorifying glossy glam. They didn't have this philosopher-prince quality. *Wired* discovered how to turn unattractive geeks into celebrities.

Can you tell us a bit more about the early "bionomics" conferences? In your analysis they played a crucial role in establishing the 1990s Wired culture of the fancy IT business culture. What's the agenda behind the use of all these biological metaphors?

Bionomics is the title of an influential book by Michael Rothschild who had been in and around the computer industry and the venture capital community for a long time. The book was distributed widely in those circles at the right time. We live in a totally mediated environment and panic about nature vanishing. We do have wilderness here in the western United States and live with the myth of living on the edge of the empire and these myths are at hand for us to borrow from. Most of the people borrowing biological metaphors do not realize that they are in fact social Darwinists. A lot don't

want to see themselves this way but they are. It's against those not meeting the test of the marketplace. "We are thinning the herd. Good ideas survive, bad ideas don't." They don't want to regulate anything because how can you regulate a rainforest? It doesn't matter that free market capitalism is destroying the actual rainforest. We don't want to touch that. Biological metaphors simplify. We shouldn't have to do anything and leave it all alone. Maybe it's that utopian strain in the American character. We all want to go back to Eden, to paradise before the goddamned government intervened. Bionomics is built on intellectual fashions such as chaos and complexity theories that are saying that things are self-organized, that we don't have to do anything except follow the genius of nature.

It is seems to be a social Darwinism without anti-Semitism. It is no longer gypsies and Jews who have to be excluded. Would you say that the bionomics discourse is free of racism?

Silicon Valley presents itself as a meritocracy. It is not. It is a lottery but it is not racist. It's fantasy success is based on brains. It's a Calvinist sense of superiority, very much like Max Weber's study of the origins of capitalism in Protestantism. The Valley is mostly whites and Asians; you don't see a lot of blacks, Native Americans, or Hispanics. The idea is that if the market does not validate your ideas, you are inferior intellectually. This does not mean that you should be exterminated. There are certainly prejudices against people with other skill sets who may not be good at programming, people from humanities or those who work with their hands. The competition is rather class based, not ethnic based. There is a diversity in national origin and ethnicity there, but on the other hand it is about as diverse as Harvard Law School. It's people with the same values, the same goals, the same education. It is not remotely diverse. I still see it as a monoculture.

Whatever happened to the New Economy? Do you believe that its goal was not so much to overthrow or destroy the Old Economy but to be a parasite on it? Dot-coms didn't seem to have time to make their money. All they did was burn other people's money.

I never believed there was a New Economy. Now, when I read <www.fuckedcompany.com>, reporting about the latest dot-com bankruptcies and job

losses, I feel as if I am reading the transcripts of the Nürnberg trials. All the people saying: "I was never a party member, I was just a cook. I was just a driver and never bought into any of this stuff." There have been trends in our society for twenty years that have accentuated the dot-com cuckoo-ness. Capital became global; there has been a rise of IT; there's been more speculation on the stock market. That didn't start with the Netscape IPO in 1995. It is silly to think that it did. There was a change in the SEC rulings in 1997 that really contributed to the boom because CEOs, VCs, and founders could flip their stock much more quickly. It really became a culture of flip and flee. The point of these companies was not necessarily to make money in the long run. They were built for early investors to get money out of it quickly. There is no virtuality. We still live in a world of matter. California has got an energy crisis. Silicon Valley is not a clean industry. We got a huge breakdown of infrastructure here because people have to live some place and citizens of surrounding communities are getting sick of Silicon Valley exporting its problems such as commuting over growing distances, housing, and parking lots without contributing to possible solutions.

Would you describe techno-libertarianism as an underlying long-term trend or rather as a mid-1990s fashion?

There is much more libertarianism in the United States compared to twenty or thirty years ago. It sure helps that the FBI is so incompetent. Elections are more corrupt than ever. The libertarian religion is still more concentrated in the high-tech sector than elsewhere in society, and I don't see that changing. It is only in the 2000 local elections that we have seen people waking up. The quality of life in Silicon Valley is so bad, in particular schools. Everything they did not want to pay for over the last twenty years is coming home to roost. Maybe we've got to find ways, they thought, to make schools decent, make some mass transit around here, and create affordable housing. Ten years ago 10 percent of the Bay area economy was high tech. Now it's become twenty percent. If you include law firms and other support sectors, it's probably much more. People who made it a more diverse economy were all forced to move out. What's sad is that this now worsens the impact of the tech slum. The region is suffering much more.

The slaves of the stock market don't have the money to buy band-aids to restore infrastructure so nothing is happening.

I see libertarianism as a religion, not as politics. Religion means it is mostly an unconsciously held common set of beliefs. People do not give up their religion. If you grow up in Europe or North America you are influenced by the Judeo-Christian system. I don't care what you are, those values seep in. The same counts for libertarianism. It's there, no matter what you think you are doing. It's in the air that you breathe. Libertarianism is so appealing in its simplicity. Geeks are attracted by its simple rules and algorithmic formulas and can't deal with adult discourses that do not reduce to elevator pitches and feature humanity in all its complexity.

Do you see a contradiction between "cyberselfishness" and the much-propagated hacker values of sharing information and code, free software, and decentralized systems?

The title *Cyberselfish* was made up by editors at *Mother Jones*, where the original essay was published. It was snappy so we stayed with it. I originally wanted to call the book "My Visit to the Hall of the Mountain Kings," a reference to the Norse mythologies where the trolls guard the gold, but nobody got the reference. There was the Homebrew Computer Club, and there was the old Arpanet culture that was all about information sharing. And there's a great part of civil libertarianism that fights for free speech and against banning algorithms. The problem is that these people often are rabid free marketeers. They may share code but do not have any communitarian feeling about anything else.

Free software is all fine but what I am getting queasy about is its sloppy economic model. We use the same term, intellectual property, for software as we use for the arts, and they are not the same thing. There is this old cultural leftover from the early Internet that everything should be free. Authorship doesn't matter. We should all do it for the better good—which is fine when it's a small group of well-intentioned scientists talking to each other about network protocols. It's not so great when you are talking about a photograph, a graphic image, a piece of fiction endlessly reproduced for free all over the world. Doing that, you are basically saying that art is worthless. There are issues of livelihood here. It's too bad what TimeWarner is doing, not allowing satire and parody, but not paying artists for their work

is something else. I don't like the big record companies either. But too often the Napster peer-to-peer evangelists don't think about what they are doing to the creator. The science fiction writer Harlan Ellison just started a campaign against kids uploading entire novels onto the Net. These writers deserve to get royalties from their work. Such actions are destroying the ability to make a living of your work as a creator. I am not against freedom, there is a degree problem.

Take the example of the MacArthur fellow and Magnum photojournalist Susan Meiselas. She has become the cultural repository for the Kurds. She published a book on it and has done magnificent work. She also worked in Central America and shot a famous photo, an homage to the Spanish civil war partisan who died. For some reason that image of him falling became the symbol of the resistance. It got reproduced everywhere, without her permission. When she came back to the country a year later and saw this, she was flattered. But on the other hand, she has to make a living. She also has to deal with the media concentration problem. Increasingly, there are fewer outlets for someone like her. Everything becomes focused on celebrity, fashion, and corporate placement. That's not what she does. So she is getting screwed from two sides, from the media monopolies and from those who think that everything should be appropriated. What is she supposed to do? The situation is getting worse, and the voices of the Meiselas are not getting heard.

Are you in favor of a "techno specificity" where you say that open source and free software are fine but that those principles should not be exported into society at large without thinking about the consequences?

Exactly. One thing does not have to do with the other. A lot of the free software guys have day jobs. They do this for fun or hobby. One of the notions you learn when you go into psychotherapy is to distinguish: This is not that. This person you interact with is not your mother. It is a fundamental insight of emotional and intellectual maturity. Even though I have been in PR mode over the last year promoting my book, I always said to people that I was not going to tell them what they were supposed to do. What I can tell is to be aware that high tech is selling this religion and you don't have to buy it. Make your own judgment rather than do I what I tell you. For example, in education I think there are things that more important

than computers. If a kid is grounded in the body, knows how to read and write, and is literate, she or he will figure out pretty quickly how to work with computers. Most kids already have enough technology and mediated experiences in their lives.

How were the responses to Cyberselfish in the United States?

I was surprised how my audience skewed older. People of older generations are not too happy where society is going and remember when things were different. They feel vaguely uneasy and don't know why. The other surprise was how many from faith-based communities were responsive to the book. From Christian fundamentalists to observing Catholics, they loved my book. These people have values that matter deeply to them and are not to be tested in the marketplace. Then there are the responses of either rage or envy. Some said to me, Why don't you go back to China? A lot of people didn't seem to have read what I said and instead fantasized about my position. I am getting adolescent libertarian raving via email and write back saying, Thank you, you proved my point, but they don't seem to get that.

Techno libertarians don't seem to have real opponents. Wired was a magazine without enemies. The Old Economy CEOs were the first to sit down and listen.

One thing I do agree about with Louis Rosetto, *Wired's* founder and editor-in-chief, is that I do believe in the Eastcoast media establishment. *Wired* could only have happened in San Francisco. You couldn't get a general interest technology magazine with culture and design in it up and going in the New York of the 1990s. Yet I could not figure why so many people in the high-tech world at that time felt so marginalized and left out. The government had been great to them. They had good jobs. To some extent, we are talking here about the revenge of the geek guys at high school the liberal arts types didn't want anything to do with. You could say that American society is based on such forms of victimhood and resentment. Silicon Valley geekdom even got exported globally. If you go to Northern Europe and see all the schools and roads, you wanna cry. It all works. So why should they be aping what these kookie Americans are doing? Also in Canada people are envious of Silicon Valley, and I kept on saying, Be careful what you wish for. As a Californian visiting Canada, I thought, "This seems pretty good—what

you have going here—and there are real trade-offs to be made.” But there is never talk about the downside of Silicon Valley as a global model.

... not to mention the electricity blackouts and the environment troubles about toxic waste. Funny enough, a lot of the IT staff is acutely conscious of ecological issues.

... and don't forget the huge amounts of water the Valley is wasting. The programmers may go backpacking in the Sierra, they may be vegetarians but they are not thinking about the larger context and they bought the fantasy that it is a clean industry. Friends of mine made the documentary called *Secrets of Silicon Valley*. It features a labor union activist who is looking into the working conditions at one of the Hewlett-Packard plants. People in the Valley buy the idea that it is virtual, disembodied; it's bits not atoms. They don't think about the plastics having been made somewhere. Then there is the problem of dumped old PCs, filled with lead. The manufacturing is now being transferred to more “business-friendly” environments such as Arizona or Malaysia. I didn't touch it in the book because a wonderful organization, the Silicon Valley Toxic Waste Coalition, is already doing this type of work. What I focused on is the ideology behind it all: We don't need regulation; we are different from other people.

An irony of the dot-com craze was that so much money that was made disappeared not into virtuality but into real estate and high rents.

When I wrote the article *How the Internet Ruined San Francisco* (Oct 27, 1999, <www.salon.com>) I got so many responses. “Have you been to Boston, Austin, London lately?” What I described appeared to be global phenomena. Up until the Netscape IPO in 1995 (which we can now date as the beginning of the crazy time) high tech was about technology. After 1995 it became about the business play. Not much new technology was created. The late nineties were not a particularly innovative period. Think about Tokyo in the 1980s. Speculative capital always dumps its money into real estate and won't invest in long-term research. It was financial speculation based on nothing much, just like the bubble in Manhattan in the 1980s. The 1990s boom had the rhetoric of technology and innovation to justify what was going on. A few years after the dot-com boom, venture capitalists started complaining that they were not seeing anything new. There has been a

whole new generation of kids going to computer science departments thinking: How can I get funding for a business idea as quickly as possible? as opposed to: What is an interesting hard problem I can work on? Dot-coms were not about technology; they were about business. John Doerr, perhaps the most evil venture capitalist, talks about this period as the biggest legal wealth creation in history. No, it wasn't. It's been the greatest legal transfer of wealth, taking it from pension funds and middle-class people and giving it to the VCs, executives, and ad agencies. The money has not been created. In response to the continuing gloomy business data Doerr recently recanted like the Pope, apologizing for two thousand years of institutional anti-Semitism. (Oops. Sorry about the pogroms and the crusades and the inquisition and all.) In California, the dot-com money actually ended up in real estate, which has eaten up agricultural land. California is the breadbasket of the world: most of America's cotton is produced here, not just oranges plus movie stars. I don't want to defend the farmers here who depend on cheap government-subsidized water to basically make semi-desert arable, but that's what is going on. We socialize the risk and privatize the gain, and the commons becomes the property of corporations whether it is mining, timber, farmland, or gold—or the Net.

Europe has by and large been absent from the technology game of the last decade. It felt left behind and, in part, had to focus on other topics. Do you make fun of the old continent's tragic position?

No. I understand that some values have more priorities than others. Europe had other stuff it had to deal with. But be careful what you wish for, things are a mess here. Young people especially are not equipped to deal with the current recession. They grew up in the full employment era where the most ridiculous jobs would get a high pay. There is no next tech wave coming immediately. Forget those who are preaching a quick recovery. People bought the idea what they were doing was deeply creative. Now that there is no funny money anymore to finance all these nonsensical websites they are at a loss. Young people don't have the intellectual framework at the moment to interpret what this was all about. I came of age when the first Ph.D. graduates started driving cabs—and so I don't have that attitude of ferocious entitlement that was so common among dot-commers. For good reasons, young people rebelled against the Stalinist PC postcolonial gender

crap they had to study—and bought into the libertarian free-market fantasies so common in high tech.

What do you expect from new media arts? Do you see any attempts to culturally embody the high-tech world?

The tools are still cruddy and so hard to master. They seem to require using a different skill set than that of people that really have creative talents. Seems to me the way people with artbrains' minds work is not the way a programmer's mind works. The tools are overmastering the creators, and that's why the output is not so particularly interesting. The 010101 exhibition at the San Francisco Museum of Modern Art (Spring 2001) reminded me about what geeks were doing as a hobby seven years ago. Was there ever interesting telephone art or electricity art? I don't know. Maybe this is not the right medium. I saw more interesting, real wacky stuff done on 16mm film. The fact that we all have access to digital sound editing software doesn't mean that more interesting music has been created. It may be too early to judge and perhaps the right people have not been born yet who can produce interesting material. How do you make a compelling narrative? That's got nothing to do with the tools. Computers are fundamentally not an aesthetic culture.

A year or so ago a guy called me up who wanted to do a television show called *L.A. Engineer* (like the television series *L.A. Law*). He said something that implied "if we could glamorize engineering we could get sexier babes." I told him that the reason we could have a show like *L.A. Law* because law deals with fundamental human drama: conflicts over money, sex, power, mourning—elements everyone can relate to. The latest software is interesting for those involved, but it takes you twenty minutes to even explain it! You can't see it. Medicine or cop shows deal with human drama, engineers don't. At best people would understand the office politics part.

In general there is not much literature about work. Po Bronson's *The First Twenty Million Is the Hardest* was not about Silicon Valley, that I knew. His *Bombardiers* about bond traders in the San Francisco of the 1980s is much better. There is no Upton Sinclair or John Dos Passos of the Valley, because it is business culture you're dealing with. I like John Brunner. He was a British dystopian science fiction writer of the late 1960s. He is best known for *The Shockwave Rider* because it apparently anticipated the Net.

His more important works were earlier ones. They deal with issues such as overpopulation and eco-catastrophes, not some artificial intelligence like in the movie *The Matrix*. Geek culture does not really want to face the fact we are all truly and deeply interconnected. It is entertaining to draw up an image of the butterfly in China causing a tornado in Kansas. But it's much more messy and distressing to get an understanding of why the Inuit natives in Canada are having more lead in their blood than Detroit inner-city kids because all of the U.S. power plant pollution blowing over the border. Geeks don't get that. For them it is more fun to get excited about the next digital organism.



“Everything was to be done. All the adventures are still there.”

A Speculative Dialogue with Kodwo Eshun

Reading Kodwo Eshun's theory debut *More Brilliant Than the Sun: Adventures in Sonic Fiction* is a hallucinating, addictive experience. For months, I carried this theory bible with me, inhaling sentence after sentence. As a DJ and music critic, Eshun speaks in record tracks. Sitting on the oblique, waving designer floor of Rotterdam's V-2 Lab, the following dialogue did not focus on Eshun's thesis of electronic black music as science fiction. Rather, we were investigating the genre of speculative thought. My experiences with this particular text mode as a member of the Foundation for the Advancement of Illegal Knowledge had shown how bewildering yet invigorating it is to go beyond fixed definitions and interpretations. Ignore the academic mind police, journalistic codes, and the postmodern zeitgeist. Concepts can freely and very precisely be pushed, stretched, reversed, blurred, recombined, negated, mutated. What are the rules of the intensive textual explorations? Certainly not all bids are successful. Theory craze can turn into paranoia, disgust, intellectual exhaustion. It is possible to misread the signs of the time in search of the right mix of cultural artifacts and turn cynical as a misunderstood genius. One gets easily lost on the wide plains of immanence. Obviously, a brilliant concept can just as easily turn you into a millionaire, pop star, or at least a celebrity inventor.

For a while speculative thought and the rise of new media had been a productive couple. In September 1999, when this interview was recorded, I felt that this historical situation, the “short summer of the Internet,” had already come to a close. Kodwo Eshun's golden days of techno, drum'n'bass, drugs and psychedelic theory, Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari, and cybernetics must have been revealed to him around that same period, in the mid- to late nineties. Eshun was still under the spell of it. We both felt that the primal energy was there. One just has to tap into it, no matter what the historical weather forecast predicts. To me, negative thinking and speculative thought were allies. Both the “alien” pole and the engagement of the critic in the everyday move away from the ritualized phrases of today's advertise-

ment and public relations (PR) discourse. Speculative thought heads way beyond today's visionary—and is much more risky. Rather than promoting linear growth scenarios, radical models for unlikely futures are being assembled. The game with ideas is all yours. But what are its rules?

Where in your biography would you locate the origins of speculative thought?

One of the key inputs is McLuhan. There is an interview he gave in 1968 called "Hot and Cool." Here I realized that McLuhan had anticipated my project. He was saying that the extraction of concepts from any field demands that these concepts be used as probes in order to get into a possibility space. Not to contextualize and historicize, tracing the archeology of concepts, where they come from, which is what academics are trained to do. Often it helps if the concept is quite empty. McLuhan was really fascinated by this.

It works well with science fiction, specifically J. G. Ballard. Science fiction as theory on fast forward. In Ballard's theory fiction, especially his "Atrocity Exhibition" in 1970, and "Myths of the Near Future," his trilogy *Crash*, *Concrete Island*, and *High Rise*, and in lots of his essays, you have a particular obsessive figure who is trying to work out and stage a particular project: World War III, or the assassination of JFK and Malcolm X all over again. In order to do that they are forced to go out and construct a theory kit. Take, for example, a painting of Max Ernst, which will then have an aggressively speculative meaning and function, which will then lead you into a new space-time. On the other side you have the scientist, who uses speculative analysis to understand the anti-hero's speculative projects. Here we have two levels of speculation, embedded inside fiction. The other thing is that Ballard is doing a science fiction of the next minutes. He drops away the *Star Wars* space opera, with its galactic and robotic elements. What you are left with is a science fiction of nine minutes from now, the technology of plastics, the pill. He is drawing a zodiac of the present.

We have the following: speculative theory embedded in science fiction, science fiction reinterpreted as an analysis of the ongoing present. Add that to McLuhan's idea of extracting concepts and using them as probes to get to somewhere new. Once I had found these aspects I became more conscious in applying them to sonic concepts that composers and musicians would adopt. Often they would not make programmatic statements. The concepts

would rather be buried in track titles or within an album cover. You would be able to see it, but they would be compressed, abbreviated, and I wanted to unstuff them.

One of the key elements I took from Deleuze and Guattari's *Mille Plateaux* was that philosophy should be reconstituted as concept manufacture. Philosophy—Heidegger, Hegel, Merleau-Ponty, Lacan—always gave me a headache because it was imponderable. Content manufacture made it more like being an electrician of thinking, trying to find circuit diagrams of the present. Deleuze and Guattari were so brilliant when they said: We can't help it if Proust tells us as much how space-time works as Einstein does. We can't help it if Henry Miller tells us as much about how desire works as Freud does. The theory/fiction border is utterly permeable.

These ideas came to me in 1994–1996, when I met Nick Land, Sadie Plant, and her Ph.D. students Mark Fisher, Steve Goodman, and Suzanne Livingston at Warwick's Cybernetic Culture Research Unit. We were all working on the same thing, the permeable membrane between certain concepts, embedded in science fiction, wanting to radicalize certain aspects of Haraway's "Manifesto for Cyborgs." We got a particular boost from music. Sonically, drum'n'bass meant that we left the song far behind. There was new music coming out every week, and this obliged you to come up with a conceptual apparatus that was totally posthuman.

We were fascinated by the way in which rhythm had taken over. In the sixties it was the guitarist who was the lead figure. In the seventies it was the synthesist. And in the 1990s it was the drummer. If you imagine a sonic triangle, with the singer in front, and a guitarist and drummer on each corner. In the nineties the drummer had moved to the front, and both the singer and guitarist had gone. It was not even a human drummer. It was the evolution of rhythm as information, from the drum kit, to the sampler, to the virtual studio—going from a mechanization to a virtualization and complexification of rhythm. This meant that we could break with the tendency in experimental music, the further you got into it, for the rhythm to drop away, rewritten into ambience and timbre.

Listening to drum 'n bass meant that it would not necessarily be that way. Rather the other way: You would go further into hyperrhythm. Once we did that, it gave us the confidence to use twentieth-century sonic concepts, use Stockhausen and Cage and reject their conclusion. Drum 'n bass was using so much remixology. Key drum 'n bass tracks were often remixes

of previous tracks. All around us people were so sober, so heavy and moral, which used to depress us. We found that we could use all this material as a speculative playground and have an adventure of concepts.

I was really pleased to find an old essay by Sylvère Lotringer that explained how they wanted people to use Semiotext(e) books for speculative acceleration. Instead, people started using these texts to prove their moral superiority, saying, "You are wrong, you have misunderstood Foucault." They used theory for prestige, to block speculation. That is why so many artists used to resent theory. You would get these lame pieces, somebody trying to apply Heidegger to Parliament-Funkadelic because they had seen the word "ontology" on a cover, instead of taking Parliament to read Heidegger. They always did it the other way round. Theory wasn't being used to pluralize, to see that there was theory everywhere you looked, and everywhere you listened.

When painters paint, they are theorizing immanently in the field of paint. Sonically, when you compose, you are theorizing tonally. That was a key breakthrough. When I wrote *More Brilliant Than the Sun*, it did not have to be historical. It could be a sonology of history; it did not have to be contextualization of sound. It could be an audio-social analysis of particular vectors. Sound could become the generative principle, could be cosmo-genetic, generate its own life forms, its own worldview, its own world audition. That's still the key break between my book and most cultural studies analyses. They still have not understood that sonology is generative in and of itself. Like every field is. Every material force can generate its own form.

I was really inspired by the Futurists and Marinetti. For ten years I read only critiques of the Futurists, saying they were fascists. In fact, they were the first media theorists of the twentieth century. They were amazed by X-rays, by artificial light and streetlamps, by new cameras and photography. They just wanted to explore how new technologies broke up the solidity of the organism and involved lines of force. Futurism, supremacism, and constructivism were the science fiction of the first machine age. The fantastic adventures of the early modernists, from Tatlin to Malevich. Machines, media, and art thinking were one and the same. Some artists are just extremely good theorists. Still hard to find, this material. Go look for the essays of El Lissitzky. The same counts for the speculative writings of the photographers Robert Smithson and Gordon Matta-Clark. I realized that Barthes never had an academic degree. And why McLuhan used to structure

his ideas with numbers or the alphabet, not be bored to death by the academic obligation to seriousness.

Speculative acceleration, in my experience, can go two ways. One is to go further and further into inner space, exploring the spaces within spaces. The other, which is opposite to this movement, is a speculative thought that wants to go out, toward the utopian, the Alien.

The first move toward inner space is the microscopic analysis. It scales right down from the imaginary sound worlds that a record generates in your head to particular figures within that world. If you talk to people, this is what they are really fascinated by. The sense that all these sonic life forms are crossing from the world of the records into the world of your head. When you put on headphones, the functional expansion of the listening capacity in your brain grows to the size of the universe. R. Murray Schaefer, the inventor of terms such as *soundscape* and *schizophonics*, talks about headphones as a headspace that is not geographical but expansive. Both moves—toward the inside and outside—are endless.

The drive toward the utopian and the alien works really strongly. I wanted to break with the compulsory pessimism at the time. During my cultural studies period, I used to work on authors such as Franz Fanon, Edward Said, Homi Bhabha. The premise was: because social relations in capitalism are bleak this sets the parameters of our thought. I did not see why this was the case. I felt all thought was being hemmed in, and locked, at a certain point. It allowed a fatalism, where the more blocked and frustrated the thought was, the more there was some strange kind of dignity. There was this nobility in pessimism and failure. Then I read Deleuze and Guattari's *Anti-Oedipus*, and Foucault who said, "Do not think you have to be sad in order to militant."

At what point do you think a concept can hit reality and be transformed into material practice? Speculative thought can easily drift away and become irrelevant. I find it fascinating, almost addictive, to see concepts being implemented into software, network architectures, artwork, living discourses. How do you think it is possible to get from the level of the individual author, like you and me, to a level of more complex organization, to jump from individual subjectivity to a level where discourse gets materialized and hardwired, where it gets written into software and networks?

Once I left Warlock University I went abroad, to Vienna in 1996. Meeting Berlin people, meeting Paul D. Miller in New York, reading Erik Davis from the West Coast, getting in contact with *Nomadsland* magazine from Paris, I realized that there are several people with a similar structural position, who had left academia, infiltrating pop cultural spaces. They did not footnote their work and refused to contextualize their work. I wasn't alone. There were sectors in every city who were exhibiting similar tendencies.

We believe that theory can explore unknown land and does not have to reduce its task to recite other people's work. It has a certain avant-garde position in it, a sense of anticipation. I do not feel ashamed by this, despite all the criticisms and the fact that the avant-garde has been declared dead at so many occasions.

I have given up listening to people saying all adventures are over, all heroism is done, we are all born too late and have got no options but to sit around and recombine the forms of other, greater people than we are. How many years I have heard this? The grand narratives are all done. There is nothing left to do. It is always told in our own good fortune. Once I started meeting Sadie Plant and Nic Land at CCRU, I realized this wasn't at all the case. Everything was to be done. All the adventures are still there. Sadie Plant's *Zeroes and Ones* is a heroic book with a massive scope. It crossed centuries, it generalizes wildly, it is rigorous, but it is also gigantic. Sadie rejects all metaphors, nothing is like. Everything is scale, can be on the one hand microscopic, and totally macro as well. Everything can be molecular and molar.

I felt as if I were on the same side as all these people who have a common enemy in the delibidinizers, the boring critics who take a sonic event and drain it, for example, by reducing the music to the social crowds it attracts. Fat Boy Slim thus becomes students' music. Instead we should see a formal analysis as a first stage of rethinking the social. Phase one was criticizing everything. Phase two was writing, being the hermit, hiding away, and refusing the phone calls, the trips, the jobs. Phase three is now, traveling, the network, when you realize that a book will never bring you any money. It is all about the communication vectors that a book makes possible.

My next book will be an Afro-futurist anthology with a historical section, from Samuel Butler to McLuhan and some of the composers. The second part will start with David Toop and Greg Tate and will travel through Belgium, Germany and France, Holland, the East and West Coasts.

It will show the spread of concepts, the linking of science fiction and sound, sonic fiction. Afro-futurism as a transversal tendency running through popular culture, acting to destabilize what people thought black identity was, what pop identity and culture identity were. There was not only a compulsory pessimism in theory when I started. There was also a compulsory ghetto-centricity of black popular culture. Always this hermeneutics of the street.

The identification of, let's say, German kids with gangsta rap has proven to be a trap.

We could reject this and travel on totally different vectors. I wanted to make what started in Sun Ra as a vector. It was important to destroy the previous, like all avant-garde does and to move forward where black identity is intermittent and hazy, often nonexistent, nullified. This led me toward identity as intermittent fluctuation, the epiphenomenon of convergent processes in the body. Identity and consciousness aren't top-down. Artificial intelligence always started with modeling the world. Artificial life instead started from local tendencies, like a small muscle, and several of them combined together make the intelligence of the leg. Identity only arrives later, as communication among motor systems. In this way you can get away from the centralized approach that is only crippling and just leads to dead ends. This is where robotics becomes so fascinating. If you see a Hollywood film from the 1940s, the only role an African American would have is that of an elevator person, the servant. Then read Norbert Wiener from the same period, who says that robots are the precise automatic equivalent of slave labor. Then I realized why all these voices in machines are women's voices, because women used to do all these jobs. I really like Sadie Plant's parallel of women and machines. The rise of automated systems frees women from these drugged roles.

Instead of the writer offering some form of compensation, leaning toward a humanist position, and making sense of the world as itself, theory should try to imagine the impossible and transcend the world of possible connections. Do you think this is a favorable option?

Ballard said that the writer should access inconceivable alienations. People do not know what they want until they are presented with it. Nobody knows what he or she desires. There is a machine, but it takes the form of book. You know books are boring. Still, when you open my book it says at

the top: "Discontents." The writer is admitting right up front his irritation, impatience, and restlessness.

I have experienced cycles in speculative thought, of discovery and excitement, traveling further and further, until you reach a moment of realization (or not). The concept then dies, fades away, loses its magic, and starts to feel worn out. In certain cases, speculative thought is being developed in complete isolation. It is even likely that these journeys toward the end of theory are undertaken in uncontemporary circumstances. Though the hermit position is not always a voluntarily one, forms of criticism that are engaging, searching for new languages and aesthetics, could be a way out. In your experience, how are speculation and criticism related?

Everywhere around you, the death of critique becomes visible. But critique and criticism are not the same. In my case, I started to connect music with art and science fiction. Then you start realizing they are already connected and social disciplinary apparatuses are at work to separate them. Once you see that they are connected, the effort stops to bridge them. You stop being reactive. It turns around. That's when scale becomes more important than analogy or metaphor. You start thinking how across scale and materials general processes emerge that you can see and follow. That's when cybernetics start to become more important. You want to be specific generalist. At a certain point you want to be maximalist.

The Guggenheim Museum in Bilbao is only a start. In ten years more and more things will use spine vectors. That is why the futurists and constructivists are so useful. They tried to extend the immanent processes that their medium suggested to them, which was coined at a moment of extreme mutation. The digital artists I worked with all try to understand psycho-geography and what computer networks are doing to location, topology, and place. Where they are when they are online and what happens when they go offline.

That's when concepts start to achieve functionality and are no longer just ideas, ideologies, or fashions.

I started noticing how many neologisms were used in hyperarchitecture. I counted so many of them! All these architects were obliged to introduce neologisms, to carve out this space they are working in. William Gibson's idea that neologism is the primal act of pop poetics. It is the first phase of concept manufacture, which depends on immanent analysis of the forms of

the medium you are in. Since this medium is the process of extreme change, this puts pressure on your language. I love the idea that digitization does not stop at the screen. Concept manufacture on the one hand is an indulgence of the intellect, on the other an absolute necessity. Everything is being digitally mutated. And all the descriptions are obliged to change as well.

Let us look a bit closer at the moment where concepts, distracted from the speculative mind, are revealed and get transformed due to exposure to the outside. Now in my view, some of these transformations are successful, whereas others fail. Like what you said during the talk you gave, here in V-2: Men find it more difficult to transform themselves than do women. Can we say the same about the art of metamorphosis in higher cyborgian stages? Can we speak of failed transformations and successful attempts to become cyborgs?

One is always inside mutation and certain ways of understanding are more useful than others. In the world of music, the mutation has now moved into R&B and garage. A lot of ideas that were useful in jungle music are of no use anymore. That is why in the talk I gave here I used terms I would never have used two or three years ago: intimacy and love. That is, intimacy inside the machine. Now all the energy in pop culture has moved there. That is the risk of the new. I would not say failure. It is more liveliness. Concepts that take the temperature of thought, and those that lag behind processes. New music demands new immanent analysis. Concepts have to live as much as the culture they are accelerating, or complicating. I would not say that they have to be in a state of permanent revolution. Not failure or success. It is more rates of quickness and intensification. You want concepts to amplify states of mind, mood vectors. Opening up a possibility space which music suggests but never explicates.

Dance music is so covert. Everything is so buried in the song. If you conduct an interview with musicians, they won't tell you anything. They will speak about their personality and keep the sound world totally mysterious. Pop music is a public secrecy. This is contrary to the world of classical music, where musicians and composers will tell you everything about the music and its structure, but tell you nothing about themselves.

There are experiments with Internet radio. MP3 suddenly became big. These developments tend to focus on distribution, not on production. How

could we imagine networked music? Most musicians, in my view, still work under the conditions of Bach and Mozart. They act like the individual genius, compose a work offline and then dump it online, if they use Internet at all. Can we envision a production of music that is situated within computer networks?

This is all true. Say, you go to an MP3 site and there are between three thousand and eight thousand tracks, sitting there to be accessed. The question then becomes which site attracts you, draws you. So far MP3 is only threatening the middle-range apparatus of the music industry. You can now have Web sites that act as virtual record labels and virtual studios, an entire strata of musical structures. It has not happened so far that the network is seen as the starting point of music. Even on the Net, it is mainly Sony and other big record companies you hear about. It is only when their bulk starts to become a problem, and their massiveness turns into a flaw, that the micro sites of postmedia initiatives will start to appear on the radar. So far nobody knows they are there, until you are there, with them. What is disappointing to me about net.radio is that its sonic artifacts are not more radical than the music generated offline. That is why I do touch the MP3 topic. Instead I would rather focus on something like *Earshot* (www.deepdisc.com/earshot), which is simultaneously a search engine and an audio interface, combing the sound files the search engine pulls down.

Apart from MP3 databases, there are free radios and Web masters jamming together and clubs connecting other clubs. What do you expect from these online events?

Can you download the parameters of emotion and affect that make a club? It is the sound of music traveling through bodies, the entire affective convergence that makes a club. There was an event I went to in 1996, *Digital Diaspora*, with Scanner in the ICA in London and DJ Spooky at The Kitchen in New York.

But that's already much too public. The pressure of representation in such a setting is huge. I think such linkages can only succeed in an informal atmosphere of freedom and relaxation. We have the technology now to cut out mediators such as record labels, shops, and magazines and to contact each other directly, on a global level. Mediation is becoming a distraction, dominated by large, controlled portals that will try to monopolize live events.

You could be right. The failure of linked projects so far has been that things happen on a screen and then everybody is watching them. At some stage we will get music that amplifies the sound of the network. Soon we will witness the birth of an immanent Net sound that is produced and distributed within the networks. I got online only in 1998, and I turned this lateness into my advantage. Old media love the backlash of the Internet that is happening at the moment. Everybody gets caught in this fascination for rejection of no more online, back to the street, to drugs and sex. Under the radar of this fascination a Net-based music culture could come into existence. Both the doom and boom aspect of the Net are over. Once they both collapse, you get something else. Still, I feel this the lack because it is still not there yet. Net theorists are hoping too much for something to come out of MP3, but nothing is happening. Sonic evolutions happen when people give up on things. It is when you give up on break beats; that's when drum'n'bass happens and nobody notices it. Hip-hop is dead. That is when you get extreme mutations.

As a newcomer, what do you think of Internet criticism and media theory, all the work that is done outside of academia?

I like the fluctuating bits, where theory loses its authority, deauthorizes itself and starts to become a babelogue. The Babel moment Pattie Smith used to talk about. Rigorous polylogues and all mashed, that is what networked thinking looks like. That's what Nettime's *Readme!* anthology looks like. Cross-town traffic of tones and registers. The next stage could be aphorisms, slogans, and instructions. What Deleuze and Guattari said: Write with slogans. The best of Nietzsche has that. They make you feel brave and heroic. My book was rewritten eleven times, staying offline, making the text clearer, more compressed. If I thought of an online hypertext continuation, I would work with margins, extended footnotes, other text levels. On the other side, one of the worst books ever written is *Imagologies* by Taylor and Saarinen. The level of media theory is so banal, yet the design was so high-level. I like Lars Spuybroek's slim book, *Deep Surface*. There is lots more to be done yet. The format of the book can be reconfigured in a much stronger way.

Is there any future for the cultural industries, cultural studies, and pop in the United Kingdom under the third regime of Tony Blair?

The convergence of pop and the Blair administration has allowed traditional, old media back in. The Millenium Dome functions here as an attractor, from Britpop to cultural studies. Well-known fashion designers certainly play a role in it. On the other hand, there is fashion nowadays that operates at a conceptual level and barely sells anything, such as Vexed Generation from London. For the first time there are fashion theories. I liked the remarks of Bruce Sterling at the end of *Readme!* where he says that there will be this demand for new content in the years to come. The dome is a wonderful container for all these people, walking around from exhibit to exhibit, showing each other how brilliant they are, captivated by their own excellence. They can stay there, casting a shadow over themselves.

This leaves the rest of us quite free to do everything else. Britpop, Damien Hirst, and Blair—that's what they think the nineties was all about. Not Sadie Plant. Mutual flattery in the media really works and the dome is the symbol of this mirror world. It is Debordian spectacle to the max. Some will always carry the dome around with them. The Berlin Wall came down, but the wall was still in people's heads for another decade. You can never knock it down because it is stronger than ever. The dome will be like that for a certain industry. It is not a visionary exhibition like the 1939 World Expo. There will be no spin-off products. Its only result will be a self-satisfied containment of culture.

Profiles

Norbert Bolz is a philosopher, assistant to Jacob Taubes, and Walter Benjamin expert, who has taught at Free University Berlin. Since 1992 he has been a professor of media, design, and communication at the University of Essen. Throughout the 1980s, together with Friedrich Kittler and Christoph Tholen, he was an active member of the Kassel media archeology research group. Since the mid-nineties, Bolz changed his focus to marketing, product design, and new media. His books include *Auszug aus der Entzauberten Welt* (1989), *Theorie der neuen Medien* (1990), *Eine Kurze Geschichte des Scheins* (1991), *Chaos und Simulation* (1992), *Philosophie nach ihrem Ende* (1992), *Am Ende der Gutenberg-Galaxis* (1993), *Das Kontrollierte Chaos* (1994), *Die Sinngesellschaft* (1997), *Die Konformisten des Anderssein* (1999), and *Weltkommunikation* (2001). In English, he has written *Walter Benjamin* (1995), with Willem Van Reijen. English translations of his essays and reviews can be found at <<http://www.mediamatic.nl>>.

Paulina Borsook is a Bay area-based journalist working within the IT industry. She is a former contributing writer at *Wired*. Her fiction, essays, humor pieces, and journalism on technology and culture have appeared in print and online in publications including *Newsweek*, *Mother Jones*, *Salon*, *Suck*, and *Feed*. She is author of *Cyberselfish* (New York: Little, Brown, 2000). More information on Borsook appears online at <<http://www.cyberselfish.com>>. Borsook's unofficial Web page is <<http://www.transaction.net/people/paulina/>>.

Luchezar Boyadjiev, based in Sofia, Bulgaria, works as an artist. His background is in art history and theory, studies he pursued in both Bulgaria and the United States. Recently he had shows at the CIX Gallery, Skopje; the Ata Center for Arts, Sofia; and the Swiss Embassy Residence, Sofia. He also participated in *After the Wall*, Stockholm/Budapest/Berlin; *Negotiations*, Sète,

France; *Kooperativ—Kunstdialoge Ost-West*, Ulm, Germany; "Pro@Contra," Moscow; *L'Autre Moitié de l'Europe: Social Reality/Existence/Politics*, Paris; and *Worthless (Invaluable)*, Ljubljana.

Kuan-Hsing Chen, an Inter-Asian cultural critic, is executive editor of *Inter-Asia Cultural Studies* (Routledge), president of the Taiwan Cultural Studies Association, professor in the Department of Foreign Languages and Literature at National Tsing Hua University, and coordinator of the university's Center for Asia-Pacific Cultural Studies. He was the organizer of the first Inter-Asia Cultural Studies conference, "Problematising Asia," held in Taipei in 1998. He is editor of *Trajectories: Inter-Asia Cultural Studies* (1998).

Călin Dan is an art critic, curator, and artist who was born 1955 in Arad, Romania, but has been based in Amsterdam since 1996. His background is in art history and theory, with interests in narrative writing experience in art journalism/management/production/teaching. Active in photography, interactive media proactive in infotainment, docufiction, and commercial mythology, Dan was editor-in-chief of the Romanian art magazine *Arta* (1990–1994). He is a member of the artist group subREAL, was director of the Soros Contemporary Arts Center in Bucharest (1992–1995), and held artist residencies in Berlin, Stuttgart, Vienna, and Helsinki. He was artistic director of the interactive installation *Happy Domsday!*, produced by V-2 in Rotterdam (1998–1999). In 2001 he became creative director for rich media products at Lost Boys Interactive Media. More information is available online at <<http://www.v2.nl.v2-lab/hd>> and <<http://www.plueschow.de/fellows/subreal>>.

Mike Davis, pioneering urbanist, is known for his scathing social and ecological histories of that most mediated city, Los Angeles. Davis is the author of *Prisoners of the American Dream* (1986), *City of Quartz* (1990), *Ecology of Fear* (1998), and *Late Victorian Holocausts* (2000). In 1998, Davis was a MacArthur Foundation Fellow. He teaches in the Department of History, SUNY Stony Brook, and previously was on the faculty at SCI-Arc, the Southern California Institute of Architecture. He lives in Papa'aloa, Hawaii.

Mark Dery is a New York-based critic. He has written for numerous magazines, from *The New York Times Magazine* to *21C: The Magazine of the Twenty-First Century*, *The Village Voice*, *Feed*, and *Suck*. He edited *Flame Wars*

(1993), a collection of essays on cyberculture. Author of *Escape Velocity* (1996) and *The Pyrotechnic Insanitarium* (1999), in 2000 he was the editor of *Artbyte* magazine.

Kodwo Eshun is a concept engineer and imagineer who writes about electronic music, science fiction, technoculture, postwar movies, and drug culture for magazines such as *The Face*, *The Wire*, *Melody Maker*, *Spin*, *Arena*, and *The Guardian*. His much-praised theory debut, *More Brilliant Than the Sun: Adventures in Sonic Fiction*, was concept-engineered in 1998.

Susan George is vice director of the Transnational Institute (TNI) in Amsterdam, a union of researchers who work all over the world investigating issues of development politics and the economy of North-South relationships, war, conflicts, and democratization processes. American-born, she served on the board of directors of Greenpeace International from 1990 to 1995 and remains active on behalf of the French board of directors. George has repeatedly been engaged as an advisor to the United Nations. Her books include *How the Other Half Dies* (1976), *Food for Beginners* (1982), *Ill Fares the Land* (1984), *A Fate Worse Than Debt* (1988), *The Debt Boomerang* (1992), *Faith and Credit* (1994, with Fabrizio Sabelli), and her fictional work *The Lugano Report* (1999).

Boris Groys is a Russian-born, German art critic who has taught philosophy and aesthetics at the School for Design Karlsruhe, Germany. In 2000 he was appointed director of the Viennese Academy of Fine Arts. Among his books, all in German, are *Gesamtkunstwerk Stalin* (1988), *Die Kunst des Fliehens* (1991, with Ilya Kabakow), *Über das Neue* (1992), *Die Erfindung Russlands* (1995), *Die Logik der Sammlung* (1997), and *Unter Verdacht* (2000).

Frank Hartmann, D.Phil., lives in Vienna and pays his rent by working as a media consultant and scientific writer. He is a lecturer in media theory at the Institute of Communications Science at the University of Vienna. Publications include *Horkheimers Materialistischer Skeptizismus* (1990), *Denker Denken Geschichte* (1994), *Cyber.Philosophy* (1996, reprint 1999), *Informationsgesellschaft* (1998), and *Medienphilosophie* (2000). His Web page is at <<http://www.medienphilosophie.net>>.

Michael Heim is a philosopher, virtual reality expert, and tai chi teacher, based in Southern California. He is translator of Martin Heidegger's *The Metaphysical Foundations of Logic* (1983). His three books are *The Metaphysics of Virtual Reality* (1983), *Electric Language: A Philosophical Study of Word Processing* (1987, 2d ed. 1999), and *Virtual Realism* (1998). His Web page is at <<http://www.mheim.com>>.

Dietmar Kamper has been professor of sociology at Free University Berlin since 1979. Influenced by Ziegler, Cioran, Kierkegaard, Boehme, he developed a nondisciplinary, reflexive metaphysics, out of the margins, with the human body at its center. Together with Christoph Wulf, he edits a series of anthologies on historical anthropology. Kamper was an early promoter of contemporary French thinking in German-speaking countries. His works include *Geschichte und Menschliche Natur* (1973), *Zur Geschichte des Körpers* (1976), *Zur Geschichte der Einbildungskraft* (1981), *Das Gefangene Einhorn* (1983), *Zur Soziologie der Imagination* (1986), *Hieroglyphen der Zeit* (1988), *Bildstörungen. Im Orbit des Imaginären* (1994), *Abgang vom Kreuz* (1996), and *Von Wegen* (1998). A short biography, in German, written by Rudolf Maresch, can be found at <<http://www.microflash.de/rmaresch/texte/text22.htm>>.

Zina Kaye is a new media (sound) artist, based in Sydney, Australia. As a programmer-designer, she works in a variety of fields including robotics, airplanes, airports, video, pictures, radio, writing, sound, streaming, and rockets. Some of her projects are *Fantasy Lounges: The Lost Airport of the Parallel Universe*, *Agent All-Black*, the *Hydrogen Jukebox* show on 2SER, *Liftworld*, and digital theater sets. She is an Australian pioneer of Internet broadcast. More information on Kaye is available online at <<http://laudanum.net>>.

Thomas Keenan teaches literary theory and media at Bard College in New York, where he also directs the Human Rights Project (<http://www.bard.edu/hrp>). He is author of *Fables of Responsibility* (Stanford University Press, 1997), and editor of books on the museum and on the wartime journalism of Paul de Man. He is currently at work on *Live Feed: Crisis, Intervention, Media*, building on his research in media and contemporary conflicts. He was co-organizer of the conferences on "Humanitarian Intervention in the Media Age" (The American Center in Paris, 1994) and

"Data Conflicts: On the Geopolitics of Cyberspace in Eastern Europe" (Potsdam, December 1996).

Arthur Kroker is professor of political science at Concordia University, Montreal, Canada. He is author of *Technology and the Canadian Mind* (1984), *The Possessed Individual* (1992), *Spasm* (1993), *Data Trash* (1994, with Michael A. Weinstein), and *Hacking the Future* (1996, with Marielouise Kroker) and editor of *Digital Delirium* (1997, with Marielouise Kroker), a collection of essays on electronic culture. With Marielouise Kroker, he edits both the CultureTexts Series and the electronic journal *CTHEORY*. Additional information is available online at <<http://www.ctheory.com>>.

Bruno Latour is a French philosopher and anthropologist who specializes in the analysis of scientists and engineers at work. He is professor at the Centre de sociologie de l'Innovation at the Ecole Nationale Supérieure des Mines in Paris and visiting professor at the London School of Economics. He has written *Laboratory Life: On the Construction of Scientific Facts* (1979), *Science in Action* (1987) and *The Pasteurization of France* (1988). He has also published a field study on an automatic subway system *Aramis, or the Love of Technology* (1996), an essay on symmetric anthropology *We Have Never Been Modern* (1993), and *Pandora's Hope* (1999). His most recent book, *Politiques de la Nature* (1999), is being translated into English. Latour's Web page is at <www.ensmp.fr/~latour>.

Marita Liulia is a Finnish artist and multimedia author who holds a B.A. from the University of Helsinki. Director of the multimedia company Medeia, she is cofounder of the m-cult New Media Center in Helsinki. Her works include *Jackpot*, an interactive laser disc installation (1992); *Prejudices*, a telematic performance between Finland and Sweden (1993); *Maire*, a CD-ROM and installation (1993); *Ambitious Bitch*, a CD-ROM, Web site, and installation (1996); *Son of a Bitch*, a CD-ROM and Web site (1999). Selected exhibitions in 1999 and 2000 included those at Gallery 101 (Ottawa), F2F—UCLA (Los Angeles), and Urban Futures 2000 (Johannesburg) as well as multimedia works (St. Petersburg), *All You Need Is Love—Bathouse* (Gdansk), *Prix Möbius International* (Paris), *Nordic Postmodern—KIASMA* (Finland), Center d'Art Santa Mònica (Barcelona), Ars Electronica (Austria), *Melbourne Film Festival*, *The dLux media arts—Artspace* (Sydney), *Retrospective*

—Pori Art Museum (Finland), and *Femme Totale International Film Festival* (Dortmund). She has won numerous grants and awards for her work. More information on Liulia can be found online at <<http://www.medeia.com>>.

Geert Lovink is a media theorist, publisher, and radiomaker. He is an organizer of conferences, online forums, publications, and projects such as community Internet providers, mailing lists, and media laboratories. Over the last fifteen years he has lived and worked in Berlin, in Budapest, and throughout Central and Eastern Europe, teaching media theory and supporting independent media and new media culture. He is a former editor of the new media arts magazine *Mediamatic* (1989–1994) and is a member of Adilkno, the Foundation for Illegal Knowledge that has produced two books in English translation: *Cracking the Movement* (1994) and *The Media Archive* (1998). In 1995, together with Pit Schultz, he founded the international mailing list *Nettime*, whose material was brought together in the *Readme!* anthology (1999), which he coedited. He was a *Nettime* co-moderator in 1998–1999. He is now based in Sydney. His text archives are available online at <<http://thing.desk.nl/bilwet>> (through 1998) and <<http://laudanum.net/geert>>.

Rafael Lozano-Hemmer, a Mexican-Canadian electronic artist, works in relational architecture, technological theater, and performance art. His pieces have been shown in over a dozen countries and have received awards such as the Golden Nica (Austria), the Interactive Digital Media Award (Canada), an SFMOMA Webby distinction (USA), and a Cyberstar Prize (Germany). Together with his wife, Susie Ramsay, he organized the Fifth Cyberconf and initiated the “LIFE x.0” Art and a-life competition for the Telefónica Foundation in Madrid. For more information on Lozano-Hemmer, see <<http://www.lozano-hemmer.net>>; for *Vectorial Elevation*, relational architecture 4, see <<http://www.alzado.net>>; and for *Positioning Fear*, relational relational architecture 3, see <<http://xarch.tu-graz.ac.at/home/rafael/fear>>.

Peter Lunenfeld, who teaches in the Media Design Program at the Art Center College of Design, is the founder of *mediawork: The Southern California New Media Working Group*, and editor of *The Digital Dialectic: New Essays on New Media* (The MIT Press, 1999). His most recent book is *Snap to Grid: A User's Guide to Digital Arts, Media, and Culture* (The MIT Press,

2000). He writes "User," a column for the journal *art/text*, and is editor of the *Mediawork* pamphlets series for The MIT Press, which he describes as "a collection of intellectually sophisticated, visually compelling short works that unite contemporary thinkers with cutting-edge graphic designers to create theoretical fetish objects."

Lev Manovich is a Russian-born, U.S.-American artist, theorist, and critic of new media. He is the author of *Tekstura: Russian Essays on Visual Culture* (Chicago University Press, 1993) and *The Language of New Media* (2001) as well as over fifty articles. Manovich has been working with computer media as an artist, computer animator, designer, and programmer since 1984. His art projects include little movies, a digital film project designed for the Web (1994–), and *Freud-Lissitsky Navigator* (1999–), a conceptual software for navigating twentieth-century history. He has been teaching digital art and the theory of new media since 1992 at a number of universities in the United States and Europe. Currently he is an associate professor at the Visual Department at the University of California at San Diego. His Web pages are <<http://www.visarts.ucsd.edu/~manovich>> and <<http://www.manovich.net>>.

Mongrel is a mixed bunch of London-based people and machines working to celebrate the methods of an "ignorant" and "filthy" London street culture. In the group's own words, "We make socially engaged cultural products employing any and all technological advantage that we can lay our hands on. We have dedicated ourselves to learning technological methods, which means we pride ourselves on our ability to program, engineer and build our own software and custom hardware." For more information, see <<http://www.mongrelx.org>>.

Eduard Muka, artist, art critic, and curator, graduated the Academy of Fine Arts, Tirana, Albania, in 1991, where he has been an assistant professor since 1995. In 1999–2000, he was director of the International Cultural Center, and since 2001 he has been curator at the National Gallery and at the Tirana Biennale (www.tiranabiennale.org). Exhibitions include *Untitled*, a one-man show at the National Gallery, Tirana, and he participated in *Translocation: New/media art*, Vienna (1999) and *Who, How and for Whom*, Zagreb (2000). He was curator of *Riorientim* (Reorientation), Porcelain

Factory, Tirana (1997); *Untitled*, Academy of Fine Arts, Tirana (1998); *Pyramedia*, International Meeting on media art, National Gallery, Tirana (1998); *Welcome to Wonderland*, National Gallery, Tirana (1998); *Onufri 98*, National Gallery, Tirana (1999); *Albania Today*, Albanian Pavilion of the 48th Venice Biennial (1999); *Albanische Kunst Heute*, Haus am Lutzwoplatz, Berlin, Germany (1999); and *We Love Italy, Italy Loves Us*, Museum of Contemporary Art, Ortona, Italy (2000).

Jonathan Peizer has been chief information officer of the Soros Foundations, New York, since 1993, where he is responsible for developing and implementing operational automation strategy throughout the 30+-country foundation network and for coordinating an extensive Internet project that provides connectivity to over 400,000 people throughout the world. Peizer has defined Internet connectivity projects in more than thirty countries using traditional and wireless technologies to deliver connectivity to thousands of end-users. His work includes creating project and funding partnerships with international organizations, local academic/research networks, and corporations to implement the projects. He is involved in setting up NGO and for-profit ISPs. More information is available at <<http://www.soros.org>>.

Saskia Sassen is professor of sociology and social studies at the University of Chicago and Centennial Visiting Professor at the London School of Economics. An expert on political economics, she primarily studies the social and political consequences of globalization. Some of her publications are *The Mobility of Labor and Capital* (1988), *The Global City* (1991, second edition 2001), *Cities in a World Economy* (1994), *Losing Control? Sovereignty in an Age of Globalization* (1996), *Globalization and Its Discontents* (1998), and *Guests and Aliens* (1999).

Herbert I. Schiller, professor emeritus of communication at the University of California at San Diego, died in January 2000. His last book was *Information Inequality* (1996). Other publications include *Mass Communications and American Empire* (1969, second edition 1992), *The Mind Managers* (1973), *Communication and Cultural Domination* (1976), *Information and the Crisis Economy* (1984), and *Culture Inc.: The Corporate Takeover of Public Expression* (1989).

Gayatri Spivak is a paradisciplinary, ethical philosopher, and professor at Columbia University, New York. She established her reputation with her translation of and preface to Derrida's *Of Grammatology* (1976). She has since applied deconstructive strategies to various theoretical engagements and textual analyses, from feminism, Marxism, and literary criticism to, most recently, postcolonialism. Her publications include *In Other Worlds: Essays in Cultural Politics* (1987), *Selected Subaltern Studies* (1988, edited with Ranajit Guha), *Outside in the Teaching Machine* (1993), and *A Critique of Post-Colonial Reason: Toward a History of the Vanishing Present* (1999). Her work also appears in *The Spivak Reader* (1996), edited by Donna Landry and Gerald MacLean.

János Sugár studied in the Department of Sculpture at the Hungarian Academy of Fine Arts in Budapest from 1979 to 1984. Between 1980 and 1986, he was actively involved in the exhibitions and performances of Indigo, an interdisciplinary art group led by Miklós Erdély. Sugár has participated in national and international exhibitions since 1984 and has also produced numerous performances, films, and videos. Between 1990 and 1995, he was on the board of the Balázs Béla Film Studio, Budapest. Since 1990, Sugár has been teaching art and media theory in the Intermedia Department, Hungarian Academy of Fine Arts, Budapest. In 1992 he exhibited at Documenta IX, Kassel. In 1995, he published *Minus Pathos* (Budapest, 1998). His films were screened at the Anthology Film Archives in New York in 1998. More information on Sugár is available online at <<http://www.mrf.hu>>.

Ravi Sundaram is one of the directors of Sarai, the New Media Initiative, a program at the Center for the Study of Developing Societies in Delhi, India (www.sarai.net). He has been writing on new media in India for the past few years, arguing that it is part of a "pirate" modernity, opening up new possibilities of action and mobility.

Toshiya Ueno is an associate professor at the Expressive Cultures Department at Wako University, Tokyo. Several of his papers in English are available in the Nettime archive (www.nettime.org). He is writing a book titled *Urban Tribal Studies* with the Amsterdam-based Croatian sociologist Benjamin Perasovic. His published books, in Japanese, include *Situation*,

Cultural Politics of Rock and Pop (Sakuhinsha, 1996), *Artificial Nature, On Cyborg Politics* (Keisoshobo, 1996), *Thinking Diaspora* (Chikuma Shobo, 1999), and *Cultural Studies, an Introduction* (2000, with Joshi Mori and Chikuma Shobo; vol. 2, forthcoming).

Tjebbe van Tijen studied sculpture in the Netherlands, Italy, and Great Britain. He conducted experiments with environments, happenings, and expanded cinema in the mid-1960s. One of his first projects was to set up a documentation center on “art, technology and society” in 1967, temporarily housed in the Stedelijk Museum Amsterdam. This idea later led to the founding of a documentation center for modern social movements at the University Library of Amsterdam that operated for twenty-five years and was later transferred to the International Institute of Social History in Amsterdam. He has developed interactive systems for the visualization and dramatization of pluralistic social and historical information. Projects include *Imaginary Museum of Revolution* (1988–1990, with Jeffrey Shaw), *Orbis Pictus Revised* (1991–1996, with Milos Vojtechovsky), and *Neo-Shamanism* (1997–1998, with Fred Gales). He explores the social processes of remembering and forgetting with two ongoing research projects: one called “Literary Psycho-Geography of Tokyo & Amsterdam” and another on aerial bombing of the human habitat from 1911 to the present called *Unbombing the Cities of the World*. His Web page is at <<http://people.a2000.nl/ttijen/Index.html>>.

McKenzie Wark is the author of three books: *Virtual Geography* (1994), *The Virtual Republic* (1997), and *Celebrities, Culture and Cyberspace* (1999). With Brad Miller, he produced the CD-ROM *Planet of Noise* (1997). He has been a contributing editor to *21C: The Magazine of the Twenty-First Century* and was a columnist for *The Australian* newspaper for nine years. He was coeditor of the *Nettime* anthology *Readme!* (1999) and is a regular contributor to the *Nettime* mailing list. In 2000–2001 he was a visiting professor in comparative literature at the State University of New York and a guest scholar at New York University. He is editor of the media.culture book series for Pluto Press Australia. His Web page is at <<http://www.mcs.mq.edu.au/~mwark>>.

Hartmut Winkler, an architect, programmer, and trained philosopher, has worked at different universities in Germany as a media theorist—namely, in Siegen, Frankfurt, and Bochum. Since 1999 he has been professor of media

studies and media culture at Paderborn University, establishing a comprehensive media department there. He has published three books (in German): *Switching, Zapping* (1991), *Der Filmische Raum und der Zuschauer* (1992), and *Docuverse: Zur Medientheorie der Computer* (1997). His Web page, <<http://www.uni-paderborn.de/winkler>>, features a number of his archived articles in English.

Slavoj Žižek is a post-Lacanian philosopher and cultural critic; senior researcher at the Institute for Social Studies, Ljubljana, Slovenia; and founder and president of the Society for Theoretical Psychoanalysis, Ljubljana. He is editor of the following book series: *Analecta* (in Slovene), *Wo es war* (in German), *Wo es war* (in English, with Verso), and *SIC* (in English, with Duke University Press). His English publications include *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (1989), *Looking Awry* (1991), *For They Know Not What They Do* (1991), *Everything You Always Wanted to Know About Lacan But Were Afraid to Ask Hitchcock* (1992), *Enjoy Your Symptom!* (1992), *Metastasis of Enjoyment* (1994), *The Invisible Remainder* (1996), *The Plague of Fantasies* (1997), *The Ticklish Subject* (1999), *The Fragile Absolute* (2000), and *Did Somebody Say Totalitarianism?* (2000). His work also appears in *The Žižek Reader* (1998), edited by Elisabeth and Edmond Wright.

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Uncanny Networks

Dialogues with the Virtual Intelligentsia

Geert Lovink

For Geert Lovink, interviews are imaginative texts that can help create global, networked discourses not only among different professions but also among different cultures and social groups. Conducting interviews online, over a period of weeks or months, allows the participants to compose documents of depth and breadth, rather than simply snapshots of timely references.

The interviews collected in this book are with artists, critics, and theorists who are intimately involved in building the content, interfaces, and architectures of new media. The interviewees include Mark Dery, Kodwo Eshun, Bruno Latour, Rafael Lozano-Hemmer, Lev Manovich, and Slavoj Žižek. The topics discussed include digital aesthetics, sound art, navigating deep audio space, European media philosophy, the Internet in Eastern Europe, the mixing of old and new in India, critical media studies in the Asia-Pacific, Japanese techno tribes, hybrid identities, the storage of social movements, theory of the virtual class, virtual and urban spaces, corporate takeover of the Internet, and cyberspace and the rise of nongovernmental organizations.

Geert Lovink is an independent media theorist and Net critic, the founder of *Nettime* mailing lists, a member of Adilkno, and a cofounder of the online community server Digital City. He is the author of *Dark Fiber: Tracking Critical Internet Culture* (MIT Press, 2002).

"If you want to know what media theory will say five years from now, then read *Uncanny Networks* to see what Geert Lovink said five years ago. For a futurist like myself, this useful, handy book saves time and trouble all around."

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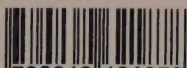
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